

THE HOUSE OF MACHIAVELLIANISM

DANSE
MACABRE

JULIE ANNE ADDICOTT

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“It’s only cannibalism if you swallow.”

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DANSE MACABRE – *The House of Machiavellianism*

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CONTENT WARNING

THIS NOVEL IS **NOT** A ROMANCE

Danse Macabre contains gratuitous and graphic violence.

This story includes various paraphilias, brutal murder, mutilation, torture, and sadistic, perverse, and immoral deeds. For an extensive list of themes that may be triggering, please check the author's website by clicking the link below.

[CONTENT WARNING LIST](#)

*The author **does not** recommend anyone partake in the actions of the **fictional characters** in this novel.*

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Julie Anne Addicott is an Australian author and writes in British English.

This story is set in fictional locations based in Australia.

(Please keep this in mind if you come across spelling, words, or phrases that do not match those of your country, dialect, and/or language.)

A cast of characters list can be found at **the end** of this book.

**** Please note that this list contains major spoilers. ****

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CONTENT WARNING

BREAKING NEWS

PART ONE

I

II

III

PART TWO

IV

V

VI

VII

VIII

IX

X

XI

XII

XIII

XIV

XV

XVI

XVII

XVIII

XIX

XX

XXI

XXII

XXIII

XXIV

XXV

PART THREE

XXVI

XXVII

XXVIII

XXIX

XXX

XXXI

[XXXII](#)

[XXXIII](#)

[XXXIV](#)

[XXXV](#)

[XXXVI](#)

[BREAKING NEWS](#)

[FINALE](#)

[XXXVII](#)

[XXXVIII](#)

[XXXIX](#)

[ABOUT THE AUTHOR](#)

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DIABLO KING

*If you dance with the devil, you're going to burn.
And, oh, how I love to dance.*

I am no god. I seek no glory.
Still, they come to me.

They want me to right their wrongs and give them hope.
But how can they know hope if they haven't seen the dark?
And I am the darkest of them all.

KILLIAN GRAVES

*I crave something no one can give.
I yearn for death, but he lets me live.*

I have secrets.
Dark, deadly, depraved secrets.
There's only one man who can give me what I crave.
And I'll do anything to make him mine,
even if it kills me.

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DEDICATION

Tania,

There will never be enough pages to write about how grateful I am for your unwavering support and friendship. Thank you for everything, always.

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IN THE BEGINNING

“A man has not truly lived until he has indulged in the delectable flavour of human flesh.”

- Arthur Phillip Kingsford during his murder trial in May 1990.

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BREAKING NEWS

Monday September 25th, 1995

BREAKING NEWS FROM IRON TOMB MAXIMUM SECURITY PRISON

ARTHUR PHILLIP KINGSFORD, the world's most prolific serial killer, was found dead in his prison cell in the early hours of Sunday morning. Our sources say guards found the serial killer known as *The Savage* unresponsive. No attempts were made to save Kingsford's life. Inside sources say that when the coroner arrived, the inmate's body was so badly beaten it was unrecognisable. No one has been held accountable, and detectives say there will be no investigations into the thirty-five-year old's death.

Mayor of Newhaven and governor of Iron Tomb Prison, Connor Monroe, declined interview requests, but said in a written statement,

At Iron Tomb we house the most violent offenders this country has ever seen. It is common for fights and riots to break out at any moment. Inmate deaths are inevitable.

Some say Monroe's blasé attitude towards inmate deaths is inhumane, while others praise the governor for his no holds barred stance.

After eluding police for almost 15 years, Kingsford's sensational arrest in May 1990, made headlines across the world. He was sentenced in June the same year to 187 consecutive life sentences after a killing spree detectives believe started in the mid-seventies. Arthur Phillip Kingsford was convicted of multiple counts of rape, necrophilia, cannibalism, and murder. His victims included 74 children between the ages of 2 and thirteen and three babies between six and twelve months old.

During their investigations, police made a shocking discovery when they found dozens of journals detailing Kingsford's crimes. In the journals, Kingsford listed the names and ages of each victim and admitted to performing lewd sexual acts on their corpses before dismembering them, and later consuming their flesh and organs. In his later journals, he wrote about regularly feeding his young son, Darius, human flesh disguised as pork to test whether the child would develop a taste for what *The Savage* called "a delicacy."

Shortly after his father's arrest, a then five-year-old Darius underwent numerous psychological assessments at Newhaven Asylum. A team of psychiatrists found Darius to be "*A quiet but aloof child of above average intelligence.*" It is believed the youngster will be placed in foster care in the coming weeks.

Newhaven—home to Iron Tomb Prison and Newhaven Asylum—is rampant with crime, corruption, and a slew of unsolved murders and missing persons. Once a bustling tourist town thanks to Ironbark Mountain's hiking trails, camping grounds, and wildlife reserves, the controversial opening of Iron Tomb prison in 1983, saw the population of Newhaven rapidly decline. A census conducted in April 1994 put the town's population at just 568 permanent residents.

In a public statement, Officer Jameson Oaks warned, "While we do everything in our power to maintain a solid police presence in the town, we strongly advise the public to avoid Newhaven and its surrounding suburbs."

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PART ONE

NATURAL BORN KILLER

*Through destruction and chaos I'll stay
I'll endure it all for you
An endless life of torment
If that's what I must do*

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I

*Inevitable Cruelty
They clipped off both your wings
Now the only time you cry
Is when the devil sings*

DARIUS KINGSFORD

Ten Years Old

1995

Prickly, dry, brown grass tickles my bare feet as I walk away from the dam at the back of our property. With Max in my arms, it's hard to push the gate to our fenced backyard open, and when I manage to shove it, Max's head bumps into it. His wet hair sticks to my skin, and it makes my lip curl into a snarl. I twist around to push the gate closed with my elbow, and that's when I hear my mum scream.

She's so loud that all the birds in all the trees around our farm squawk and flap their wings to fly into the sky. Mum's mouth is open into a big O, and I wonder if I can put my hand in there and pull out her tongue so she stops screaming.

"What have you done?" She cries and falls on the dirt near my feet. "Not my baby." Her hands wrap tight around my legs, making me wobble a little. She stares up at me with big, fat, watery tears in her eyes. When she tries to grab onto Max, I drop my arms and let him fall to the dirt in front of Mum.

She holds onto Max and shakes him very hard before she brings him close to her chest. His head drops to the side and dark red blood makes a puddle underneath him.

"No, no, no, not again," Mum cries. "They said you wouldn't do it again—Oh, oh, God no."

The steel door bangs against the side of the shed when my dad pushes it open and runs towards us. "What the fuck?" Dad rubs his dirty hands over his head. "Fuck," he shouts. From inside the house, my baby sister screams, and I scrunch my eyes because all the annoying screaming is making my head hurt.

“What did you do?” Dad’s fingers dig into my shoulders when he shakes me. “What the fuck happened?”

“Dunno, I found him near the dam,” I say. “Must’ve hit his head on a rock.”

He watches me for a very long time, his eyes go from my face to Max’s. Blood is all over my hands, and my white t-shirt is red and sticky. Some blood got on my face too, and I think that’s why Dad’s staring at me with his eyes squinty and his lips pressed into a flat line.

“Go inside,” Dad says to Mum. “Check on Maisy.” Mum puts her hands on Max’s face and kisses his head. She’s still crying when she runs inside. A few minutes later, my baby sister stops crying.

Dad kneels on the ground, one knee right next to Max’s bloody head. He puts his hand over Max like he’s going to touch him, but he pulls it back and in a different, quiet voice, he asks me, “How did this happen, mate?” His face is a little bit red. I think he might be sad or angry.

Doctor Benson says people get red faces or cry and have tears in their eyes when they are sad or angry, or sometimes when they’re scared. It would be good if the watery drips were red drops of blood. I blink my eyes and shake my head because I need to look at Dad to see if I can find out what he wants me to say.

Doctor Benson told me that Mum cries a lot because she doesn’t know how to help me. But I don’t need any help. I carried Max all by myself from the dam to the house, and I didn’t drop him one time.

I shrug. “Dunno,” I tell Dad. “Must’ve hit his head on a rock.”

The big bump in Dad’s throat moves up and down and he starts to say something, then he covers his mouth with his hand and squeezes his eyes shut. When he drops it away, he opens his eyes. “This isn’t from hitting his head on a rock, Darius. Do you think something else could have happened? Did you hurt Max?”

I look at my dad’s dark brown eyes and tell another lie. “No.”

Dad does a big sigh and stands up. He puts his hand on my shoulder again and squeezes it very hard. “Come with me.”

“Okay,” I say.

I follow Dad to the shed where he gets an old shovel. I watch Dad wrap Max in a white sheet and all the blood from his head comes through and makes big red patches. Dad doesn’t care, he keeps carrying Max to the tree where two, small, white crosses stick out of the ground. Sometimes,

Mum puts flowers on them, and sometimes she just sits on the grass and cries.

The rope ladder hangs down from the treehouse near the trunk. I watch it swing in the breeze while Dad is on his phone sending messages to someone. Dad shoves his phone into his back pocket and drops the shovel at my feet, then he crosses his arms over his chest.

“Start digging,” he says.

I dig the shovel into the dirt, but it’s very dry and it takes a long, long time to make a little hole that Dad says isn’t big enough. He goes back to the shed and gets a can of red spray paint. Dad sprays a red rectangle on the ground where he wants me to dig the hole. “You’ll stay here until this hole is done.”

“Okay,” I say.

Dad’s face goes all red and blotchy, and he slaps me hard across my cheek. I fall over and land on my butt. When I look up at Dad, his eyes are scrunched up and wrinkly, and his hands are in big fists like he’s going to punch me. He punches me all the time, so I’m not even scared.

“What the fuck is wrong with you?” he shouts. “I know you did this!” He walks back and forth, stomping his boots in the dusty dirt. “Why?” he shouts. “The dogs, the chickens, the fucking rabbit. The twins—Now Max. Why do you keep doing this?” He squats and pushes his fingers into his hair. “No amount of fucking money is worth this shit.”

I sit up and scratch my neck. It’s dirty and the sticky blood is all dry and crumbly now. I don’t tell Dad that my favourite colour is blood. I like it when the sticky, icky, dark red blood dribbles down my fingers and falls in big red drops on the ground.

“WHY?” Dad shouts and stomps towards me.

I shrug because I don’t know what words he wants me to say.

Dad leans down and grabs my t-shirt in his big hand to lift me up. My feet can’t touch the ground. “You fucking disgust me,” he says. “I don’t care what your doctor says, you’re a fucking psycho like your fath—We should’ve never agreed to this!”

“What’s a psycho?” I ask, but he doesn’t tell me, he only pushes me onto the ground again.

“Dig the fucking hole, and if you’re lucky, I won’t put you in there too.” Dad walks back to the house.

I get up and dig the shovel into the dirt again.

At nighttime when the sky is black and all the tiny little stars look like holes in the world, I lay down on the ground next to Max and put my fingers on his face. He's very cold and a little bit hard now, but he smells like blood and something else. I squeeze my eyes shut and do a really big sniff. Then I smile because I remember the smell from when I lived with my real dad.

It's the smell of dead things.
And I like it.

* * *

Three Days Later

"Oh my god, it's true, Betty," the old lady says.

"The whole family." The paper makes a crinkly sound, and the other old lady reads the page that has a picture of me on it. "On Saturday night, ten-year-old Darius Arthur Kingsford, son of infamous serial killer, Arthur Phillip Kingsford, was found wandering the Leader Highway just after one a.m., covered in blood and dressed only in a pair of pyjama pants. The ten-year-old was carrying a hunting knife and was said to be in a state of shock.

With no other suspects, or fingerprints found at the scene, detectives believe Darius is responsible for the murder of his foster parents, Kevin and Desi Sallow, and his infant foster sister, Maisy, who was reportedly found stabbed to death in her crib.

Less than twelve hours later, detectives made a shocking discovery when they uncovered the body of missing three-year-old, Max Sallow. Reported as missing by the Sallows twenty-four hours earlier, the toddler—who appeared to have died from a blow to the head—was found buried in a shallow grave beneath an oak tree on the couple's property.

The Sallows, who were well known for taking in troubled and abandoned babies and children, were no strangers to tragedy. Five years ago, their adopted twin daughters, Natalie and Jemma, were tragically killed when Darius pushed the twins' pram into a large dam on the property. After a lengthy investigation, the deaths were ruled accidental.

At just ten years old, Darius Kingsford could be charged as the country's youngest murderer in history."

"Oh my God, why wasn't he locked up sooner?" one of the old ladies says. "He's his father's son. Everyone should have known."

“Yes, yes, I agree, but...” The other one shakes her head. “God only knows what that monster did to that little boy.”

The white jacket that wraps around my body doesn’t let me use my arms. I tell one of the old ladies to take it off me, but she just stares at me with a wrinkly face and scrunched up eyes.

When the door opens, Doctor Benson comes in. She has a little bit of a smile, but her eyes are all scrunchy too. She closes the door and sits on the bed beside me. The old ladies smile at her then turn around to look at their computers.

“Hello Darius. Do you remember why you’re here?” Doctor Benson asks.

I wiggle my nose because it’s very itchy, but I can’t scratch it with my hands stuck in the jacket. “Because I made everyone bleed,” I say.

Doctor Benson writes something in her notebook, then she asks, “Can you tell me what happened?”

I shrug. “Dad doesn’t care what you think.”

“What did your dad say to make you think that?”

“I don’t fucking care what your doctor says, you’re a fucking psycho,” I say.

Doctor Benson stares at me for a long time. I think it’s because she forgot that I am good at remembering everything I hear and everything I see. It’s all stuck inside my head and it never, ever goes away. I even remember when a good lady came to see me one day. She told me that she knew my real dad, but he was going to prison for a long time, so I had to stay with Kevin and Desi and call them Mum and Dad.

“Can you tell me what happened the night you made everyone bleed?” Doctor Benson asks.

I shake my head to make the pictures of my real dad go away so I can tell Doctor Benson the things she wants me to say. “Mum and Dad were sleeping. I wanted to play with Dad’s pig-hunting knife. He always leaves it near the back door on a hook. It’s sharp.” I try to wiggle my fingers and think about how the knife felt in my hand, and how the blood smelled when it was dripping off my fingers, but Doctor Benson keeps talking to me.

“What did you do with the knife, Darius?”

“I did some cuts on things. The couch, my bed, some photos of the twins and Maisy and Max, and a cut on my leg.” I look down to see if I can

find where the cut on my leg is. I can't see it because the dumb nurse put a bandage and clean pants on me before they tied me up in this jacket.

"Then what happened?" she asks.

"I wanted to show Dad the blood on my leg, but he was sleeping, so I cut him. A big slice across his throat like when he bleeds and guts the pigs. It sprayed on my face, and some got in my eyes, but I wiped it with the blanket. Mum was snoring and it was making me angry."

"Did your dad try to stop you?"

My eyes feel itchy, so I blink very fast. "No. He put his hands up and covered his neck. A lot of blood was coming out and he made some weird noises. He had his eyes open, and he was looking at me. I told him I would dig a big hole so he could be dead next to Max."

"What happened to Max?"

"He's dead. Must've hit his head on a rock." I don't tell her the truth because she'll just keep asking "Why? Why? Why?" and it's so boring when I have to listen to her.

Doctor Benson makes a soft humming noise and writes some more in her book, before asking, "What about your mum? Did she wake up?"

"No. She takes medicine to make her go to sleep. Dad said Maisy is a difficult baby and Mum needs her rest. He said he'll give Maisy a bottle if she wakes up."

"How did your mum die, Darius?"

I squint my eyes because Doctor Benson should know how Mum died. "I cut her neck like Dad's. So much blood came out, but Mum didn't spray it all over me."

"Tell me about Maisy," Doctor Benson says.

"She's a baby, dummy. You saw her lots of times."

"I did. She was very small. Can you tell me what happened to her?"

"She was screaming, and the talking in my head was getting too loud. I punched it with my hand, but the talking didn't stop."

"Can you tell me what kind of talking was in your head?" she asks.

I nod. "It said kill the baby, kill the baby. If I don't kill the baby, he'll come back and break it into pieces."

"Who'll come back?" Doctor Benson asks.

I don't want to tell her any more about my dad or the talking in my head, so I shrug and keep telling her about Maisy. "I looked in the crib and

Maisy was wiggling like a worm with her mouth open. She had a jacket like this." I wiggle my shoulders but it's still too hard to move.

"A jacket?" she asks.

"Yeah. Mum said it's called a swaddle. Dad said it's a straitjacket for babies. The old lady said this one is a straitjacket. Can I take it off now?" I ask.

"No, I'm sorry, Darius, you need to leave it on."

"Why?"

"So you don't hurt yourself."

I laugh because that sounds stupid. "I don't wanna hurt myself. I wanna be the same as my real dad. I only wanna hurt other people and sometimes animals."

A gasping noise comes from one of the old ladies, but when Doctor Benson does a loud cough, they're quiet again. "Tell me more about Maisy," Doctor Benson says.

"I pulled off the swaddle thing and she rolled onto her tummy. Mum said babies need to be on their back, so I climbed in the crib and rolled her over. She was still screaming, and it was making me angry. I told her if she doesn't shut up, she's gonna be dead like Mum and Dad. She didn't listen. I hit her and hit her and hit her with the knife, and blood was everywhere, and my hands were slipping on the knife, but I didn't drop it." I smile like Mum used to do to Maisy. Mum said babies like seeing happy faces. Doctor Benson probably likes happy faces too.

When Doctor Benson doesn't say anything about my happy face, I stop smiling and huff through my nose.

"Darius, can you tell me why you killed your family?"

"No."

"Okay. Remember when we talked about feelings and emotions?"

I nod, remembering when I was little, and she told me what emotions are.

"When your family was bleeding; how did it make you feel?"

"Happy," I say.

"What about when Maisy was screaming?"

"Angry."

"And can you tell me how you feel now?"

I shrug. "It's boring here. I want to go home."

"Do you feel sad?" Doctor Benson asks.

“No.”

“Do you miss your family?”

“No.”

She does a little sigh, then writes down lots of words. When I lean forward to try to look at what she’s writing, Doctor Benson closes her notebook. “Darius,” she asks, “what makes you happy?”

“Dead blood.”

“What’s dead blood?” Her eyebrows scrunch up and make little lines between her eyes.

I shrug. “When people and animals are dead and not moving, or talking, or crying or screaming and all their blood is sticky and drippy. Have you smelled dead blood? My real dad likes dead blood. How long do I have to stay here?”

She crosses one leg over the other and shakes her foot. “A very long time. Does that make you sad?”

“I want to go home. Can I have a drink?” I ask.

“Not yet. At twelve o’clock it will be lunch time.” She looks at her watch. “It won’t be too much longer.”

“Can I take off this jacket?” I wiggle and twist and kick my legs, but I’m still stuck in the stupid jacket.

She shakes her head. “No, you can’t. A nurse will feed you and help you drink some water.”

“I need to pee,” I say.

Doctor Benson stands and pushes her notebook and pen into her bag. “Okay.” She looks over to the two old ladies. “One of the nurses can take you to the toilet.”

“I don’t want a nurse to take me. I’m not a baby.” I press my teeth together very hard and squint my eyes so Doctor Benson knows I’m angry.

She puts her hand on my shoulder, and I move away quickly so she can’t touch me. “You’ll need help to go to the toilet while you’re wearing this.” She pats my arm, and this time I stare at her and think about cutting her neck open with a big, sharp knife.

My angry face and staring aren’t working, so I let them stop and do another big smile before I let all my pee come out and it drip, drip, drips onto the floor.

Doctor Benson’s face does something weird, then she smiles a little bit. “The nurse will come and clean you up.”

“Okay,” I say.

When the nurse pushes me back to lay me on the bed and take my pants off, I do the biggest kick I can and my foot hits her face. She screams, and blood comes from her nose. I smile when she jumps back and covers it with her hands.

“I’ll kill you all,” I say, but no one cares. They just stand and stare at me, their faces all look the same, big eyes and open mouths.

“Call Doctor Monroe,” Doctor Benson says.

I kick hard, trying to make them all get bloody noses. A nurse holds me down, but I stop moving when I hear a voice I remember.

“Hello Darius, I’m Doctor Monroe. I’m going to help you go to sleep for a little while,” she says. It’s the good lady I met when I was little. She asks everyone to leave the room, and when the door closes, she comes very close to me. “Do you remember me, Darius?”

I nod. “You’re the good lady. Can I see my real dad now?”

“No, darling, he’s gone.” She pats my arm and does a very big smile. “Everything will be okay now, my little devil.”

There’s a sharp poke in my neck, and I stare at her. She says something else, but I can’t hear it because my eyes slowly close until I can only see black.

* * *

One Week Later

BREAKING NEWS

In the early hours of Sunday morning, a fire tore through Newhaven Asylum. It’s believed the fire started in the children’s wing and quickly spread through the hundred-year-old building. Two doctors and three children have perished in the inferno that took firefighters four hours to bring under control.

Doctor Loren Monroe, Director, and Head Paediatric Psychiatrist at Newhaven Asylum, spoke to reporters early this morning. “We are deeply saddened by the loss of life at Newhaven. A full investigation is underway into the events that caused the fire on Sunday morning.” Monroe went on to say, “Patients injured in the fire have been moved to surrounding hospitals, while others have been transferred to Parklake Psychiatric Hospital. Our

thoughts remain with the families of the deceased. At this time, the board has not discussed reopening or rebuilding the asylum.”

Just one week ago, Newhaven Asylum was thrust into the public eye when ten-year-old Darius Kingsford, son of serial killer, Arthur Phillip Kingsford, was admitted after allegedly killing his foster parents, Kevin and Desi Sallow and his two foster siblings, three-year-old Max, and two-month-old Maisy.

It's believed Darius was one of the children who perished in the fire.

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II

The House of Machiavellianism

DARIUS

Fifteen Years Old

2000

“Social hierarchy dictates each choice a human makes.” Chadwick’s intense stare sends a shiver down my spine. I remain still, hands clasped behind my back, and I listen intently as he continues, “At the top, like hunters watching over the land, are the rich and powerful. Each move we make is calculated, measured, and weighed to ensure the outcome benefits those of us deemed worthy.” His thick fingers, adorned with gold rings embedded with rubies and diamonds, wrap around his favourite crystal glass. After taking a sip of rum, he says, “Greed, envy, lust, and pride reign supreme. A smorgasbord of cardinal sin awaits us.”

I open my mouth to tell him I know what cardinal sin is, but when he raises his hand, I press my lips together and remain silent, remembering to wait for my turn to speak.

“At the bottom of the hierarchy are...?” he trails off, extends a hand towards me, and nods for me to complete his sentence.

Shoulders straight, I inhale, then exhale slowly. “The weak. The hunted. The prey,” I speak each word clearly. Chadwick expects perfection, and if I don’t give it to him, I will pay the consequences.

“Correct,” he says. “And what are the rules we must follow?” He stands and paces to the other side of the room.

I know the answer to this one, too, but my mind wanders when I hear the familiar sound spill from the antique gramophone. *Danse Macabre Op. 40* by French composer, Camille Saint-Saëns, plays softly. The music Chadwick calls “complex and haunting” evokes a sense of urgency as the tempo rises and falls. A thrill reaches into the marrow of my bones, and I wiggle my fingers and toes, trying desperately to ignore the pull of the music.

After swallowing down the lump in my throat, I reply to his earlier question, “No indiscriminate murder. Always remain calm and in control. Focus on the task at hand and leave only when that task is complete.”

“Why are you fidgeting?” he asks, relaxing back into his leather recliner. He has one foot resting on his opposite knee, and his left hand is clenched around the crystal glass of rum. Elbow on the arm of the recliner, he scrutinises me while he puffs on a thick cigar.

Before Chadwick and Loren adopted me, I had no idea of the breathtaking beauty of music and dance. The House of Machiavellianism has given me the opportunity to satisfy most of my desires, but there are times I want more. I yearn for the world outside, but for now, it’s forbidden.

Chadwick constantly reminds me that I’m lucky to have been one of the children he adopted into his prestigious, wealthy family, and that I should be grateful for everything he has given me.

I inwardly smile when I think about Salem and Liam, and how grateful I am that Chadwick and Loren took us in and raised us as brothers after a fire burned down Newhaven Asylum. The three of us, all patients in the children’s wing, were rescued by Loren and later listed as deceased.

In time, Loren will give us new identities, but for now, we need to remain hidden until our schooling is complete, and Loren decides we are ready to be integrated back into society.

When Chadwick clears his throat, I recall his question and admit, “The music, sir.” There is no use lying, he’ll see right through me. “It makes my body want to move... to feel. To dance.” I try exceptionally hard not to allow my lip to tilt into a smile when I mention dancing.

After inhaling the acrid smoke, he blows it from his lips in a cloud of misty grey fog. “And what have I told you about dancing?”

“Dancing is a reward. One I must earn.” My long, black, footless tights feel like a second skin as the urge to dance sends tiny buzzes of excitement through my veins. A voice in my head tells me to dance, to sway into the foreboding lull of the tritones that first drew me to the symphonic poem I cannot ignore.

Chadwick nods once before his eyes shift to look past me. The heavy wooden door behind me creaks open, and Loren steps inside. My eyes drop to her round belly. When she rubs her hand over it, I narrow my eyes, and a sharp, stabbing sensation pierces my chest.

Loren catches my attention and shakes her head slightly. “Darius,” she warns, reminding me to mask my emotions. When I nod once, she drops her hand from her belly, and smiling at Chadwick, says softly, “Darling, it’s time.”

I bite down hard on the inside of my mouth to ensure I show no reaction as Chadwick stands once again. He places a hand on my shoulder and squeezes it hard, his thick, strong fingers dig into my flesh. “Let’s go, Darius. We should never keep our guests waiting.”

Danse Macabre fades away as I follow Chadwick down the long, wide hallway. Pictures of his ancestors hang in ornate, gilded frames. The last frame holds a picture of Chadwick’s father, Connor Monroe who’s both the mayor of our town, Newhaven, and the governor of Iron Tomb prison.

My attention shifts when I enter the banquet hall where four, long rectangular tables are spaced evenly along the two side walls. Guests, dressed in long, black cloaks, sit on the sides against the walls, giving them an unobstructed view of the polished, black marble dance floor.

At another table at the back of the room, Loren sits alone, the two seats beside her remain empty. One is Chadwick’s, the other is mine.

Chadwick guides me to the centre of the dance floor and when we reach the middle, he leans down and whispers against my ear, “I expect perfection.”

I nod once and straighten my back as Chadwick heads to his seat.

When the lights dim and the music begins, I close my eyes to focus on the rhythm. I stretch my neck, rise up onto my toes and extend my hands high above my head to begin. The music plays, taking me away and sending my body and soul into another world. Every beat reverberates through my bones and comes out as a graceful, fluid movement. As the music grows sombre, I spin and twirl and glide across the dance floor and into the air, allowing myself to flow through each choreographed move.

When I dance, I am free from the constraints of this life, and in that freedom, I focus on the things I truly desire. Images fill my mind. Flesh, blood, death. Memories flicker, and dreams turn to reality as the music envelops me. As the images fall away, my focus returns and the fading music has my movements slowing. One last spin leads to me dropping gracefully into my final position. Knees on the floor, head down, and hands clasped loosely behind my back.

The lights that were dimmed when I began, brighten slightly as footsteps approach. Even with my eyes closed, I know who it is. Anticipation has me curling my fingers into my palms. The heavy weight of his stare causes my heart to race, a staccato-like beat that resembles the music I yearn for.

“It’s time,” Bruce, the butcher says in his deep, gravelly voice.

I extend my hands, palms facing up as I inhale, forcing myself to relax. To remember that here, I am allowed to feel the things I was told were wrong. I won’t be locked away in another white-walled room. I won’t be forced to talk about what’s good and bad. And I won’t have to explain for the thousandth time why the smell of blood, of death, of fear, makes my heart race, my mouth water, and my feet beg to dance.

Hushed whispers fall across the room before Chadwick clears his throat. “Darius, the time has come for you to be inducted into The House of Machiavellianism as a fully-fledged hunter and gatherer.”

I nod once, and when the cold knife is placed onto my palms, I stand slowly.

Chadwick continues, “Like your father before you, you have honoured us with your loyalty, and tonight, when you complete your final test, we will feast in your name.” When the soft applause dies down, he speaks my father’s words, “A man has not truly lived until he has indulged in the delectable flavour of human flesh.”

Eyes still fixed on Chadwick, I recall my lessons.

The House of Machiavellianism is a secret society created in 1985 by Chadwick and my father, Arthur Phillip Kingsford. To become part of The House, children of senior members must pass a series of four tests to determine our worth.

The first test is *The Hunt* where we are given a random name from the ballot. Guilt, innocence, age, race, or social status plays no part in the ballot. Nothing and no one are off limits. It is our responsibility to *hunt* our prey. Once we complete the hunt, we *Gather* our prey and bring it back to *The House*.

The *Kill* takes place in the banquet hall. Using the antique, bone handled knife gifted to us by our parents, we slit our prey’s throat and allow them to bleed out.

The butcher then slices and serves the carcass as part of the final *Feast*.

Chadwick is responsible for ending the lives of those who fail to complete just one of the four tests.

I stand slowly, folding my fingers over the solid, bone handle of the knife.

The butcher approaches again, this time his hands grip the sides of the wheeled table as he pushes it to the centre of the room. When he stops in front of me, I look into the wide eyes of the naked man stretched out and bound to the stainless-steel mortuary table.

Four days ago, five men and women were chosen from the ballot and released into the hunting arena behind Monroe Estate. Spanning one hundred acres of dense, Australian bushland between Monroe Estate and Newhaven Asylum, the arena's twelve-foot-high fences mean there is no chance of escape.

Along with four other inductees, I set out on the hunt with my own engraved silver hunting knife, gifted to me by Loren and Chadwick on my thirteenth birthday. Within an hour, I had captured, gagged, and hogtied my prey. After dragging him back to the gates, I hefted his body into the van, and Devin, the groundskeeper and cleaner, drove me back to the estate with my kill.

My prey's incoherent mumbling catches my attention. His pupils are huge and black, only a thin line of his brown irises are visible. I tilt my head, studying his features before I hear the familiar ting, ting, ting, of cutlery against crystal glasses. The sound travels around the room for exactly ten seconds before Chadwick says, "Begin."

The man on the stretcher wiggles, but the butcher strapped him down well, and he isn't able to free himself. I reach out and place my hand on his shoulder. "Thank you," I say, "For allowing me this privilege."

He makes some mumbling sounds that I ignore as I lift the knife. Tears fall from the corners of the man's eyes, his screams of terror muffled by a gag. I consider swiping the tears up with my fingertip and tasting them. *Do not touch.* I remind myself to focus on the task at hand. I need to make Chadwick proud.

But his tears.

His fear.

His blood.

What will he taste like before death, and after? My mouth waters when I think about tracing my tongue across the seam of his cold, pale lips. I allow my eyes to trail down the length of his body as a familiar sensation coils in the pit of my stomach.

When the butcher clears his throat, I ignore my wayward thoughts.

I point the tip of the knife to the man's throat then slowly drag it across, watching in fascination as his skin splits open, and thick, red blood spills from his neck. There's a gurgling sound as his nostrils flare and his eyelids flutter.

When his chest stops heaving and his panting breaths cease, goosebumps spread across my body. I shiver and inhale the rich essence of his lifeblood as it drains into the bucket beneath the table.

Bruce, the butcher, extends his hand. I reluctantly hand over the knife before bowing slightly then making my way to the main table to sit between Chadwick and Loren.

From my seat, I catch the attention of Salem. He raises a brow and smirks before averting his gaze. Beside him, Liam's eyes lock onto my kill, and he licks his lips. Like me, Salem and Liam have been junior members of The House of Machiavellianism for five years.

Last week we attended Liam's feast, and tomorrow night, it will be Salem's turn to bleed his hunt. As the youngest members of *The House*, we spend up to eighteen hours a day together. Loren says that learning about each other's strengths and weaknesses is imperative, and that forming strong connections and friendships with like-minded individuals, ensures The House of Machiavellianism's future success.

"Well done, Darius," Chadwick says, dragging my attention away from Liam and Salem. "Tomorrow night I'll allow you to dance at Salem's induction ceremony."

I stretch my mouth into a wide, toothy smile, but Loren pats her hand on my knee. "Not like that, darling," she says. "Like this, remember." I look up at her and try to match the small smile she puts on her face. "That's right, much better." She gives my knee another pat.

I watch as the butcher slices into the flesh using the carving knife. He cuts thin slivers of meat from the carcass and arranges them on a silver serving platter.

On the tables, tiny fires billow from beneath black cast iron pans. Every member of The House is here tonight, and I watch as they poke their forks into the flesh and place it onto the pans. The meat sizzles before they pop the delicious morsels into their mouths and hum in satisfaction. When Bruce serves me, I poke my fork into a piece of thinly sliced meat and bring it to my lips.

Chadwick places a hand over mine and gently lowers it. “No,” he whispers.

“Sorry, sir,” I mumble quietly before I reach out and drop the meat onto the pan, allowing it to turn a muddy shade of brown. Disappointed, I dip the meat into a small crystal dipping bowl that’s filled with a pungent, spicy mustard before I take a bite.

“Remember, Darius,” Loren says, “We are not heathens. We sear our meat before we consume it.”

“Yes, ma’am,” I say, nodding. I stab my fork into another piece of meat and repeat the process of searing it as little as I can get away with, dipping it into the mustard, then popping it into my mouth.

After dinner, there are a lot of discussions about the meat and the remaining carcass. Some of the guests purchase cuts to take home. The butcher prepares and wraps it before he places it into small, insulated boxes that will keep it fresh for their drive home.

“When’s the next free hunt?” a man whose name is Harold, asks Chadwick.

From the age of seventeen, members of The House are able to participate in ‘Free Hunts’. For one hundred thousand dollars, fully fledged members, and invited guests can hunt and kill human prey within the confines of the arena. Occasionally, Chadwick’s father, Connor, will use the free hunts to cull the inmates at Iron Tomb’s overcrowded prison.

“September thirty,” Chadwick says. “The details will be delivered tomorrow.”

Harold nods and smiles, then turns his attention to me. “You enjoyed your hunt and induction, boy?”

I turn to Chadwick, knowing I’m not allowed to speak to anyone unless he approves. When he nods, I face Harold. “Yes, sir, it was quite enjoyable.”

Little wrinkles form at the corners of his eyes when he smiles. “So, you’re fifteen, hmm. Same age as my boy.” He turns to Chadwick again. “Perhaps we can set up a get together for our boys. Lionel could use a friend like Darius to toughen him up.” Harold rubs at the thick, grey stubble on his jaw. “Even better, I’ll extend the invite to the other two young ones.” He waves a hand to where Liam and Salem sit. “I’d like to have Lionel join The House at some point, and the boys here would make perfect friends for my son.”

Loren clears her throat. "I don't think that's a good idea, Harold. The boys have extremely busy schedules that do not allow time for frivolous activities and childish exploits."

Chadwick raises a hand, a half-smile on his thin lips. It's the smile he has when he's going to do "*something stupid*." That's what Loren calls it.

"It's a marvellous idea," Chadwick says, patting the back of Loren's hand. "A few hours can't hurt, darling. Let them have a little fun."

* * *

One week later

According to Loren, it was not a marvellous idea.

I stand between Liam and Salem in Chadwick's office.

"I warned you," Loren says to Chadwick as he paces. "They are not like other boys. They haven't been socialised. This is your own fault."

She rubs a hand over her belly, and when anger rises in my chest, I blink once before shifting my attention to her face.

A small smile forms on her lips as she takes us all in. "These boys have far exceeded my expectations, but do not mistake me, Chadwick, they are *not* ready for inclusion into society. I told you I'd like to wait until they're eighteen."

Hands still clasped behind my back, I remain silent until Chadwick stops in front of me. "Tell me again what happened?"

I nod once and I repeat what I told Loren. "We were sitting on the roof of the woodshed. Lionel said, "*I dare you to jump*". When I said no, he said I was scared." I glance from the corner of my eye to see Salem staring straight ahead.

"I pushed him, sir," Salem says.

Chadwick shakes his head and lets out a heavy sigh.

"Go ahead, Darius, tell him the rest," Loren says.

"His leg was twisted, and a bone was sticking out." The memory causes a smile to tilt the corner of my mouth. "It was the tibia. He has lovely, creamy white bones. The break was so clean—"

"Darius! Focus," Chadwick scolds.

I clear my throat before explaining, "He was screaming and we told him to be quiet, but he wouldn't stop." I turn to look at Liam. He nods.

“Liam said we needed to put him out of his misery. That’s when I saw the axe by the woodpile.”

“What did I tell you boys?” Chadwick walks around to the opposite side of the desk again and drops down into his leather chair. When none of us speak, he says, “Well?”

“No indiscriminate murder,” I reply.

“And what does indiscriminate mean?” His eyes peruse each of us, stopping on Salem.

“Without careful judgement,” Salem answers.

“Did any of you use careful judgement?”

I nod once. “Yes, sir. Liam checked to make sure no one was around. Salem pulled off Lionel’s shoe and shoved his sock into his mouth so he’d stop screaming. I picked up the axe and cut his head clean off.”

Chadwick’s eyes grow wide. “Fucking hell!” he shouts, then lowers his voice. “Are you stupid, Darius? We have rules for a reason.”

I swallow the lump in my throat, unable to reply. Chadwick says we shouldn’t use foul language because it makes us sound unintelligent. He says language is used to communicate, and that communicating effectively shows others that we are above them, and worthy of the utmost respect.

Loren rubs Chadwick’s shoulder before she waves a hand dismissively. “Not to worry, Bruce and Devin have taken care of everything, including Harold. We can discuss the finer details after supper.” She walks towards the door, stopping when her manicured fingers wrap around the brass door handle. “Come along, boys, it’s time for your dancing lessons.”

I turn my attention to Chadwick, who sighs, waves his hand towards the door, and says, “Go on then.”

III

*Savages are screaming
You just cannot resist
They beg you for salvation
This is the catalyst*

DARIUS

Two Months Later

2000

Savages! The voices in my head wail. *Kill them!* She's dying. They're taking her life. *Kill them!*

"Please," she begs softly. Eyelids heavy, skin pale. "Help—" Blood pools between her thighs. "Call Chadwick, please."

One infant writhes, its skin pink and flushed. Another screams, its wide mouth devoid of teeth. They spare no thought for their dying mother.

A vague memory flickers.

"Tell me about Maisy."

Blood coats my fingers. Drips onto scuffed, hardwood floors.

"She was a baby..." My chest constricts with a reminder. *"Can I take this off now?"*

That was before the fire.

Before they took me in.

Before I knew the hedonistic pleasures that awaited me.

Another memory assaults me. I stumble, my hands splayed on the wall at my back.

"In five days, I'll come back to take you home."

"Can I call you Mum?"

"No, my little devil. You'll call me Loren, but I will love you like a mother should."

A warm hand on my chest.

A soft kiss on my forehead.

A smile.

Kill them! The voices are relentless as they drag me back to the richly decorated bedroom and the ornate, carved timber bed where she lies, writhing in pain.

“Don’t,” she whispers as though she can hear the voices in my head. Long, delicate fingers try to hold onto me, but her strength is waning. “Darius, my sweet, sweet boy. My little devil.” She speaks as though I am cherished. As though I am not on the verge of a massacre.

“Loren—” I swallow the lump in my throat. “Don’t.” For the first time in my life, salted droplets form at the corners of my eyes. I allow their descent. Relish in the trickle of tears... for her.

“Kill them,” I whisper.

She reaches down, hand patting at empty air before she finds the head of the firstborn infant. “No,” she says. “Please—” She’s cut off by a wet cough. “Sa—save them.”

I shake my head. Watch her blood soak already crimson sheets.

Umbilical cords still attached, the infants continue to scream. Large clots ooze thick, rich blood from between her thighs.

My mouth waters.

My fingers twitch.

Kill them.

Devour them.

Life fades from her eyes. Gentle fingers slip from my forearm. A blank stare is all that remains.

The savages fall into silence. Hands clenched into tiny fists, knees drawn up to small, heaving chests. Blond hair sticks to fragile scalps. Wide, pale blue eyes search for something... Comfort? Safety?

They will never find it here.

I tighten my fist around the hilt of my hunting knife and raise it in the air.

This is the catalyst.

PART TWO

HEDONISTIC PLEASURES

*And if the sky should fall
I'll fall with you too
There'll be nothing left on earth for me
So let me die for you*

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IV

*You beg for hope
But you're bathed in sin
And the dance of death begins
The moment you let me in*

DIABLO KING

*(previously Darius Kingsford)
30 years old*

2015

Human beings are inherently flawed. They are born to navigate the world on the cusp of death. One wrong move, one mistake—an accident, or a micron of the right—or wrong bacteria and they cease to exist. Easy to wound, easy to manipulate, and oh, so easy to kill.

Most of my life has been spent watching them closely, paying attention to their tells. A sideways glance filled with shame or self-loathing. A tic of the jaw to show their annoyance, or a flutter of lashes to show interest. Faces contorted in sorrow, in happiness, in pleasure.

Of course, I am merely mortal, like them.

The difference is, I have learned to manoeuvre my way through life with an ease brought about by wealth, knowledge, and power. No one approaches or questions me unless I allow it. I move through this town seamlessly because I am superior. They may treat me as another face in the crowd, but as I pass by, fear seeps from their pores, so pungent I can almost taste it. They feign ignorance and lie in the face of authority, all in an effort to protect themselves from me—from my family.

I see them.

I see all of them.

I watch them in the darkness, in the shadows, in broad daylight.

I've witnessed and committed heinous acts against innocent, and not so innocent victims. Watched as paedophiles, murderers, and rapists have been set free—released onto the streets to continue their monstrous deeds. I've followed them into back alleys and bedrooms, lured them into and out of the darkness. I've heard their confessions, their joy, their desires to sate their sickest needs.

They trust me because I am like them in so many ways.

My own hands are covered in blood, it's true, but I am nothing if not meticulous and exceptionally selective. Indiscriminate murder does nothing for me. Logic and reason play a part, no matter how small. I yearn for the complete experience. From that first glance of obliviousness to the final, exhilarating moment of sheer terror, and then my favourite part, the ultimate dance with death. The moment I inhale their last breath is when I become one with the lifeless corpse of my willing victim.

In the end, they all beg for death's final embrace. They beg for me.

"With this, I'll be able to track who interacts with the site. I'll add them to a register, and we can see where their interests lie." Salem's statement reminds me where my attention should be focused.

"Finding names and adding them to the ballot is Liam and Stefani's job. What's the point of this?" I ask, leaning over Salem's shoulder to take a closer look at the computer.

"Yes, it is. But Chadwick's ways of doing things are outdated now. We need to start thinking about the future of The House, and where we're headed. Chadwick won't be around forever." Salem brings up a bar chart and moves the cursor, circling the numbers on the screen. "Over eighty percent of Australians are online for at least six hours a day," he explains. "Kinks, fetishes, and paraphilias that were once considered taboo, and in some cases, illegal, are all over the internet now. People are searching these topics, seeking us out. They're flocking to Newhaven to explore their depravities, looking for like-minded individuals, or—" He pauses, tilts his head, and looks up at me, a sly smirk playing on his lips. "Looking for prey."

I rub my jaw, contemplating. "Hmm... So, we can find these people, guide them to us."

His lip quirks. "Absolutely. And we'll add them to the ones Liam and Stef are already tracking."

I turn over my thoughts, wondering what Chadwick would think of this. *He'd hate it.* The thought sends a thrill of excitement coursing through my veins. Anything that causes his perfect world to unravel even slightly, is always fine with me.

Salem goes on to explain how the website will work, and I watch as he brings it to life before my eyes. "Do you want to ask them any

questions?” He sits in my antique, wingback leather chair, elbows resting on the polished oak top of my desk. Tilting his head ever so slightly, he awaits my reply.

I look over the details, satisfied. “No. No questions.”

He drops his gaze back to the monitor and continues tapping at the keyboard, a rapid eighty-eight words per minute. As Salem sets up the secret, encrypted site buried deep in the dark web, I cross my arms over my chest and watch intently.

A few minutes pass before he taps the enter key one more time. “Done.” Leaning back into the chair, he crosses his legs and pushes the chair back from the desk. “Take a look.”

I lean over to read the white text on the black screen.

DANSE MACABRE

Are you struggling to find someone who understands you?

We offer experiences, treatments, and cures for the most depraved paraphilias. You no longer need to suffer in silence or hide your true self away. Find the cure to what ails you or come dance with the devil and fulfil your wildest dreams.

diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

A slow smile curves my lips as I hum in satisfaction. “Perfect,” I tell Salem. “Now, let’s go, we have work to do.”

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V

*A willing victim
You crave the pain
Will you come
When he calls your name*

KILLIAN GRAVES

24 years old

2024

Current Day

The first blow lands with a sickening thump against my chest, sending me to the floor. I struggle to catch my breath. Erratic gasps spill from my lips in whispers of pain.

Gavin's enraged voice rings in my ears. "Four fucking times and you expect me to believe you're not responsible for this shit?" he shouts, twisting the neck of my t-shirt in his fist. The second blow slams into my face, grazing across my mouth and splitting my lip.

I scramble back as a trickle of blood oozes from my mouth. "I—I'm sorry," I say, raising my hands in an attempt to placate him as I press my back against the wall.

Twelve months ago, after Gavin pimped me out to Allen Young—a straight, married, politician's son—two masked men burst into the dingy hotel room and dragged him off me. With a knife to his throat, Allen pissed himself as he pleaded for his life.

One man straddled me, the weight of his body held me face-down on the bed. "Watch," he whispered against my ear.

Head pressed into the sweat stained pillow, I obeyed and watched with morbid fascination as the second masked man pulled Allen's head back and slit his throat. Blood spilled from the gaping wound and rushed in a river of dark red down Allen's chest before he ever had the chance to scream.

"Go home, Killian." The one who'd held me down on the bed spoke with a calmness that didn't fit the scene. Allen's bloody body was splayed out on the beige carpet like a sacrifice to some long-forgotten deity.

Dressed head to toe in black, and with balaclavas covering their faces, the men appeared as covert assassins, and I wondered if Gavin had

sent them to try to scare me. Some of my proclivities were no secret to Gavin, he used them against me regularly, and had a long list of clients ready and willing to use me however they saw fit.

There was something uncannily familiar about the murderer, though. The way he stood by, a strong, unforgiving presence looming over his kill, set my heart racing.

After that first night, four more men were murdered within minutes of meeting me. Each time the scene was the same. The first man held me down while the second man slit their throats. Afterwards, I was ordered to *“Go home.”*

At first, Gavin brushed it off as a vigilante group targeting cheating spouses, but this last death has put him on edge, and he’s becoming suspicious of me.

Gavin’s hand wraps around my throat like a vice, bringing me back to the present. “One more time...” He presses his body against me until there’s no space between us. “One more, and you’re fuckin’ dead, Killian, you hear me? Clients are backing out, that means you’re losing me money.”

I bite down hard on my tongue and force myself not to react to the intense pleasure building inside me at his venomous threats. Gavin knows me too well. With a sinister chuckle, he lifts his chin and shoots me a knowing smirk. My cock, trapped between us, betrays me by throbbing against his thigh. I let out a pathetic whimper.

“You sick little fuck,” Gavin sneers before a wide smile stretches across his thin, chapped lips. “I’ve got the perfect job for you.”

He steps away from me, pacing as he texts someone before he settles back into his chair behind the desk. “Get yourself cleaned up and prepared, a car will be here in ten.”

As he looks me over with his dark, calculating eyes, I know pain and degradation are coming. The type of pain I’ll feel for days, if not weeks.

As I head to the shower to prepare, a flicker of desire envelops me. Will the men in black find me tonight? Memories of the murderer flood my vision, and in the shadows of my mind, I cling to them with desperate hope.

An hour later, an Uber drops me off at a lone warehouse. It sits on an empty street in an old industrial estate. “This is a dangerous area, mate, you sure you want to be dropped off here?” There aren’t many Uber drivers

willing to venture this far from the city centre, and although his concern is warranted, I wave him off as I step out of the car.

The town of Newhaven is a shadow of its former self. Its streets are lined with dilapidated buildings and abandoned stores with shattered windows. Where footpaths once laid, cracked concrete and deep potholes have taken their place.

On the outskirts of town, empty warehouses have been condemned, taken over by nature, graffiti adorns the steel walls. Bright, bold colours against bleak, grey eyesores.

The thick forests that surround the town create an eerie, isolating atmosphere, while razor wire fences warn of the danger within. Despite the decay and decline, the city centre bears all the marks of a prosperous society. Old, Victorian style buildings stand tall, their ornate facades and arched windows stand out against the desolate surroundings.

During the day, Main Street bustles with activity, and is home to quaint cafés, bakeries, supermarkets, and an expansive shopping centre. There's a calm beauty on the outside, but when the sun sets and darkness reigns, morality disappears into the shadows and the dark underbelly of Newhaven comes to life.

Further out from the city centre, sprawling estates and stately mansions belong to the wealthy elite who have found refuge in Newhaven's isolated location. For them, the town is a literal haven where they can indulge in violence and depravity without fear of repercussions.

For most residents of Newhaven, life is so far from idyllic it doesn't make the scale. Crime runs rampant through the streets, aided by corruption and the ever-present threat of violence. The notorious Iron Tomb Prison is overcrowded and plagued by riots and escapes on a regular basis, and the understaffed police department does little to nothing to instil confidence in a community that has lost all faith in authorities.

Despite the dangers and hardships, tourists still flock to Newhaven in droves. They come to explore the rubble on the outskirts of town, or take part in midnight tours of the abandoned asylum. Some come seeking drugs, prostitutes, and other illicit activities. Then there are those with Bonnie and Clyde syndrome—otherwise known as hybristophilia—who are intent on discovering the sordid history of Newhaven Asylum, the town, and the eight serial killers behind the bars of Iron Tomb prison.

Amidst all this chaos and strife, the poor suffer the most. They live in fear and poverty, relegated to run-down apartment complexes and boarded-up houses. Desperation drives them to scavenge for scraps to survive, while the homeless live in rat-infested squalor.

Prostitution, human and drug trafficking, and black-market organ trades are all too common in this forgotten corner of society. For the residents of Newhaven, danger and uncertainty are a part of daily life, their survival dependent on navigating through a city that has become an almost dystopian wasteland.

The car engine rumbles, the headlights fixed on the warehouse ahead of me.

I slap the roof of the car a couple times. The driver takes off, tail lights disappear into the night. My heart pounds with anticipation as I approach the dark building.

A single, dim light casts a soft glow above a wide roller door with a small, narrow door beside it. My hand trembles as I reach for the buzzer, excitement and adrenaline coursing through my veins.

The sound of footsteps comes from the other side of the door. It's unlocked and pulled open by a tall, heavy-set man dressed in faded blue jeans and a navy polo. He eyes me suspiciously, gaze roving over my body before he stops at my face.

"Gavin sent me," I say, shoving my hands into the pockets of my jeans.

His jaw tics once. "You'll do." The man, who introduces himself as Ray, gestures for me to follow him inside.

We make our way through a maze of strategically placed pallets until we reach a room sectioned off by a large, steel workbench and stacked cardboard boxes. A cloud of cigarette smoke lingers in the air where three men sit around an old, worn table covered in empty beer bottles and pizza boxes. They leer at me, hungry predators eyeing their prey.

"That's Craig, Paul, and Jim," Ray points to each one before turning to me.

"So, you're one of Gavin's boys, huh?" Craig asks. "The one who likes it rough, yeah?"

I only nod, used to playing the meek, submissive boy. They drink it up, their eyes filled with lust.

Jim, a bald man with a long, grey goatee, scratches at his chin. His eyes roam over my body. "Is that true, boy? You like it rough?"

I shrug, avert my gaze, and reply quietly, "Yes, sir."

Jim grins viciously before ordering me to strip naked. As I do, my mind is once again consumed with thoughts of the men in black. There's a part of me that yearns to see them again, but if Gavin keeps losing money, he'll let me go. Without this job, I'll need to find other ways to sate my sick, twisted desires.

"Boy!" Jim's voice catches my attention as he approaches with a coiled length of rope and a large black bag. My heart quickens at the sight of the bag, wondering what horrors it holds inside.

"Get over here," Ray barks, swiping his hand across the table and sending bottles and cans crashing to the ground. He orders Jim to tie my arms behind my back. Craig stands in front of me, his hot, sour breath makes me recoil in disgust.

With a wicked smile, Craig declares that Gavin gave them one rule. "You gotta be alive when we leave. Alive, *not* unharmed." He laughs, his yellow teeth showing between cracked lips.

Remembering Gavin's instructions to act like "*a scared submissive slut*," I flinch and look down, feigning a fear I don't feel. I'm wired with anticipation for what's to come.

They bend me over and tie me spread eagle to the end of the table, and excitement courses through my veins. One of the men smacks my bare ass, eliciting a hoarse cry that tethers me to the present where I can forget about the men in black and embrace the debaucherous pleasures that await.

A sharp crack rings through the air. A leather whip slices across my back, sending waves of searing pain pulsing through my body. There's no space to breathe between the cracks of the whip, and while I relish in the pain, my fake cries are drowned out by the sounds of the men laughing and cheering on the brutal assault.

Before I can catch my breath, rough fingers dig into my hips and a slick, hard cock is thrust inside me without warning. I gasp in shock and agony as it tears through me, leaving me trembling and writhing. A sharp, stabbing pain pulsates through my ass and into my lower back and abdomen.

Thrust after merciless thrust, the man takes pleasure violating me. Drops of sweat drip from my hairline as emotions war inside me. *Hurt me.*

Kill me. I want to beg, but something stronger tugs at my subconscious and tells me it's not time.

Not yet. Not yet. Not yet. Muffled voices in the back of my mind warn me.

When another man takes his place, the vicious pounding starts over.

The cycle repeats until all four men have had their turn, each one leaving behind a trail of destruction. For as long as I can remember, I've been used and discarded. Slivers of my life torn away piece by piece, each loss decimating yet another part of my humanity.

Logic and reason always tell me to fight, to scream, to run and never look back. The part of me that's eternally broken, tells me I need this. That I want and deserve everything I get, and more. That part always wins, hands down.

Against the hard wood of the table, sweat and precum creates a slick, wet surface beneath me. My cheeks heat with shame. I shouldn't want this, shouldn't enjoy it.

Finally, they untie my legs and shove me to the cold, hard ground. My knees hit the concrete with a thud, tiny slivers of broken glass dig into my flesh.

Before I can gather myself, Craig steps forward with a sadistic smirk. "Would you look at that," he says, loud laughter follows. "Dirty bastard's getting off on it. Look at that hard little prick."

He presses the toe of his boot against my erection and laughs at my obvious arousal. Instead of kicking me in the balls like I expect—and brace myself for—he shoves his cock into my mouth and begins thrusting roughly. The assault doesn't last long, and when he steps back, Ray takes his place. He holds his limp dick in his hand, and with a filthy sneer on his pockmarked face, he proceeds to piss on me.

The rancid stench of urine smothers my face and chest. I gag when bile rises in my throat. Clamping my eyes shut, I turn away from the hot stream only to be punched in the jaw.

Ray's manic laughter follows. "Open your mouth and take it, slut," he demands.

"Nah, Ray, let's hang him from the meat hook," one of the other men says. I don't know who's who anymore. Their faces blur in and out of my vision between slaps and punches that leave my head spinning and my body aching.

I'm dragged across the rough concrete, the sensation like a cheese grater grazing my thighs and ass. Minutes later, I'm hanging by the rope tied around my wrists.

For what feels like hours, I'm lashed, beaten, fucked, and assaulted. The screams they pull out of me are real, but they're not from fear, they're screams of rage. I'm so fucking sick of being at the mercy of these men, of Gavin... of my desires.

I want to give in.

I want to let go.

My head hangs low, chin against my chest as tears mix with the saliva and blood dribbling from my split lips. When I get out of here, I'm going after what I want, and I won't rest until I get it—*until I get him*.

My body's survival instincts finally kick in and take over. Legs kicking out, I sway back and forth, lashing out at the men who jeer and chant as I hang limp.

I wanted this. I remind myself. But there's a deep sense of apprehension because, yes, I want to die, but not yet, and not like this. My twisted mind imagined a different scenario. A different man.

Memories flicker, transporting me back to the night I first laid eyes on the man who quickly became my obsession.

My parents splayed out on the bed.

Their throats slit.

Bloody sheets.

My brother's pleas.

The glint of the knife.

I will make him mine.

"Fuck, Craig, look, he's leaking all over the damn place," he says, "alive but broken sounds pretty fuckin' good to me, guys. What do you think?"

As the hook is lowered, my legs are spread wide and I'm impaled on a hard, dry cock. "You like that, huh? You like me fucking you raw and dry, tearin' up this tight ass. Gonna make you bleed, boy."

A cock is forced between my lips. "That's it, take it ya dirty rat. Yeah, suck my fat cock."

Tears stream down my cheeks and beads of sweat sting my eyes. Panting breaths saw in and out of my heaving chest. A third man's

punishing grip strokes my painfully hard length until I'm pleading with them to let me come.

Laughter is the only response I get. The physical and emotional assault takes its toll, and before I know it, I'm sobbing relentlessly. Instead of wanting to come, I beg them to stop. Laughter continues until I'm being hosed down with a high-powered pressure washer. The icy blast feels like thousands of tiny needles piercing my already damaged skin.

As I hang there, barely conscious and covered in blood and body fluids, bile rises in my throat seconds before I vomit. The overwhelming stench assaults me, and another bout of vomiting ensues. "Please, let me—"

My pleas are cut off when a loud crash has the men frantically huddling in the corner. "The fuck was that?" one of them whisper-shouts.

"Go check it out," another says.

I blink away the gritty sensation in my eyes, wishing I could rub them. Another few blinks and my vision is clear enough for me to see through thin slits. I think it's Jim—staring at me, eyes wide with what appears to be terror. A second later, a wave of red sprays into the air and when I blink again, Jim is headless. His whole fucking head is gone. I watch with sick fascination as his body falls in a heap, inches from my dangling, bare feet.

A dark shadow comes into view. A man, dressed in black, a balaclava covering his face. Head tilted to the side, I'm certain I see a hint of amusement in his dark eyes, but my eyelids are so heavy I can barely keep them open.

"Looks like you got yourself into a bit of trouble, Killian." The voice is deep, raspy, unfamiliar but welcome. His clothed body brushes against my naked, sensitive skin and a gloved hand comes up to cup my cheek. "You're playing a dangerous game," he says, his breath hot against my split, bleeding lips.

For long, drawn-out seconds, the man breathes against my jaw as though he's inhaling my ragged breaths. I open my mouth to speak—nothing but a needy whimper escapes. My cock gives a valiant twitch. Aching desire and perverted desperation claws its way through the haze of pain.

The hand that was soft against my cheek seconds ago, squeezes my jaw in a punishing grip before it drops away and gloved fingertips trail

down my torso. When the warmth of his body and the caress of his fingers disappear, a cold chill sends a shiver down my spine.

My eyelids refuse to open. “Knew you’d come,” is all I manage before my body becomes weightless and I’m carried away on a cloud of emptiness.

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VI

*Whispers in the darkness
You pray for sweet release
Help me now, you plead
Cure this disease*

DIABLO

39 years old

Three days later

“You—you said you’d help us,” the man says, confusion creases his sweat covered brow.

“I did, didn’t I. And here I am, striving to give you the best service possible, Mr Stanton.”

A spray of blood spurts across the ceiling. It’s followed by a heavy thud. Glancing down at the blood-spattered tiles, I watch the head, covered in a mass of thick, black hair, roll towards me before I give it a kick with the side of my boot. It spins a few times then stops and comes to rest against the stark white wall, dead eyes stare into an empty abyss.

I shift my focus back to Mr Raymond Stanton, the near naked man I have hanging from the old steel pipes, squealing like the pig he is. Thick chains bind his wrists and a butcher’s hook holds him in place.

“As I was saying—”

Another thud.

A scream of agony.

“Salem...” With all the calm I can muster, I ask, “A little silence please?”

“You hear that, Craig? The boss wants you to quiet down a little.” Salem grabs the bound man’s jaw between his thumb and fingers and squeezes. “Now, if you can’t be quiet from here on out, I’ll have to take your tongue.” The tip of the blade is forced between the man’s quivering lips. Blood-streaked saliva dribbles down his jaw. “Would you like that, Craig?”

Craig, one of the three violent gang rapists we’ve had caged in the basement for three days, shakes his head, moaning and groaning as he continues to drool from the corners of his mouth.

These fools truly believed they'd get away with using and abusing what belongs to me. Of course, my precious Killian doesn't know it yet, nor do they, but *he will* be mine. Mine to hunt. Mine to bleed. Mine to kill.

Gavin will pay dearly for his part in this little escapade, too. I make a mental note to pay the wannabe crime boss a visit to remind him whose streets he's currently living on.

As I turn my attention back to my unwilling victim, there's a wild, high pitched shriek of delight before an arm lands at my feet. A finger twitches once, blood oozes from the freshly severed limb.

Turning slowly, I raise a brow and take a step towards Stefani and her victim—I think his name was Paul—who's so far lost his head and both arms. "Stefani—"

She spins on her five-inch heels, a toothy grin between bright red lips. A bloody axe in her hand and fresh blood trickling down her forearm, she asks, "Something wrong, boss?"

"Keep it down. I'm trying to have a conversation with Mr Stanton here." I lift my chin towards said man whose eyes are wide.

Stefani nods. "Yes, boss."

"You're all fuckin' psychos, lemme go! That kid wanted everythin' he got! Fuckin' begged for it." Raymond shouts and writhes as his body swings like a pendulum, legs kicking out at empty air. The man spits out a glob of blood that lands on my polished leather boots.

"Fuck you, asshole! People are gonna come looking for me, and when they do—"

He stops talking when I raise my head and glare at him. Knife in hand, I drag the blade all the way down his torso, leaving behind a raw, open wound and a trail of blood.

Garbled pleas and screams of pain continue to spill from the rapist's mouth. I tuck the sharpened tip of my knife into the waistband of his stained underwear. He's already pissed himself twice, and the stench of urine assaults my nostrils.

"And when they do?" I ask with a wave of my hand, motioning for him to continue. "What will they do, Raymond? Please, enlighten me."

His eyes dart around the room, panic stricken. His hairy, bloody chest heaves, and the pulse in his neck flutters as terror courses through his veins.

In the corner, Salem is now chopping his victim into pieces before shoving most of the remains into the large cremation oven. The flank, thighs, and heart are carefully packed and placed into ice boxes that will be delivered to the butcher and prepared for our next feast.

In the middle of the room, Stefani hefts her victim's torso onto a stainless-steel mortuary table. Humming to herself, she uses a surgical saw to cut through the rib cage and remove the chest plate. There's a beat of welcome silence as I watch her remove the heart from the chest cavity.

"No, no, no, fuck, lemme go!" Raymond shouts, "Please, please—"

"Hush now. There's no need for all this useless shouting." I tug his filthy underwear down with the tip of my blade. He bucks wildly, twisting and turning as he tries to avoid my knife that's pointed directly at his shrivelled dick.

"Y—you, you said—you said you'd hel—help us," he stutters, and I sigh.

"Raymond." I click my tongue in annoyance. "Can't you see? I am helping you. I'm going to cure you."

With a gloved hand, I pull his dick away from his groin and tug on the limp appendage until he cries out. From the corner of my eye, I catch a glimpse of Stefani watching intently. She licks her lips, smirks, then goes back to rummaging through the chest cavity of her limbless torso.

"No, no, please no. Wha—What do ya want? Money? Drugs? I can get anythin' ya want, jus' lemme go." His begging and pleading falls on deaf ears. Instead of replying to his incoherent babbling, I drag my razor-sharp blade across the base of his dick and slice it clean off.

A blood curdling scream comes from deep in his lungs. "This is what happens when you touch what belongs to me." Before he can take another breath and start screaming again, I shove my knife into his throat and slice through his carotid artery and jugular vein in one swift movement. As Raymond bleeds out, I walk over to Stefani and hand her the severed dick.

Smiling, she lays it on the mortuary table alongside the other two. "They're perfect for my collection," she says, bouncing on her toes. "We should celebrate."

"Good idea," I say. "I need to make a few calls first," I remind her. Stefani's smirk morphs into a full-blown smile as she stares at me.

"Say it," I state without emotion. "I know you're dying to."

“Your boy... he’s so pretty.” A dreamy expression smothers her face, making her look younger than her thirty-four years. “I can’t wait to taste him.”

Salem snorts out a laugh, and I turn my back on the heathens who know me far too well. I allow a small smile to dance across my lips.

Taste.

Devour.

Kill.

I shake off the thoughts, and with a blank expression back in place, I turn and say, “Let’s get this mess cleaned up and get out of here.”

With the three of us in agreement, we get to work disposing of the bodies and hosing down the room.

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VII

*Embrace the shadows
Don't light the flame
Give into the darkness
That whispers your name*

KILLIAN

Two weeks later

My best friend, August drops down onto the sofa beside me, handing me a bottle of water. "How are you feeling?" he asks.

I take a mouthful of water and nod. "Good actually, ready to get back out there."

"You don't want to take some more time? I can tell Gavin you're not ready," he says, rubbing a gentle hand on my thigh.

I shake my head. It's been two weeks since I was released from hospital. My body has healed and the bruises have faded, but August's overprotective streak is becoming tiring.

While August was out grocery shopping this morning, Gavin stopped by to tell me in no uncertain terms that if I wasn't back on the streets tonight, I'd be cut loose. This house I live in with August is one of the perks of working for Gavin. Getting kicked out would mean being homeless, and in Newhaven, that's a death sentence.

We live here rent free, and in return, Gavin gets to decide what we do with our bodies, and who we do it with. Although, with August being older, and having been around longer, he gets a lot more leeway than I do.

"I'm fine," I assure him, but the truth is, my mind is still spinning from the night four men used and abused me. And it's not fear, it's *his* voice. It's embedded into the depths of my soul, caught on a loop in the grey matter of my brain. Branded into the marrow of my bones, his voice haunts me in my sleep, and calls to me in daydreams.

Before I knew his name, I was infatuated. When I discovered who he really was, there was an intense, dire need to know more. Now that I've heard his voice, I'm obsessed.

I knew the killer in black was familiar. He's the same man I've been stalking for six long years.

Diablo King murdered my family.

He should terrify me. The man exudes danger. He has no qualms about committing cold blooded murder while I watch on, a helpless, but all too willing observer.

“Email him,” August urges, “I know you want to.”

I smile, rubbing my thumb across the black business card in my hand, tracing the embossed email address.

diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

When I left the hospital, the nurse gave me an envelope with my discharge papers and a copy of my blood test results. I didn’t open it until I got home, that’s when I found the glossy, black plastic card. There’s no logo, no business name, and no other details.

Diablo.

He’s given me a way to contact him.

Propping my feet up on the old timber coffee table, I bring up my email app and start typing.

* * *

Email to: diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

Subject: Your card

Hi, I got your card.

Can we talk?

Killian

* * *

I press send. “Done,” I say to August, who only smirks.

I leave my phone on the coffee table and head to the bathroom for a shower. While I stand beneath the stream of hot water, steam fills the bathroom, and I drift into relaxation.

If anyone were ever able to look into the deep, dark recesses of my mind, they’d be horrified by the thoughts of violence and depravity that comfort me when the rest of my life is tumbling into the abyss. The more I fight against those thoughts, the more they consume me. Not a day goes by where I’m not thinking about death. And it’s not fear of the unknown or a sense of impending doom. It’s a longing. A dream shrouded in anticipation. I covet death the way others crave life.

I am consciously aware that what I feel is not normal—I'm not normal.

At night, the shadows whisper my name and fill my head with visions of murder and violence. I am a prisoner of my own twisted nature, condemned to wander the world as an outcast.

Self-control and the fear of getting caught and going to prison are the only things stopping me from becoming a murderer. There is no escape from the darkness that dwells inside me.

Eighteen years old

"Killian!" Gavin's harsh tone drags me away from my thoughts and back to the dank room where the scent of sex, weed, and cheap whiskey lingers.

Kaspian stares up at me from the bed, his eyes glazed over and glassy, lips slightly parted. His wet, pink tongue darts out and glides across his bottom lip.

It's like staring into a mirror. My own face reflected back at me, the same but somehow so fucking different I can't believe we used to be mistaken for one another. When I dyed my hair black, Gavin was furious, but it was the only way I could separate myself from the boy I shared a womb with. My plan backfired spectacularly when Gavin Rafferty started pimping us out as a pair. The Devil and The Angel.

In the beginning, it was our parents, along with Gavin's help, who made a small fortune selling videos and photographs of us on the dark web. Thanks to their drug addictions, the money slowly dwindled away. A few days after our thirteenth birthday, our parents handed us over to Gavin in return for an unlimited supply of drugs.

"Kill," Kaspian whispers. I blink once, then twice. In Kaspian's eyes I see longing and desire, and a need so desperate it will never be satiated.

In my eyes, there is nothing. I learned early on to keep my emotions in check. To look at people with nothing more than apathy and indifference. Everything I've endured since childhood has been branded into the marrow of my bones. My placid façade is a farce. One I'll continue until I find someone who will give me what I so desperately desire.

“Harder, Kill,” Gavin calls from behind me. “Gotta make this client happy.”

I squeeze my eyes shut. The spotlight directed at the single bed is so bright it warms my back as I thrust into Kaspian, my cock buried deep in his tight, firm ass.

I hate him.

I hate his body.

I hate his voice.

I hate his fucking face.

A flood of bile rises in my throat, burning with the acrid taste of revulsion. It clings to my tongue, a corrosive poison refusing to be swallowed. My stomach lurches as the ever-present voices in my head begin their chanting. “Do it, Killian. Give in to your desires.”

On the outside, I continue to go through the motions. Inside, my heart pounds like the beat of a war drum. The weight of Kaspian’s gaze bears down on me. The too-soft caress of his fingertips like slithering eels across my skin.

“That’s it, keep going, boys,” Gavin praises us. “Good, you’re doing good.”

I rein in my rage. Remind myself to make it through yet another scene so that I can call my best friend, August. I need to get out of this house before I lose what’s left of my sanity.

Gavin continues calling out instructions. There’s a list he uses when we record. Some of the sick fucks who watch our videos have been following our lives since we were children. Others stopped when we reached puberty. Each time we go live, there’s a slew of comments, messages, requests. Anything and everything the sickos want, Gavin ensures they get.

Nothing is off limits. If it’s not videos, we’re standing on street corners, pimping out our bodies to anyone willing to pay. We’ve been fucked, raped, beaten, and degraded, too many times to count by both men and women over the course of our short lives.

Kaspian slowly became obsessed with me, and I slowly but surely grew to despise his very existence. I withdrew into myself, and at fourteen, I realised I no longer felt pain the way Kaspian did. I didn’t flinch at the beatings, the rape, the torture.

I craved them.

Something inherently sinister had taken over my soul.

I wanted to die, and I wanted to kill.

I needed pain the same way my parents yearned for the coke they snorted until their nostrils bled. I became a talented actor. Gavin doesn't know that I dream of slitting his throat and bathing in his blood. Or that some nights, I wish he'd do the same to me. He thinks I want pain, but I want so, so much more.

I've turned into a shell of a human being. Someone so desperate to feel, I seek danger wherever I can find it. I want to be touched while simultaneously loathing the sensation of anyone's hands on my skin.

Every day I use people the way they've continually used me. I trick them into thinking I'm happy to go along with their plans. I manipulate every conversation, every interaction.

"Kill," my brother whisper-shouts against my ear. "Fucking concentrate!"

Gritting my teeth, I twist my fingers through his thick, blond curls and give a harsh tug on the soft strands until he winces in pain. Then, I pound into his ass until the only sound I can hear is flesh slapping against flesh. When I glare into my brother's eyes, his are filled with a sheen of tears. All that does is force me to thrust harder.

"Good, good," Gavin says from behind me. "Slap his face, Killian."

Kaspian's eyes narrow and his lip trembles when a grin stretches across my lips.

"Don't," he pleads before the smack of my open palm against his pale cheek causes a blush of red to bloom across his too-pretty face. Tears spill from the corners of his eyes.

I slap him again, then once more for effect, and of course, because I despise everything about him. Each breath I take is tainted with the putrid stench of loathing.

"CUT!" Gavin calls.

A few seconds later the room is bathed in a bright, white light. The door opens with a creak and whispered conversations begin as I pull out of Kaspian without any care. Ignoring his wince and the hand that reaches out to grab mine, I walk stark naked to the small, dingy bathroom and turn on the shower.

From the bedroom, Gavin calls, "Get cleaned up, Kill, you're back out at eleven."

With the water as hot as possible, I shove the mouldy shower curtain aside and step into the filthy cubicle. I grab the nailbrush and start scrubbing at my skin until the pain receptors in my brain finally awaken, and a sensation of calm washes over me.

* * *

Now

I crouch in the shadows, my heart racing as I watch him approach. My obsession emerges from his black BMW and strides towards the dark house. Eyes forward and head held high, he doesn't spare a glance at his surroundings.

As I take a step forward, the weight of my boot crushes a twig against the ground, the sound echoes through the silence. My body tenses and I stay low, hidden and waiting for a reaction, but the man continues without so much as a flinch. He is truly fearless, and that fearlessness is what draws me to him. He is the embodiment of vicious strength and immorality. The callous disregard he shows for human life should terrify me, but I yearn for him. I hunger for his deadly touch, and dream about the moment our eyes will meet again.

I've heard people call him The Devil—apt considering his name is Diablo.

He's well known in Newhaven. A millionaire businessman, a criminal mastermind, a cold, calculating killer. Rumours have called Diablo King many things, yet he's never been arrested, let alone charged with anything remotely criminal. He walks the streets as though he's untouchable, and here in Newhaven, he truly is.

Diablo enters the quiet house. When the door closes behind him, I wait for a few tense minutes, then I dart across the lawn and squat beneath a window at the side of the house. Muffled voices come from inside before a high-pitched scream cuts through the silence.

There's a heavy thud, what sounds like a scuffle, then a cried shout of "NO!" is abruptly cut off.

Standing to my full height, I try to peek through the blinds, déjà vu washing over me as I catch a glimpse of *him*. On a worn, brown sofa, a second man sits, one leg crossed over the other, he casually puffs on a cigarette. Unlike Diablo, the man's face is hidden by a black balaclava.

Diablo is standing over a naked woman who's bound and gagged. Tied to a wooden chair, she struggles against her binds, black streaks of mascara mar her tear-stained cheeks.

My breath fogs the window and I lift my hand to swipe away the condensation.

When the glass clears, I'm mesmerised by what I see. Diablo moves to stand behind the woman, her black hair wrapped around his fist as he pulls her head all the way back, exposing the long, pale line of her throat.

The other man stands. He leans down to the woman's ear and must whisper something because she shakes her head slightly.

A wide smile stretches across Diablo's face, but his dark eyes remain blank, empty.

My cock thickens and presses against the zipper of my leather pants. The urge to tuck my hand into the front of my boxer briefs and stroke myself, is strong, but I rein in my desire.

Sweat beads across my brow, my heart pounds beneath my ribcage. My fists clench with a primal rage. I want to smash through the window and force him to acknowledge me. I want to beg him to drag his gaze away from the woman's bared throat and bring his knife to my own fluttering pulse.

As Diablo's knife slices across the woman's throat and blood spills down her bare chest, coating her breasts in a sea of crimson, his smile grows even wider. When he raises the blade, he twists and turns it, staring at the blood coated silver with something akin to lust in his eyes. He brings the knife to his lips, and one, long, sensual stroke of his tongue swipes the bloody blade before he turns it and repeats the action.

I give in to my desperation and shove my hand down my pants. My cock twitches as I curl my shaking fingers around its length and stroke furiously. Panting, my mouth hangs open as I imagine Diablo's blade slicing through the soft, pale flesh of my neck.

Would he taste me? Would he finger the gaping wound, lick my essence from his bloody fingertips, and groan in pleasure as he takes my life?

My thumb slides across my crown, precum creates a slick lube that heightens my pleasure. Saliva dribbles from the corner of my mouth. I swallow, and the metallic tang of blood coats my tongue when I bite into my bottom lip.

My breath continues in frantic pants as I jerk off to visions of Diablo obscenely violating me while I lie helpless, trapped... dying.

A tiny moan escapes my lips as my release spills over my hand. I bring my fingers up to my lips and dip them into my mouth, sucking them clean the way I dream about sucking the blood off *his* blade, his fingers, his tongue.

My killer.

My killer.

My killer.

Yes, I will make him mine. Force him to give me what he has so freely given to so many others.

The first time I watched him kill, something inside me settled into place. I always knew I was different, but it wasn't until that fateful night that I figured out exactly what it was I desired.

Mine. Mine. Mine. The voices in my head chant.

As the minutes tick by, I can't force myself to flee. I remain frozen in place, watching as my killer and the other man use a saw to cut the woman into pieces. Diablo smooths his hand over the woman's severed thigh with a gentle caress before he brings his hand up to his mouth and licks his fingers clean.

Do it, Killian!

Go in there.

Join them in their depravity.

I clamp my eyes shut. "No," I whisper into the darkness. "NO!" I can't risk being caught, not yet. I want that, but for now, I'm nothing more than a voyeur. Hidden in the shadows, desperately wanting Diablo to notice me. I'm conflicted, though, if he catches me, it means an end to my furtive voyeurism, and there's still so much I want to experience before I finally die.

A few minutes, then I'll leave.

They pack her body parts into an icebox as though each piece of flesh is a precious commodity that must be handled with the utmost care. Jealousy surges through me, but I remain calm and silent, hypnotized by the way the two men move seamlessly around the room. They never look at or speak to one another, yet it's as though they're completely in sync and aware of the other's presence at all times.

With one last glance at Diablo, I commit his face to memory. His blood-tinged lips, deep, dark brown eyes, and that perfectly chiselled jawline draws me in like a moth to a flame. Logic tells me I should fear him, but the ever-present voice of my lust-drunk brain tells me to pursue him with reckless abandon.

Mine.

I slowly sink to a squatting position before scanning the surrounding area. When I don't see or hear anything, I make a run for it.

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VIII

*With lust in your gaze
You beg for a chance
I'll sate your sickest need
And grant you one last dance*

DIABLO

Email to: diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

Subject: URGENT HELP NEEDED

I need help urgently. I need a cure. I can't stop and it's getting worse. I can't tell you here can you come to me or meet me somewhere?
Please help me.

Ben.

* * *

My meeting with Ben takes place in my eccentric, macabre café in the heart of Newhaven. At nine in the morning, Sinners carries the pungent odour of eggs and bacon fat combined with the underlying scent of citrus cleaning spray, and the welcome aroma of freshly ground coffee.

At the black marble counter, Scott, the barista, an average looking man in his twenties with brown eyes and short, spiked brown hair, gives me a nod. "How's it going, King?" he asks, his tone light and jovial.

I force a practiced smile onto my face and return his greeting without a verbal reply as I make my way to my usual table. The black, wrought iron chair is littered with crumbs and a streak of what appears to be vanilla ice cream. I step back, raising a hand to garner the attention of the young, unfamiliar waitress who stands at the counter, chatting with Scott as he textures milk beneath the steam wand.

Her lack of attention tells me she's new here, doesn't know who I am, and hasn't been trained appropriately. Salem should know better than to hire someone without my approval. A muscle in my jaw tics, but I rein in my frustration and shift my focus to the task at hand.

Ben, the man I agreed to meet, sits at the opposite side of the table, his left foot tapping a steady beat on the floor. He hasn't noticed my

presence yet.

Finally, the waitress sees my raised hand and scurries over, tucking a strand of hair behind her ear. “Are you ready to order?” Her eyes dart between me and the seat I refuse to sit on.

I raise a brow, watching her confusion morph to frustration. She glances around the café, brows creased as she nervously chews on her gloss covered bottom lip.

Relegated to having to explain the issue, I huff a breath of air through my nose. “The chair,” I say with all the calmness I can muster. “Clean it.”

Her eyes widen and her pale pink lips open into an O as though she’s completely unaware that this is part of her job description. Not taking my eyes off her, I lower my voice, “Clean the chair, now.”

A vein in her neck flutters, and her gaping mouth closes immediately. My thoughts turn to picturing her hogtied and gagged, face bruised and bloody, eyes wide, and those pale limbs shaking and dripping with blood as terror consumes her.

I close my eyes momentarily. *Control*, I remind myself as the girl spins on her heels to rush back to the counter. She returns quickly with a damp cloth and a bottle of the wretched, citrus cleaning spray, and finally cleans the chair.

When I sit, Ben drops his hands from his reddened cheeks and places them on his lap, likely to hide the fact that they’re now trembling.

Three minutes pass in a silence that’s broken when Scott approaches the table to drop off my double espresso. I thank him and turn my attention back to Ben. Scrutinising his features, I allow my gaze to linger. His bone structure is perfect, and his nose is straight. High cheekbones, wide-set eyes surrounded by laugh lines, and straight white teeth without a hint of nicotine stain. Such an attractive specimen, and with his flesh and muscle carved from those lovely bones, he’d make a beautiful addition to my collection.

Nervous apprehension causes his lashes to flutter, and he blinks rapidly. A hand comes up to toy with the thin, silver chain around his neck.

“What do you need?” I ask the same question of everyone who contacts me, and I expect an honest answer. For reasons unknown, Ben does not reply.

Leaning forward, I lace my fingers on the table and lower my voice. “What. Do. You. Need?” I enunciate each word to ensure he knows I will not put up with insolence.

“Help,” he finally says.

I nod once and straighten before taking another sip of my espresso, inhaling the rich, robust aroma.

“Help with what, Ben?”

“I can’t, I—” His Adam’s apple bobs as he swallows down his fear, eyes darting around the quiet café. “Can we go somewhere else? I can’t talk about it here, there’s too many people,” his voice quavers.

I glance at the counter, then to a table where an elderly couple are chatting over loose leaf tea and scones. At another table, a lone businessman in an expensive, pinstripe suit and garish yellow tie sits, tapping away at his laptop. Two women wait by the front counter for their take-away orders. Their eyes glued to their phone screens, they’re completely oblivious to the outside world.

“There are nine people in this café including you and I,” I state. “None are interested in what you have to say. In fact, if you were to disappear, not one of these people would remember you were here, or care that you’re gone.”

He squeezes his eyes shut. When he opens them, panic remains. “B—but wh—what if they? They might hear me.”

His stuttering causes my left eye to twitch, and I inhale, long and deep as I battle against the voice in my head urging me to be reckless. “Did you listen to a word I said, Ben?”

He shakes his head, then nods. “But, but...”

“Enough,” I say. Another sip of coffee settles my racing thoughts, and I raise a brow at this man’s utter stupidity. If he believes even a single one of these people is more of a threat to him than I am, he is sorely mistaken.

I swallow down the last mouthful of my coffee and stand, tugging on the cuffs of my suit jacket and adjusting my tie.

Panic in his eyes, Ben begins stuttering again, “Wh—where are you go—going?”

“Goodbye, Ben.” I stand and turn my back on the man as I walk out of the café.

“See ya, King,” Scott calls. I lift a hand to wave as I continue out the door, counting the seconds in my head.

Five. A child’s scream comes from a stroller being pushed by a young mother.

Four. In the distance, a dog barks.

Three. The pedestrian walk signal goes off, the maddening blip, blip, blip causes me to wince.

Two. “Don’t forget milk,” a high-pitched, feminine voice calls from the passenger side of a sleek, silver Audi.

One. “King!” Ben shouts, his footsteps quicken to catch up with mine.

Ignoring him, I continue walking.

“Please can you help me?” he begs from beside me, his hurried footsteps barely keeping up with my long strides.

I stop in my tracks and turn to him. His face is red and blotchy from exertion, pupils still wide with panic. “Please,” he says again. “I’ll do anything.”

I slip my hands into my pockets. “Talk,” I say.

He glances around frantically. “Here?”

Jaw clenched, hands balled into fists, I remind myself of the reasons why it is still frowned upon to murder people in broad daylight, even if said person is an insolent fool.

“Two options, Ben. Talk or leave.” I pull a hand from my pocket and make a point of tugging up my sleeve to check my watch. “I don’t have all day.”

“Th—there’s something inside me, something dirty... I did—” His eyes dart left and right as he looks up and down the street. He leans in close to my ear. “I did bad things... to children. I—I touched them. Lots of them. I can’t go to prison, but I can’t stop. Please, you have to get rid of this feeling inside me.” He rubs at his chest with a closed fist. “Cure me. Please, King, I’m begging you.”

Expression blank, I take out my card and hand it to Ben. “Meet me here next Saturday night at six. Do not be late.”

He nods and opens his mouth to say something else, but I’m already walking away.

* * *

Thirty minutes later, I pull open the heavy steel door that leads into Snare, and I make my way to the office I share with Salem.

I find Salem sitting at his desk. "How'd it go?" he asks.

"Very well," I say. "He'll be there next Saturday night. What are you working on?"

Salem leans back in his leather chair and nods towards the screen.

"We've got some new emails."

I lean in to read them.

Email to: diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

Subject: HELP!

I have urges. I dream of murder. I want to meet.
M.

* * *

Email to: diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

Subject: Please reply

This is the fourth time I've emailed. Are you ignoring me?
You know who I am.
Killian.

* * *

Email to: diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

Subject: Hunt

I want to hunt people. I can pay any amount.
Heard you do this kind of thing.
Email me back asap.
Steve

* * *

Email to: diablo.dansemacabre@gmail.com

Subject: PLEASE

ANSWER ME! I NEED TO MEET YOU.
Killian.

* * *

“I’ll take care of Killian. You check the others out,” I tell Salem, trusting him to get the details before we commit to anything.

There’s always a chance law enforcement has managed to weasel their way into our encrypted servers, and for this reason, our associates, Liam and Stefani, make preliminary appointments to check out the legitimacy of each client.

With Liam currently in the U.S.A., hunting down the human traffickers responsible for his sister’s death, and Stefani hunting her next kill, their usual tasks have been passed onto Salem.

Ten years ago, Chadwick handed over the reins of his clandestine sex club, Snare, to Salem and I. Nestled in dense bushland on a ten-acre property, from the outside, Snare looks like any other abandoned, rundown farmhouse. Beneath the hardwood floors of the old, weatherboard house, an entire club has been built deep below ground.

Snare allows us yet another way to hide in the shadows. By ridding Newhaven of those we consider unworthy, we maintain control of the city and ensure those we lure in, bend to our will.

From the moment they adopted us into their family, Chadwick and Loren embraced our differences. Chadwick taught us how to properly torture, kill, lie, and manipulate.

During our lessons with Loren, we learned how to mimic facial expressions, tones of voice, posture, and speech patterns, allowing us to blend into a society that frowns upon our way of life.

Today, with Chadwick now the mayor of Newhaven, and Governor of Iron Tomb prison, we’re well known throughout the town and its surrounding suburbs as prominent business owners. Rumours are rife about our lives, with many believing Salem and I are Chadwick’s sons. We never confirm or deny the allegations, and as long as we don’t interfere with Chadwick’s role as Mayor, more often than not, he acts as though we don’t exist.

With enough money—and more than a few dirty cops and politicians on our side—we can and do get away with anything.

While Salem works on the possible new clients, I take a seat at my desk and rummage through my files for five minutes before I sigh in resignation, realising I’ll need to ask for help. “Where’s that blonde girl?” I ask Salem.

He glances up and laughs quietly, shaking his head. "You mean our assistant, Jessica?"

Looking up at him, I narrow my eyes, confused. "She's not blonde?"

"Yeah, she is. But her name is Jessica."

"I don't care." I wave him off. "Where is she?"

"Called in sick, actually." He shakes his head. "Fourth time in two weeks. This one may have to go, too."

"Hmm... I agree," I say. "Relieve her of her duties and remove her from Newhaven. And get rid of the new girl at Sinners. I don't like her."

"I don't like her," Salem mimics as he looks up at me. "You don't *like* anyone."

When I raise a brow, he adds, "She's a friend of Scott's. He said she needed a couple days work before she moved on. Something about backpacking 'round Australia. She won't be back after today."

Satisfied, I give him a single nod and return my attention to the computer screen in front of me. It's time to find out what my reckless stalker is up to, but first...

"Perhaps he could work for us," I muse aloud.

Salem hums in acknowledgement. "I don't think that's a good idea. You know how much he affects you."

Stretching, I lace my fingers behind my neck. "You're right." I admit. "But I'll continue to toy with him."

He lets out a quiet chuckle. "You really shouldn't play with your food, D."

The corner of my mouth quirks. "You're not one to talk. Tell me, how long has it been since you've caged your little firebird? Must be about time for another hunt."

Salem's eyes darken and his jaw tics as a mask of rage spreads across his face. "Do not mention him," Salem growls as his shoulders rise and fall with his heaving chest. His attempts to rein in his rage at the mention of his obsession, fail dismally. "I mean it!" he shouts.

Like me, Salem often struggles with impulsivity. It's been almost three months since he's indulged, and his desperation is beginning to show. One mention of his pretty little firebird is all it takes to send him spiralling. It's fascinating to watch, and I do love taunting him.

"Forgive me," I say, raising my hands.

"No," he mutters.

I feign placating him. "I'm sorry." One look at my face will tell Salem I got the reaction I wanted.

"Fuck you," Salem retorts.

"You already did," I remind him.

When I look up, Salem is glaring at me, his angry scowl slowly morphing into a smile. He shakes his head, sighs, then goes back to work.

"I hate you," he mutters under his breath.

"Liar," I reply.

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IX

*I watch you from the shadows
While you hide in plain sight
I crave undying devotion
While you stalk me through the night*

DIABLO

With a clenched fist, I pound on Gavin's front door. The cloying stench of cigarettes, weed, and garbage seeps from inside the house as I wait for someone to answer. After a few minutes, the door creaks open. A waif-like woman in black lace underwear greets me with a cigarette dangling from her cracked lips.

"Where's Gavin?" I demand.

"Sleepin'," she says, leaning against the door frame. "What d'ya want?"

My jaw tics in annoyance. I loathe interacting with Gavin's drug addicted whores.

"Wake him up." I push my hand against the door as she tries to shut it in my face. Shoving my foot into the gap to stop it from closing, I say, "Move."

The woman stumbles back, cigarette falling from her lips as she curses. I push past her and storm inside.

She scrambles across the stained carpet to search for the lost cigarette. "Fuck you, asshole!" she screams after me.

Ignoring her, I make my way down the hallway, searching for Gavin. The first bedroom is empty, clothes and drug paraphernalia strewn across the unmade bed. The scent of vomit and urine hang in the air.

I kick the next door open. My lip curls in disgust when I find Gavin's obese, naked form lying in the middle of a king-sized bed, sandwiched between a boy and a girl who appear to be in their teens.

"You can't go in there!" the woman I met at the front door shrieks. Her thin, bony fingers cling to my long, black coat. I spin and slam my fist into her face, knocking her out cold. Her body slumps to the floor, head lolled to the side, blood dribbling from the corner of her lips.

My fingers twitch. The urge to pull out my knife and slit her throat tugs at my self-control, but I restrain myself when I hear Gavin's voice.

“Fuck,” he mutters.

Turning, I greet him. “Hello Gavin.”

“Shit!” He freezes, fear etched across his face. “Di—Diablo...”

The young boy and girl leap from the bed, both huddle against the wall. Knees to their chests, and their eyes wide with panic, they shift their attention between me and Gavin.

Drawing my knife from its sheath, I point the tip of the blade against a meaty roll of fat on Gavin’s stomach. A trickle of blood begins to dribble from the wound.

“Who are they?” I ask, nodding towards the cowering teens.

When he doesn’t answer, I press the blade in further, causing Gavin to shout out. “Ahh, fuck. I dunno, man. Found ‘em on the street last night. They wanna be here, ask ‘em,” he rushes out. “I didn’t do nothin’ they didn’t want.”

“Do not move,” I say to Gavin as I draw my knife back and walk around to the other side of the bed.

Standing over the teens, I look down at them with disdain. Killing them would be simple, but the clean-up will take time. Time I don’t have.

I squat before the naked teens. Eyes on the boy, I take in his flawless, freckle smattered skin and dishevelled red hair. I allow my eyes to linger on the fluttering pulse in his neck for a moment before I ask, “How old are you?”

“Si—sixteen,” he stutters.

“I’m fourteen,” the girl says quickly. When I shift my gaze to her similar features, I wonder if they’re siblings and consider taking them now. My mouth waters at the thought. Their screams of terror would be music to my ears as I slice into their soft, young flesh.

Taste.

Devour.

Kill.

Ignoring my hunger, I narrow my eyes, looking over my shoulder to where Gavin lays on his bed, unmoving. If only I had time to torture him.

“Killian Graves,” I say without inflection.

Gavin’s eyes widen. He raises his hands in surrender. “You um—you wanna buy him?”

I scoff, shaking my head. “Oh, do not be mistaken, Gavin. If I want something you have, I will simply take it. You know that better than

anyone. Now, the ball,” I say.

He nods. “Yeah, yeah, I’ll be there.”

“And you’ll arrange for Killian to attend.” I wave a hand towards the teens. “This... I’ll allow to continue. For now.”

His face pales as he understands the gravity of my words. “F—for now?”

Standing, I take the two steps towards his bed and reach out to wrap my hand around his throat. I squeeze until his face begins to purple.

“Remember why you are still alive.”

Nodding frantically, Gavin struggles to breathe as he sputters, “Yes, yes, I re—remember.” I release my grip from his throat. If it wasn’t for Chadwick’s orders to keep Gavin alive, I would have killed him years ago.

On my way out of the bedroom, the woman, who I didn’t notice had regained consciousness, lunges at me, screaming.

I drive my knife deep into her stomach, sending Gavin into a panic as he scrambles off the bed. “Fuck!” he shouts, frantically trying to stop the bleeding by pressing his hands over the wound. “Fuck it, D, she’s one of my best!”

The teenagers scream in unison. One glare from me and a glance at the blood dripping off the blade of my knife, and they cover their mouths with their hands, muffling their cries.

Turning back to Gavin, I say, “It would be in your best interest to make sure those two don’t leave Newhaven.”

His eyes dart between me, the teens, and the bleeding, writhing woman on the filthy carpet. Nodding, he stutters a reply. “Ye—yes, yes. I, I will.”

“And Gavin, if I find Killian damaged the way I did last time, you will pay dearly,” I growl, my voice dripping with menace.

Another nod from Gavin is followed by a plea for forgiveness, but I am no god, and I do not forgive. I won’t kill the remaining people in this house today. No, I’ll allow them to live in fear a while longer. Set them free with the knowledge that in time, I will return for them, and when I do, there will be no mercy.

Gavin stammers out an agreement, adding, “Please, let me call Doc. He’ll keep his mouth shut.”

A heavy sigh escapes my lips as I shake my head. “No.”

“Diablo, come on, man, please, let me keep this one.” He tries to protest, begging me not to kill the woman.

I lean down close to him and whisper against his ear, “When have your pleas ever satisfied me?”

He swallows hard and closes his eyes as the dying woman tries to crawl away, weakly kicking out at me. Crimson blood dribbles from her mouth, and her high-pitched screams grate on my nerves. I raise my knife and press the sharpened blade to her throat. One quick thrust of my knife silences her, permanently.

After cleaning my blade on Gavin’s stained white sheets, I walk out of the bedroom, tucking my knife back into its sheath. “Clean that mess up,” I call out as I allow the front door to close behind me.

Fifteen minutes later, I pull into the carpark of the local supermarket. I lift my eyes to look into the rearview mirror. The red Hyundai pulls into a parking space further along the opposite row as I cut the engine to my black BMW.

Leaning back in my seat, I make a show of lifting my phone to my ear and pretending to talk while I watch Killian, dressed head to toe in black, get out of his car and turn his head my way.

He’s hoping to catch a glimpse of me, eager for me to meet those scrutinising eyes and give him what he so desperately craves.

A frisson of excitement hums in my veins. My silent companion, always hiding in the shadows, watching my every move. If it were anyone else, their lives would have ended years ago. Killian is different, though. The light in his eyes when he watches me kill, stirs an unfamiliar sensation inside me.

I want him to watch. Knowing he’s there and that his sole focus is on me, gives me a rush I’ve only ever found while stealing the dying breaths of an unwilling victim.

I am the hunter becoming the hunted.

I allow it because I will never truly be his prey. The delight I find in his antics is something I never imagined I’d take pleasure in. There’s an inherent risk to this enjoyment, though.

Impulsivity almost ruined me once before. I cannot allow it to happen again. Distractions lead to errors in judgement, and errors in judgement lead to danger.

When my not-so-secret stalker disappears through the doors to the supermarket, I call Salem.

“Hey boss,” he says. “What’s up?”

I resist the urge to roll my eyes. “You know I despise it when you call me boss.”

“Ah huh. So, what’s up?” His nonchalance is also something I despise, and since he is well aware of this, I refuse to mention it.

“My imprudent little hunter?” I ask, keeping my eyes on the supermarket in case he reappears. “Are we still tracking him?”

“Aww, *your* little hunter. That’s sweet as fuck.” Salem laughs.

I clench my jaw at Salem’s mocking, but before I can chastise him, he adds, “I know, I know, you don’t like me mocking you. What goes around comes around, D. Besides, you need to loosen up. It’s been a week since your last kill. I can tell you’re getting antsy.”

He’s right. This is the longest I’ve gone without hunting or killing, and I don’t count or mention the woman I killed less than an hour ago. She was irrelevant, effortless.

A complete waste of my time.

In the background I hear Salem tapping on his keyboard. “He starts work at three. Then Gavin has him out at eleven tonight.”

“Thank you.” I end the call.

I tap the photos app on my phone and when I look down at the image of Killian Graves, my blood turns to fire in my veins. Bright, aquamarine eyes stare back from my screen, contrasted by thick, ebony curls that frame a perfectly symmetrical face with creamy ivory skin and full, pink lips.

His stunning features are enhanced by an eyebrow piercing, a silver hoop through his bottom lip, and a black, horseshoe septum ring. He craves individuality.

Killian doesn’t look twenty-four in this image. Not with that soft, unmarred face, and the veiled innocence behind those striking eyes. Six years ago, eyes identical to those captured me. Like a foolish fly caught in a web, I was ensnared. It cannot happen again, and yet, a strange yearning coils in the pit of my stomach.

It may be time to lure in my beauty.

But will I be able to let him go? The question taunts me.

What a lovely and dangerous predicament I find myself in.

* * *

When Killian leaves the supermarket and heads back to his car, I make a quick trip inside for some essentials. A few minutes later, I'm heading along the busy sidewalk to the bookstore and bakery café in the heart of town. The quaint business, Belle's Books, is run by Annabelle Collard who is a senior member of *The House*, and one of our oldest informants.

At sixty-four, the old woman comes across as timid and harmless, but I've watched her kill and butcher a human carcass with a smile on her face and not a hair out of place.

Stepping inside, I inhale the rich aroma of strong, dark coffee. The same beans I purchase for my own café leaves a lingering sense of familiarity beneath my nostrils.

A few people look up from their table when I stride through the café, and I catch a quiet whisper of "That's Diablo King," and "Come on, let's get out of here."

Showing my face here in broad daylight is not something I'd normally do, but the innate need to get closer to my little hunter is a new compulsion I cannot control.

Ignoring the stares and whispers, I reach the counter and take in the old woman with frizzy, unkempt white hair who looks up at me with a questioning gaze.

"Diablo, what a pleasant surprise," she says, not a hint of enthusiasm in her tone. "If you're here to cause trouble—"

I cut her off, "Calm down, old woman. I'll be gone by five past three."

With a knowing smile, she raises her brow. "Ahh, you're hunting?"

Giving her a discreet nod, I say, "Double espresso." I peruse the cakes, scones, and biscuits behind the display case. "And a slice of red velvet cake."

"At the back," Annabelle says. "I'll make sure he doesn't see you."

Satisfied, I find a seat at a small, round, wooden table at the back of the café near a floor to ceiling bookshelf filled with a variety of classic novels. I pick a random book and settle in, not reading, but watching the

comings and goings around me while I wait for Killian to arrive for his 3pm shift.

Ten minutes later, after downing my coffee and half the cake, I catch a glimpse of my prey. The moment I see him, the world stops as I take him in. He is the epitome of perfection.

Annabelle's grandson, Eddie, having taken the place of Annabelle behind the counter, greets Killian with a wave.

Killian sports a brooding look of disinterest that smothers his features, and I continue my blatant perusal. His long legs are covered in tight, black jeans that are slashed with tears from thighs to calves where a pair of Doc Martens are adorned with buckles, chains, and silver, spiked studs across the toe.

On top, Killian wears a black t-shirt depicting a human skull with blood oozing from every orifice beneath a black leather jacket, also adorned with chains and buckles. His thick, dyed black curls frame a pale, flawless face.

When he raises a hand to wave to Eddie, I catch a glimpse of leather cuff bracelets and thick chains around his wrist. The bottom half of a skull tattoo on the back of his hand peeks out from beneath the sleeve of his jacket.

He talks quietly to his co-worker before he heads through the kitchen doors. He returns a few minutes later wearing a black apron.

I shake my head slightly. This will not do. He should not be covered up, he should be front and centre, on display for everyone to see. Though none will ever dare touch him once I've staked my claim.

After watching Killian for another few minutes, I duck out the side door of the café and walk down the street to where my car is parked.

I call Salem back.

"Everything ready?" I ask.

"Yeah, good to go," he says.

"And Kensington won't be an issue?" My jaw clenches at having to mention his name.

"Don't worry about Kensington, he knows what he has to do." There's a pause, then Salem adds, "He's done everything we've asked so far. He won't be a problem."

"If he fucks this up, I'll kill him," I warn Salem.

“Oh, I know,” he says with a laugh. “I’ll see you later.”

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X

*A voyeur in the darkness
I pray he'll notice me
And sometimes, when I close my eyes
Death whispers, come, I'll set you free*

KILLIAN

With my hands pressed hard against my ears, the muffled voices still taunt me. *Give in. Kill them all. Give in, Killian!* They never stop. Whispers, screams, bellowing laughter, and deep, rumbling commands spill from faceless demons.

Head down, I rock back and forth as I murmur the words repeatedly, “I’ll do it. I’ll do it. I’ll do it.” The need is an un-scratchable itch beneath my flesh.

A shiver of fear laced with disgust slithers down my spine as cool, slender fingers trail up my arm to my shoulder. Her touch brings me back, though. Somehow, she always brings me back.

“That’s it, Killian. Listen to my voice. Control your breathing. Inhale. Exhale. Inhale.”

Finally, she removes her hand from my shoulder, but the lingering disgust remains. It will take hours to scrub my skin clean and rid myself of her sickly-sweet stench.

After a minute of deep, steady breathing, the voices recede and the sound of my blood rushing through my ears is all that I hear. I drop my hands slowly, opening my eyes as I gather myself and straighten on the leather sofa.

My psychiatrist, Doctor Kate McCallister, smiles, then drops her gaze to jot something down on her notepad before she meets my eyes again. “How are you feeling now?”

I shrug. “Fine, I guess.”

She knows I’m lying, it’s all I ever do here. She figured that out years ago. Now, she merely waits until I reveal the truth, or I cut our session short and walk out. The only reason I continue to come here is because it’s part of the terms and conditions I agreed to when I joined Snare.

Snare, right here in Newhaven, caters to dark, depraved kinks and paraphilias.

Thanks to August already being a member, he was able to invite me. When he offered to pay my membership fee, I was ecstatic.

Doctor McCallister is also a member. I've heard whispers Diablo King, and Salem Frost—who is never far from Diablo's side—are the owners of the club that requires each member to attend monthly psychiatric evaluations to be allowed continued access to the clandestine sex club. Just another reason I cannot lose access to Snare.

After a few silent minutes, Kate says, "Whenever you're ready, we'll continue."

The minutes tick by as I watch the clock like a hawk. Every tick signalling one second closer to the end of yet another session.

When I don't say anything, she asks, "Did you talk to August about what we discussed last session?"

I swallow the lump in my throat and trace the tender flesh of my neck with my fingertips. The marks are a reminder of August's touch. *I need it.* I need the club. It's the only place I can sate another one of my sick desires.

Below my Adam's apple, I stop to press my fingers into the most sensitive part of the wound. "*You look so beautiful lying there. Dying for me. For my touch.*" The words play over in my mind, his voice, a haunting reminder of my filth and depravity.

One week ago

August moved quietly around the room, attaching leather cuffs to my ankles and wrists before he removed my choker and looped the rope around my neck.

"Eyes closed," he said, his breath warm against the shell of my ear. I obeyed and my eyelids closed as my mind fell into a blissful silence.

August trailed his fingers across the expanse of my torso. When the bed dipped and he sat over my thighs, my cock twitched.

"You look so beautiful." His hands splayed across my chest, slowly glided up to my collarbone, then to my throat where he squeezed gently before removing them and sitting back.

When the rope tightened, I gasped. A low whine involuntarily left my lips.

August shifted his weight and tugged on the rope as he ground against my aching cock. "So beautiful lying there." Another tight pull. I swallowed against the rope around my neck. "Dying for me."

Another harsh tug, and I choked on a sob.

"Dying for my touch." August crossed the ropes, pulled them taut until I could no longer swallow, let alone breathe.

My brain kicked in, survival its only agenda as I fought against the hold.

I writhed, choked, whined.

My eyelids flickered open.

August's calm expression was all I could see. He leaned down and pressed his lips to the corner of my open mouth.

"Please," I tried to beg, to tell him to take me all the way, but no words came out.

My eyes rolled back as dizziness took over.

Black spots appeared in my vision.

Then... peace.

If only he'd take me further. I've begged and pleaded, I even offered to be his twenty-four-seven slave, and still, I'm stuck with the bare minimum. And if I stop—

I shake my head. "I can't." *Don't stop.* I drop my hand to my lap, lacing my fingers together. "I can't stop."

Kate flips through the pages of her notebook. "You've been hospitalised five times in the past six months." Her voice is stern, scolding. "Of all the paraphilic disorders, erotic asphyxiation and hypoxophilia are some of the deadliest. Death or total and permanent disablement are real risks, Killian. Not to mention the consequences involved for the club if something unfortunate were to happen to you." Her lips press into a thin line.

Don't tell her. The voices taunt, reminding me that if I reveal all my secrets, life as I know it will end. I'll be locked away in a white-walled room and forced into a straitjacket, unable to touch, or to be touched. And I'll lose access to *him*.

Run, Killian!

I cut her off before she can continue. "The meds, Doc, I'm scared they'll make me numb. I *need* to feel. I need it." I stand quickly, pacing

back and forth as I attempt to put my thoughts in order. “I know what I’m doing. I’ve been doin’ it for years and I’m still here, aren’t I?” Hands shoved into the pockets of my torn jeans, I sigh. “I know how far I can go. Two or three times a month is safe. It’s fine. I’ve seen other guys doing it way more often than I do.”

Kate looks up, studying me. I hate it when she looks at me like that. “The medication is to help with your compulsions. It’s not fine, Killian. I’d like you to drop it down to once every three months. I’ll also discuss this with August, and the club owners. If you prefer, we can start with a lower dose of medication and gradually increase it over time. Unfortunately, if you don’t agree to this, I’ll have to make a recommendation to revoke your membership.”

Panic coils in my gut and I drop my head, nodding reluctantly. “Fine.”

The medication in question was first prescribed to me six months ago. A single pill is yet to cross my lips, and I have no intention of changing that. The mere thought of losing the one thing that keeps me grounded, is terrifying.

“Now,” she says, “let’s talk about your family.”

I rub my sweaty palms over my jean clad thighs. “Okay,” I say reluctantly.

“Have you been to the cemetery lately?” she asks.

I shake my head. “I’ll go next week.”

“How do you feel about that?”

“I don’t really know. Guilty?” I say as a question.

“Why do you feel guilty?”

“Because I don’t care enough. I don’t cry about them, or wish they were back. I don’t feel anything at all. Shouldn’t I be sad about it—about the way they died?”

Kate shakes her head, studying me closely. “You don’t have to feel a certain way about them. You had a terribly abusive childhood, Killian. It’s understandable that you’re conflicted about your feelings.”

I sigh and scrub my hands down my face. “I’m angry at Kas,” I admit.

“You’ve mentioned this anger towards Kaspian before. Are you ready to talk about it yet?”

“There’s not much to say.” I shrug.

He stole your dream. A voice in my head reminds me, and I'm taken back to the night my brother stole what should have been mine.

Six years ago

Gavin's party house was dark but for a single, dim light in the kitchen. After sneaking out while the partygoers were busy getting high and drinking themselves into oblivion, I returned to a strangely quiet house, considering it was 2am on a Saturday morning.

Usually, Gavin would be the centre of attention, regaling his guests with tales of his criminal activities and his ability to outsmart the cops at every turn.

My parents were regular attendees at these parties. They never batted an eye when me and Kas were forced to our knees to suck some random guy's cock or be gangbanged by any number of Gavin's friends.

Quietly, I made my way along the grass, keeping off the gravel path that led to the back gate.

I peeked into mine and Kas's bedroom window. He wasn't there. I pulled out my phone to see if he'd texted me.

Kas: *Where are you? You're meant to be here tonight.*

Kas: *Hurry up and get your ass back, Gavin is pissed!!*

Kas: *Answer me Kill!*

His texts were all sent just after midnight. About the same time I was getting fucked-down by a nameless blond in a filthy bathroom cubicle of a gay club out of town.

Ignoring Kas's texts, I shoved my phone back into my pocket. Just before I headed through the side gate and into the backyard, my phone vibrated again. When I reached for it, a strangled cry came from inside the house, and I dropped my hand.

I reached the spare bedroom window and peered through the gap in the stained vertical blinds. What I saw caused goosebumps to break out across my body. I squeezed my eyes shut and sucked in a ragged breath. With one hand clamped hard over my mouth, I looked into the bedroom again.

The small, dim lamp on the bedside table highlighted my parents lying on the bed, blood-soaked sheets beneath them. Their throats slit so

wide open it looked like they'd almost been decapitated. Between their legs, more dark blood pooled as though they'd bled from every orifice.

I felt nothing for them. No sense of loss or anger. No sense of panic or a need to call the police and report their murders.

My thoughts were on the man in the room. Only his back and shoulders, covered in a long sleeve black tee, were visible from my vantage point. Cursing my height, I searched the garden for something to stand on. The large hose reel lay flat on its side, and as quietly as I could manage, I moved it beneath the window. Standing on top gave me a few more inches of visibility.

What I saw stunned me.

My brother was splayed on his stomach, head twisted at an odd angle, eyes wide open. Blood had dribbled from his mouth and nose and seeped into the beige carpet.

The man, dressed in black, released his gloved hands from Kas's neck and moved them to his shoulders. From this angle, I could see the man's profile. Dark hair, dark stubble, and a sharp jawline. He was fully clothed, his black pants open at the front as he thrust into my brother's ass.

Kas struggled beneath his weight, fought for freedom. His hands reached out, grasping at empty air. I should have been horrified.

Instead, heat pooled in my gut and a sense of urgency overtook me. I shoved a hand down my pants and wrapped my fist around my aching cock. One stroke, then another.

The man thrust into my brother again. Kas's body moved with the force, his cheek rubbed against the carpet. Eyes open, he stared into oblivion.

I stared right back, an envious rage building inside me, along with a desire so achingly strong I could barely breathe through my panting. I stroked my cock again, harder this time as I bit down on my tongue to hold back a moan. Blood filled my mouth, and I shifted my attention to the man who was so very clearly raping my dying brother.

I stroked myself in time with each of his violent thrusts.

"Sick. Sick. Sick." Gavin's words played over in my mind. "You sick little fuck!"

I shook my head to free myself from the image of Gavin and returned my focus to the man.

When he reached behind himself, I leaned in closer, my frantic breaths fogged the window as the man raised a wicked knife. Before the knife came down, he stopped and turned his head towards the window.

I panicked.

I sucked in a breath and fell to my knees. My own release spilled over my hand and smothered my boxer briefs. Panting, I pulled my hand out quickly and in a frantic run, I raced across the backyard to the small tool shed. Tucked behind the shed, I hid beneath the branches of a large shrub and pulled my knees to my chest.

“Sick. Sick. Sick,” I chanted over and over.

That night, my brother was murdered, along with our parents, and the tight hold I had on my desires, slipped.

“Killian?” Kate’s voice brings me back.

I avert my gaze and rub the back of my neck. Recalling her earlier question, I answer, “I’m angry he got to experience that, you know? I wanted to be in his place... to feel what he felt. I wanted it to be—”

“You wanted to die?” she questions without judgement.

When I realise how much I’ve said, I stand and turn my back to her. “NO!” I shout but shake my head hard. “Yes,” I admit quietly. “I’m not suicidal. I want...”

Her voice is barely a whisper, “You want to be killed.” I flinch when Kate places a hand on my shoulder. “There are others like you. You’re not alone, Killian.”

Jaw clenched, I turn to face her. I expect to see disgust. All I find is a curious expression and a small, genuine smile.

It’s a well-known fact that while Kate is a qualified psychiatrist, some of her sessions, and the treatments she offers, and services she provides, aren’t always moral or ethical. She does, however, have the final say in who is and isn’t allowed to enter Snare.

Reluctantly, I drop my ass to the black leather sofa. “Like me?” I ask. “I don’t even know what the fuck is wrong with me, and you’re saying there are others like me.”

Kate’s smile widens. “I’ve seen you at Snare, remember, not to mention our sessions, and the fact that you never fail to bring up your hatred towards Kaspian. So...” She pauses as she closes her notebook, leans

back in her chair, and crosses one leg over the other. “Why don’t you tell me exactly what’s going on inside that head of yours.”

Before I can stop myself, the words rush out of me. “I want to be raped, killed, murdered. I don’t know—sometimes I want to do those things to other people, but most of the time, I want it to be me. I want the pain, the degradation. I want to be the victim.” I press my hand over my mouth as bile rises in my throat. *Why did you tell her?* My heart races as images of my brother’s bloody, lifeless body assault me.

Don’t tell her everything.

Don’t spill your secrets, Killian!

“Killian!” Kate’s firm voice causes me to gasp, and when my eyes meet hers, she softens her tone. “Calm down. It’s safe here, and this is nothing I haven’t heard before.” I nod but remain silent, and Kate continues, “There’s a high possibility you have what psychologists call autassassinophilia. It’s one of the rarer paraphilias. People with autassassinophilia gain sexual arousal or orgasm with the belief that their life is in imminent danger, specifically the danger of being killed. Some can be satisfied with staged, roleplay type scenes that end with extreme pain and brutality, whereas others crave the real risk of murder.”

A frisson of heat courses through my veins as I listen to Kate explain the emotions and desires I’ve always kept hidden. The urge to spill the rest of my sordid, sick secrets is strong, but stronger is self-preservation—and surprisingly, I still have some of that to spare.

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XI

*A carcass ready to butcher
Your blood will spill like wine
You entertained the devil
One too many times*

DIABLO

Life is a dance, each move synchronised and graceful, impromptu, or inevitable, and I always take the lead. Especially when my dancing partners are nothing more than crimson, blood-filled hearts encased within a slowly dying body. Ending that rhythmic, steady beat of a heart is all it takes to snuff out the lives of those I consider deserving of my touch.

The privileged few who dance with me, are immortalised. When their once beating hearts are finally still, the worthy are enshrined and beautifully displayed to showcase their final, lasting gift to me.

“Why are you doing this?” The garbled words are choked out through a mouthful of blood and saliva that dribbles from the corners of his lips. Crimson tributaries trickle down his jaw towards his neck.

I approach my victim, perusing my handiwork. The six-foot tall, hand carved cross stands in the corner of my workspace. Attached to it, my victim’s hands are splayed open. A large, solid steel nail pierced through the palm of each hand, ensures little to no movement without excruciating pain. The blood that was flowing freely not so long ago, is slowly but surely beginning to clot.

His ankles, still bound by thick, braided rope, are bruised and broken. The sight of his left foot, twisted at a grotesque angle, sends shivers down my spine.

I stand in front of the man as he trembles with fear. His pupils dilated, his mind a whirlwind of racing thoughts. He wants to know why I’m doing this. He wants to buy time, barter for his freedom, beg for his pathetic life.

A single drop of blood forms in the middle of his forehead where the thick, steel band holds his head up. The blood trickles, slowly making its way down the bridge of his nose. With my index finger, I smooth the red stain across his quivering lips and inhale the coppery scent as my own lip twitches into a smile.

“Do you enjoy dancing, Ben?” I breathe the words into his mouth, forcing him to swallow them down—to taste them... to inhale them the way I will inhale him—before death, and after.

“Stop, please stop.” He squeezes his eyes shut and his brow creases, creating deep wrinkles between his eyes. He murmurs, “I don’t—Why are you asking me that?”

Cupping his cheek, I tuck my thumb under his chin until his eyes are once again fixed on mine. “It’s simple, really. Soon, we’re going to dance, and I’d like to know if you’ll enjoy it.” I drop my hand and step back to reach for the surgical scalpel on the stainless-steel table.

“But first, it’s time to choose.” With a flick of my wrist, I twist the scalpel so the glint of light coming from the single, dim bulb in the middle of the room catches on the silver blade. The theatrics are always just as important as the torture.

“Ple—please, no. I—” There’s a familiar scent of urine as he whimpers like a frightened dog and pisses himself. “I’ll dance. Yes, yes, I want to dance with you. I lo—love da, da—dancing.”

“Shhh...” I lower my voice. “Not yet. You need to choose your punishment. Removing your nipples is quite tedious. It takes some precision.” I release a heavy sigh as I trace the tip of the scalpel around the blush of his pink nipple. “Removing your cock... well, it’s fast, but inherently more painful.”

His whimpers continue, and he begs for mercy, pleading with me to stop the torture. But the real torture hasn’t begun.

“Kill me,” he says, his tone belies his words.

I force out a laugh. “Oh no. I’m not going to kill you, not yet. You reached out to me, Ben, begged for my help. Told me all your filthy secrets. You filled my head with images of what you did to those children. The ways you touched them—*touched him*. How you broke him, tried to ruin his young body and mind with your heinous actions.”

Ben’s words slam into me again.

“He was so young, so beautiful. So willing. He begged me to hurt him.” Ben’s eyes glazed over with lust.

“What was his name?” I asked.

A quick glance at his crotch told me all I needed to know. He was getting off on the memories. He didn’t want a cure, he wanted someone to

listen. Someone to acknowledge his perversions.

“Killian,” he whispered into the darkness. “Killian,” he said again.

“Killian,” I repeated. Volcanic rage flowed through my veins.

Nodding, he pressed down on his straining erection. His eyelids fell closed. He sucked in a deep, ragged breath. “He was perfect.”

“What did you do to him?” It took all my strength not to gouge out his eyes for laying them on what belonged to me.

Ben lifted his head, rubbed his cock, smiled wistfully. He leaned forward, and in a conspiratorial whisper, asked, “You really want to know?”

A muscle in my jaw twitched. I clenched my clasped hands until my knuckles strained. “Yes.”

Ben dropped his head back, exposing his pale throat.

My hands shook as he swallowed.

“I set up a meeting through his pimp. He gave me an hour with the boy, uninterrupted. He was nearly fourteen, I think, a little older than I wanted, but he, he wanted it—” Ben released a soft moan and licked his lips. “I had him on his knees, sucking my cock, the way he gagged...” Eyes on me again, Ben asked, “Have you ever—Have you had a child? The way they look up to you, their eyes so full of want.”

A burn unlike anything I’d ever felt before erupted deep in my chest. I’d heard worse than this many times before. I’d killed people for less. I never cared. Never felt anything but apathy. This time, it was personal.

Ben wanted—no, he used—what was rightfully mine.

He took it.

Tainted it.

Broke it.

“You fucked him?” I questioned.

A wide smile stretched across Ben’s face. “Yeah, he was so tight. Thought he was going to fight, you know? He took it so well, begged me to make it hurt. Never had a kid beg like that before.” He shifted and moaned. A damp spot appeared on his pants.

I stood slowly and unclenched my fingers. “It’s time,” I said, my voice void of emotion.

Ben tilted his head back to look up at me. He smiled.

Until I drew my knife from its sheath.

“What? What are—” Panic in his eyes, he tried to move back, but hit the wall.

Less than five minutes later, he was strung up to my cross.

“Killian is mine.” I lean in and press a soft kiss to his lips, lick the dribbling blood away, and say, “You tortured me with those secrets. Now, I’m going to torture you.”

“Yours? What? What do you mean?” His attempts to shake his head are useless. “Nonono! You said, you—you said you’d cure me.” He chokes on a mouthful of blood. “That’s why I came here. To be cured.”

Tilting my head, I explain, “The only cure for paedophiles is death, I’m afraid. Perhaps next time it would pay to ask questions.”

“Next time?” There’s a fleeting glimmer of hope in his gaze.

I force out an entirely fake, manic laugh, throwing my head back for effect. “Silly me,” I say, shaking my head and tutting at myself. “There won’t be a next time, not for you. Now, make your choice, or I will be forced to make it for you.”

“Can’t—I can’t.” Chest heaving, he clamps his eyes shut. Blood drips from his chin onto the floor.

“You can, and you will.” One minute passes, then two, and three.

When I grow tired of waiting, I place my scalpel on the table and make my way to the back of the room. I switch on the speakers connected to my phone. *Danse Macabre* flows through the air. The classical music drowns out his incessant begging and quiets the voices in my head that urge me to hurry this along. I need to escape to the city and start hunting again.

Hacksaw in hand, and with the haunting melody in the background, I head back to my screaming victim and begin sawing through the flesh of his wrist. It takes a few passes of the hacksaw for the sawing motion to begin its smooth glide through flesh, fat, and muscle. Blood spills from the raw, open wound, and I continue sawing until I finally feel the bone beneath the jagged blade.

As Ben screams, I move my body in time with the music. Swaying, side-stepping, and adding a spin now and then for a little extra flair. Ben doesn’t seem impressed with my dance, alas, when I look down, he does seem to have two left feet, rendering him incapable of dancing himself. Such a shame.

Minutes pass before I've finally cut my way through Ben's wrist, and his arm drops, hanging limp and handless by his side. His hand, still nailed to the timber, hangs like a blood-filled glove.

"Let me die," Ben says.

I press my lips to his ear. "I want you to beg for it."

He breaks into heaving, choking sobs and I pat his cheek before I smooth my thumb across his chapped bottom lip. "Open wide," I say.

The stupid man tries to clamp his jaw shut. He weakly shakes his head before the begging continues. "Please... please stop."

"What was that?" I ask, arms crossed over my chest.

"Kill..." He chokes on a sob. "Kill me, I'm begging you, please kill me, Diablo."

"Well done, Ben. Now, since you asked so nicely, let's get this done." With a wide smile, I work quickly to fix the jaw spreader into his mouth, opening his jaw to its full extent.

I take his flaccid cock in my hand and with one quick slice of my knife, I remove it from his body. Blood gushes from the open wound. His wailing scream is music to my ears, and I close my eyes and relish in the sounds of another filthy paedophile dying at my hands.

I hold up his cock and wave it in front of his face. "How did it feel, Ben? Violating those children with this fat piece of meat. Was it worth it?"

His eyelids droop as he vomits up blood and bile. It spills from his gaping mouth, down his bare chest and onto the concrete floor.

I shove the shrivelled cock into its owner's mouth. Using two fingers, I force it down until his throat is bulging and he's choking around the amputated appendage. After removing the jaw spreader, I hold his mouth closed and wrap duct tape around his head. Blood-streaked vomit and bile expels from his nostrils. His eyes roll back, and his heaving breaths finally cease.

I pull his right hand off the nail and drop it into the garbage bin, then, I remove the steel band from his head and step back to watch him fall to the concrete with a heavy thud.

After dragging his body to the centre of the room, I wrap thick chains under his armpits and around his neck. I attach the chain to the butcher's hook and switch on the electric hoist to raise Ben's carcass.

“Dance for me.” Loren’s voice in my head is a whisper I try to ignore.

Taking Ben’s remaining hand in mine, I circle the drain. Each step I take causes the chain to twist and tighten until the steel links strain under the pressure. I step back and smile as the chain unravels, sending Ben’s carcass into a violent spin.

“Now spin. And again. Perfect! You’re just perfect, darling.”

I squeeze my eyes shut and run my fingers through my hair, threading them through the black strands and tugging until my mind stops wandering into the past.

“Dance for me, Ben,” I call out as an arc of blood from his handleless arm sprays across the floor. “Perfect!” I step back once more, arms crossed over my chest as Ben’s spinning carcass slows, then comes to a stop.

With him hanging over the large steel grate that covers the drain, I slice down the middle of his chest, saw through his chest plate, and splay him open, allowing his intestines and blood to spill onto the floor. Blood runs down the drain, and I watch with macabre fascination as the crimson liquid swirls away.

The shrill ring of my alarm goes off, telling me it’s time to wrap this up. Using my scalpel and a gentle touch, I slice through the arteries and veins of the heart until it’s free from the chest cavity.

I bring the slowly cooling heart to my mouth and press it to my lips. My fingers slide into the incision I created with my scalpel. I relish in the soft squelch of blood as I gently finger the muscular, bloody organ.

Images of Killian flicker through my mind, unbidden. His blood, his screams, his final, dying breaths against my parted lips.

Taste.

Devour.

Kill.

My mouth waters as I inhale. Sweat beads across my brow, and when my cock thickens, I allow a quiet moan to escape before I swipe my tongue across my bloody lips.

Not yet.

I remind myself to wait. To focus on the tasks that need to be completed before I allow myself to indulge. With a sigh of longing, I wrap

the heart, gently tuck it into a lined, organ transport box, and close the lid. I place it on the benchtop so I can begin the arduous task of cleaning my workspace.

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XII

*Let me in, the devil sings
Let me in, I'll watch you sin
Let me in, the devil sings
Dance for me, I'll watch you spin*

DIABLO

From my spot at the bar inside Lure, I watch Killian dance with August. He moves with a seductive grace, his body a masterpiece of perfection as he twists, spins, and sways to the pulsing music. His every movement is an invitation, a promise of pure ecstasy. As I watch, my thoughts turn to something darker, something abhorrent and deadly.

I imagine cradling his beating heart in the palm of my hand, feeling its frantic rhythm slow until finally, it stops, completely under my control. With sick fascination, I envision the light fading from those mesmerising eyes, the lids slowly closing until long, dark lashes come to rest. And those perfect pink lips... I picture them losing their vibrant colour and fading into a muted grey-blue hue as his body falls limp against mine.

To kill or to keep? I'm balancing on the precipice.

As much as these thoughts arouse me, I'm mindful that I need to take into consideration the consequences of keeping someone like Killian. To own him would be akin to opening the doors to a forbidden vault, allowing someone to see the savage, perverted secrets contained within the depths of my blackened soul.

Shaking my head free from my wandering thoughts, I look up in time to see a man slither up behind Killian and wrap his arms around his narrow waist. The stranger grinds against Killian's precious ass. Killian drops his head back to the man's shoulder and allows him to trail kisses along his scarred neck.

I almost leap to my feet to put an end to the man and his wandering hands. My vision clouds with a red haze. How dare he touch what belongs to me.

In disgust, I press my hand down on my hard cock, unable to resist the desire seething inside me. The urge to claim Killian grows stronger with every caress he exchanges with the interloper. Killian may revel in the attention, but soon, he will come to learn who truly owns him.

I clench my fists then pick up my glass of vodka to take a mouthful.
“Hi Mr King,” a soft voice says from beside me.

I turn my head to glare at the young man who bats his lashes. “No,”
I say.

The stupid boy doesn’t take no for an answer. He places a palm on
my thigh, rubbing until his fingertips reach my hard cock.

He smiles, licks his lips, bats those lashes again. “You want a
blowjob?” he asks.

Gripping his wrist until he visibly winces, I lean into his small
frame. “I. Said. No.”

When I release his delicate hand, he scowls, shakes his head, then
turns and struts away.

Irritated my attention was diverted from Killian, I scan the dance
floor, searching for his face. When I don’t find him, my jaw clenches in
annoyance.

I head outside to get some fresh air, knowing Salem, who’s sitting in
his car across the street, will text me the moment Killian leaves.

In the dank alley behind Lure, the darkness that had been festering
within me as I watched Killian’s arms wrapped around another man,
consumes me. I bite down on the inside of my cheek until my tongue is
coated with the familiar, metallic taste of blood. My skin prickles with
irritation as the stench of sweat and alcohol clings to my flesh. With each
step I take into the empty alley, my heart pounds like a caged animal pacing
inside my chest.

When the door creaks open and stumbling footsteps approach, I
pause, ready to strike.

“Hey man, you got a light?” the slurred voice asks from behind me.

Turning, I come face to face with the stranger who was only minutes
ago, all over Killian. He tilts his head, eyes perusing my taller frame before
they narrow into thin slits.

Clearly intoxicated, he sways slightly. “You look familiar.” He leans
against a rusted dump bin and digs into the pocket of his jeans for a packet
of cigarettes.

The music from inside the club spills out to the dark alley. Flashes
of his hands on Killian appear at the forefront of my mind. His lips on
Killian’s neck, his fingers digging into Killian’s narrow hips. Him grinding
against Killian’s ass.

Kill.

Kill.

Kill.

The slivers of control I'd been clinging to, snap, and rage boils over.

I lunge to unleash my pent-up frustration on this man who thinks he can touch what is mine. There's a muffled gasp as my hands tighten around his throat. His eyes grow wide, pupils dilated, face reddening quickly as he panics and claws at my hands to escape my grasp.

I drag the smaller man further down the alley until we're bathed in darkness. Hidden in the shadows, I shove him to the ground, straddle his pelvis and lean down close to his ear as I release my hold on his throat.

Gasping, his arms swing wildly, but in his inebriated state, I'm faster, and quickly subdue him by holding his thin wrists above his head. "He. Is. Mine!" I growl against his ear.

"Wha—what're you talkin' 'bout?" he asks. "I—I dunno what you're—"

Pressing my finger to his lips, I shake my head. "Beg me to kill you." I draw my knife from its sheath and point the tip of the blade to the soft flesh beneath the man's chin. Tears stream from the corners of his eyes as he shakes his head and bucks his hips.

"Beg," I repeat.

"No! Ple—please, noooo." He squeezes his eyes shut and chokes on a sob, head shaking frantically.

"Not good enough," I scold. With one hand pressed hard over his mouth and nose, I stare into his eyes as I shove my blade upwards. The sharpened tip pierces into the hard palate at the roof of his mouth, and I keep my eyes fixed on his.

A horrified expression steals across his face, an aphrodisiac that calms my corrupted soul and satisfies my murderous urges. I forcefully twist the blade then draw it out slowly, watching as blood oozes from the gaping wound and the man's life is finally snuffed out.

I lean down and inhale long and deep, my lips mere inches from his as I draw in the decadent scent of fresh, crimson blood. The urge to taste is strong, but stronger is my desire to find Killian.

After wiping off my blade on the man's now bloody, white shirt, I tuck my knife away and pull out my phone to text Salem to get rid of the body. Then, without a backwards glance, I head back inside the club.

It takes ten minutes to find Killian. He's in the VIP Lounge, straddling August's lap. August's hands stroke Killian's thighs as he nuzzles at Killian's smooth, pale neck. When their lips meet in a soft kiss, I narrow my eyes, pondering the ways I could kill August with my bare hands, when finally, Killian stands.

After a quick conversation with August, he leaves the lounge. I make my way through the crowd on the dance floor until I reach the back of the club. I assume he's heading to the bathroom, and I head the same way, reaching it first.

There are two men inside. "Out," I growl. They both turn to me from their positions at the urinal, frowns mar their expressions. "Get out," I say again.

This time, their eyes grow wide before they drop their gazes and obey. "Sorry, Mr King," one of the men murmurs as he passes by me on the way out the door.

After turning away another two men, I'm finally alone.

I wait by the door for my prey to arrive. From my vantage point, I can see who's entering through the large mirrors along the bathroom wall. Luck is on my side when the door is pushed open, and a head of black curls comes into view.

I grab him from behind, lock the door, and drag a kicking and struggling Killian into one of the cubicles. I press one hand over his mouth, and he lashes out. His hands scramble for purchase until I shove him hard against the wall and grip his wrists with my other hand. Unzipping my pants draws my hand away from Killian's mouth and allows him the opportunity to cry out.

"What the fuck? My boyfriend is outside the door waiting for me, let me go!"

Oh, my lovely little liar. "Shhh..." I breathe into his soft, ebony curls.

He kicks back, his heel searching for my shin. With my taller, stronger body splayed against his, he doesn't have a chance to move again. I shove Killian's pants down and slide my fingers between his ass cheeks. Instead of feeling his tight, bare hole, there's the end of a warm, steel plug.

A low growl leaves my lips. I tug the plug out roughly before reaching back to drop it into the toilet bowl. Killian lets out a whine when I

shove two fingers deep inside his already prepped ass. He groans out a cry of what I know is relief as I finger fuck him hard and fast.

I let go of his wrists, satisfied he's not going to try to fight or run, and I spread my hand over his throat and squeeze, digging my fingernails into his soft, delicate flesh.

"I've seen you watching me, Killian." He gasps, squirms, and rocks against me as though he doesn't know what to do with his body. "I see you everywhere. Stroking your perfect, needy cock." Desperate whimpers and heavy pants leave his lips with each frantic beat of his heart. "I see you, watching from the shadows."

"Please. I—I want... ahhh," he begs.

Without another word, I release my cock from my boxer briefs and slide into him, thrusting hard and deep, pounding him into the wall as my grip around his throat tightens.

"Please," he cries out. "Please, let me see you."

With my free hand, I curl my fist around his hard cock, and with a punishing grip, I stroke him fast.

Killian lets out a long, desperate whine. "Ahhh, please, pleasepleaseplease. I want to see you." His broken sobs send a wave of pleasure rushing down my spine.

When he tries to turn his head, I command, "Close your eyes."

He obeys immediately. I trail my tongue up his jaw to his cheekbone, gathering salted droplets in my mouth, savouring the taste of his glorious tears.

Chest heaving, Killian's cries spur me on.

I thrust into his ass while simultaneously stroking his cock. Mouth open, I breathe against his temple, my tongue darting out to taste his sweat covered skin.

When I feel his ass clench around my cock, I murmur against the shell of his ear, "Come for me, little hunter." With those whispered words, he cries out and his release paints my gloved hand and the wall of the cubicle, and with a final, tight squeeze of his throat, he passes out.

As he loses consciousness and falls into me, my release fills him, wet and hot.

Finally, I've claimed him.

I wrap one arm around his shoulders to hold his limp body in place while I pull out of his ass and adjust my clothing with my free hand. After

tugging up Killian's pants, I lift him into my arms and press my lips against the seam of his plush mouth.

When his head lolls back, his mouth falls open and I dip my tongue in, savouring his taste, allowing it to sit on the tip of my tongue until I've calmed myself enough to head back out.

* * *

KILLIAN

"Help!" a loud, masculine voice shouts. "Someone help!"

A light, euphoric sensation smothers me. Ecstasy courses through my veins. It feels like every fibre of my entire being is floating on the cusp of an impending orgasm.

"What happened?" someone asks.

"OH MY GOD, Killian!" That voice I recognise. It's August.

"I found him in one of the cubicles," a deep, familiar voice says close to my ear. "Looks like he passed out."

"Here, give him to me," August says.

A second set of arms tighten around me as the comforting, masculine scent disappears, and I'm pulled into August's strong arms.

"What happened?" August asks.

I keep my eyes closed. As the euphoria from minutes ago subsides, there's a twinge in my ass, and my body feels off, as though my muscles have been overused and exhausted to the point of pain. Blinking back into consciousness, I take in the faces surrounding me and I struggle to get to my feet.

"Killian, what the fuck happened?" August demands.

"Give him a minute to come to," that deep, sexy voice says.

I rub my eyes with the heels of my hands and look up.

It's him.

My killer.

My devil.

Diablo King.

He stares back at me, dark eyes blank and emotionless.

For the first time, I get the opportunity to take him in properly. His neck, adorned with dark tattoos. What appears to be a death moth covers his throat, and just below it, something I can't make out is written in a gothic

style font. When my eyes trace the length of his body, I wonder what else he has hidden beneath that long, black coat, and the black suits he always wears.

“Please. Please let me see you.” My choked off pleas float through my mind. The urge to fall to my knees and beg for his attention, overwhelms me. My knees buckle.

August holds me up, concern in his tone when he asks yet again, “What happened?”

Blinking a few times, I shift my attention to my best friend. “I don’t—I don’t remember.” The blatant lie comes so easily.

August’s eyes narrow in suspicion, and a muscle in his jaw tics as he looks me up and down. “Were you raped... assaulted?” he asks.

“No. Fuck no!” I say adamantly.

“Kill?” August’s hand is gentle against the small of my back.

I shake my head hard. “I wasn’t, Aug. I’m fine, I think I had too much to drink.”

The memories from minutes ago tumble back into my mind, spinning, swirling, vibrant, erotic. My body still hums, and my ass clenches, the plug gone. Instead, I’m filled with his release that’s currently dripping down my thighs.

I bite down hard on my tongue to stop myself smiling as I recall his whispered command. *“Come for me, little hunter.”*

XIII

*Welcome to my world of lies
You'll never discover
What's hidden inside*

KILLIAN

Three days later

A tingling sensation prickles at the back of my neck. I whip my head around to scan the area. I know I'm being watched. I feel him surrounding me. For six, long years, I've followed him, and finally, he's noticing me. His dark presence hovers like a constant companion. Does he like it when I watch him? Does he shiver with anticipation, or wring his hands in concern at the thought of me peering into his life?

"Hey!" The guy leaning against the wall at the end of the alley slaps the side of my head then jerks his hips forward, forcing his cock further down my throat. "Keep sucking."

Closing my eyes, I wrap a hand around his length and pump him with my fist to finish him off. A few seconds later, his release spills over my hand and he quickly tucks himself away, throws a wad of cash at my face, then takes off.

I pull a few wet wipes from my backpack to clean my hands and face, then I tuck the cash into my back pocket. At the same time, my phone vibrates, and I tug it out to check the message.

Gavin: Where are you?

Me: Main Street

Gavin: Get back here ASAP!

Sighing, I grab my backpack off the ground and sling it over my shoulder.

At the opening of the alley, a strong hand is pressed against my chest, and I'm shoved back into the brick wall. I let out a gasp.

"Where are you off to so fast?" August asks.

I bat his hand away. "Gavin wants me back asap. I gotta go."

August narrows his eyes, his fingertips come up to trace my throat. When he lifts his gaze, a frisson of excitement courses through my veins.

“You coming home tonight?” he asks.

Nodding, I open my mouth to speak, but August leans in close, his hand planted on the wall beside my head. He whispers against my ear, “Good, I have something for you.”

I lick my dry lips. “Oh—okay.” I duck beneath his arm and take off, calling out, “Later!”

Less than five minutes later, the front door to Rafferty’s Pawnbrokers chimes when I push it open and rush inside. I make my way to the back of the showroom and head into Gavin’s office.

When I open the office door, I come face to face with a cop. I step back, crossing my arms around myself. Before I can ask what’s going on, the cop looks me up and down. “Killian Graves?” he asks.

I nod. He’s huge, with thighs the size of tree trunks and thick, corded muscles in his forearms. “Senior Sergeant Jameson Oaks,” he says. “I’d like to ask you a few questions.” He shifts his attention to Gavin. “In private,” he adds. His *don’t fuck with me* expression tells me he’s not the type to take shit from anyone.

Gavin stands, a warning in his narrowed eyes as he brushes past me.

When the door closes with a soft snick, Sergeant Oaks extends his hand towards the chair. “Please, take a seat, Killian.”

Reluctantly, I drop into the worn leather and wait.

He sits on the seat beside me and pulls out a photograph from the manila folder that was tucked under his arm. “Do you recognise this man?” he asks.

I peer down at the image of a clearly dead man with familiar features. What stands out most is the gaping wound across his throat. My fingers twitch, eager to reach out and trace them along the curve of the wound, and over his grey-tinged skin.

A flicker of a memory takes me back to last Friday night.

Kneeling in a dank alley, my hair was twisted around thick, unforgiving fingers as he thrust his cock into my mouth. The foul stench of body odour enveloped me when he shoved his filthy cock down my throat, causing me to choke and gag.

The punch to my temple came seconds after he came... all over my face. Another second later, I was shoved into the side of a dump bin, his rank breath wafting across my face.

As I tried to shove the man off me, a figure appeared from the shadows.

Dressed in black and wearing black leather gloves and that same black balaclava, I knew who it was. The man's expression turned to one of confusion when I allowed a full-blown smile to curve my lips.

"The fuck are you smil—" His words were abruptly cut off when Diablo stepped up behind him and shoved his blade deep into the man's side. As he withdrew the knife, Diablo's sinister smile and cold eyes met mine.

Fist tight around the hilt of the knife, he sliced the man's throat wide open before letting him fall. His head hit the ground with a thud, blood poured from the wound.

I stepped back, eyes wide as I watched the dark blood follow the cracks and crevices of the concrete.

Diablo took a step forward, our bodies inches apart. His dark, soulless eyes penetrated mine. He raised his gloved hand, and I waited for his touch.

Goosebumps spread across my skin. My heart felt like it was about to leap from my chest. The touch never came.

"Get out of here, Killian." Diablo turned and walked away, disappeared into the darkness as though he was never there at all.

And I ran.

My breath hitches, and it isn't until Sergeant Oaks says my name again that I realise my reaction isn't what he was expecting.

Panicking, I turn my back to him, desperately trying to wipe the hint of a smile from my lips. I bring my hand up to my throat and allow my fingertips to dance along the rough lines of my scars.

Another beat of silence passes before he continues, his tone soft, friendly. "Look, Killian, I'm not here to arrest you. A few people said they saw you with this man on Friday night." He reaches out, finger tapping the photograph in my hands. "Look at him. Take a real close look and tell me if you saw him."

I shake my head. "No, I don't remember him."

He hums softly. "What happened to your face?"

"Bar fight," I lie, this time adding a shrug. "Some guy couldn't take no for an answer."

Sergeant Oaks stands and digs into his pocket. He hands me a business card.

When I reach out to take it, he tugs it back and steps into my space. Voice low, he says, "This is the fifth man to end up like this after being seen with you, Killian. Another four are missing."

I clench my fists to hide the tremble in my hands as he continues, "Now, I know you don't have the skills to pull this off, but you know who does, don't you?"

I ignore him, not willing or able to speak. I need to get out of here before I give myself away. I'm already balancing on the precipice.

Sergeant Oaks' stern voice and dominating demeanour is causing my body to react in ways I don't want it to. He's silver-fox sexy, and with that grey hair and fatherly presence, the little boy inside me aches to be acknowledged, while the submissive inside me craves a firm, possessive hand.

Give in. Give in.

Not. With. Him.

When the voices in my head begin their chanting, I shake my head, but he must take that as my answer, and says, "Rumours say you have an avenging angel who goes by the name of the devil. Diablo King ring any bells?" Crossing his huge arms over his chest, he raises a brow, his body emanating strength and power.

I remain silent, swallowing down the lump in my throat. With one command, he could have me on my knees.

Push him.

Make him snap.

Force him to use you!

"NO!" I say out loud. I clear my throat, adding, "I know who he is, but I've never met him."

Sergeant Oaks narrows his eyes. "Look, kid, I don't know what's going on with you and King, but something ain't right, and I'm going to find out what's going on."

I finally find my voice. "I'm not a fuckin' kid." I scowl. "And I don't know what you're talking about." I shove past him and yank the door open to leave.

He grabs my arm and I jerk out of his hold, turning on him. "Leave me alone."

Without a backwards glance, I throw my backpack over my shoulder and storm out.

As soon as I step onto the footpath outside the shop, a meaty fist grips my biceps.

It's Gavin. He pushes me against the wall, face close to mine, he asks in a low growl, "What did you tell that cop?"

"Nothing," I say quickly. "I didn't tell him anything."

Gavin's eyes search my face for a long minute before he steps back, slapping my cheek. "Got another job for you." There's a cruel glint in his eyes when he chuckles and shoves a piece of paper into my front pocket. "Do whatever the fuck he tells you to do," Gavin says.

"Who is it?" I ask.

"It's—" He's cut off when Sergeant Oaks steps out of the shop.

His eyes dart between us. "Sergeant," Gavin says with a nod.

Ignoring Sergeant Oaks' stare, I turn and walk away.

* * *

I cross my legs on the thick, dry grass and lean forward to place a hand on the sun warmed, marble headstone. "Did you know it would come to this?" I ask the question into the still silence. "You lived—" I pause, a snarl forming at the corner of my lips. "No, you didn't live my dream. You died... that was my dream. My wish. You stole that from me." I curl my hand into a fist and rub it against the burning anger rising in my chest.

In the distance, the sound of a mower hums and the scent of freshly cut grass is carried on the breeze. Huge, old ghost gums stand tall, their leaves rustling, branches creaking. Behind me, the soft clink of chains catches my attention.

"Gavin said you took off. Knew I'd find you here," the familiar voice says.

Eyes still on the headstone in front of me, I say, "I hate him."

"I know, but you can't change the past, Kill." August drops to the grass beside me, one leg outstretched. Taking a black Sharpie from his jacket pocket, he leans over and in his messy scrawl, writes on the white marble, FUCK YOU KAS!

When he caps the marker and shoves it back into his pocket, I smile. "That's desecration," I tease.

“Would you prefer defecation?” he asks. “It’s all the bastard deserves.”

I laugh and shove him, but I rest my head on his shoulder as he lights up a cigarette. When he blows a puff of grey smoke into the air, I wave my hand in front of my face, forcing out a fake cough. “They’re bad for your health, you know.”

“You know what else is bad for your health?” Before I can reply, he adds, “Stalking. He’s going to catch you, Kill...” he trails off as he stubs his cigarette into my brother’s headstone. “You’ll end up like Kas.”

“He won’t do anything,” I say adamantly, then I frown. “Besides, I’m pretty sure I’m just a game to him. Someone to fuck with.”

“He’s Diablo-fucking-King. He doesn’t play games, and you promised you’d wait.”

It’s true. I did tell August I’d wait, but the urges inside me are getting harder to ignore, and so much harder to control. Now that I’ve felt Diablo’s touch, I need more. *I want more.*

When I don’t reply, August gets to his feet and extends his hand. “Come on, I got somethin’ for you, remember?”

“Fine.” I feign disinterest, but anticipation sets my heart racing. It’s been weeks since we’ve been to Snare, and longer since we’ve done a scene. With tendrils of hope growing, I take his hand, and he pulls me to my feet.

August’s motorbike is parked alongside the gravel road. He hands me the spare helmet and I push it down over my head as I straddle the back of his Harley. Clenching my thighs against his, I wrap my arms around his middle and breathe in the familiar scent of cigarettes and woodsy cologne as he takes off towards the highway.

When August pulls up in our driveway, I crack my neck and stretch my back before I get off his bike. Inside, I flop down on the sofa and prop my feet on the coffee table.

As August walks past, he runs his fingers through my hair, stopping to drop a kiss on my forehead.

I smile to myself. Having August in my life means I have unrestricted access to the kind of affection I crave. My innate need to be touched is something August has become adept at satisfying, and the fact that he doesn’t expect more, is perfect. There’s only one man I want, and I will get him.

“I’m gonna have a shower,” he says. “Book your next appointment with Kate, then get changed, we’re going out.”

Leaning my head back, I watch him go into his bedroom as I pull my phone from my back pocket. Thinking about my upcoming appointment with Kate has me groaning in annoyance. After my last session, I don’t know how I’m going to face her again. I never intended to reveal as much as I did to Doctor McCallister. Somehow, she wormed her way into my brain and encouraged me to spill some of my most closely guarded secrets.

Appointment reluctantly booked, I change into a clean pair of black jeans and a plain black tee. I pull on my leather jacket and exit my bedroom to find August tapping away on his phone.

“Where are we goin’?” I ask.

Looking up, he tucks his phone into his back pocket and smiles. “I got tickets for the asylum tour.”

Eyes wide, I stare at my best friend. “You’re serious?”

Nodding, he digs into the inside pocket of his jacket and pulls out two tickets to Newhaven Asylum’s midnight guided tour. Waving them in front of my face, he says, “I’d sing you happy birthday, but I know you hate today.”

I scrub my hands over my face. “Thank you,” I mutter under my breath.

August is right, I hate my birthday. It’s a reminder of my past. Of my parents, and my brother.

“*Sick. Sick. Sick.*” Gavin’s words. Kaspian’s words, the words of my mother and father, they all assault me. “*Sick. Sick. Sick.*” The flashback comes quickly and without warning.

Eighteen years old

Kaspian leans against the wall, arms crossed over his chest, his voice is heavy with accusation. “This is bullshit. Why don’t you trust me?”

I can’t open up to him. Can’t reveal my darkest secrets. Instead, I continue rummaging through my drawer for a clean pair of boxer briefs, ignoring his prying.

“I’ll tell Gavin you’re doing jobs on the side.” Kaspian’s smug tone pisses me off. Rather than start a fight I won’t win, I release a heavy sigh.

“You know everythin,’ Kas. And the jobs on the side... Gavin already knows about ‘em,” I lie.

Cutting his hand through the air, Kaspian shouts, “Stop lyin’ to me! I checked your search history. I know what you’ve been lookin’ at. It’s sick. You’re fuckin’ sick.” He lowers his voice, an attempt to placate me. “I love you, Kill. Let me help you.”

“You’re spying on me?” The anger I was trying so hard to bury, explodes inside me. An eruption of fiery rage. I shove him against the wall, my fists clenched around the neck of his t-shirt. “What the fuck?” The suffocating fog of betrayal has me sucking in a breath. I’m so fucking stupid. I should have expected this, especially from Kas.

Kaspian doesn’t back down and the hot burn of hatred bubbles up inside me. I shove a knee into his groin, grinding it into his balls until he winces in pain. Even in his vulnerable state, Kaspian’s hand comes up to my neck, his thumb brushes against my jaw as he looks deep into my eyes. “Please, Killian, let me in,” he begs.

I clamp my eyes shut, turning my face away from my brother. “Stop,” I say through gritted teeth. “I don’t want you.”

As though I never said a word, Kaspian leans in, his warm breath against my ear. “Well, I want you. And all those things you want, they’re not safe. I can keep you safe. I can give you something better.”

I drop my knee from his groin to step back. He grinds his hard cock into my soft one. “No one has to know.” His lips brush my earlobe and I recoil, backing up to the bed.

I step back. “No.” I say firmly. “You’re my fucking brother. It’s sick.”

Anger twists Kaspian’s face into a scowl and he storms towards me. “SICK!” he shouts. “You think fucking your brother is sick?” He paces the small bedroom, feet pounding the hardwood floor, his fingers tugging on the strands of his thick, blond curls. “You’re watching snuff videos. You’re jerking off to torture and rape and murder. That’s not fucking normal.”

As his tirade continues, I shove a pair of jeans and a black hoodie into my bag. I have no comeback. He’s right, I’m not normal.

Kaspian grabs my shoulder, spinning me to face him. “You’re not leaving,” he says. “I’m not letting you go.”

“I am,” I counter, pulling away from him and zipping up my backpack.

“I’ll tell Gavin everything.” He nods towards our shared computer where I should have known better than to not clear my search history.

“Every. Fucking. Thing,” he warns.

Shrugging with feigned nonchalance, I say, “Go ahead, I don’t care anymore.”

In a huff, Kaspian storms out of our shared bedroom and slams the door behind him. Alone in the silence, I sink down to the floor and curl into myself. Do it. Do it. Do it. The voices are relentless, the urges growing stronger each day. Do it. My mind fills with images of violence, torture, and blood.

My hands shake uncontrollably as I fumble for my phone and call August.

“Help,” my broken whisper turns into a choked sob.

August’s voice is urgent, “Kill, tell me where you are. I’m on my way.”

“Gavin’s. Kas is telling him everything.”

“Pack a bag,” August orders, “Meet me out front in twenty minutes.”

I end the call and get to my feet, slinging my backpack over my shoulder and shoving my phone into my back pocket.

When I reach the living room, I’m met with a barricade in the form of Gavin standing stoic at the front door. Arms crossed over his chest and revulsion in his eyes, he looks me up and down. Kaspian stands by his side, a sly smirk dancing across his full lips.

“You sick little fuck,” Gavin spits. “What else are ya’ into, boy?” He shakes his head. “Sick. Sick. Sick.”

Heart pounding, I spare a glance at my brother before shifting my gaze back to Gavin. “I’m leaving,” I say with all the confidence I can muster.

Gavin laughs. A low, sadistic laugh that sends a frisson of fear racing down my spine. His fist connects with my jaw, causing me to stumble backwards and hit the wall hard. A picture frame falls to the floor, glass shatters at my feet. Gavin’s hand wraps around my throat and he squeezes until I’m gasping and clawing at his hands. “You wanna die, Killian?” I fight against his hold, but at the same time, my dark, deadly desires creep in to remind me this is the kind of sick depravity I crave. “Want me to choke the life out of you, right here?”

As black spots appear in my vision, my cock hardens to the point of pain. Sick. Sick. Sick. The voices wail.

My eyelids grow heavy.

The front door slams against the wall.

I catch a glimpse of August's face before everything fades to black.

“Killian! Kill, snap out of it,” August’s voice pulls me back to reality.

I shake my head. “Sorry... flashback.”

August grabs my wrist and tugs me closer, his strong hands cup my cheeks. “Hey, wanna go to Snare afterwards?”

When I meet his heated gaze, I nod, knowing that August has the ability to give me something I need, something that will take my mind off the past and send me spiralling into the dizzying heights of pleasure.

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XIV

*The past is gone
You're here right now
And you play the victim
Oh, so well*

KILLIAN

The near empty carpark is shrouded in a thick, eerie fog as we pull into Newhaven Asylum's visitor entrance. As we get out of August's car, a blue sedan pulls up beside us and cuts their engine. Three people get out, waving as they follow us towards the large sign that reads *Asylum Tours Entrance*.

A thrill races down my spine as I take in the ominous grounds of the asylum.

From here, the upper section of the asylum is visible over the razor wire topped concrete walls. The red bricks of the façade, worn and cracked with age, are covered in a thick layer of dark, seeping grime, giving the impression the entire asylum is weeping with blackened tears. Behind the arched, barred windows, silvery moonlight catches on broken, jagged shards of glass.

A sea of stars scatters the vast midnight sky, and behind the asylum, a graveyard and a dense, dark forest threatens danger lurking in the shadows. The entire scene feels like it's been pulled from a horror movie.

A dark, hooded figure approaches from the other side of the closed gates. "Hey there," a woman's voice calls. When she reaches the gates, she pulls back her hood, revealing pale skin, oversized, black framed glasses, and a messy blonde bun atop her head. There's a soft clicking sound, followed by the low hum of a fluorescent light flickering on and lighting up either side of the gated entrance.

"I'm Fiona, one of the caretakers. Come on through, I'll walk you up to the asylum."

Gravel crunches beneath our feet as Fiona leads us through the rusted iron gates and down a narrow, tree-lined path illuminated by the glow of her torch light. The towering gumtrees creak and sway, the cool wind rustles their leaves, and knobbly branches reach out like gnarled fingers grasping at the shadows.

The imposing, double doors of Newhaven Asylum open with a loud creak as Fiona ushers us inside the white foyer. The lingering scent of mildew hovers in the air along with the hint of bleach and disinfectant. After brief introductions, the front door creaks open again and Fiona introduces us to our tour guide, Stefani, before she says her goodbyes and heads out.

Stefani is a striking woman with long, dark hair pulled up into a high ponytail. She wears black jeans and a black tee emblazoned with the words “Fairview Asylum Tours” printed across her chest above a silhouette image of the abandoned asylum.

Before we can proceed, Stefani hands each of us a waiver to sign, and instructs us to leave them on the table by the door. As I read through the legal jargon, I think back to the deaths that catapulted the asylum into the news shortly after they started doing tours.

The company behind the tours came under fire after a group of teenagers snuck into the asylum while it was closed. According to news reports, four teens died when the third-floor balcony they climbed up to via the building’s scaffolding, crumbled, sending the teens to the unforgiving concrete below. Three died on impact after suffering massive head and internal injuries, the fourth, a thirteen-year-old boy, later died in hospital.

After signing my waiver, I place it on the table as instructed and step back to stand beside August who’s leaning against the wall, hands shoved into his pockets.

When everyone’s form is signed, Stefani wastes no time delving into the history of the asylum. “Built in 1924, Newhaven housed over one hundred and sixty patients at its busiest time.” She points to a large, tarnished copper plaque on the wall, explaining, “In 1995, a fire tore through the children’s wing. Believed to have been started by an electrical fault, the blaze led to the deaths of two doctors and three children. Although the asylum never opened its doors again, this plaque was placed here a few months after the fire, in memory of those who lost their lives.”

I read the plaque on the wall,

**In loving memory of our dedicated doctors
and the three children who lost their lives.**

Stefani places her hand on the plaque, palm splayed open and a sombre expression on her face, as though she knew the deceased personally. After a brief second, she drops her hand and returns her attention to the group.

The older woman, who introduced herself as Jill, asks, “Did their families even care? Do you know why they were here to begin with? Those poor children deserve someone to remember them.”

Stefani nods. “Yes, they do deserve to be remembered. At the rear of the grounds, there’s a small graveyard, the boys are buried in the children’s garden, each one lovingly cared for by the caretakers of Newhaven Asylum. And yes, we do know why they were here, but I’ll save that for when we’re in the children’s wing.”

Jill nods in acknowledgment.

“Before we head in—” Stefani extends her hand towards a stairwell blocked by a barred steel door. “Parts of the asylum are restricted due to safety concerns. Please remain close, watch your step, and don’t go wandering off alone.”

August moves to stand behind me as Stefani pulls open a massive wooden door and leads us through. A clear path has been made through rubble and debris, and among the detritus, a few steel tables still stand, their tops dented and scratched. Above, the ceiling is a mismatch of boarded up holes, broken glass, and timber rafters that have stood the test of time. At the end of the wide, open space, the moonlight shines through a wide crack in the ceiling, allowing a sliver of light to penetrate the darkness.

As if searching for life among the ruins, the moonlight casts a glow on a lone wheelchair, its wheels and armrests tangled with weeds and vines.

“Do you know who that wheelchair belonged to?” Jill’s husband, Ezra, a tall, balding man with a beer gut, asks.

His son, a young teen who introduced himself as Marty after Jill told everyone his name was Martin, rolls his eyes. “Dad,” he whines, “how would she know that?”

Stefani’s smile brightens. “Actually, the wheelchair was owned by the asylum. The last person to use it was a gentleman by the name of Herbert Watson.”

“Did he die?” Marty asks, eyes wide with curiosity. “Was he crazy or somethin’?”

A flicker of irritation crosses Stefani's face, and although she smiles, it doesn't reach her eyes. "We don't use the term *crazy*," she states, a hint of annoyance in her tone. "While all patients suffered from some type of mental or psychological anguish, not everyone admitted to the asylum suffered from delusions or psychosis. In fact, Mr Watson was admitted after experiencing a severe breakdown after the death of his beloved wife."

Stefani leads us further along the path. "Despite restoration efforts funded by generous donations back in two thousand and three, the asylum fell into disrepair. Today, Newhaven Asylum is owned by an anonymous benefactor. He pays a small team of volunteers and caretakers to handle the upkeep of the buildings and grounds surrounding the asylum."

Wind whispers through the broken windows. Doors creak on old, rusty hinges, and the air carries the scent of decay and neglect as Stefani guides us towards an old wooden staircase. She opens and secures a steel door with a heavy chain, and it feels like we're stepping into the bowels of a prison.

My excitement intensifies as we continue the tour.

Stefani never falters as we pass each room, stopping to tell us about the patients, their afflictions, and the secret horrors that lay buried beneath the walls of Newhaven.

When a particularly loud gust of wind blows through a broken window, Jill's voice trembles, and she asks, "Are there really ghosts here?"

Stefani's smile turns into a wicked grin as she nods. "Oh yes. Newhaven is home to many ghosts. For those who believe, it's common to catch a glimpse of a figure walking the corridors, or hearing muffled voices or whispers as you pass by the rooms."

"Is there really horror stuff, too?" Marty asks. "My mate's girlfriend said there are recordings of patients screaming." While his voice never shakes, his eyes are wide, and his arms are crossed tight over his chest as he bites his bottom lip.

Jill raises her hand, her brows scrunched. "Is that true? What if we're too scared? Can we leave?" She peers down over the railing, looking towards the door we entered through on the ground floor.

I want to shout at these people. Tell them to shut the hell up so we can move along and see more of the asylum. August must sense my annoyance because he nudges his shoulder against mine, shaking his head with a knowing smirk.

“You’ll hear many recordings on the overhead speakers. And of course you’ll be able to leave,” Stefani responds calmly. She reaches out to give Jill’s hand a reassuring squeeze. “My colleague will be close by. If you’ve had enough, just let me know and he will escort you back to the foyer.”

Satisfied, Jill nods, and we finally continue along the landing.

At the end, where the landing looks out over the entire ground floor, there’s a sudden, loud bang that echoes through the asylum.

Jill screams, and her husband laughs. “Wow, honey, we just started,” he jokes.

Do it, Killian. Spinning on my heels, I scrub my hands over my face, desperately trying to ignore the voices in my head. They taunt, laugh, and mock.

Push her.

Kill her.

Do it, Killian!

“Kill,” August says against my ear, his strong hand grips the back of my neck and squeezes hard. His thumb brushes my nape before he tucks a finger over the edge of my leather choker and gives it a harsh, but discreet tug. It’s enough to bring me out of my head and force me to focus on the present.

After giving him a nod to let him know I’m okay, August drops his hand.

“I—I’m fine,” Jill stammers, her hand pressed against her chest. “Marty, give me your hand.”

He pulls away from her, scowling. “Muum... stop it. Hold Dad’s hand.”

“Okay, everyone. Let’s keep moving,” Stefani says after checking in with Jill.

As we walk through the dark corridors, we hear footsteps from somewhere above us and a chill runs down my spine. Adrenaline laced with fear courses through my veins. The feeling of being followed—or hunted—sends a rush of blood to my cock, and every nerve ending tingles with excitement.

Another loud bang reverberates through the speakers and off the dilapidated walls.

There's a crash of metal against concrete. An ear-piercing scream. Then nothing. A deathly, hollow silence hangs in the air.

My heart races as I search the darkness. I try to make out shapes. A figure in black. A shadow creeping along the wall. Footsteps. Another high-pitched scream cuts through the silence.

"Fuck!" Marty shouts. "That scared the crap out of me."

His mother scowls at his cursing, tutting and shaking her head.

His father laughs, trying to lighten the mood, but his face is scrunched in concern, and possibly fear. "Scared the hell out of me too," he says, eyes wary as they scan our immediate area.

"Come on." Voice upbeat, Stefani leads us to an open door as she says, "In this room..." but is interrupted by a blood-curdling scream followed by maniacal laughter coming from a speaker above the doorway.

When silence ensues, she continues, opening the door to reveal a small six by six-foot cell with cracked paint peeling off the walls. A single, steel framed bed leans on its side against the wall beneath a barred window. In the corner, what's left of the plumbing reveals a rusted pipe and a murky brown stain on the cracked and discoloured tiles.

"As I was saying," Stefani continues, "records show that the patient in this room would scream until her throat bled. One night, she managed to free herself from her straitjacket and violently clawed at her face before ripping out her tongue. The young woman proceeded to bash her head against this wall right here..." Stefani takes another step into the small room, hand extended towards a dark brown stain on the wall. "She was found dead the next morning by a nurse who later, unable to come to terms with what she saw in the aftermath, took her own life."

Filled with morbid curiosity, I ask, "Didn't they have padded walls or cells?"

Stefani explains, "Padded cells weren't used here. Patients who self-harmed were secured in straitjackets. Those who tried to hurt themselves further, were restrained to their beds and sedated. The records don't mention how this patient managed to free herself from the straitjacket."

After allowing us all a few minutes to take in the room, Stefani gestures towards a set of double wooden doors at the end of the corridor. "This is the children's wing. The ten rooms housed up to fifteen paediatric patients at any time. Low risk children were allowed to use the playroom for up to two hours a day."

A chill runs down my spine at the sight of the fire-damaged walls, and rotting, blackened doors. When I inhale, I'm positive I can smell the cloying stench of smoke and ash.

Goosebumps smother my arms when I consider my own childhood.

If my parents had even an inkling of what was going on inside my twisted mind, I could have ended up in a place like this. Cut off from the outside world, destined to live in a six-by-six-foot white walled room with only my own, depraved thoughts to keep me company.

Stefani pushes the door open, and as the old, worn hinges creak, the sound sparks a memory of the night I met August.

Sixteen years old

I pulled on the handle, the loud creak of the buckled steel door had me freezing in place. Hesitating, I scanned the area, searching the shadows for movement. The sound of traffic on the highway rumbled like distant thunder. Around me, there was nothing but the pitch-black darkness, and the sound of my own steady breaths.

Inside the dilapidated warehouse, I stopped to take in the vast empty space that echoed like the hollow void that was my heart and soul. I had nothing left to cling to, no reason to go on.

Confused by memories of pain and humiliation, I was spiralling out of control. My body was scarred and ruined. The abuse had taken its toll on my flesh and had seeped into the marrow of my bones. I wanted it, needed it, begged for it until my throat was raw and my voice was hoarse.

At first, drugs and alcohol were my only escape. They numbed my senses and blurred the nameless faces of those who used and abused me. The high never lasted, and my desperate search for pain was never fulfilled.

The voices in my head that were once merely monsters from my childhood, had returned as vicious demons, intent on ruining my life with their constant, agonising chants.

With each inhale, I thought about murder. I wanted to kill everyone who'd ever touched me. On every exhale, I wanted to die, to be stabbed, strangled, carved into tiny pieces, or eaten alive by savage beasts.

I danced with death every day, but death refused to let me lead.

I teetered on the edge of insanity, bleeding out and broken. I pushed my limits and went in search of danger. I was beaten to a bloody pulp over

and over again. Somehow, Gavin always found me and pulled me back from the brink before sending me out on the streets again.

As I took the stairs to the second level of the warehouse, I twisted the leather cuff on my wrist. The smooth leather against my scars was a reminder of the times I attempted to leave this world behind.

Each creaking step I took felt like a countdown towards assured destruction.

When I reached for the narrow ladder leading to the roof, a sense of calm washed over me. Welcoming. Knowing.

The inevitability of surrender.

By the time I made it to the edge of the corrugated iron roof, I felt like I was floating. Serenity smothered me. I was finally detached. No longer tethered to my depravities, I was ready to take the final plunge into the abyss.

Feet on the edge of the building, I extended my arms and raised my head to the heavens. Stars twinkled above, sparks of light in an otherwise empty sky.

I balanced precariously.

Blinked into the moonlight.

Inhaled.

Exhaled.

The chaos that consumed my every waking moment was about to end.

Solace awaited.

“Don’t do it,” a voice said from behind me.

“He killed them all?” August’s voice floats through my subconscious.

Kill them all. The voice inside my head is a fragile whisper, a gentle plea that begs me to listen. Kill them, Killian.

There’s a scream, then a loud gasp. I can’t tell whether it’s lodged inside my own throat, or if it’s right here in a reality I can’t seem to reach.

“Kill,” August crowds me, forcing my back into the wall, his body pressed hard against mine. “Killian, look at me.”

I blink once, then twice. Hushed voices come from nearby. A dim sliver of light shines through the cracked open door beside us.

“Hey, snap out of it,” August says.

I shake my head to free myself from the voices, and finally, I focus on August's face. His dark brown eyes framed by thick lashes, his full, pierced lip, and the rough stubble across his jaw. He runs his fingers through his long, black hair and pulls it into a low bun. "You good?" he asks.

Nodding, I scrub my hands over my face. "The warehouse," I admit. "I was just... remembering." I sigh, shaking my head. "I could have ended up in a place like this." I avert my gaze, cheeks burning with shame. "If they knew what I wanted, what I—"

"Come on," August says, cutting me off. He grabs my hand and leads me through the double doors.

On the other side, Stefani is gesturing towards the walls of a large, open space. The floor is littered with child sized chairs and tables, upended and broken as though they've been thrown haphazardly across the room. In one corner, a large, filthy teddy bear sits at an angle, its ruined, furry head resting on a stack of children's books.

What's left of the narrow doors that lead to the children's rooms, hang on rickety hinges, creaking softly when the wind blows through the exposed beams above.

"As you can see, there's a lot of fire damage here," Stefani says.

"You'll tell us about the children now?" Jill asks. "And the little boy who killed his family."

Ezra asks, "Darius Kingsford, right? He was the son of that serial killer, The Savage."

"Yes," Stefani says. "Darius Kingsford was a patient here in nineteen ninety-five. He was only here for about a week before he died in the fire."

She pulls a heavy, steel door open and when I step inside, I suck in a breath.

"Holy shit," I say in shock. I look at the once white walls where peeling paint is stained with rot and mildew. Still visible, but well and truly faded on the aged walls is the word DIE written hundreds of times up to where the boy must have been able to reach.

"That kid did all this?" I question.

Stefani nods. "He did. Darius was admitted to Newhaven after allegedly murdering his parents and siblings. The few records that were salvaged report that at the time, he showed signs of psychopathy. One

doctor believed Darius was born a psychopath, others said he was heavily influenced by his father, and perhaps even watched or assisted in some of The Savage's murders."

"How did he even manage to kill his whole family. He was just a little kid," Marty says. "Surely they could've stopped him."

"They were sleeping," Stefani explains. "No one expects to have their throat slit while they're sleeping in their own bed, in the safety of their own home. And certainly not by a child."

An image of Diablo enters my mind. His gloved hands and masked face. That wicked knife. The sliced flesh, and the blood that poured down so many chests after he callously slit his victims' throats while I watched on, mesmerised.

Jill, whose hands are covering her mouth, blinks back tears. "That poor child," she says. "At least he's at peace now."

"I remember hearing people say that his father fed him human flesh. Any truth to that?" Ezra asks while he cranes his neck to look up at the empty space where the ceiling once was.

Through the opening between the ceiling joists, the moon casts an eerie glow on the tiny room where a little boy was locked away for murder.

"There is," Stefani says. "After his arrest, some of Kingsford's journals were discovered. In them, he admitted to regularly feeding Darius human flesh."

"That's gross," Marty says, face scrunched in disgust. His parents nod in agreement.

Deep inside my own rotting soul, a spark of intrigue bursts to life.

How would it feel to be so utterly and primally consumed by another person? To be so viscerally craved that your body becomes their only sustenance. I picture Diablo again, this time licking crimson blood from his silver blade, tasting the essence of life directly from the body of his victims—from me. My heart races at the thought, and I turn to face the wall, discreetly pressing down on my growing erection.

As Stefani steps outside the room, there's a loud clang of metal against metal, then another scream of terror. Distracted by my thoughts, I don't expect it, and I jump, then laugh. "Fuck, that sounds so real," I say to no one in particular.

"Actually..." A sly smirk dances across Stefani's lips. "The recordings have been restored from old recordings of patients who were

admitted to the asylum back in the nineteen forties.”

“So it’s really not just some actor or somethin’?” Marty asks, eyes wide.

The sound of footsteps pounds up the stairs before breaking into a sprint.

We all freeze as the footsteps come closer.

A speaker crackles, and Jill and Ezra sigh in relief.

A cold chill brushes over the back of my neck. I shiver, trying to ignore the heat stirring inside me at the thought of being stalked through this abandoned asylum, and dragged to my bloody death.

As we make our way through the children’s wing, I take one last glance back to Darius’ room to see gloved fingers curl around the edge of the door and pull it closed.

I stop in my tracks, staring at the door, waiting for a shadow, a noise

“Killian,” August calls from the top of the stairwell where the rest of the group are waiting.

I rush over and apologise before looking over my shoulder one more time. I saw someone, I’m sure of it. *Go back, Killian.* I shake my head at the voices, trying in vain to ignore them.

The next room we enter is a morgue. There’s a chill in the air here, and the scent of death and blood lingers, though it has to be my imagination. This place hasn’t been a morgue for almost thirty years.

I look around the room, walking slowly, taking everything in. The quiet chatter of everyone else is background noise as I step around a spotlessly clean mortuary table and approach the cremation oven.

Surrounded by stone, the heavy metal door has a large, steel handle and a heavy lock on the front, but my eyes catch on something else. A dark, red ooze that seeps ever so slowly from the bottom of the locked door.

I extend my hand to reach out, to touch the substance so I can see if it’s what my mind is telling me it surely is. *Fake!* I tell myself. Tentatively, I reach out.

Soft, cool fingers circle my wrist and tug my hand away. “No touching,” Stefani’s voice is so quiet I barely hear her. There’s a warning in her eyes.

I glance back at the dark red ooze that’s becoming more obvious by the second. “Is that...?”

She squeezes my wrist, her long, talon-like nails dig into my flesh and send a tiny frisson of heat through my veins. She whispers, “No,” then she drops my wrist, claps her hands together once, and says aloud, “Who’s ready to see the next room.”

Slowly, I turn to head out, but not before taking one last glance back at the cremation oven. A shiver runs down my spine as I walk through the doorway.

“What’s up?” August asks, pulling me back as everyone else walks ahead of us.

“Nothing,” I say quickly, then add, “I thought I heard something, that’s all.”

August’s scrutinising stare gives me the once over before he smiles and shoves me forward. “Get your ass moving,” he says.

“The last room tonight is the wax display,” Stefani says. “It’s located in the basement where the temperature is controlled to keep the display from being damaged. We’ll be viewing it through a glass window.” Stopping, she points to a row of plastic chairs lined up against the wall. “If you have a weak stomach, this part may not be for you. Feel free to take a seat right here, and through that door over there...” She gestures towards the other end of the room. “Is a bathroom.”

“Yes!” Marty shouts. “Finally, some horror.

Jill groans, peeking through her fingers as though she’s playing peek-a-boo. “How real does it look? Is there blood and gore?”

“We aim for realism,” Stefani says, giving her a wink. “So we hope it looks real.”

When we reach the open door, I stand, waiting anxiously as heavy, black vinyl drapes part to reveal what looks like a scene from a slasher movie.

“That’s sick,” Marty says, rushing forward. “Dad, come look, it looks so fucking real.”

“Language!” Jill says, scolding her son. Her voice jumps an octave higher. “Oh my god.” She chokes, gags, then runs to the small bathroom in the corner of the room and throws up. Her husband follows her with a sigh.

Oblivious to everyone else, my eyes are glued to the body hanging from the ceiling by a thick chain that’s looped around a butcher’s hook. Bloody ooze forms at his mouth and from the raw, open gash across his

throat. Intestines and organs spill from the gutted man onto the floor where they sit in a pile of blood, flesh, and viscera.

Stefani begins talking, and while I listen, I keep my eyes on the wax model.

“When the asylum first opened in nineteen-twenty-four, one of the doctors was believed to have murdered up to thirty-five patients. They called him The Reaper. This model is based on a report by a nurse who later died from strychnine poisoning. In her journal, the nurse listed numerous acts of torture and extreme violence against patients, including live lobotomies, amputations, cannibalism, and necrophilia. She wrote that the asylum would regularly remove organs from comatose or non-verbal patients and sell them on the black market.”

“It looks so realistic,” Marty says. “Look how well they’ve done the hair. And the eyes are so...” he pauses then adds, “it’s like he’s real.”

Squinting, I take in the scene, searching for a sign that it’s not a wax figure, but a real, dead human. I swallow down the lump that rises in my throat as my heart rate increases. Fear and excitement war inside me as I stare at the man. The sickest, darkest, and most depraved part of my entire being wishes I was the one hanging there. The tortured victim.

My heart almost bursts from my chest and threatens to explode as my eyes lock onto a single, minuscule droplet of blood welling up at the corner of the man’s mouth. It traces a path down his chin, teetering on the edge of his stubbled jaw before it falls to the stainless-steel grate and disappears down the drain.

I watch intently, searching for something else, something to tell me my mind isn’t playing tricks on me. I train my eyes on his fingers, and when his pinky twitches ever so slightly, a small smile curls at the corner of my lips.

Cadaveric Spasm. While I’m no expert, I’ve researched everything I could find on the dead and dying, and the longer I watch the body hanging from the butcher’s hook, the more I know it’s real, and what we are seeing here is in fact a victim of a brutal murder.

The screams aren’t recordings. They were real, too, I know it.

Everything here is real. It’s not wax.

I bite down on my tongue to stop my smile widening even further.

“What the hell, dude? Why are you smiling?” Marty asks, shaking his head.

Steeling my features, I rub my hand across my mouth before replying, “It’s so well done, don’t you think? Imagine the skill it takes to make something look so lifelike.”

Feeling the weight of a stare on my back, I look over my shoulder to find Stefani glaring at me. She tilts her head, eyes dark and knowing as they study mine. She looks down at her phone and starts typing.

“Yeah, but that’s sick... you’re sick, man,” Marty says with a shiver of disgust.

Sick. Sick. Sick. Those words slam into me, tumble around inside my brain. My hands clench into fists, my jaw tics, and my heart races.

Kill him! The voice is back with a vengeance. *Kill him! Do it, Killian!*

There’s a thud, then a scuffle, and it’s not until I hear August’s voice that I snap out of my thoughts and come back to the present.

“The fuck did you say?” August growls. Marty’s face is red, his eyes wide with panic as August shoves him into the glass viewing window.

Marty shakes his head. “Sorry, sorry, jeez man, I’m sorry.”

I grab August’s arm. “Aug, stop, it’s fine. I’m fine,” I assure him.

A throat clears behind us and when I turn, Stefani is watching August intently. For a moment, she doesn’t speak, then, she clears her throat. “Everything okay here?”

August steps back, pats his hands over Marty’s chest, and nods once. “It’s all good, right, Marty?”

Marty nods furiously. “Ye—yeah, yeah, it’s good. I’m good.” He shifts his attention between me and August, before saying, “Sorry, I’m sorry.”

I wave off his apology and turn back to the murder victim. I need to come back here alone. I *need* to find out more.

XV

*I stalk you through the darkness
The chase is what you crave
Now tell me, little hunter
Are you really brave*

DIABLO

The sky is heavy and drenched in shades of graphite and pewter. To the naked eye, it's drab, colourless, and empty. Motivated perception causes most people to see nothing more than shadows and light, daytime and nighttime. They're blind to the changes that occur right in front of their eyes. Ignorant to anything that doesn't serve to excite, provoke, or arouse. Few will ever notice the shifting phases of the moon as more than circles, halves, and crescents, and even less will stop to take in the glory of the earth on which they reside.

Eradication of humanity would solve much of the world's issues, and while I do adore the thought of such an occurrence, it would unfortunately mean an end to what I am destined to continue.

Fat drops of rain tumble from the sky and land on the pavement. Ahead of me, the man I'm following pulls the hood of his jacket up to protect his head from the onslaught of the storm. His footsteps quicken and his elbows extend to the sides as he pushes his hands into his pockets.

As I gain on him, his strides grow longer. He doesn't turn to look over his shoulder. Fear tells him to hasten his steps, not to run... yet, but to put space between himself and the quickening footsteps coming up behind him.

We approach a busy intersection, him and I.

We are one now.

Him, the hunted.

Me, the ever-present, shadowed hunter, looming at his back.

He slams a hand on the pedestrian crossing button. The bright, red silhouette of a man warns him not to cross. Surprisingly, he doesn't.

His body moves, feet shifting, head almost turning, but not quite. He wants to look over his shoulder. He wants to see me. To look me over and calculate the risk.

Blip, blip, blip. *That wretched sound.*

The silhouette turns green, and he crosses quickly, upping his pace and breaking into a short, quick jog. We pass by a closed electronics store, the bright yellow neon sign in the window flashes 'SALE'. The next store is closed, its front window covered by a roller door.

Ahead, a fluorescent light flickers, electricity buzzes.

Jog, walk, jog.

He trips and stumbles, hands come out of his pockets as he flails, catches his balance, then continues, arms pumping by his sides as he breaks out of his jog and into a sprint.

Finally, there it is. A glance over his left shoulder. The hood of his jacket falls back revealing a mass of dark, wet hair. Eyes wide, rain splashing into his face, he sucks in a gasp of air, turns his head, and runs faster. His boots slap the wet footpath, water splashing up behind him.

I jog, easily keeping pace with his long strides.

When the footpath ends, he has two choices.

Left will take him home. Right will take him along the dark, gravel road that leads to the abandoned asylum.

Head frantically whipping back and forth, his shoulders rise and fall as he breathes heavily. I slip into a small alcove. Tucked away from the onslaught of the encroaching storm, I wait for my prey to make his decision.

"Fuck," he curses aloud, his instincts play havoc with his mind.

The rumbling of an engine approaches, wet tyres on slick bitumen. The car comes to a stop at the T-intersection, tail lights glowing red, the indicator flashing a fiery orange against the heavy rain. A few seconds pass before the car turns left around the corner, its tail lights disappear into the night.

Tugging the hood of his jacket over his head once more, my prey finally makes the decision to go left, too. A twinge of annoyance settles in the pit of my gut, but I trudge on. There's no point stopping now.

* * *

My prey enters the small, cottage style home and closes the door behind him. Through the front window, I watch as a dim light flicks on. He walks over to the window and stands for a long moment, staring through the sheer curtains into the darkness outside.

He knows I'm close, and I know he's excited. His fat little heart beats with anticipation. Blood pumping, muscle clenching and unclenching as much needed blood flows through its veins.

The storm hasn't let up. It gives me the opportunity to sneak into his home, unannounced. Before I take the steps to the back door, my phone vibrates in my pocket.

I press my back against the house, shielding myself from the rain as I pull my phone from the inside pocket of my coat.

"What?"

There's a muffled scream in the background, then Salem clears his throat. "Where the hell are you? You're supposed to be here."

"I have something to do first, I'll be there in an hour," I say.

Salem sighs. "You should have waited for me."

One of the cell doors slams and I hear Salem pulling the chain through the steel bars. "You have him?" I ask. "I thought we were waiting until tomorrow."

"That was my plan, but... Wait, are you outside? The fuck, D, it's pissing down," Salem says.

"Yes, I am aware. You called me as I was about to go inside." The bathroom light goes out and I remain silent for a beat.

"D?"

"I have to go," I say, lowering my voice. "An hour," I remind him.

"An hour," he repeats, and he ends the call.

A clash of thunder smothers the sound of the unlocked back door being cracked open. *Perfect*. I shuck off my long, hooded coat and hang it on one of the hooks behind the laundry door, then I kick off my wet boots. Moving quietly, I make my way out of the laundry, through the kitchen, and into the living room.

A squat lamp with a beige shade sits on a narrow timber side table beside an empty coffee mug and half a packet of Tim Tams. The lamp creates a soft, yellow tinged glow that highlights the green suede sofa and the coffee table.

I freeze in place for a second, listening intently before I manoeuvre my way around the furniture and head towards the arched opening of the hallway. There's some rustling of bedding, and a minute later, the bright

light from beneath the bedroom door is gone, replaced by a dim sliver of lamplight.

I take a tentative step forward, then another, and one more. Another silent step brings me to the bedroom door where my prey awaits. I reach out slowly, my hand hovering over the round doorknob. After counting down ten seconds in my head, I turn the handle and slowly push the door open.

The familiar scent of his aftershave and cologne fills my nose.

He gasps, and I cock my head and take in this man. My man—*my prey*—who has a literal death wish. “Hello Killian,” I say evenly.

“You—y—you—” His mouth gapes open, and damp, black hair hangs in messy curls around his face. I imagine force feeding him my cock, wrapping my fingers around his throat, and tightening my grip until that perfect face turns mottled shades of purple and blue.

I take a step forward.

Killian attempts to scoot back on the bed, bringing his knees up to his bare chest. His fists are clenched so tight in the pillows either side of him, his knuckles have turned white.

“You—you came,” he says. His expression of awe floors me. He wants this. Desperately.

I step forward again. He licks his lips then bites the inside of his cheek.

Narrowing my eyes, I ask, “You thought I’d ignore you after our last encounter?”

“I th—thought,” he stutters. “I didn’t know if...” When he eyes his phone on the mattress, I leap forward, swiping it away with the back of my hand before I climb onto the bed, yank him down by his ankles, and straddle his thighs.

“Please,” he says breathlessly.

I press my hand hard over his mouth and nose until panic takes over and his body trembles beneath me.

He shakes his head, his brain in survival mode as he tries to suck in much needed oxygen. He wants to die, craves it with an ache so powerful it’s all he thinks about, but his body will betray him until the very end. His skin turns from pale pink to bright red as my hand halts even an ounce of air from getting into his lungs.

As he thrashes beneath me, my erection strains. I reach down, one hand still smothering his mouth and nose, the other reaching between us to

tug down his boxer briefs. When my knuckles brush over the swollen head of his erection, he whimpers and kicks out. I slip my hand down slightly so he can breathe through his nostrils. They widen with each lifesaving inhale. Tears trickle from the corners of his eyes as he continues to whine and writhe.

Now that he's breathing, albeit with difficulty, he bucks his hips towards me, a desperate, pathetic attempt to seek friction on his aching cock.

I lean down, whispering against the shell of his ear, "This is what you wanted, isn't it?"

Eyes wide, he nods frantically.

I free his cock from his underwear and wrap my hand around his hot, hard length. "You're so hard, so desperate for my touch."

More muffled whining comes from his muted lips. His hands come up, fists clenched tight, but when he meets my gaze, I shake my head slightly. A warning. Fear flashes in his eyes, quickly replaced by heat. His hands drop back to his sides, gripping the white sheets.

I pump his cock once with a grip that's far too tight to be anything but painful. He squeezes his eyes shut, more salted tears trickle down to his hairline as his chest heaves and he sobs into my hand.

"You want more?" I ask, giving him another brutal jerk. "Harder?" I tighten my hand around his length.

He shakes his head, then nods, a low whine comes from deep in his chest.

Breathing in his clean, fresh scent, I whisper against his ear, "You are flawless." I loosen my grip and brush my thumb over his crown, gathering his precum and using it to slick his dry shaft. "I want to know what you'll look like when I cut you open." With a slow, gentle stroke, I continue, "My little hunter becomes the prey." I lift my hand and Killian sucks in a lungful of fresh air before he pulls his bottom lip between his teeth, biting down hard.

"Please..." This time he's begging. Not for his life, though. He's begging for his death. He raises his hips again, and I grip his cock, clenching my fist around it until he lets out a cry of pain.

"Beneath this flesh..." I stretch my fingers and reach out to curl them around the smooth expanse of his scarred throat, and I squeeze. "I

know you'll be just as perfect. A delicious carcass to butcher. A gorgeous mass of raw flesh and crimson blood."

I simultaneously choke him and jerk him off in fast, brutal strokes. Precum leaks from his crown, dribbles down his shaft and over my hand. The scent of sex and fear hovers beneath my nose, a heady rush of erotic pleasure.

His eyes are fixed on mine and his garbled pleas send a shiver of delight down my spine. "Diablo," he cries out. "Please!"

My cock hardens as his face turns purple and his eyes roll back. "Your death, little hunter... it will be magnificent." I unbutton my pants and free my cock from the confines of my boxer briefs. When I wrap my fist around both our cocks and my piercings rub against his shaft, Killian lets out a desperate whimper. "And when I finally taste you, when I devour your sweet flesh, and lick your essence from my blade..." I close my eyes and let out a groan of pleasure, imagining the taste of his flesh on my tongue. "Your heart will be mine—" I glide my free hand up to where the precious organ beats beneath his ribcage and dig my nails into his chest. "It will take pride of place among my most treasured possessions." I draw my knife from its sheath.

When he catches a glimpse of the silver blade, he panics and tries to scramble away, even as his cock, still tight in my hand and throbbing against mine, continues to leak.

I press the tip of my blade to his flank and nick his pale flesh. Blood seeps from the wound. I smooth the flat side of my blade across the crimson stain, smothering the knife in his blood.

As I drag my tongue along the length of the blade, Killian watches, eyes ablaze.

"Please, let me taste—" Killian's voice quivers. "I want—"

I cut him off, releasing our cocks to lean down and slam my mouth over his, to devour his cries, his moans, his whimpers.

When his hands come up and lace around the back of my neck, I allow him to pull me closer, to nip at my lips and bite my tongue as it thrusts into his needy mouth.

While our lips meld, I grind against him, wanting... needing. I reluctantly pull away from his mouth and sit upright to drag my knife across the expanse of his tattooed abdomen. As blood beads to the surface, I move

up an inch and drag the sharpened tip across his flesh again, and again, and again. Blood slowly oozes from the wounds.

I drop my knife on the bed and smooth my hands over his abdomen and chest, smearing the blood across his torso before I take our cocks in my fist again and stroke us, hard and fast.

Killian pants, and when I shove two bloody fingers into his mouth, he sucks them greedily. I force them in further, pressing down at the back of his tongue until my fingers slip into his throat and he gags around them. At the same time, my orgasm builds.

Killian's rock-hard cock pulsates against my own and a few more brutal strokes is all it takes for him to spill over my hand.

As my own release spills over, I continue jerking him off, squeezing, and rubbing my thumb over his sensitive crown until he's crying and begging me to stop.

I don't stop.

I stroke, tug, and squeeze his limp cock with one hand, while I use my other hand to smear his come and blood, mixing it to create a lovely pink tinge that matches the blush on Killian's flushed cheeks.

Slowly, he begins to harden again, needy whimpers and garbled pleas spilling from between his perfect lips. I tighten my fist around the bone handle of my knife and raise it in the air.

Killian's breaths come out in fast pants as he begs, "Please, do it. Pleasepleaseplease, Diablo."

Not yet!

I bring my knife down hard, plunging it into the pillow mere inches from Killian's head.

He lets out a loud, hoarse cry, and I lean down again, slamming my mouth over his, tongue fucking him. I slide my hand under Killian's head, tighten my fingers in his thick, dark curls, and pull on the ebony strands until he cries out.

Spreading his legs with my knees, I use the combined blood and come as lube to slick my cock before I position it at his hole.

Killian sucks in a ragged breath as the crown of my pierced cock penetrates him. With one long, hard thrust he whimpers as one by one my Jacob's Ladder barbell piercings slip into his tight ass.

"Hurt me," he begs against my mouth. "Hurt me, kill me." Tears leak from the corners of his eyes, and when his hand covers mine on the

handle of my knife, he begs, “Stab me. Make me bleed, I—I need it.” A choked sob spills from his lips. “I want it.”

Cheeks red and wet with tears, Killian’s bottom lip quivers as I thrust into him. His face is a picture of pain, of innocence, and of a need so desperate I have to slam my eyes shut to stop the thoughts that relentlessly assault me.

Taste.

Devour.

Kill.

“Mine,” is the only word that leaves my lips. “You.” Thrust. “Are.” Another, vicious thrust. “Mine.” I growl into his mouth.

I flatten my body over his, plunging into him, deeper with each thrust of my hips.

I reach between us, take his hot, hard length in my hand, and begin pumping him from root to tip. Our kisses turn frantic, teeth clash, tongues tangle for dominance, and I bite down hard on his bottom lip until the taste of his blood coats my tongue. I lick my way along his jaw and down his neck until I reach his shoulder, and I bite down again. When my teeth finally break through his skin, I suck his blood into my mouth.

My cock pulsates inside his tight ass, and he cries out in pleasure.

I lift my head and stare into aquamarine eyes. I watch him watch me, his pupils dilated, breaths frantic.

When I hit his prostate and his mouth opens on a silent cry, I allow his blood to dribble from my mouth into his. The crimson stain looks decadent smeared across his full lips, and when he swipes his tongue over them to gather the blood, I stare in awe.

Killian plants his feet on the bed either side of me and forces his ass onto my throbbing cock, a second later, I’m coming, and his own release spills over for the second time tonight.

When I pull out, Killian lets out a whimper. “Don’t,” he says, “I want—”

I press my hand over his mouth. “This isn’t about what you want, my little hunter,” I remind him. “It’s time you learned your place.”

I wrap my hand around the front of his throat. Pressing my thumb into the soft flesh beneath his jaw, I squeeze. This time, he doesn’t fight, he doesn’t writhe, or beg, or plead. He simply stares into my eyes, a serene

expression on his face as the light in his eyes slowly fades and he loses consciousness.

Mine.

I can't kill him.

Mine.

I need him.

Mine.

"FUCK!" I shout.

I wipe my hands on the sheet and tug up my pants.

After retrieving my phone and my coat from the laundry, I return to the bedroom and sit on the end of the bed to call Salem.

"You're late," he says as soon as he picks up.

"I fucked up," I admit for the first time in my life.

"Diablo?" Salem says slowly, "What have you done?"

I glance back at Killian, he's covered in blood and our combined releases. There's an ache in my chest and when I press my fist against my heart, I can feel it pounding against my ribcage. I suck in deep breaths, each one ragged and desperate.

"DIABLO!" Salem's shout draws my attention away from Killian.

"Killian," is all I say. "I—Salem, what the fuck is happening to me?" The glint of my knife on the side of the bed catches my eye. I swipe it up, fisting the handle.

I hold it up, staring at the silver blade. "Savages," I whisper into the silence. "I have to kill them—*kill him.*"

Salem's voice is a fading echo. "Fucking hell, stay there, I'm on my way."

I drop my phone and the knife on the floor.

Elbows on my knees, I lean forward and stare down at my blood covered hands.

* * *

An hour later, I'm in the basement of the asylum watching Salem put the finishing touches on the human-size, golden cage he's been working on for six months.

He lifts the welding mask from his head and peruses his work before turning his attention to me. "So, let me get this right. You can't kill him

because he *wants* you to kill him?” His brow creases in confusion. “That’s what we do. What’s the problem here, D.”

Scowling, I avert my gaze and trace my fingers over the skull that sits on the work bench. “I don’t want to give him what he wants.” Turning, I cross my arms over my chest. “I want him to fear me. I want him to beg for his life.” I let out a huff of annoyance. “He’s too easy.”

Salem shakes his head. “Let him go then, find someone else. There’s no shortage of *unwilling* victims—”

There’s a quiet moan from the other side of the room. Salem’s head whips around, a smile stretching across his lips. “Finally,” he whispers as he removes his welding mask and paces towards the barred, steel cells.

“Please, let me go,” the quiet voice begs.

With his firebird awake and talking, Salem’s sole focus has shifted, so instead of worrying about Killian, I follow Salem to the cells.

Salem wraps his hands around the bars of the cell. “You know I can’t do that, baby. The ball is in two days. I need to prepare you.”

Inside the cell, the man is huddled in the corner. Naked and shivering, his arms are wrapped around his knees. When he sees me, he raises his head. Green eyes meet mine before quickly flicking back to Salem. “I—I don’t want to, Salem, please... don’t make me do it again.” He sniffs, then chokes back a sob. “Please let me go.”

An idea comes to mind, something that could work to instil fear into my courageous little hunter. “Perhaps he needs a friend,” I say to Salem.

Glancing over his shoulder at me, Salem smiles before turning his attention back to the man in the cell. “What do you think, my little firebird? Would you like a new friend?”

The man shakes his head frantically. “No, nonono. No, I—I’m fine. I don’t want anyone.”

Laughing, I take another step forward. “Don’t worry, this one won’t end up like your last friend, I can assure you of that.”

The man’s eyes dart between me and Salem, then over my shoulder to where the skull sits on the workbench. Miniscule remnants of the dead man still cling to the eye sockets and bone, giving the skull a dishevelled appearance.

“Perfect,” Salem says, peering into the cell. “I’m going to finish off your cage, then I’ll bring you some dinner.”

“I’m not hungry,” the man says quickly, his voice shaking with every word.

Salem’s eyes darken and his jaw tics. “You will eat,” he states, then turns and storms back to the other side of the room.

The man stares up at me. “Please, please tell him to let me go,” he whispers. “I need to get out of here.”

I smile, ignore him, and follow Salem.

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XVI

*His firebird
A golden cage
His little hunter
All on stage*

KILLIAN

Two weeks later

“August, we’re going to be late!” I shout from the living room. When there’s no reply, I shout again. “August!”

“Fucking hell, Kill, we’ve got an hour. It’s a ten-minute drive, calm down.” His bedroom door slams shut, and I fall onto the sofa, sighing.

Without August to distract me, the voices return.

He doesn’t want you.

You’re sick and twisted. That’s why he left.

Images of Diablo flicker through my mind. The way he touched me, rough one minute, then gentle the next. My blood on his hands, my come on his lips, and the heated look of hunger in his eyes as he stared into the depths of my soul and choked me into unconsciousness.

When I woke alone, covered in my own blood and our combined releases, disappointment tore through me. My need to be touched by him is all consuming.

It’s all I think about.

He’s all I think about.

I want him naked and hard so I can explore his body inch by perfect inch.

I shake my head hard and begin humming along to the classical music August always has playing on his phone while he showers and dresses. The gentle lull finds me like a lantern in the dark and calms my racing heart. I tuck one finger under the back of my collar and tug on it until it’s tight against my throat.

“Where’s your mask?” August asks, coming out of his bedroom. In his hand, he’s holding his own black, plague doctor mask. Over his three-piece suit, he’s wearing a floor length, black, hooded cloak. According to

August, who's attended these balls in the past, the masks and cloaks are part of the dress-code.

"When's the first time you went to one of these balls?" I ask.

"I was fifteen, so twenty years ago. Gavin took me to the first one, actually."

"Do you think he was acting weird earlier?" I ask August about Gavin.

He shrugs. "He's always fucking weird, Kill. You know that."

"Yeah, but something was off," I muse aloud. "He seemed worried."

It was Gavin who stopped by this morning to tell us we were invited to attend the Hunters and Gatherers Ball at Monroe Estate tonight. After handing over the masks and cloaks with strict instructions that once we enter the mansion, we are not to remove them, Gavin left. The whole interaction took less than five minutes, and not once did Gavin attempt to intimidate or assault me, which is completely out of character for him.

"Forget about him," August says, "and focus on what you're really interested in." He raises his brow and gives me a lascivious smirk.

Of course, I told August everything that happened when Diablo followed me home. While he's still concerned about my obsession, he knows that after six years, there's not a chance I'm giving up on making Diablo King mine and forcing him to give me everything I crave.

"You really think Diablo will be there?" I question as I smooth my hands over my thick, velvet cloak.

"Oh, he'll be there," August says. "He's always there."

A small smile dances across my lips as I pick up my own mask.

August smirks, takes a step forward and cups my cheek as he leans down to press a soft kiss to my lips. "You look good, Kill." He extends his arm. "Shall we?"

Nervous and apprehensive about the night ahead, I only nod.

* * *

The back door of the limousine is pulled open, and a white gloved hand extends towards the paved path. "Welcome, sirs," the deep voice says as I step out of the limousine.

I give him a nod in thanks and turn back to see August getting out of the limousine behind me.

Our long, hooded cloaks billow behind us in the cool breeze as we pass by the security guards. Wearing black suits and plain, black eye masks, their eyes follow us, but they remain stoic, unmoving.

With the mask cutting out my peripheral vision, I turn my head to find August. While my mask is black leather, studded with small onyx stones, August's softly curved beak is lined with spiked copper studs, giving it a worn, steampunk appearance.

We stop at the bottom of the white, marble steps that lead into Monroe Estate's palatial mansion. "Are you ready for this?" August asks.

I nod, but pause, trying to get used to the weight of the mask. "I'm ready."

August's hand is gentle at the small of my back before he steps in front of me, whispers something to the masked door attendant on the left, then steps back as the two attendants pull the heavy wooden doors open.

A lump catches in my throat when I take in the opulence of the mansion. A long, red carpet stretches out ahead of us, lined by dozens of six-foot-tall, gold candlesticks. The black candles atop each one drip with red wax that looks like blood dribbling down the lengths of the candles.

Three chandeliers hang from the ceiling, each one lit up with more candles. The scent of wax, however, is non-existent, instead there's a lingering floral scent that hangs in the air.

In large, cut crystal vases, an abundance of flowers are grouped together in giant, colourful bouquets that don't quite match the surrounding décor.

I walk beside August in silence, taking in the grandeur as we follow the red carpet to another large doorway that sits between the curved staircases.

Two more attendants stand in their hooded cloaks, wearing venetian style masks. Again, August whispers to the attendant and the second set of large, ornate doors are pulled open and the sound of classical music fills the air.

When I step into the ballroom, the first thing I see are the giant, gold scales. Hanging from the ceiling by long, thick chains, the lower side of the scales holds a human sized bird cage.

Inside the gilded cage, a man stands, stark naked except for the leather harness that crosses over his chest with small, gold wings on the back. His wrists are chained to the bars of the cage, arms extended, he

mimics a bird in flight. The plague mask he wears is lavishly decorated with plumes of black and gold feathers, and a long, curved, golden beak that shines beneath the glow of the candle chandeliers.

The other side of the scales sits empty, leaving them tilted in favour of the heavy cage and its bird-like human captive.

“The Scales of Justice,” August says.

I can’t help stating the obvious. “They’re unbalanced.”

August lets out a soft chuckle. “Yeah, the scales are always tipped in favour of The House.” He extends his hand towards the polished gold scales. “There is no justice unless The House grants it.”

“The House?” I question.

“Come on,” he says, tugging on my hand. “I’ll explain it all later.”

As I gaze up at the cage again, my attention shifts to the domed ceiling. It’s intricately detailed with a hellish mural depicting a gruesome fight between a group of men with swords and shields, and another group wearing black plague doctor masks. Severed limbs, headless bodies, and rivers of crimson blood traverse through a city ablaze. Bones with ragged, torn flesh still attached are stacked to resemble woodpiles, some alight with orange flames, some surrounded by dancing skeletons.

In stark contrast, the ornate, filigree chandeliers cast soft, flickering candlelight across the polished, black marble dance floor.

Familiar, classical music plays throughout the cavernous space, and the rapid beat of the haunting melody reverberates off the walls of the ballroom. Couples twirl and spin with graceful steps, their hooded cloaks swish and flow as they move around the dance floor in time with the music. Each of the dancers wears a plague doctor mask, the beaks of each one embellished—I assume now—to reflect its owner’s personality, but unlike traditional plague masks, everyone’s eyes are visible.

August extends his hand. “We have to dance,” he says, pulling me close until I’m flush against his body. “I’ll lead,” he whispers, “just act like you know what you’re doing.”

Nodding, I place one hand on August’s hip, and clasp his other hand as he leads me around the marble dance floor. His steps are graceful as he glides, and I step quickly trying to keep pace with him. After a few minutes, my feet find their rhythm and we’re waltzing around the other couples.

As we dance, I’m enveloped in an otherworldly scene, reminiscent of a priceless oil painting. My body is thrumming, the music capturing my

heart and soul and sending me freefalling into this beautifully macabre world.

At the richly decorated tables, other guests huddle together in hushed conversation. An air of secrecy envelops them. Faces masked and identities hidden beneath a sinister veil of secrets I yearn to uncover. *Are they like me? Have I walked past them at Snare? Have I watched their naked bodies writhe in ecstasy, or witnessed them being choked, fucked, or bound? Do they know Diablo King the way I do?*

I have so many questions.

At the opposite end of the room, two arched, stained-glass windows frame the wall from floor to ceiling. The top of the red carpeted staircase leads to a white marble statue depicting the form of a headless, naked man. A fountain of red liquid resembling blood pours from the statue's neck, trailing down in long rivulets until it reaches a small pool at its carved, bare feet.

I stop dancing and take a step forward, eager to get closer, when, from the shadows of the landing, a dark figure in a tailored, gothic style suit appears. Gloved hands clasped in front of himself, he turns his head, scanning the ballroom as if searching for something—or *someone*.

When he takes a step forward, I catch a glimpse of the crimson lining of his suit jacket and the glint of gold buttons that adorn his Victorian style, ruffled shirt.

Hushed whispers fall across the room as one by one, in an almost choreographed fashion, every guest stops in place. When August's steps come to a halt, I stop beside him as we turn to gaze up at the man who wears an elaborately carved, gold, plague doctor mask.

He stands tall at the top of the staircase, observing the crowd as though they're peasants in the company of a god. He exudes strength and power, and for a fleeting moment, I picture him as an ancient vampire in a gothic castle.

Soft murmurs float around the room, the guests speaking his name until they're chanting as one.

"Diablo."

"Diablo."

"Diablo."

"Diablo." His name leaves my lips on a whisper. My eyes are fixed on him, and when his head shifts ever so slightly in my direction, I suck in a

gasp of air.

A hand touches my shoulder. I flinch before I realise it's August. "Told you he'd be here," he whispers.

I open my mouth to speak, but it's so dry I can barely breathe, let alone form words.

As Diablo's focus shifts, I follow his gaze to the other side of the landing, a woman approaches him. She's sheathed in a long dress that drops to a V between her breasts all the way down to her navel. The sheer fabric is covered in tiny crystals that shimmer beneath the chandeliers and matches the glittering silver mask she wears.

Diablo leans down slightly, whispering against her ear.

She laughs out loud, throwing her head back and revealing the long, slender line of her pale throat. After hooking her elbow through his, they make their way down the grand staircase as the music picks up and the guests take to the dance floor again.

As the dancers sweep by the couple, another man, this one wearing a silver mask, manoeuvres his way through the crowd until he reaches the woman and leans in close. He mimics kissing her cheeks before he turns and gestures to the far side of the room.

Diablo looks our way and nods once.

August pats my shoulder. "He wants to see you," he says, and before I can question him, he heads towards the threesome whose intense stares burn into the marrow of my bones.

I stop in my tracks. August comes to a halt beside me. Turning, I position myself so that my back is to Diablo. "Aug, you know *him*... you know them all?"

"I do," August says. "You want to know why I didn't tell you?"

I nod. "What's going on, Aug?" When I sense a dark shadow over my shoulder, I freeze.

Diablo's presence invades every fibre of my being. His eyes peruse my cloaked body as though he can see right through the heavy layer of fabric and into the depths of my soul. There's a flicker of heat in his eyes when his dark gaze meets mine, and I relish in it. If he let me, I'd kneel and worship this man until the end of time.

As if summoned, the man in the silver mask appears and extends his hand, distracting me from my blatant perusal of Diablo.

"I'm Salem," he says. "Lovely to meet you, Killian."

“*Watch.*” I know that voice, I’ve heard it before. “*Watch.*” Salem is the one who held me down. The one whose body smothered mine and commanded me to watch as Diablo slit the throat of the men in the hotel rooms.

I reach out and shake his gloved hand. “You—” I’m cut off when Salem raises a finger and presses it to the side of his mask’s silver beak. “Shhh...” he whispers.

The woman reaches out next and clasps my hand gently in her ungloved ones. “Stefani,” she says. “We’ve already met.” She winks beneath her mask. “The asylum.”

Blood seeping from the cremation oven.

The hanging man.

Her cool, calculating gaze.

Beneath my ribcage, my heart pounds with excitement, but it’s laced with building anger and confusion. For eight years, August has been my best friend. I’ve spilled all my secrets to him, trusted him with my innermost thoughts and depraved desires.

Why didn’t he tell me?

Eighteen years old

When the rumble of the car’s engine faded away, I crept out from behind the toolshed, my heart pounding like a jackhammer in my still heaving chest. Scanning the backyard, I cautiously made my way towards the house, the back door creaking on its hinges as I pushed it open.

Inside, the scent of blood lingered. Goosebumps prickled my flesh, and the hairs on the back of my neck stood on end as I walked through the kitchen and into the living room.

By the time I reached the bedroom, a thin sheen of sweat had formed across my brow. Anticipation and morbid curiosity kept my feet moving forward.

Door already ajar, I kicked it with the toe of my boot, staring at the scene before me as the door slowly opened. This close, the pungent scent of blood and death was so thick I imagined it was seeping into my pores, burrowing beneath my skin, a permanent reminder of what I witnessed—and found pleasure in.

Another step forward was all it took for me to see the brutality that had unfolded in the bedroom, and on the bed. The covers were bunched at the foot of the bed, crumpled around my mother's feet as though she'd been struggling to free herself. A bloody handprint was smeared across her thigh. My father's head, twisted at a grotesque angle, was almost separated from his neck, and the sheet beneath him was soaked with blood.

I approached with caution.

Inhaled.

Exhaled.

A deafening silence hovered in the room. As I leaned down to inspect the wounds on my parents, my fingers twitched, desperate to reach out and touch the deep, raw gashes on their mutilated corpses.

The bleeding had well and truly stopped, but I could see the lacerations between my mother's legs. The killer had shoved that wicked knife deep inside her and violently fucked her with it. The torn flesh and gaping wounds of my father's ass told me he received the same, torturous treatment.

I stood and stared. Waited for an inkling of grief or horror. A hint of fear, shame, or anything resembling sadness. There was nothing. Nothing but curiosity.

Why did he choose my family? And where was everyone else tonight?

It didn't make sense.

Shaking my head, I walked around to the other side of the bed where my brother lay dead, face down on the blood-stained carpet. His eyes were open wide, and I tilted my head, watching, waiting, wondering if this was all one of my sick fantasies come to life in the middle of a twisted dream.

I knelt by Kaspian's side, taking in the pallor of his grey skin, the mottled bruises around his neck, and the fingertip bruises that spread across his ass and hips.

I reached out, allowed my hand to caress the cold, smooth flesh of his ass. I trailed my fingertips up his spine and over his shoulder. I traced his jaw and ran my fingers across his blue-tinged lips. There was something beautiful about his death. Face slack, eyes cloudy, mouth hanging open. He was still perfect.

Do it. Touch him. Feel him. The voices encouraged.

Swallowing down the lump in my throat, I pushed a finger into his open mouth. His tongue was firm and cool, and when I added another finger and forced them down his throat, his head moved slightly. I inhaled, my cock hardening as I fingered my brother's gaping mouth. I leaned down close to his ear, the scent of blood and what I thought were the beginning stages of decomp, assaulted my senses.

Logic told me to recoil in disgust.

The sick, twisted urges inside me, told me to continue.

"How did it feel?" I asked. "Did you like it when he fucked you?" A sudden surge of anger tore through me.

I pulled my fingers from his mouth and slapped his face. There was no reaction. He didn't move, didn't flinch. Nothing happened. I slapped him again.

"Sick!" I threaded my fingers through his blond curls and yanked his head back before slamming it into the bloody carpet. "You're sick!" I slapped him again. "Fucking sick!"

I swiped at a tickle on my cheek. It took me a few seconds to realise I was crying.

I fell to my knees beside Kaspian, my hands hovering over his lifeless corpse as I pictured myself violating his cold, dead body.

Do it. The voices urged. You want it, Killian. Give in to your desires.

I leapt to my feet, kicked his body once, then again. With each kick I delivered to his still form, I screamed my hatred and anger until my voice was hoarse.

"Kill?" a soft whisper floated by. A familiar voice. "Killian!" the voice was louder this time.

I spun on my heels.

In the doorway, August stood, long, black hair a dishevelled mess that brushed his shoulders. Thick, black eyeliner lined his lower lids, slightly smudged, it gave the appearance of dark bags under his eyes. He took a step forward, the chains on his black pants clinked together.

"What happened?" he asked, voice calm.

"I—I..." I scrubbed my hands over my face, then froze. My fingers—my fingers that had only minutes ago been inside my dead brother's mouth, slid over my own, warm lips. I gasped, clenched my hand into a fist. "They were murdered."

“Yeah, you’re stating the obvious, Kill.” August took another step forward. “Are you hurt?” He looked me up and down, reached out and patted my shoulders, my arms.

I looked down at my brother’s body, turned to look at my parents. “I’m fine.”

The sound of sirens in the distance grew closer by the second. “I didn’t do it,” I said quickly.

August took my hand, squeezed it hard. “I know. Come on, we need to get out of here.”

I nodded, took a step towards the door, and stopped.

I rushed back to Kaspian’s body and felt around his neck for the silver chain he wore. When my fingers touched the necklace, I tugged it from his neck and curled my fingers around the jewellery before following August through the house and out the back door.

Diablo’s voice drags me away from the memory. “It’s time,” he says.

I stand between August and Stefani as the rest of the guests gather either side of the dance floor.

A hush falls over the ballroom as a single beam of light casts a soft, amber glow on the marble floor. Wisps of white smoke curl and writhe, the tendrils creating an otherworldly atmosphere. A hooded, cloaked figure enters the room and the crowd shifts in the shadows.

The man pulls back his hood to reveal white hair, dark, emotionless eyes, and a neatly trimmed, pure white beard. It takes me a few seconds to realise I know this man. Not personally, but I’ve seen him in the news, on TV, and on billboards around town. Chadwick Monroe. Mayor of Newhaven, and Governor of Iron Tomb prison.

“Shit,” I murmur in a low whisper.

His voice, a deep rumbling baritone, commands attention from every corner of the room. “Welcome to The House of Machiavellianism’s annual Hunters and Gatherers Ball,” he announces. “Each of our loyal members has invited a guest tonight.” He scans the crowd before his gaze stops on Diablo. “Tonight, all of your guests have been added to the ballot.”

There’s a loud gasp, what sounds like a choked sob from somewhere behind me. Confusion spreads through the crowd as the guests exchange whispers and murmurs.

Before I can make sense of it all, Chadwick beckons the invited guests to come forward. A few people step towards him, so I follow suit. I'm about to reach the centre of the dance floor when a loud voice cuts through the silence.

"Stop!" Diablo bellows. "What is this?"

I freeze in place, waiting as the two men face off, the tension so palpable it hovers like the zing of electricity in the air. My heart races as I wait for someone to break the silence.

Chadwick raises his brow, eyes dark as he glares at Diablo who storms towards him. When they're chest to chest, Diablo leans into Chadwick's ear. From where I'm standing, I watch his gloved hand curl into a fist. "I said no!" Diablo says loud enough for everyone to hear.

I turn, expecting to find August beside me, instead, he stares back at me from his place beside Salem. There's no mistaking the concern I see in his eyes, or the fact that he's not one of the invited guests, but one of the *"loyal members."*

"What's going—"

I'm cut off by Chadwick's voice. "You." He points at me.

A shiver runs down my spine as I cautiously approach, my eyes locked on his piercing gaze. When I'm standing in front of him, Diablo moves so that he's standing directly behind me. The heat of his body pressed against my back should be a welcome relief, but confusion runs the gamut in my mind.

Chadwick stares into my eyes, and his narrow. When he raises his hand, I suck in a breath, unable to exhale. He wraps his gloved hand around the beak of my mask and lifts it from my head to another round of gasps, and a murmured "Fuck," I know is from August.

Chadwick Monroe scrutinises me. He shifts his attention to Diablo, then back to me. "Do you know where your brother is?" he asks me.

I swallow down the lump in my throat. If I tell him, will Diablo get into some kind of trouble? "He's—"

Before I can finish my sentence, I'm cut off by Diablo. "Dead," he states.

Chadwick watches me, almost as though he's gauging my reaction. When I don't show any emotion, a sinister smirk twists his lips as he pulls my mask back over my head.

“Perfect,” he says before stepping back. “Salem,” he calls out. He cranes his neck to look up at the caged man. “Release your firebird, it’s time to hunt.”

He turns to address the crowd. “And at midnight, we feast.” As his words echo around us, a shudder runs through me at the thought of what lies ahead.

Applause and bellowing laughter now echo through the ballroom as guests begin to mingle again. Those on the dance floor stand frozen, like me, confusion clouds their wide eyes.

Diablo grabs my hand tightly and practically drags me to the far corner of the ballroom. He shoves me against the wall, slamming his hands against the gold embossed wallpaper either side of my head.

His mask brushes against my ear, the golden curve of the beak rests on my shoulder.

“I had other plans for tonight. Now they will have to change.” He sighs.

“This was not supposed to happen,” he says, anger lacing his tone. Diablo lets out an almost animalistic growl. “You will not die,” he commands. “Do. Not. Die.”

Die? The word sends shivers down my spine and my already hardening cock begins to ache. “What—Why would... What’s going on?”

The haunting music from earlier starts up again and Diablo steps back. Ignoring my question, he smooths his hands down his jacket. “It’s time,” he says sharply. “Follow me.”

I obey without question and follow him back to the dance floor. From the ceiling, the scales are slowly being lowered. Inside, the naked man looks down as the entire contraption descends silently.

Everyone backs away, except for Salem who walks towards the gilded cage.

He pulls out a gold skeleton key from a chain around his neck. Salem unlocks the ornate padlock on the cage door and steps back, pulling the door open and extending his hand.

Once freed, the naked, heavily scarred man takes two shaky steps towards Salem. I can’t see his face, but his body language conveys his terror.

Salem shakes out a cloak and drapes it over the man’s shoulders before pulling the hood up to cover his head. “Please,” the man begs, voice trembling. “I don’t want to, Salem, not again.”

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XVII

*Hunters in the forest
Are searching for their prey
Run for your life now
Run, run away*

KILLIAN

Sweat runs in rivulets down my back and chest as I race through the dense forest, jumping over fallen branches and side-stepping large rocks and tree stumps. It's so dark I can barely see my hand in front of my face. In the distance, spots of light flicker through the trees.

At first, I thought they were torches, but as I crept around the large trunk of a tall cypress, I saw the floodlights. Mounted high on top of some kind of timber platform, they shine from each corner, beams of light smattering the otherwise pitch-black night.

Every time I hear a scream, I stop in my tracks, squat down, and wait for the silence. I had no fucking idea I was going to be hunted tonight. This should be a dream come true, being stalked through the night, death on my heels as I literally run for my life.

There's just one problem, Diablo isn't the one hunting me.

This sickness inside me, the need to be ravaged, devoured, killed—it's not logical.

If it's not Diablo doing the hunting and killing, I don't want it. His eyes are the last ones I want to see. It's his hands I crave to have wrapped around my throat. And it's his lips I want pressed to mine, inhaling me as I take my last breath.

The moment I saw Gavin brandishing a long, curved knife, I panicked. I don't want to die at his hands. I refuse to give him that satisfaction. Thankfully, the fat bastard walked right by me less than five minutes ago as I crouched behind a large boulder. The rushing river smothered my heaving breaths.

"Shit!" a voice whisper-shouts from somewhere close by. "Ahhh, fuck!" There's a grunt of pain, then silence.

With careful steps, I creep closer to where the sound came from. One step, then two, then another. As I round a towering gum tree, I catch a glint of light from the corner of my eye.

* * *

DIABLO

“Darius!” Chadwick’s grip on my forearm is like a vice.

I grit my teeth and force a calm expression, but the leather seat of the Bentley is suffocating. Being this close to Chadwick brings back too many memories. Memories I want and need to forget.

“My name is Diablo,” I state. “Loren chose it for me, remember?”

Chadwick’s hand tightens on his thigh as his jaw tics and a vein in his neck flutters. A sense of triumph washes over me, knowing I can still affect him by mentioning her name.

“You haven’t told Killian who he is. Why?” he asks, brushing off my last comment.

I shrug, feigning indifference. “He doesn’t need to know.”

He hums, then says, “You will not kill him, I have plans for that one.”

A dark laugh escapes me as I turn to face him. “You think you can stop me?”

I refuse to acknowledge his comment about his plans for Killian. If so much as a glint of curiosity crosses my face, he’ll use it as leverage to manipulate me. While I am a master manipulator myself, the skills Chadwick has honed over the course of his life, far surpass my own, and he knows it.

Chadwick glares at me, and when I refuse to back down, he smiles the fake, sickeningly sweet Mayor Smile he uses to manipulate the public. “I allowed you to create Danse Macabre, and I may have given you free rein over Snare and The House, but I am still the leader. Remember who is in control of this city, Darius.”

I bite my tongue as a wave of anger threatens to consume me.

For years, I have been working with Salem, Stefani, and Liam on plans to overthrow Chadwick. He still has too many allies, and too much power.

The House favours him. To the senior members, age and wisdom, means strength and power. His rule has been challenged only three times since The House of Machiavellianism was formed in 1985, each time, Chadwick remained victorious.

On the surface, Chadwick Monroe puts on a charming façade as a wealthy and benevolent politician, committed to transforming Newhaven into a thriving tourist destination. The whispers of corruption, bribery, and murder that linger beneath the surface are quietly swept under the proverbial rug to cover up his misdeeds.

Those who challenge Chadwick's tenure as Mayor, or Governor of Iron tomb prison, fail dismally. Like his father, Connor Monroe was before him, Chadwick remains in full control of the city and its people.

"I am warning you, do not kill him," Chadwick says. "And Darius, if he is killed during this hunt, you will be severely reprimanded."

Inwardly seething, I ignore him and step out of the car to make my way towards the arena gates. I should have known better than to bring Killian to Chadwick's attention so soon.

Driven by lust and the intense desire to consume, I acted impulsively. Now, I'm paying the price.

I scan the small crowd of hunters that have gathered, finally spotting Salem at the gates to the arena, Stefani by his side. "I should have expected something like this tonight," I say as I approach them.

Normally, the Hunters and Gatherers Ball is just that. A ball followed by a feast. Adding the hunt is something Chadwick has never done before.

Stefani crosses her arms over her chest. "I bet he's having us followed again," she says. "Why don't you just kill him, D? There's nothing we can't do without him."

"It's not time," I say, "We don't have enough people on our side."

"So, what did the old bastard want this time?" Salem asks me. He pulls the gate open, and Stefani and I follow him through.

For a few minutes, we walk in silence. Other members pass us by, making their way to the viewing platforms that are strategically placed within the boundary of the arena. Each twelve-foot-high platform includes night vision binoculars so those not participating in the hunt, can watch it unfold.

When we reach the path that leads to our own central viewing platform, I slow my steps. "He warned me not to kill Killian," I say. "Said he has plans for him, although he didn't elaborate, and I didn't ask."

"I wouldn't be concerned," Salem says, tugging up his sleeve to check the time. "I think we should focus on our plan. Keep bringing them

down from the bottom up. It's about time for Devin to go, and if need be, Bruce will be next."

I nod once. "I agree." I turn my attention to Stef. "Will you let Estelle know we'll be calling on her?"

Stefani's childhood best friend, Estelle, joined The House twelve months after Stef did. With her meticulous attention to detail, and her ability to get into and out of places quickly and quietly without leaving a trace of evidence behind, she's one of The House's most valuable cleaners. Having her take Devin's place will remove another one of Chadwick's loyal followers from our midst.

Stefani steps over a fallen log, then turns. "Of course." Walking backwards and smiling, she adds, "We need someone inside Iron Tomb, something's going on in there."

I nod in agreement. "Yes, I know, but it's almost impenetrable. Everyone we've sent in has ended up dead. The guards are loyal to Chadwick."

"Anyone can be bought," Stefani says. "I'll look into a few of the new guards, see if anyone's willing to turn."

Satisfied for now, I give her the okay to go ahead with her plan as my mind returns to the reason we're here tonight. "I didn't get the opportunity to discuss the hunt with Killian," I say. An unfamiliar sensation spears my chest at the thought of my little hunter bleeding out on the forest floor, broken by hands other than my own.

"He'll be fine, Salem's firebird knows all the best hiding spots, and he's such a sweetheart he won't be able to resist helping the little hunter escape," Stefani's smile lights up her eyes.

Salem and I share a glance of frustration before sighing in unison.

Stefani laughs and shivers in mock disgust. "This is why I will never keep a man as my pet. So much fucking drama. You're both going to be ruined." She spins around again and jumps over another log. "Fuck them, kill them, eat them. It's not that hard, guys." Now dressed in a long, flowing black, hooded cloak like Salem and I, Stef blends into our dark surroundings and disappears for a few seconds behind a pine tree.

There's a high-pitched scream, then a gurgled plea cut off by a loud grunt. "Another one down," Salem says as we continue through the dense forest towards the viewing platform. Artificial light flickers through the

trees, scattering the ground at our feet and the long, thick trunks of the gum trees.

Rapid footsteps come from our left. Stefani stops ahead of us, raising her head to listen. Leaves rustle as the steps draw closer.

A petite body creeps out of the shadows, eyes wide when she spots us. Long, tangled red hair hangs in sweat-damp strands over her freckled face.

"I'm fourteen." The memory brings a smile to my lips.

More footsteps cause her eyes to widen with terror, a scream comes from deep in her lungs. "Help me," she cries, gripping my cloak. "He's going to kill me. Please, you have to help me." She falls to her knees at my feet.

I stare down at her, uninterested.

"Oh, my sweet, sweet child," Stefani says, feigning concern and extending her hand. "Come here, I'll help you, darling."

The girl reaches out, her fingertips about to touch Stefani's when a masked hunter approaches from the shadows. He releases a heavy sigh. "Fuck it!"

It's August, and my smile widens as I tuck my hand into my cloak.

"D," Salem draws out the single letter in a warning tone. "It's not time. Let it go."

I inwardly sigh, knowing he's right.

The girl, now pressed tight to Stefani's side, shakes violently as she stares up at August. "Please, please let me go. I won't tell anyone about this. I just want to go home."

Jaw clenched, I narrow my eyes at August. "Have you seen Killian?"

He extends his hand, and using his knife, points towards the river that runs along the rear boundary of the arena. "He was heading that way last I saw. I told him to stay out of the light."

"What about Jus—" before Salem can finish, August says, "Same as always. He's unharmed. They're close by one another."

My fingers twitch, itching to reach for my knife and draw it from its sheath. August's blood would look beautiful against the razor-sharp edge of my silver blade. Flashes of him at Snare, fucking Killian, play over in my mind, a low growl comes from deep in my chest.

Salem elbows me hard before I can pull my knife. Reluctantly, I drop my hand.

There's another scream.

"Stef," August whines. "She was mine."

Turning my head, I watch as Stefani twists her knife in the girl's abdomen then draws it upwards, slicing her open. Blood gushes from her gut. Mouth agape, tears streaming from the corners of her eyes, and a silent scream on her blood coated lips, she chokes and grabs at her bleeding stomach.

Salem nods towards August. "Get out of here," he says, "and August, it's in your best interest to watch them." With one last glance back, August takes off, running into the darkness.

Knife still in her grasp, Stefani shakes her hand out, sending a spray of blood flying around us. She drops the girl on the ground, kneels by her side, and slices a thin sliver of flesh from the dead girl's pale thigh. Standing, Stefani pops the slice of flesh into her own mouth, closing her eyes and savouring the raw, delicate meat.

I shake my head. "Come on, Stef," I say. "While I'd love to indulge, I'm more concerned about finding Killian and ensuring he's still alive."

"He'll be fine," she says, looping her arm through mine. She leans forward to look past me at Salem. "So will your little firebird."

* * *

KILLIAN

From the shadows, a cloaked figure takes a step towards the tree I'm hiding behind, their focus on something to my left. When they lunge into a leafy shrub, I do the same, landing on their back. The man goes down with a curse and a loud grunt, and I wrestle him, reaching for his hand to grab the knife from his closed fist.

He rolls over, forcing me onto my back as he swings a punch that slams into my jaw. If I still had my mask on, I'm certain I wouldn't have felt the hit.

On Chadwick's orders, the prey—me and a dozen other people, including the scarred man from the birdcage, and a red-haired girl who appeared to be around twelve years old—were divested of our masks,

cloaks, shoes, and clothes. After dressing in black cotton pants and thin, black t-shirts, we were led to the fenced arena and told to run.

“You fuckin’—” The man’s shout is cut off when I shove my knee into his balls. He cries out in agonising pain. On instinct, his hands come down to grab his crotch, and I make a grab for the knife.

This time, luck is on my side, and I grip the handle of the long, wicked blade.

“You have to kill him,” a quiet voice says.

Through slivers of moonlight, I make out the features of the man from the cage.

The hunter beneath me writhes in pain. I press the knife to his throat the way I’ve seen Diablo do it so many times. *Can I really kill someone?* Am I strong enough to slice this man’s throat open and kill him in cold blood.

He was going to kill you, I remind myself.

The floodlights begin sweeping over the bushland, and as one passes by us, the man from the cage rushes over. “Hurry, kill him before another one finds us.”

I swallow hard, a sheen of sweat breaks out across my brow. I shove the tip of the knife into the side of the man’s throat and his arms come up.

Fists clenched, he punches at the air, aiming for me, but missing every time as I dodge his attacks. I shove the knife in further, watching with rapt attention as his eyes widen and his mouth opens. He doesn’t scream, but there’s a gurgle and a sputter.

When I give the knife one last hard shove, the man’s head falls to the side. I pull the knife back, staring at the bloody blade, a smile spreading across my lips.

I did it.

“Come on. I know where we can hide,” the scarred man says.

Standing, I scan the area then drop my gaze to the knife again, the blood like a beacon calling to me, urging me to bring the blade to my lips and glide my tongue along its razor-sharp surface.

“Who are you?” I ask the man who’s crouching by a large boulder.

“Justice,” he says, then he points to the knife in my hand. “Bring that, we need to go.”

With no other options, I follow Justice along the river. We drop down an embankment and I follow him further along the river’s edge,

wading through the frigid water until we come to a small cave that's been dug into the side of the embankment.

He crawls in, presses his back to the wall of the narrow cave, and waves for me to follow him in.

It's cold and damp, and so dark I can't see my hand in front of my face. The feeling of claustrophobia sends a shiver down my spine, so I position myself closer to the opening of the cave. I pull my knees up and hang my arms over them, the knife tight in one hand while the fingers of my other hand trail along the length of the sharp, blood coated blade.

"How did you know about this cave?" I ask.

Justice shifts slightly and when his knee knocks into mine, he almost jumps out of his skin. "I—I've been prey before," he says quietly.

There's a long silence between us, and sensing Justice isn't going to elaborate, I ask, "What's with the cage? Why were you in there?"

He lets out a heavy sigh. "I belong to Salem."

"Belong? Like his partner?" Screaming draws my attention to the opening of the cave. A ribbon of moonlight flickers then quickly disappears behind the clouds.

"It's complicated," Justice says. "What about you? I saw you talking to Diablo. He doesn't talk to anyone except the leaders and senior members of The House. I've never seen him interact with the prey."

Ignoring the question about myself, I ask, "The leaders of The House? August said I'd find out more, but..." I trail off.

"Chadwick is the founder," Justice explains, "Salem and Diablo are the leaders. Liam and Stefani are second in charge. The guys have been part of the house since they were children. Stefani joined later." He shifts again as though he's trying to get comfortable, which is near impossible in this cramped, cold hovel. "No one gets into their circle, especially outsiders. And I know you weren't inducted, were you?"

I shake my head even though he can't see me. "No. This is my first time here. I don't think Diablo wanted me to be a part of this."

"Not surprised. He's just like Salem. When they find something they want to keep, they'll never let it go."

When a scream nearby cuts through the silence, Justice reaches out and pats my arm. "Shhh..." he whispers.

Another scream fills the air, then one more, and a few seconds later, a loudspeaker crackles to life. "Hunters and surviving prey, please make

your way to the gates. Drivers are waiting to escort you back to the mansion.”

Justice’s hand drops away. “We can go now,” he says. “It’s over.”

“That’s it?” I question. “They won’t try to kill us now?”

“No, they’ll be on their way back.” He moves quickly, and I follow him out of the cave to find dozens of floodlights lighting up the surrounding bushland.

It takes us a good five minutes to reach the gates, and I’m shocked to find we’re the only two prey leaving the arena.

We’re guided to a black car with dark, tinted windows by two balaclava clad security guards, then bundled into the back seat before the car speeds away.

Back at the mansion, I get out of the car to find Diablo standing at the same door I walked through when I arrived with August earlier. Hands clasped behind his back, and mask now gone, his dark eyes are fixed on mine. He looks me up and down, a snarl curls his lips.

I remember the knife in my hand and wonder for a moment why the security guards didn’t take it. I extend my hand, and like the knife, it’s covered in blood. “I—”

He cuts me off, “Drop it.” He waves a hand in the air, motioning for us to follow, then he turns and walks inside.

“Come on,” Justice says from beside me. “We’ll be able to shower before the feast.”

After showering and putting on my clothes from earlier, including the cloak, I’m led back to the ballroom where the tables are now set with gold candelabras, fine China, and polished gold cutlery. A man wearing a black suit and eye mask leads me to the table where Diablo sits. Beside Salem, Justice is already sitting, his head down, hands beneath the table. He doesn’t look up.

I scan the room and find Gavin at the table opposite me, his furious glare has me averting my gaze. Beside him, August sits—he doesn’t look my way.

At the front of the room, a wide table is set for two people, but Chadwick sits alone, a place setting and an empty chair beside him.

A fleeting thought enters my mind. Do the police know about this? Or do authorities in Newhaven simply ignore the fact these people are hunting and killing humans. My guess is it’s the latter.

When I glance at Chadwick, he stares back, those dark eyes sear into mine. His jaw tics, he blinks once and shifts his attention to the crowd. “Congratulations on a hunt well done,” he says. “The butcher has prepared a selection of meats for our feast tonight.”

From either side of the ballroom that now resembles a dining hall, waiters dressed in crisp black tuxedos enter. Each one carries a silver platter covered with a matching silver, domed lid. As they’re placed on the tables, the scent of seasoned meat wafts around us, and my mouth waters.

“Would you like me to serve you?” Salem asks Justice who lifts his head, his eyes red and bloodshot as though he’s been crying.

He shakes his head. “I’m not hungry,” he mumbles.

Salem’s stare turns deadly, and for a second, it reminds me of Diablo’s intense, cold gaze.

“I’ll have the same as you,” Justice decides, and Salem’s cold stare morphs into a blinding smile. The change is so fast, and so extreme that I don’t notice my pinched expression until Diablo clears his throat.

I smooth my features and turn my attention to him.

When Diablo offers to serve me, I nod and thank him. “Eat,” he says. “You must be starving.”

On cue, my stomach rumbles and I take my fork and poke it into the thinly sliced, rare meat. After popping the meat into my mouth, I chew once, then stop. The taste is unlike anything I’ve had before. It’s mildly sweet, chewy, and slightly salty. The texture is similar to pork. I chew a few more times, and when I look up to see Justice swallowing hard with his eyes clamped shut, I swallow down my mouthful and scan the room.

Everyone is focused on their food—their meat. Everyone is chewing as though each bite is an orgasmic morsel of the rarest, most delicious meat they’ve ever tasted. Across from me, Stefani licks her lips. When she catches me watching her, she smirks and winks.

I look over at Justice again, his hand shakes as he brings another tiny mouthful to his lips, and when he shuts his eyes and exhales hard, I gasp way too loud.

The clinking of cutlery halts. A blanket of silence hovers in the air. I swallow hard.

Hunters and Gatherers.

We’re the prey. They are the hunters.

“The butcher has prepared a selection of meats...”

My eyes fixate on the meat, studying it closely. The colour isn't right. The texture... the smell. And the taste... I swallow hard, wishing I didn't enjoy that lightly salted sliver of meat. But I did.

“It's—”

Hot breath whispers against my ear. “Hush.” Strong fingers dig into my thigh. A shiver runs down my spine, and I suck in a breath.

“Eat, my little hunter,” is all Diablo says.

I nod and poke my fork into a piece of meat. I savour the taste of human flesh on my tongue.

And I smile.

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XVIII

*Savage need is raging
Beneath his pale skin
The devil whispers in his ear
Give in, give in, give in*

KILLIAN

One week later

As I approach the bluestone mansion, my heart pounds in my chest and a twinge of apprehension stops me in my tracks. One week after the feast—where I sat among a crowd of people I now know are killers—and willingly consumed human flesh, Diablo invited me back to the mansion.

This is it. *This is what you've always wanted, Killian.* The voices in the back of my mind are there, but quieter than they've ever been. I take the steps slowly, unable to resist the pull towards the front entrance.

Hanging brass lanterns flicker on either side of the double doors, shining with a faint, yellow tinged light. Shadows dance across the dark walls as the moon dips behind the clouds, only to return seconds later to illuminate the deep green vines of ivy that crawl across the mansion's façade. Two large brass knockers in the shape of horned devils hang from the centre of each wooden door.

Reaching out, I curl my fingers around one and bang it against the door three times before I step back. Without so much as a creak, the door swings open.

An old man with a slightly hunched back and wisps of grey hair extends a white gloved hand. "Welcome," he says, gesturing for me to enter. "I'll fetch the master of the house for you."

I open my mouth to thank him, but he's already shuffling away down a dark, narrow hallway.

When I cross the threshold, I'm enveloped in an otherworldly atmosphere. The air is thick with an ominous darkness, but my lips still curve into a small smile as I take in the eccentric decor. The dimly lit entrance embraces the macabre. From the old-fashioned side tables and curio cabinets to the vintage style furniture, every space is filled with antiques and curiosities. Taxidermy insects and small birds are displayed in

gilded frames. Beady eyes stare out, almost as though they're following my every move.

What appear to be priceless artworks, hang in ornate gold frames, each one featuring barbaric scenes of torture, depictions of murder, and dancing skeletons.

From the ceiling, waxy, candle chandeliers enhance the eerie, gothic ambience of the foyer. A large altar topped with animal and human skulls and lit pillar candles sits against one wall, the flickering candles casting ghostly shadows against the brocade wallpaper.

Either side of the altar, two more cabinets hold rows of apothecary jars. Larger glass jars are filled with human organs and body parts, and on the centre shelf, taking pride of place, a jar holds what appears to be a human infant.

Eager to get a closer look, I walk across a thick, floor rug, my steps silent until I reach the polished marble floor again. Another five steps have me standing in front of the cabinet.

Peering into the largest jar, I inspect the infant. It's definitely human, and with the umbilical cord still attached. In a morbid twist, the umbilical cord is coiled around the infant's body and neck. Tiny hands are clenched into fists, and as it hovers, suspended in a clear, viscous fluid, I wonder if it's some kind of wax effigy, and not a real infant at all.

Regardless, I feel like I should be horrified, not perversely fascinated.

As I peer into the other jars, I notice that unlike the jar containing the infant, the others are all labelled and dated. I reach out, my fingers mere inches from the shelf, my breaths heavy, nervous.

Sweat beads across my brow. My fingers twitch when I remember his words,

"Your heart will be mine—"

"It will take pride of place among my most treasured possessions."

Are these jars filled with pieces of his victims. Are they people he once loved? Could the preserved infant be the body of his own newborn baby? A cold chill prickles at the back of my neck. I inhale, and on an exhale I—

"Killian."

Gasping, I spin on my heels and clench my hand into a tight fist. I'm panting as I take in the man standing before me. He's close. So close I can feel the heat emanating from his body.

"Diab—"

His hand darts out, a black gloved fingertip presses against my trembling lips.

* * *

DIABLO

Ten minutes earlier

When I heard the knock at the door, adrenaline coursed through my veins.

After ordering my manservant, Watson, to let Killian in, I took a few minutes to calm myself before I made my way downstairs.

From the shadows, I watched as Killian wandered the foyer. No one has entered the mansion via the front doors for twenty-five years. The paved, rear entrance with its elaborate porte cochère is the only one that's been used since Loren's death. The foyer is my shrine. A place to hoard and immortalise my most coveted possessions. It's perfect for my little hunter's first introduction into my world.

I stepped out of the shadows as Killian's shaking hand reached out to the shelf of human hearts and body parts, and hesitated. I was standing mere inches from his back when there was a slight shake of his head. His fingers twitched ever so slightly.

I breathed against the back of his neck. "Killian."

A loud gasp escaped as he turned, pale blue eyes wide with shock. Cheeks flushed pink, full lips slightly parted.

They'd look perfect wrapped around my cock, was my only thought.

Hands twisting nervously, he stared up at me. "Diab—"

I pressed a gloved finger to his lips to silence him.

* * *

Now

His tongue darts out and swipes across the piercing in his bottom lip. I resist the urge to pull him into me and bite down hard on the soft flesh until his blood seeps to the surface.

With a wave of my hand, I turn my back on him. “Follow me.”

Like the perfect submissive, he obeys. His footsteps follow mine across the foyer to the small alcove where a narrow stairwell leads to the upper floors of the mansion.

On the second floor, I lead Killian to the master suite at the end of the landing and lock the door behind us. Other than Watson, no one is here tonight, and none would ever dare enter this room without my permission, but clicking the lock into place causes Killian to flinch. His reaction to the soft snick is exactly what I desired.

In the soundproof bedroom, I stand with my hands clasped behind my back, watching, waiting, anticipating Killian’s next words.

“I um, I don’t know what—” he stops, his voice soft with uncertainty.

When he averts his gaze, I reach out to cup his cheek with my gloved hand. It’s a touch that promises comfort, warmth, safety. Things other people crave. From my hands, that gentle touch is nothing more than a prelude. A gentle caress to put my little hunter at ease, and to rein in the devil that lurks beneath the surface of my skin.

Pupils dilated, Killian releases a tiny puff of air from between those full, pink lips. His eyes never leave mine as I place my hands on his biceps and walk him backwards. His back hits the wall with a soft thud.

I reach down and pull my knife from its sheath. Bringing it up, I watch Killian’s expression as I press the flat edge of the blade to his jaw. His body trembles, and he licks those perfect lips again, swiping over the silver hoop pierced through his bottom lip.

When I press the blade harder into his cheek, he whimpers.

I smile at his desperation. “Get undressed,” I command, gesturing with my knife.

“Yes—yes, sir,” he says, nodding. With shaking fingers, he works quickly to do as instructed, fumbling with the button of his tight, black jeans, then the laces and silver buckles of his worn Doc Martens.

He’s standing against the wall, stark naked, and I take him in. His taut, lithe body is a canvas of detailed tattoos. Black wings, horned devils, and anatomical hearts pierced with arrows and knives dripping with blood adorn his chest. Smaller, random macabre tattoos of gravestones, ravens, skulls, and roses cover his arms, and across his collarbone, the words *memento mori* are written in a gothic style font.

With my fingertip, I trace the words on his flank where the embellished script reads,

Play for me, death's symphony.

When I raise my head, Killian tilts his head ever so slightly and opens his mouth to speak. My right hand darts out to grip his throat. As I squeeze, he attempts to suck in much needed oxygen. When I glide my tongue across the seam of his lips, a tiny moan escapes and I drop my gaze to find his cock hard, precum leaking from the tip.

Squeezing harder, I narrow my eyes, enthralled as I watch his expression change from confusion to fear. "Plea—" His attempts to speak are cut off when the tip of my blade drags along the length of his cock. Killian's entire body comes alive as he hyperventilates.

He sucks in gasps of air through his nostrils. His gaze heats, sweat beads across his brow, and a long, low whine comes from deep in his throat. His release spills over, covering my pants and my gloved hand seconds before he loses consciousness.

Oh, what fun I will have playing with my prey before I finally feast.

I release my grip from Killian's throat and slowly lower his body to the floor. I move to the bed and begin fastening the chains and cuffs to the wrought iron frame.

After placing Killian on the bed, I take him in. His perfect body is splayed on crimson sheets, so still, so pale. So perfect I ache for him. I crave nothing more than to slice him open and crawl inside his flesh. To tear him apart and bathe in his blood.

From the side of the bed, I hover over him, fingers twitching, hands curling into fists as I try to restrain myself.

Kill him! The voice in my head taunts.

Feast on him. It urges.

Devour him.

"NO!" I shout, shaking my head. Why this one? Why Killian? What is it about him that sets an inferno ablaze beneath my flesh?

Kill him! Yes. Killian Graves needs to die.

Insanity is beginning to take over. Flashes of memories collide, twisted, shattered sparks of recognition. Each one assaults me like the jagged colours of a kaleidoscope, exquisite beauty in disorganised chaos.

One vision takes over the rest. I close my eyes and allow the memory to take me back.

Six years ago

Salem sat across from me, swirling a glass of whiskey in his hand, a sinister glint in his eyes.

“You’re sure it’s them?” Years of searching yielded nothing but dead ends, so I was sceptical this time would be any different.

He nodded. “One hundred percent. Kensington has everything in place. Three of them will be there. You just need to go in, take care of them, and get out.” Salem leaned forward, elbows on his knees. “You ready for this?”

I took a mouthful of whiskey from my own glass before nodding slowly. “Of course. First, explain to me how Kensington found them? We’ve been looking for years.” Suspicion crept into my tone, but Salem ignored it.

He crossed a leg over his knee, and explained, “Dear old Mum and Dad dipped their toes into the dark web not long after they adopted them. Started off selling photographs then moved onto videos. Gavin was pimping them out on the side. Apparently, there’s quite the market for twins.” Salem’s lip curled into a snarl before he took another sip of his drink. The ice clinked against the sides of his glass when he set it down on the table. “When the twins hit puberty, the money started to dry up.”

He hesitated, but I motioned for him to continue with a wave of my hand. “Keep going.”

“Turns out Mr Gavin Rafferty has been running a secret side gig. Underage porn and prostitution, drug running, and faux snuff films to name a few. When the parents couldn’t pay for their next month’s drug supply, they offered Gavin the kids.” Salem shook his head. “Now according to Kensington, Kaspian is obsessed with his brother Killian, who doesn’t return his affections. Kaspian wants him gone, permanently. I guess it’s a ‘if I can’t have him no one can’ scenario.” He shrugged. “The parents have a habit of snitching when they think it’ll benefit them, so... collateral damage.”

Salem averted his gaze, stood, and paced the office. “Kensington didn’t get a chance to tell me everything, but I get the impression one of the twins shares some of our proclivities. I don’t know which one, though.”

Interest piqued, I raised a brow. “Does Chadwick know about this?”

Salem shrugged. “No idea. I wouldn’t be surprised if he handed them over for that very reason. Probably hoped he could have them grow up in the right environment. Make them easier to train, to manipulate. He wouldn’t be able to do it properly without Loren.”

A surge of anger burns deep in my chest. “If he wasn’t going to use them, he should have let me kill them.”

Salem sighed. “Everything’s about control, D. We were never anything more than pawns to him. He used, abused, and tortured us. She was the one who guided us, the one who taught us how to blend into society.” He dropped down onto the sofa again and shrugged. “Maybe he let them go for her.”

I let out a sigh. “I don’t know. I doubt it.” With a huff of disgust, I placed my glass on the coffee table and paced the room. A moment of silence passed before I felt a hand on my shoulder.

Turning, I took in Salem’s determined expression. “We’ll end him,” he promised. “And when we do, The House, the money, this town... It’ll all be ours.”

“Ours.” I nodded in agreement. “Let’s get this done,” I said.

** * **

Early the next morning

“No, no, please don’t,” he begged. “I won’t tell anyone. Please, let me go.”

Knife in my hand, I hovered over the boy. His parents lay dead on the filthy bed, sprawled out like lifeless, broken dolls. The sheets beneath them, soaked in crimson blood. Their throats sliced open.

Five minutes earlier, the mother—after revealing her part in the abuse of her children—begged for her life as I fucked her with my blade. The father tried to fight as the same knife ravaged his ass. It was a futile attempt that ended abruptly when I shoved my blade deep into his heart. Slitting their throats was my final, glorious touch.

While licking my knife clean, a gasp came from behind me, followed by a muffled scream. It took less than five seconds to grab the boy by the throat, shove him to the floor, and straddle his slim body. I watched as his eyes shone with terror.

“Please don’t ki—don’t kill me,” he begged. “I’m glad they’re dead.” A tiny smile appeared on those plump, full lips. “They were bad people,” he said. “They deserved to die.”

Something inside me stirred. An unfamiliar, fleeting warmth that caused my stomach to clench in knots. I stared down at the boy with thick, blond curls and the brightest, clearest blue-green eyes I’d ever seen. Aquamarine, that’s what colour they were.

I’d seen eyes as bright as those before.

Long, long ago when the only thing on my mind was murder.

When she was dying.

Bleeding.

Crying.

Begging.

“Savages!” The voices wailed in the back of my mind, a chorus of longing and desperation. “Kill them.” I waited too long. This time, he was going to die.

I shifted my weight, stood, and took a step back.

He was small, young, barely enough strength to overpower me. I had nothing to be afraid of. Nothing to fear from this eighteen-year-old boy on the cusp of manhood who stared at me with terror. And damn, it was a heady feeling. A rush I’d only felt in the throes of passion between blood laced lust, and the final dying breaths of my victims.

“It was you,” I said. “You killed her.”

“Save them...” her voice soft, fingers gentle.

His brow creased in confusion. “What? I didn’t kill anyone.” He glanced at the bed where his parents’ mutilated corpses lay. “Did you—did you kill my brother, too?”

I froze. His brother’s here? My plans were always meticulous. Nothing ever caused me to hesitate. To question myself.

“Three of them will be there...”

“One of the twins shares some of our proclivities...”

Which one?

I stared up at the boy whose eyes never strayed from mine.

I wanted to fuck him, kill him, devour him.

The memories wouldn't stop.

"What makes you happy?"

"Dead blood."

My head was pounding, spinning with images, voices, memories. I was heading towards total annihilation. Desperation had led to carelessness.

I was unprepared. For him. For those eyes that reminded me of hers.

Flawless, pale skin... like hers.

Full, pink lips... like hers.

"Killed them," his mumbled voice said in barely a whisper.

"What?" Confusion clouded my thinking. Multiple scenarios raced through my mind. I needed to call Salem. This wasn't going to plan.

I shook my head hard.

Get rid of the evidence.

The boy.

His brother.

Their parents.

"Save them," her voice was a relentless whisper.

"Darius, my sweet, sweet boy..." Her final wish.

"Killian," the boy in front of me said. "My brother, Killian. You were supposed to kill him."

I clamped my eyes shut.

Shook my head again.

Pictured her face.

Her smile. A gentle hand. A soft kiss on my forehead.

"Can I call you Mum?"

"No, my little devil..."

"Killian," I said the name out loud, tasted it on my tongue, felt the weight of it in my mouth. "Killian." I sighed heavily. "What a delicious name."

The boy in front of me huffed. "Figures," he said. "Everyone prefers Kill. It's so fucking cool. And what do I get? Fucking Kaspian." He glared at his dead parents. "I fucking hate them."

Killian.

Killian.

His name taunted me, pushed me to the brink of madness.

Killian.

My cock twitched.

“Save them.”

Taste.

Devour.

Killian.

Kill... him.

Kill!

While I was distracted, Kaspian grabbed a vase from the bedside table and threw it. Unprepared, I stumbled backwards when the vase slammed into my shoulder.

My knife hit the carpet with a soft thud.

Kaspian leaped forward, grabbed the knife, and pointed it at me. His hands shook violently. “Get back or I’ll kill you!” he screeched. “I’ll do it!”

I raised my hands, a defensive posture I was certain would calm him. Head back in reality and free from the past, I took him in. Such a delightful morsel.

“You were supposed to kill him.” He took a step towards me. Gestured with the knife. “Back against the wall,” he ordered. “Not me, not me, not me,” he repeated.

I stepped back the three paces to the wall, prepared to pounce. My erection strained at the zipper of my jeans. Sweat beaded across my brow. I came here for three kills, the thought of a fourth was setting every nerve ending on fire.

Realisation set in. Kaspian had come to watch his brother’s murder, instead, he was about to take his place. Does Kaspian share our proclivities? Or is it Killian who craves the darkness?

He edged closer. “When I spoke to that guy...” He blinked rapidly. “I said the one with black hair.” He shook his head hard. “Not me. FUCK! Not me.”

“Where is your brother?” I asked, keeping my voice calm.

“I don’t know!” Kaspian shouted, waving the knife in his outstretched hand. “Look, just, just wait, I can fix this.” He reached into his back pocket and pulled out his mobile phone. I watched as he texted someone, then sighed. “He’s still not replying.” He glanced at the screen for a second too long.

I grabbed the knife from his hand and shoved Kaspian face down onto the floor.

Tightening my other hand around his pale neck, I squeezed. He gasped, shook, tried to scream. His legs kicked out and his hands grabbed at empty air as I slowly starved him of oxygen.

I ground my cock and balls against his ass. The friction, a delicious ache I craved.

As he began to choke and sputter, I pulled his track pants down over the swell of his ass, cut them away from his body with my knife and spread his legs with my knees.

He fought hard. Squirmed and wriggled, kicked and begged. Tried to grab onto the bedside table.

Little did he know that every frantic cry only brought me closer to orgasm.

As his struggle waned, I positioned myself so that I could force my cock into his tight hole. In one long, hard stroke, I entered him, thrusting violently.

I leaned down, forced his head to the side, and covered his mouth with mine. As I fucked him raw, I swallowed his panicked breaths. I licked at his tongue, his mouth, his full, pink lips. I inhaled his every exhale, and I continued pumping my hips and devouring his mouth as I fucked his dying body.

When his body went limp, I sat back on my heels, cock still pulsing inside him. As I raised my knife, my release filled him, creating a slick lube.

A shadow outside the window caught my attention and I flicked my head to the side.

A fleeting glimpse of black hair.

“You were perfect,” I whispered against Kaspian’s ear as I dragged my cock from the tight hold his body still had on me, and shoved my knife into his neck.

I brought the knife to my lips and licked the blood from the silver blade before I ran my fingers across the seam of his lips, and for the last

*time, looked into those pale blue eyes.
Kaspian Graves died that night.
And Killian Graves became my prey.*

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XIX

*Raw and aching bloodlust
My warnings you don't heed
I'm ready to devour you
My appetite, you will feed*

DIABLO

“Diablo?” Killian’s voice pulls me back to the present.

I glare at the young man who lies on my bed, head resting on the pillows, black curls framing his head like a gothic halo. Those pale blue irises—more exquisite than a thousand priceless gemstones—thin, as his pupils dilate. Desire never hidden, ecstasy seeps from his pores with the scent of his sweat and the fading tinge of his cologne.

He has the power to obliterate my world.

He is the one who will bring me undone.

The one who will destroy all I’ve worked for and render me incapable of rational thought.

“Diablo.” Pure, raw need surrounds my name. It tumbles from his lips in an avalanche of wanton lust coated with the promise of imminent danger.

A supernova explodes behind my eyes. Visions of him stretched out, muscles bulging, veins throbbing beneath pale, unmarred flesh. Blood seeping from raw, open wounds. Layers of flesh, tissue, muscle. The ivory tinge of bone peeking through crimson pools and still pulsing veins, teasing me... taunting me... torturing me the way I yearn to torture him.

Killian Graves is so painfully exquisite. I have to avert my gaze to stop myself thinking about killing him.

Taste.

Devour.

Kill.

No. Not yet.

Not until I’ve had my fill.

I straddle his thighs and take his hardening cock in my gloved hand. My other hand is splayed across his abdomen. I curl my fingers into his tattooed flesh as though I can tear it from his body. Gaze fixed on Killian, I

slide my hand up his torso, pinching his taut, pink nipples with my thumb and forefinger before I reach his neck and freeze.

Another burst of fury envelops me. The scars aren't new. I've seen them before. Traced them with gloved fingertips. Thick and raised, they encircle his entire neck.

"Where is he?" I asked Kate McCallister one Saturday night at Snare.

"Doing a scene with August," she said. "We need to keep an eye on that one. He's pushing the limits. His own and the club's."

"How often is he doing it?" I asked.

"Alone, not often. With August, two or three times a month that I'm aware of. Although, I'm not sure where he's getting those bruises from. August doesn't do impact play with him."

With a low growl at the reminder, I shove his chin up so I can take a closer look.

I remove my gloves and drop them on the floor so I can feel his skin beneath my fingers.

August. The one who dared to touch what I own. Yes. Yes, I own him.

Killian opens his mouth, but before he has a chance to utter a single word, I tighten my hand around his throat. "These scars, August did them all?"

Eyes never leaving mine, he shakes his head. "To—Tony did some of them."

When I squeeze his throat again, he squirms beneath me. I drop my gaze to find his cock hard, the crown flushed a deep pink. Precum beads at the tip and I circle my fingertip around it before pressing my thumb nail into his slit.

Killian bucks wildly, but I remain calm. "Who is Tony?" I ask, "And where did this happen?"

"Gay, ahhh... Gavin sent me to him. We did some videos—Faux snuff." His tongue pokes out to trace the piercing in the middle of that full bottom lip, and his Adam's apple moves against my palm. "Please, please touch me," he begs, and I immediately remove my hand.

"You wanted it?" I question.

He nods, then quickly adds, “Yes. When I was a kid—thirteen, fourteen—but yes, I wanted it. I begged for it.”

“How many videos?” I close my fist around his cock and stroke slowly. “Where did you do these scenes?”

Through panting breaths, Killian shakes his head. “I don’t, um... I don’t know, ten, fifteen.”

When his eyelids fall closed, I give his cheek a hard slap. “Answer me!”

He sucks in a breath, another long, low whine spills from his parted lips. “Ahhhh—please, oh my god.”

Hand pressed over his mouth, I lean down and whisper against his ear as I tighten my fist around his cock and stroke him from base to tip. “Where?” I demand, then remove my hand and allow him to suck in a breath of air.

“A club.” He coughs, then adds, “Vapour. It’s in—”

I cut him off, “I know of it.” And Tony will be getting a visit from me very soon.

“What are you going to do to me?” Killian asks. “Are you going to fuck me again? Stab me? You can do anything to me, I have no limits.” His words spill from those plump lips without concern.

A smirk tugs at the corner of my own lips, and I raise a brow. “No limits?”

He shakes his head. “None.”

Drawing my knife from its sheath, I hold it up, twisting the blade until it catches on the glint of light that comes from the dim lamp in the corner of the room. With the tip of my sharpened blade pressed to his jaw, I whisper against his ear, “And if I want to torture you, little hunter?”

Killian cries out, his body trembles beneath my weight. I remain calm as his hand shoots up and he grips my shoulder, begging, “Please.” He gasps, chest heaving, needy whimpers echoing around the room. “Please, please, Diablo, do it.”

“Save them...”

“Darius, my sweet—”

“NO!” I shout before I leap off the bed and rush to the bathroom, slamming the door behind me.

Killian Graves should not have been born. His birth annihilated the finely spun threads of sanity I had left. He killed the only person alive who could control the savagery inside me. His first breath should have been his last.

Kill him! I can't do it. I'm overcome with a frenzied desire I can barely control.

Kill him! Not yet. I need to keep him. Play with him. Taunt him. And make him pay for what he did twenty-four years ago.

If anyone is going to give Killian what he craves, it's me. Then, I will obliterate him. I'll exorcise him from my life. Carve away his flesh and feast on his carcass.

After splashing cold water over my face, I pat it dry with a towel and leave the bathroom. I stalk towards the bed, Killian's eyes follow my every move.

When I reach him, he fixates on the knife in my hand, a longing in his eyes I know all too well. As I move around the bed, I fasten the leather handcuffs to his wrists and smooth my fingertips over the scars that were covered by his leather cuff bracelets, now lying discarded on the floor among his pile of clothes.

"You did these yourself?" I question, pressing my thumb hard against the countless raised scars.

"Yes," he says.

"No more. From now on, I am the only one who inflicts pain on you. The only one who touches you."

His eyes grow wide, and a helpless whimper escapes his lips.

"But, but I can't help it."

"What did I just say?"

He stutters, "You—you're the only one who inflicts pain on me."

I nod and move to his ankles, but he continues his babbling. "I can't just... I've tried to stop before, I need—" A glassy sheen of tears wells in his eyes. "Please, don't make me stop."

Ignoring him, I continue fastening the cuffs to his ankles before I stand and remove my pants and underwear. When I'm naked, I straddle Killian's chest and grip my cock, painting his pink lips with my precum.

Bottom lip trembling, his breaths come in fast, desperate pants as his eyes rove over my tattooed, scarred body.

I close my fist around the length of my cock, each warm, silver stud of the Jacob's Ladder piercing sits snug in the spaces between my fingers.

Killian's tongue flicks out, curling around the thick Prince Albert piercing as he swipes the precum from my crown.

I grab a fistful of his hair and lift his head to shove my cock into his mouth. Pumping my hips, I fix my stare on the corners of Killian's eyes where tears fall in salted trails down his cheeks. He chokes and gags as I thrust into his tight throat.

"Does anyone else give you this?" I grip his hair even tighter and force his head into my crotch. I hold him on my cock for five seconds, ten, fifteen.

When I shove his head back, he's gasping for breath, and I ask, "Does anyone else give you what you so clearly want?"

Eyes glazed, and lips wet and puffy, Killian shakes his head, his mouth covered in a wet sheen of saliva.

I reach over to the bedside table for my knife, and when Killian sees it, he whines, drool dribbling from the corner of his full lips.

I press the tip of my blade into the head of my own cock until blood beads at the surface. The rush of intense pain sends adrenaline coursing through my veins, and I groan at the pleasure.

Killian gasps, then licks his lips. "Please! Oh, fuck ple—"

His pleas are cut off when I shove my cock back into his mouth. He sucks greedily. Swallowing around the head, lapping at the slit, tasting the essence of my blood.

"Do you taste that, Killian? My blood on your tongue, in your mouth." I hold him still and lean right over him, my fingers curled around the wrought iron bedhead. I thrust deep into his throat. "Do you taste the power I have over you? Do you feel it pulsating against your tongue?"

Garbled, wet choking sounds come from Killian's throat and when he gags again, I pull my cock out and sit back, still straddling his torso. Through the myriad of tattoos, a pink flush smothers his chest and neck, and his eyes are red rimmed and tear-stained. Wet lashes blink away a slew of tears.

Grasping his slender throat, I curl my fingers into his soft flesh until they're positioned perfectly, and I press down, lightly starving him of oxygen.

When his face turns red, I watch as ecstasy plays over his features.

“This is what you want, isn’t it? Someone to take you to the brink... to swallow your fading breaths while you beg for your life.”

Killian nods, nothing but a ghost of a whisper leaves his lips until I release my hold, and he says, “Yes, yesyesyes, but...” His cheeks flame red, eyes dart away from mine. That crimson blush reminds me so much of blood that I swipe up my knife again and drag the tip of my sharpened blade across his torso, just below his navel. Blood beads to the surface.

“I want more,” he whines. “Need—Fuck!”

I cut him off when I point the tip of my blade beneath his chin. “You’ll get what I give you.” I drag the blade down to his throat, carefully trailing it across his scars.

I slide down the length of his body, drop my knife on the floor, and settle between his legs to cup his ass cheeks with both hands. My breath fans over the length of his leaking cock.

“Please. I’m begging you, Diablo.”

Ignoring his begging, and his needy cock, I shuffle down lower and bite into the soft flesh of his inner thigh.

Harder.

Harder.

Harder.

Killian screams when my teeth break through his pale flesh. His warm blood fills my mouth. I suck, and he screams again, fists gripping the sheets as his stomach clenches, his back arches, and his release coats his tattooed abdomen and chest.

“Fuck!” he shouts, body rippling and legs shaking as I continue to bite deep into the flesh of his thighs. Three, four, five times. I swipe my tongue across each bite mark. Press my thumbs into the wounds. Lick them again.

When Killian’s a sobbing, begging mess of needy desperation, I move up his body, swiping up his release with my tongue, tasting, licking, devouring.

I take his mouth in a hard kiss. Bite down on that full lip and suck it into my mouth.

Killian is frantic, mouth wide open, tongue searching for mine. He sucks my bottom lip into his mouth and bites down, gentle at first.

I groan, twine my fingers into his thick, ebony curls and pull. He whines, writhes, and bucks his hips against me before another soft, tentative

bite at my lip.

“Do it,” I growl, “Bite me, little hunter.”

Killian bites down hard on my lip, drawing blood and tracing his tongue over the wound, then sucking again, pulling my lip into his mouth with quick, frantic sucks. Saliva and blood coats our mouths as we explore, ravish, consume.

“*Save them...*” Loren’s voice is an almost forgotten whisper.

A twinge of knowledge coils in the back of my mind.

There is no saving Killian now. He will never be free again.

I will worship him, and I will annihilate anyone who dares to breathe in his presence.

My little hunter has decided to dance with the devil, and Newhaven is about to burn.

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XX

*Confusion spreads like wildfire
Questions still remain
Is everyone a liar
Or are they all insane*

KILLIAN

A sliver of sunlight warms my skin and I roll over, burying my face into the soft pillow. I inhale, the scent of Diablo's cologne still lingers beneath my nose, a heady, intoxicating blend of vanilla and musk. I open my eyes, foolishly hoping to find Diablo stretched out beside me. Of course, he's not there.

The heavy, black drapes are open wide, giving me an unobstructed view of the pristine lawns of Monroe Estate and the forest that surrounds the property. A fleeting thought crosses my mind. Is Chadwick Monroe Diablo's father?

After reluctantly leaving the bed, I find the bathroom and take a long, hot shower that washes the reminders of last night from my skin. Looking down, I smile as my eyes linger on the bite marks scattered across my inner thighs. When I trace my fingers over the wounds, heat coils in my gut, and my cock twitches. Fuck, I'd give anything to have Diablo back between my thighs, feasting on my flesh like a savage beast.

I towel dry and pace back to the bedroom, relishing in the sensation of thick, plush carpet beneath my bare feet. On the antique bedside table, my phone sits atop a wireless charger and I swipe it up to find three messages from August. Since the Hunters and Gatherers Ball, I've been avoiding my best friend. My anger has subsided. All that's left is hurt and betrayal, and a feeling of loss I can't stand.

August: Kill, where the hell are you?

August: I'm sorry I didn't tell you about them. Please let me explain.

August: Call me.

Ignoring his messages, I drop my phone on the bed and go in search of my clothes. When I find them, I tug my jeans on, foregoing underwear,

then pull my t-shirt over my head and smooth out the wrinkles with my hands.

I have no idea where Diablo is, or if he's coming back, so, instead of waiting around, I decide to leave. When I reach the staircase with its carved timber balustrade, I stop in my tracks. The mansion is silent, and seemingly empty. Along the landing where I stand, there are three more doors.

Filled with curiosity and a dire need to know more about Diablo King, I reach for the handle of the first door. The gold doorknob is cool beneath my fingers, and I turn it slowly pushing the door open. It's another bedroom. Decorated in shades of deep green, gold, and black.

The next door opens into an office with a leather topped desk, and a huge, leather, wingback chair. I step inside, eyes scanning the walls that are adorned with gilded frames of old men. They all have that same dead, cold look in their eyes, and I wonder if they're Diablo's ancestors.

A bookshelf on the back wall holds hundreds of books. I inspect the shelves, seeing well-read books about cannibalism, anthropology, and criminal and child psychology, all their spines worn from use. Another shelf holds a row of books about serial killers and psychopathy. My fingers twitch with the urge to reach out and immerse myself into any one of these books, but I curl them into my palm instead, and walk out, pulling the door closed behind me.

The last door I open is another bedroom. This time, I take a step inside, but freeze when my eyes lock onto the elaborately carved, four post bed complete with long, black satin curtains hanging from each corner and tied back with a gold tassel.

Crimson bedding cushions a complete human skeleton, the skull rests on the plush pillow. Separated from the neck and spine, the skull is slightly turned as though the hollow eye sockets are staring directly at me.

Intrigued, I take another step forward, perversely curious as to why there's a whole damn skeleton in a bed in Diablo's mansion. Is this another twisted sanctum like his downstairs foyer with its macabre jars of body parts?

One more step brings me close enough to touch. I clench my hands into fists and lean forward, studying the bones. Giving in, I allow my fingertips to brush across the cool satin bedspread, trailing closer and closer to the skeleton with every breath I take.

When the tip of my index finger touches the skeleton's bony finger, a shiver runs down my spine. I pull my hand back as my heart races wildly, goosebumps smother my body.

Reminders of my brother flash in my vision, replacing the skeleton with his cold, dead corpse. This time, he's not staring blankly into oblivion, he's staring right at me, judging, laughing, taunting. His eyes, cruel, and his smirk, knowing.

"I got it, Kill! I got what you wanted!"

I grit my teeth, shove my fingers into my hair, tug on the long, dark strands. When I squeeze my eyes shut, I'm reminded of my depravities, and my desperation to fulfil them.

I don't hear the creak of the door until it's too late. My first thought is that it's Diablo, so I remain still and attempt to rein in my racing heart, until hot breath against my ear whispers, "You shouldn't be here, little hunter."

Fuck! It's not Diablo. It's Salem, and he's so close I can feel his chest against my back, and the sharp tip of a knife digging into my side.

From behind me, footsteps enter the room, and I turn my head to see Diablo walking in. I watch him like a hawk as he removes his black suit jacket and drapes it over an antique chair. "You should have stayed in the bedroom, Killian," he says as he unbuttons the cuffs of his sleeves and begins rolling them up to his elbows. Never glancing at me, he continues to the opposite side of the bed.

"I—"

My words are cut off when Salem shoves the tip of the knife into my flesh, causing a bolt of pain to surge through me. "Do not speak," he says.

I nod and inhale through my nose, my eyes on Diablo as he sits on the edge of the bed. Gently holding the sides of the skull like he's cupping the cheeks of a lover, he drops his head and presses his lips to the forehead.

I remain silent as I watch Diablo's thumbs caress the bone. "I'm sorry you had to see this," he whispers. If it's to me or to the skull in his hands, I have no clue, until he closes his eyes and says, "They killed you. Took you from me when I needed you. I needed you."

Is this person—this skeleton... whoever they were, the reason Diablo is a killer? I think back to the ball. The empty seat beside Chadwick. If Chadwick is Diablo's father, could these be his mother's bones.

Behind me, Salem breathes quietly, but he's so close I can feel each exhale against the shell of my ear.

Diablo stands, and with the skull still in his hands like a precious artefact, he approaches me, his eyes dark and void of all emotion.

At six-foot-three, he towers over me, and I crane my neck to look up at him, ignoring the fact that he's still holding a human skull in his hands.

"Who is it?" I ask.

"Shut up," Salem warns.

"Someone I loved," he says, then shifts his gaze to Salem.

"Someone we both loved."

Both loved? They're brothers? I clamp my eyes shut, picturing their features, pointing out their similarities in my mind. Dark hair, deep, dark brown eyes, the same square jawline, the same cool detachment. *It's possible.*

"It's your mum?" I question.

His jaw tics once. "Yours," he states without inflection.

Confused, I shake my head. "What? You—you kept my mum's skull, her skeleton? What the fuck?"

Diablo's stare turns deadly. He drops another kiss to the top of the skull before he turns and places it back on the pillow, positioning it just so. Then, he reaches out and takes the skeleton's hand in his own. He brings it to his lips and lingers for a long moment.

"Get rid of him," he says, not turning around.

As soon as Salem starts dragging me backwards, I fight back, struggling against his hold, desperate to escape his grasp and find out what the hell is going on.

When Salem's fist slams into my jaw, I grunt in pain and let my body go lax as he drags me down the stairs by my arms. Lip split and bleeding, and my jaw throbbing, I mumble a "Fuck you" as Salem pulls the front door open and shoves me outside.

The door slams behind me, and I remain slumped on the marble stairs.

"Sir, if you'd like to get into the car, I'll drive you home." The old man I saw when I arrived last night, stands in front of me, hand extended towards a sleek, black BMW, the engine idling.

I rub my jaw and when I bring my hand away, there's a smear of blood on my fingers. I'm about to refuse the old man's offer when he leans

down and hands me a soft, white handkerchief. "Come now, I'll get you home."

In the back of the car, I hold the handkerchief to my bleeding mouth. Every encounter I have with Diablo leaves me more confused than the last. But this one takes the fucking cake for strange. It's time to talk to August and find out what the fuck is going on in this godforsaken town.

* * *

"August!" I shout as I close the front door and kick off my Docs. "August, are you home?"

He steps into the living room wearing a pair of grey trackpants that hang low on his hips. For a guy in his mid-thirties, August is in great shape. My eyes linger on his tattooed chest and arms, and his toned six-pack that trails down to the cut of a perfect V, then I remember I'm supposed to be pissed at him. I shake my head and scowl.

Scratching at the stubble on his jaw, he looks me up and down before asking, "What the hell happened to you?"

I circle my finger in front of my face. "This?" I question. "Your buddy Salem did this."

August steps forward, hand reaching out, but I raise my hands and step back. "Don't touch me," I warn. "Tell me what the fuck is going on, August."

He goes to the kitchen and comes back with two bottles of beer. I crack the top off mine and take a long mouthful before I slump down on the sofa, holding the cold beer bottle to my aching jaw. I may be a masochist, but getting punched in the face is not my idea of pleasurable pain.

"I've been waiting for you," August says. He points to the kitchen table where his laptop is. "Come sit." He types quickly, and when he's done, he drops his hands and nods at the screen, urging me to read.

Reluctantly, I sit beside him.

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With my hand pressed hard to my mouth, I reread the words that stand out like the call of a siren's song. "I—Aug... I—" I can't speak. My mouth moves but nothing comes out. My heart feels like it's about to burst free from my ribcage. I try to swallow, but I can't even do that as my hands start to shake.

All this time he's been a part of something he knows I've always dreamed about.

"Hey, calm down," August's voice fades in and out. "Killian, listen to my voice, you're having a panic attack." He rubs my thigh.

I suck in huge gulps of air and shake my head. This can't be happening. "Aug—" These conflicting emotions I've had warring inside me since I was a child, slam into me with a vengeance. "I can't—can't breathe."

On the outside, I learned early on to show a calm acquiescence. On the inside, my soul has—for a long time—been ravaged by the deplorable need for violence and brutality. I've never given in, though. But fuck, I've wanted to.

I want to.

August takes my hands, squeezes them hard. "You're not alone. Remember what I told you? There's always someone else like you."

Sixteen years old

Feet on the edge of the building, I extended my arms and raised my head to the heavens. Stars twinkled above, sparks of light in an otherwise empty sky.

I balanced precariously.

Blinked into the moonlight.

Inhaled.

Exhaled.

The chaos that consumed my every waking moment was about to end.

Solace awaited.

"Don't do it," a voice said from behind me.

A gasp left my lips and I blinked, my lashes wet with tears. Until that split second, I hadn't realised I was crying.

I inhaled, dropped my arms to my sides, and looked down at the unforgiving concrete below. One step. That's all it would take.

One step.

Then I'd land. And finally, blissful freedom.

"Don't," the deep, masculine voice said again. "Let me help you."

Eyes still fixed on the ground, I let out a huff of annoyance. "Leave me alone."

"Not happening." The sound of his footsteps coming closer caused me to groan in frustration. "I'm August, by the way," the stranger said.

"I don't care, I said leave me alone." That solace I'd found only minutes ago, was slowly but surely unravelling, and a tangled mass of confusion laced turmoil was taking over. I squeezed my eyes shut, extended my arms again, and searched for calm amidst the chaos of my mind.

I lifted one foot, prepared to step off the ledge I was precariously balancing on, and leaned forward.

I didn't fall.

Instead, I was yanked back violently, my body slammed into the corrugated iron roof of the warehouse, and smothered by a much larger, stronger body. I fought against his hold, punched, kicked, and screamed at him to let me go, all to no avail.

Those strong arms wrapped around my smaller frame, and he rolled us over until he was sitting, and I was cradled in his arms like a pathetic, whimpering baby.

"Stop fighting," he said as I fought his hold. "Give in and let it all out."

It was as though he knew me. As though his arms knew how to hold me. As though his words knew where to reach me. "You're not alone," he whispered against my ear. "Let it all out."

And I did.

I screamed.

I wailed.

I sobbed.

"Don't let me go," I begged. "Please, don't let me go."

For sixteen years, all I'd wanted was someone to hold me. I'd seen it happen to other people. Watched mothers and fathers embrace their

children, and one another.

At five years old, I'd stood at my mother's feet and begged her to hug me like I'd seen on TV. I'd crawled into her lap, only to be shoved away, or worse, locked in the basement. By ten, I'd stopped begging for affection.

Instead, I found a warped sense of comfort and safety in the arms of my abusers. The desperate need to be touched outweighed any sense of wrongness and danger.

By the time the sun had risen the next morning, I'd spilled all my dark, depraved secrets to August.

"There's always someone else like you," he'd said as I followed him down a narrow alley and into his apartment building.

"How do you know?" I flopped down onto the worn leather sofa and scrubbed my hands over my face. "I'm sick." I shook my head. "No one should think this way. It's not normal. No one should want to be hurt. No one should want to hurt other people."

August sat beside me, his feet propped on the coffee table as he lit a cigarette and puffed the acrid, grey smoke into the air. He shrugged. "You'd be surprised what people keep hidden. Murderers and rapists walk the streets every day, and no one suspects a thing. They're out there imagining all the ways they can violate, torture, and kill you." He brought the cigarette to his lips again and inhaled long and deep. After an equally long exhale, he added, "As long as you don't act on the illegal stuff, or don't get caught, who cares?"

My breath catches in my throat when I meet August's eyes. My own eyes fill with tears and when I blink, they spill over and trickle down my cheeks. I angrily swipe them away with the back of my hands.

"Talk to me, Kill," August says.

I turn my head to look at the monitor again before I take a deep breath and hold it in. Clamping my eyes shut, I focus on the steady beat of my heart and count the seconds in my head. Just a little longer and peace and tranquillity will wash over me.

"Stop!" August's voice distracts me well before I can deprive myself of oxygen and pass the fuck out.

When the panic subsides and I manage to suck in a lungful of air, I say, "The night we met, I told you everything, all my secrets, and you—you

could have told me about this... and the ball, the hunt, about Diablo.” I cross my arms over my chest. “You could have told me.”

“No, I couldn’t,” he says as he moves his chair closer to mine. He reaches in front of me to type on the keyboard.

modA.dm02: request access to Danse Macabre

admin.dm02: granted

He continues typing, and I keep my eyes on the monitor.

“Danse Macabre is part of The House of Machiavellianism,” he says as the words appear on the screen. When the prompt for a password appears, he doesn’t ask me to look away, so I watch intently as he types it in. The password is accepted, and August gains entry to a second page where he’s asked a series of random questions before he finally sits back in his chair. “Take a look.”

The House of Machiavellianism

Founded in 1985, The House of Machiavellianism serves to embrace the traits modern society frowns upon. Social hierarchy dictates each choice a human makes. At the top, like hunters watching over the land, are the rich and powerful.

At the bottom of the hierarchy are the weak, the hunted, the prey. Each move we make is calculated, measured, and weighed to ensure the outcome benefits those of us deemed worthy.

Greed, envy, lust, and pride reign supreme. A smorgasbord of cardinal sin awaits us.

As an inducted member of The House of Machiavellianism you will gain access to a group of elite and powerful men and women. Our esteemed members are protected from prosecution and free to indulge in the decadent pleasures life has to offer.

Turning to him, I scrutinise his features, searching for any sign he’s fucking with me. “So you what? Lure in random people and kill them—for fun?” I can’t hide the confusion in my tone, and I hate it. August is my best—my only—friend, and the thought of him lying to me all these years

makes me break out in a cold sweat. “Is that why you became friends with me? Were you trying to have me killed?”

“No.” He shakes his head, hands raised in defence. “Not at all. The House of Machiavellianism is a secret society of men and women with shared personality traits, paraphilias, beliefs, and goals. My stepfather was a member...” He hesitates, watching me closely before he continues, “He ah,” August lets out a heavy exhale. “He was killed in a hunt when I was nineteen. Chadwick added him to the ballot after he went to the cops.”

“He told them about all of this?” I ask, waving a hand towards the laptop.

August nods. “Yeah, fucking stupid. As if they don’t have members everywhere, keeping watch, spying.”

“Diablo killed him?” I assume.

“No. It was Chadwick. The House condones violence in any form, especially for traitors. It’s actually encouraged to gain, or to remain in power. If someone steps out of line, or even hints at wanting to leave once they’re inducted...”

“They’re killed?” I question.

“Some will be tortured first, others will be hunted. If they’re lucky, they’ll be killed quickly, that’s not common, though. Chadwick likes it to be drawn out.”

I stare at my best friend. My head spins with questions, but the first thing to spill from my mouth is, “You’re all psychopaths.” I narrow my eyes, confused, but intrigued. “Are you a psychopath?” I shake my head, unable to comprehend. “I don’t get it.”

An alert comes from the laptop in the form of a bell chiming, and I look at the screen.

admin.dm02: @modA.dm02 three minutes until you’re timed out

August reaches out and taps away on the keyboard.

modA.dm02: request thirty minutes

admin.dm02: granted

August stands and goes to the kitchen. He returns with two more bottles of beer. After a long swallow, he explains, “While we share similar tendencies, not all of us are psychopaths. In fact, we avoid using that term,

along with the term sociopath. The House is based on a shared belief system that benefits those our superiors deem worthy. We have a hierarchy, and rules we must follow to remain part of The House.”

“And you were fifteen when you joined?” I ask.

He nods. “My first Hunters and Gatherers Ball was at fifteen, as Gavin’s guest. I made it through the first hunt relatively unscathed. When I asked Gavin to add me to the ballot for the second hunt, my stepfather tried to stop me, but it was too late, I was already set on joining. I survived my second hunt, and was inducted a few weeks later,” he says.

Inducted. Justice’s words come back to me. “Justice, Salem’s ah, partner? He mentioned that. Said he knew I wasn’t inducted. He seemed surprised that I was there.” I twist the beer bottle in my hands, picking at the label as August continues.

“Yeah, him and Salem have been together for as long as I’ve been part of the house. He wasn’t inducted until he was much older, though. I think he was thirty,” he says, then adds, “To be inducted into The House, you need to be the son or daughter of a senior member. Otherwise, you need to survive a second hunt.”

“That seems kind of easy, we just sat in a cave near the river, no one knew we were there,” I say.

“The first hunt, yeah, I mean most people could get out of it alive. It’s only ten minutes, and the hunters are mainly base members, meaning they’re not as skilled as Salem and Diablo, or even me. The second hunt though—” He shakes his head hard. “It’s one hunter and five prey. Only ten people have made it out alive in the past fifteen years.”

“Bullshit.” I scoff.

August lights up a cigarette and takes a long drag. “For the past three years, no one has survived the second hunt.”

“Why though? One hunter and five prey, that’s good odds, right?”

August huffs out a laugh. “Not when Diablo is the hunter. I know you think he’s this hot as fuck killer, but he’s more brutal than what you’ve seen, Kill. He knows that arena like the back of his hand. There’s nowhere you can hide from him. I’ve seen him gut three grown men and slice their throats open in less than a minute, then he walked away, licking their blood off his fingers with a smile on his face.”

The image August paints, makes my cock hard and I shift in my seat, adjusting myself. “How did you manage it then?” I question.

“I fuckin’ ran, and I didn’t stop.” He shrugs. “He caught me, but the siren sounded before I passed out, so technically, I was still alive.”

“So I just have to outrun him until the siren goes off?” *I could do that.* I smile so wide my cheeks hurt.

August slaps the back of my head. “You’re fucking insane,” he says, but he laughs.

A buzz of excitement courses through my veins. “So, how do I get into the second hunt?” My sick, twisted desires are begging me to run back to Diablo. *You want it.* A voice in my head whispers. *You need it.*

“You need to be added to the ballot.” August reaches for the laptop and using the mouse he clicks on a menu titled “Ballot.” When he clicks on the tab, another page opens, and I read the screen.

WARNING

Once added to the ballot for a second hunt, names cannot be removed.

“You’re sure you’re ready for this?” August asks as he clicks on the empty box.

I nod. “Positive.” Since Diablo essentially kicked me out of his house, this could be my only way to gain access to him again.

August types my name into the box, then taps enter on the keyboard.

Immediately, a banner appears across the screen. The large red and white words flash...

ACCESS RESTRICTED

A few seconds later, there’s a chime, then a message pops up in the corner of the screen.

@modA.dm02 access restricted.

August Kensington, contact DM immediately. This is your only warn—.

“FUCK!” August shouts and slams the lid of the laptop closed before the text is complete. “I gotta go,” he says urgently, and races out the door.

“August, wait!” I shout, following after him.

Ignoring me, he throws a leg over his bike, the engine revving before he takes off without a word.

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XXI

*I kept sordid secrets
For the devil in disguise
Now that his mask has fallen
I have no choice but to lie*

AUGUST KENSINGTON

Four hours later

“Where the fuck are you?” Gavin’s voice grates on my nerves.

Holding the phone between my ear and my shoulder, I look down at the guy on his knees while I answer. “Training the new kid like you fucking asked me to.”

There’s a huff of annoyance. “Is Killian with you?”

“Nope. Haven’t seen him.” The dark haired twink on his knees sucks me off with all the enthusiasm of a guy who’s just discovered his love of cock. While my cock is hard, and I’m thrusting into the wet heat of his talented mouth, I’m completely detached.

There’s some rustling of clothes or sheets before Gavin’s voice returns. “Find him! And when you do, tell him to get his tight ass over here, I’ve got clients asking for him. Little fucker owes me for taking Saturday night off.”

Ignoring Gavin, I glare down at the brown eyes that stare up at me. They don’t match the blue-green eyes and pale face of the one I crave. And his mop of silky-smooth, black hair doesn’t look anything like the unruly strands of Killian’s ebony curls.

“Find him yourself. I’m not your fucking slave.”

There’s a string of curses from Gavin, so I end the call and shove my phone into the back pocket of my jeans.

Fuck. My. Life.

Everyone wants Killian, and who does he want? An unhinged fucking maniac.

Fuck Diablo! The asshole could have any-fucking-one he wants, but no, he wants Killian.

I should have taken my chance years ago, way back before Diablo decided to pursue him. What started out as me stalking some random kid, turned into infatuation overnight. Killian Graves is unlike anyone I’ve ever

met. The night I stopped him from leaping to his untimely death off the roof of an abandoned warehouse, I was immediately drawn to him.

His vulnerability sparks my primal desires. Killian calls to my dominant, sadistic side, and along with his willingness to be used, abused, and humiliated, he's the perfect submissive wrapped in a body to fucking die for.

And I have to hand him over to Diablo-fucking-King.

The past

I leaned against the brick wall outside Rafferty's Pawnbrokers. Cigarette between my lips, I watched as people walked by, indifferent to my existence. Dressed in leather and chains, with shoulder length black hair, black eyeliner, and painted black fingernails, they took one look at me, shuddered, and continued walking.

They saw me as an outcast, a criminal, someone to look down upon. They had no idea that if I was ordered to, I'd end their lives without a second thought.

At twelve, I was the youngest member of my stepfather's violent gang.

My stepfather had me stealing cars, breaking into homes and businesses, running drugs, and being pimped out on street corners. It all left me hating society.

When I met Gavin, he taught me to channel that rage, to use it against those who truly deserved it. Of course, his protection came with conditions. By then, I'd already lost faith in the world, and was willing to do anything to survive.

As my new pimp, Gavin controlled my every move, but in return, I got a roof over my head, food in my stomach, and an unlimited supply of drugs and alcohol.

At the age of fifteen, Gavin invited me to an event that would change my life.

I remember the spike of adrenaline that coursed through my veins as I was hunted like a rabid animal through a dense, dark forest. That night, I was the only survivor of the hunt.

Two weeks later, I was added to the ballot for the second hunt, and miraculously, I came out alive. Afterwards, I spent six weeks in hospital

recovering from multiple stab wounds inflicted by none other than Diablo King, who admitted he only allowed me to survive because the siren had sounded, signalling the end of the hunt.

He used to take pleasure in reminding me that it was merely his adherence to the rules that saved me from death that night.

A week before my sixteenth birthday, I was inducted into The House of Machiavellianism. As I worked my way through the ranks, I became well known within The House for my skills in tracking prey and gaining information.

As the streets cleared and businesses began closing their doors and roller shutters, I lingered on the footpath, waiting for him to appear from around the corner. I'd known Killian Graves for years, but with Gavin keeping the younger kids sheltered and well away from everyone else, we rarely crossed paths. Killian had no idea I'd been watching him, and Gavin had no idea I was aware of his paedophilic side business.

When Diablo and Salem brought me into their office one morning, the last thing I expected was to be tasked with finding a set of twins born sixteen years earlier.

All they gave me to go on was a blurry picture of a young woman with blue eyes and blonde hair—the mother, apparently, who Diablo assumed the twins would look like—and the name of a town four hours away, where the twins had been adopted out to a young couple who couldn't have children of their own.

I'd internally scoffed at them both, but on the outside, I remained calm and stoic. No one said no to Diablo King, and I sure as hell didn't want to be on his shit list.

Killian rounded the corner, dressed in black jeans and a loose black tee, a backpack slung over one shoulder. When he passed me, I waited until there was enough space between us, then started following him.

The damn kid walked for an hour, and I cursed him the whole time. When he reached the abandoned industrial estate, I hung back and watched as he pulled open the door to an empty warehouse.

By the time I'd followed him inside, made it up the old, steel ladder and onto the roof, I was almost too late.

Killian was standing on the edge of the iron roof, the toes of his Docs a few inches over the edge. With his arms spread wide, and his head raised to the sky, he appeared angelic.

What did Diablo want with him? I'd asked myself the same question many times.

Killian's inhale caught my attention, and I took a step forward.
"Don't do it."

That night, I held Killian in my arms as he spilled all his sordid, dirty secrets.

That night, my obsession with Killian Graves was born.

And I knew. I knew damn well that if I wanted to live, Diablo King could never find out.

As the memories fade, my rage boils over and I shove my cock further down the throat of Gavin's newest twink. He chokes, gags, and sputters, saliva dribbles from the corners of his mouth and tears roll from his eyes. He pounds his fists against my thighs as I watch on, apathetic to his need for oxygen.

Threading my fingers through his hair, I slam his face into my crotch, choking him with my cock until he finally passes out. I shove him backwards and step over his prone body to head to the shower.

He'll wake in a few minutes, and if he doesn't, I don't fucking care. Gavin can deal with it.

I strip off my clothes and as I'm about to get into the shower, my phone rings, and I rummage through my pants on the floor. When I find it in the back pocket of my jeans, I pull it out to see Salem's name on the screen.

"What?" I ask, still seething from Gavin's phone call, and thoughts of Killian with Diablo.

"I think you know what I'm calling about. Diablo's pissed," Salem says.

Speak of the devil. I force out a loud, fake laugh. "When isn't he pissed, Sal? Dude has a stick up his ass twenty-four-fucking-seven."

There's a moment of silence before Salem, the bastard, says, "And Kensington, you're on loudspeaker. Diablo's here."

Rather than dig my grave any deeper, I try to diffuse the situation before I end up six-feet-under. "You told me to give him what he wants,

without touching him. He wanted to be added to the ballot. I did exactly what you asked.”

There’s a grunt, then, “I did not ask you to add him to the ballot. I am also paying you for information, Kensington. Information I am not receiving.” Diablo’s voice is cold, and as usual, there’s no inflection. It’s weird as fuck to hear him speak in that flat, dull tone. “If you are unable to gather this information, your assistance will no longer be required.”

Blah, blah, fucking blah. The urge to mock the asshole is strong, but I rein in my temper. I’m already on his bad side, and it’s only thanks to Salem that I wasn’t on the menu at the last feast. I plan on keeping it that way.

Reluctantly, I give him the information I’ve been holding back for as long as he’s been paying me. Yes, I’m a traitorous bastard, but in my world—and in The House of Machiavellianism—you do whatever you can to survive, and you hope to hell you don’t get caught.

I tell him, “His parents used to lock him in a cage in the cellar. Being trapped in small, enclosed spaces in the dark is the only thing he’s afraid of.”

“And you’ve known this for how long?” Diablo asks.

I swallow down the lump in my throat. I hate the hold Diablo has over me.

“A couple months,” the lie comes easily. “He wanted to try the torture booth at Snare, freaked the fuck out. That’s when he told me.”

A door slams before Salem’s voice comes on the line. “Fuck it, Kensington. Why didn’t you mention this before? I know being tortured isn’t one of your kinks, man.”

“You know why,” is all I say.

“Yeah, well, that’s off the table, permanently. I warned you years ago not to get attached. You can’t have him, so get that thought out of your head. I need you alive,” Salem says. “My little firebird needs protection, and while I’m busy with Diablo, I’m paying you to ensure he remains safe.”

Leaning against the bathroom door, I let out a heavy sigh. “Yeah, yeah, I know. I just love being needed by you guys, Sal. Best fucking thing in the world,” I say with all the sarcasm I can muster. “I gotta go. I’ve got a comatose twink in my bedroom, and Gavin’s riding my ass about Killian.”

“Go on then. And stay out of Diablo’s way. I’ll get your access to the site reinstated tonight.”

I tap my phone to end the call, then slide down the wall until my ass hits the floor.

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XXII

*I've begged and I've pleaded
I've given up free will
What else do I have to do
To feel that final thrill*

KILLIAN

One week later

The tree lined path weaves through the dense forest and comes out at the graveyard behind Newhaven Asylum. It's after midnight, and with dark rainclouds hovering above, threatening a storm, I quicken my steps. With no fences, and no security cameras or lights to speak of, the eerie darkness surrounds me.

Using my phone's torch to light my way, I veer off the path and traipse through the long grass and shrubbery until I reach the low, brick wall at the back of the abandoned asylum.

In the far-off distance, fleeting glints of light come from Iron Tomb prison's guard towers. Built into the side of Ironbark Mountain, the thirty-minute drive to the entrance of the prison follows a winding, gravel road. Thinking about the prison brings back thoughts of the hunt, Chadwick Monroe, and the skeleton in Diablo's mansion.

"Yours." Why does Diablo have my mother's skeleton?

The way he looked at the skull... the entire skeleton with such reverence, there is no way he could have loved her, not after the way he tortured and mutilated her body.

"Yours."

"Someone I once loved."

"Someone we both loved."

I groan in frustration, sick to fucking death of the secrecy, the lies, and the fact that no matter what I do, or how much I give in, or offer to Diablo, he refuses to give me what I want.

It's been a week since Salem threw me—literally—out of Diablo's mansion. Anxiety laced with desperation is clawing at me—I'm having withdrawals over a killer. Usually, I'd see him around town, or I'd catch a

glimpse of him heading into or out of one of the stores or cafés along Main Street. But this week, there's been no sign of him anywhere.

“From now on, I am the only one who inflicts pain on you. The only one who touches you.”

His words come back to me, and a smile stretches across my lips as I form a plan.

If he's going to ghost me, I'll have to take matters into my own hands. I need to let him see me disobey him.

Gavin's been keeping me off the streets for the past week. He's had my regulars come to his house where I have to give them what they want right across the hall from Gavin's bedroom. Now, I wonder if he knows something, if he's keeping me off the streets for a reason.

Nodding to myself, a newfound confidence envelops me, and I pick up my pace.

Diablo has to be here. I *need* to see him. Then, I need to show him I'm not afraid to do exactly what he's forbidden me to do.

Adrenaline pumps through my veins as I heft myself up onto the ledge of an unbarred window and climb inside. I change my phone torch to the lowest setting, then make my way down a long, narrow corridor until I reach the main hall.

Once I've gathered my bearings, I follow the path we took during the tour.

When pattering footsteps sound behind me, I freeze in my tracks. Goosebumps prickle across my flesh. A door creaks from somewhere above. My heart pounds in my chest. Fear wars with excitement as I continue. Hand splayed on the wall, I feel my way along the corridor and deeper into the asylum.

The door to the morgue is wide open, and I step inside. Like last time, it's in pristine condition compared to the rest of the asylum. The scent of bleach lingers, almost as though the whole area has just been cleaned. Nervous apprehension coils in my gut when I approach the cremation oven. I reach out and trace my finger along the seam of the oven door, and when I pull it back, it comes away clean. I know there was blood seeping from the door last time I was here. It's definitely being used for something, and I bet it's all part of The House of Machiavellianism's human hunts.

Do they bring the prey back here to dispose of them after they're killed? Or do they use the cremation oven to cook—I shake my head hard, remembering the taste of human flesh on my tongue. The sweet flavour and delicate texture of the rare meat had my mouth watering for more. While I'd thought about cannibalism before, often with perverted fascination, the act of consuming human flesh didn't repulse me at all.

The more I think about it, the more I come to realise that I'm not, and never have been, normal. My thoughts, my actions, my desires, they're all fucked up, and I wonder if the trauma from my childhood made me this way, or if I was born like this.

Five years old

“Mumma, can I sit with you?” I crawled up onto her lap and wrapped my arms around her neck.

For a little while, she was very still, but then sharp fingernails dug into my arms, and she pushed me away. “Get off me,” she shouted.

I landed on my bottom on the floor right next to Mumma's feet, and when I crawled up to her legs, she put her foot on my face and pushed me backwards again.

“Don't touch me, filthy brat.” I didn't know what filthy brat was, I just wanted her to cuddle and kiss me like she did with my brother Kaspian.

When Kaspian climbed onto the sofa, Mumma let him sit on her lap. She held him very softly and kissed his head and she always called him “Special boy.”

I wanted to be special too.

“Mumma, I wanna sit with you too,” I said, rubbing the wet, dribbly tears from my cheeks. “Can I sit next to you?” I used my quiet voice so she wouldn't get angry again.

She didn't listen, so I tried again. Slowly, I crawled to the sofa where she sat with my brother, and I climbed up beside him. I stretched out my arm and tried to reach Mumma's hand, but she slapped my hand away and stood up, lifting Kaspian into her arms.

He wrapped his legs around her and laid his head on her shoulder. His eyes that were the same as mine, looked down at me, and he smiled.

“Mumma, please can you pick me up?” I asked in my very best voice ever.

Mumma didn't answer me, so I sat on the sofa. It was still warm from when she was sitting there, and it smelled a little bit like her smokes.

When my dad walked in, I curled up in a little ball.

"You need to put him in the cellar," Mumma said. "I can't deal with two of 'em, Don."

I shook my head very hard, and more drops of tears came from my eyes. "No, Mumma, I don't wanna go in there. The monsters are in the dark."

Dad leaned against the doorway and drank some of his beer. "He paid us to take 'em both. You wanna hand that one back and go back to living in a shit hole?" When Dad pointed at me, I covered my face with my hands so he couldn't see me.

"I told you I only wanted one!" Mum shouted. "One fuckin' kid, not two."

There was a loud slapping sound, and when I peeked through my fingers, Kaspian was sitting near the wall, crying, and Dad had his hands around Mumma's neck. Her face was all red, and lots of tears were coming from her eyes.

"You'll do what ya fuckin' told!" Dad shouted and he smacked Mumma's face with the back of his hand. She dropped down to the floor while Dad stomped his feet all around the living room. "Ya think a guy like Monroe will give us an out? He'll fuckin' bury us. We gotta do this, Val. Thirteen years tops, then we let 'em go. That's the deal."

"Fine," Mumma said. "But I don't like it."

"I was talkin' to Gav this morning. He's got clients willin' to pay for home movies. Reckons twins will bring in the big bucks." Dad sat next to me while he talked to Mumma.

Mumma wiped her hands across her wet face and sniffed. "How much?"

"Ten grand a piece," Dad said. He looked at me and did a big smile. "This one'll be easy to train, but you need to get the other one to do what he's told. Sick to fuckin' death of listenin' to his whinin'. You baby him, Val, it's gotta stop."

I shake my head to free myself from the memories, but something my dad said lingers in the back of my mind. Long forgotten conversations from the past that my five-year-old self didn't understand.

“A guy like Monroe—”

Was he talking about Chadwick Monroe?

“He paid us to take ‘em both—”

Paid?

“Oh, fuck no!” I gasp, then slap a hand over my mouth.

Was I abducted? Sold?

“Is it your mum?” I asked Diablo.

“Yours.” That single word uttered from Diablo’s lips assaults me.

“Someone we both loved.”

Could Diablo be my brother?

“NO! Nonono—” I drop to my knees, rocking back and forth, repeating “No,” over and over as my mind reels and bile rises in my throat.

I’m distracted from my racing thoughts when my phone vibrates. I check the screen to see a text message from August.

August: Where are you? We need to talk.

When my panic subsides, I reply.

Me: Talk about what?

August: Diablo. Look, Kill, it’s important. Meet me in an hour?

Me: I’m busy.

August: Tell me where you are, I’ll come to you.

Ignoring August’s last message, I get to my feet, and after taking one last glance back at the cremation oven, I turn on my heels and head to the stairs that lead down to the basement. As I pass by another corridor, a flicker of light coming from beneath a closed door catches my eye.

Curiosity piqued, I take a left turn down a narrow corridor lined with countless doors on either side. Gripping my phone against my chest to block the torch light, I cautiously approach the door emitting the thin sliver of light.

My hand trembles as I wrap my fingers around the cold, steel handle and slowly pull it open. When I peer inside, the full moon shines through the barred window and cracked glass, leaving a puddle of light that fades away as clouds pass across the moon.

I raise my phone’s torch, taking a few tentative steps forward.

A loud gasp leaves my lips before I can stop it, and I cough violently as dusty, frigid air catches in my throat and fills my lungs. I rub the back of my hand against my eyes, squinting through the shadows, wondering if I'm caught in some kind of vivid hallucination.

No, this is real.

Dozens of human skeletons are suspended above me, marionettes swinging in the breeze that blows through the broken windows. The gentle rattle of bones disturbingly mimics the sound of wooden windchimes as the skeletons sway beneath the flickering light of the moon.

Heart racing, I edge closer to get a better look. Each of the bony limbs are attached to thin wires that manipulate them into different positions, making the entire, deeply sinister scene appear as a macabre dance of death.

Are these all victims of the hunt?

I weave my way through the skeletons, avoiding contact with their bony frames and extended limbs. I'm almost back to the doorway when footsteps echo along the corridor, coming closer by the second. I tuck my phone into my pocket and dart to the back of the room where I squeeze between a heavy wooden desk and a large filing cabinet.

"Shhh..." a quiet voice says as the footsteps come closer.

There's a beat of silence, and a beam of torch light passes over the room.

"This was closed." It's Salem.

I hold my breath, waiting for him to leave.

A second voice says, "Are you sure?" It sounds like Stefani, but with my heartbeat pounding in my ears, and panic enveloping me, I can't be certain.

"Of course I'm sure," Salem replies.

I crouch in the darkness as two pairs of feet pace across the room, the torch light bounces off the walls and floor, but never comes close to revealing my hiding place.

"It's probably rats." That's definitely Stefani. "I told Diablo we need to set more traps," she adds.

I exhale slowly as they leave the room, closing the door on their way out. Their voices and footsteps fade into the distance. I wait for a

blanket of silence to smother the room before I slowly creep out and head to the door.

A few minutes later, I continue along the corridor, peeking into each room until I finally reach the staircase to the basement.

The door to what Stefani called the wax display, is closed, and I tug on the handle. Thankfully, it opens without so much as a creak. When I step inside, I sigh in disappointment. The black, vinyl drapes on the other side of the glass are closed. I can't see anything.

A heavy thud catches my attention, then a grunt, and a cry of pain.

I take a tentative step forward, my body a livewire of anticipation as I approach the glass. A tiny sliver of light peeks through the middle of the drapes. I lean in as close as I can, my hot breaths puff against the glass, fogging it up and making it harder to see.

Squinting, I swipe the fog away and peek through the tiny slit in the drapes. A body hangs from the butcher's hook, but this one isn't still. It's definitely not wax. It's a man, and he's thrashing and grunting. Blood pours from his nose and mouth and dribbles down onto the smooth, hairless expanse of his chest.

I shift slightly, hoping the change of position will allow me to see who else is in there.

Focused on the scene behind the glass, I shrug off a tickle of air that rushes across my neck, too enthralled by the man's imminent death to care about anything else.

A second later, my arms are yanked back, and I'm slammed into the glass, my cheek pressed against the cold, flat surface.

"So we do have a rat. And this isn't the first time you've been caught, is it, little hunter?" Stefani shoves me harder into the glass as the drapes open to reveal a magnificent scene. Behind me, Stefani's breasts are pressed against my back, her body unmoving. "Aren't you just the prettiest prey I ever did see?" she sing songs.

I want to fight her hold, but I can't. Nothing can steal my attention away from the killer. Wearing a leather balaclava, he looks my way. Deep, dark eyes glare into mine. And for only the second time, I see his naked torso, and I suck in a ragged breath.

He is magnificent. A smooth, hairless chest, strong pecs, and perfect abs trail down to a well-defined V. But what truly takes my breath away are the tattoos that adorn his body. Skeletons dancing around a bonfire covers

most of his torso. Surrounding the detailed scene are skulls, death moths, anatomical hearts, and twisted vines that extend down his muscled biceps and forearms.

He's perfect.

My killer.

My devil.

Diablo King.

I don't fucking care if we're somehow related, or if that skeleton in the bedroom is my mother or his.

Diablo King is mine.

My breath catches as he lifts his bloody knife and slices across the man's torso in one swift movement. The deep gash oozes with thick, red blood.

"You like what you see, don't you, Killian?" Stefani whispers against my ear. "That's what you want, isn't it? To be the one hanging there, bleeding out. Dying at *his* hands."

Breathless, I can't take my eyes off Diablo as he turns his attention away from me and focuses on the dying man who screams in terror.

Diablo reaches out and traces his gloved fingers across the man's heaving chest. He steps forward, cups the terrified man's cheek and leans in so close I think he's about to kiss him.

A low whine leaves my lips, and Stefani laughs. "Aww, the little hunter's jealous."

"Let me go," I shout, struggling against her hold.

Diablo swipes his thumb across the man's bottom lip. Whispers something against his ear. Steps back and trails those gloved fingers down to the man's hand.

Stefani was right. Jealousy courses through my veins, and I beg, "Please, please let me in there."

"Hmm, do you think he wants you in there?" she teases. "Do you think someone like Diablo King wants anything to do with such a disobedient little boy?"

"Ughhhh, let me go!" Grunting, I try to fight her off, but damn, she's so strong I can barely move.

Diablo lifts his knife, his fist tight around the hilt as he shoves it into the man's stomach, then drags it down to his groin, gutting him.

Tears well in my eyes, and I blink them away. I don't feel a shred of empathy for the man. I don't care that he's being murdered, or that I can hear his gurgled pleas. These are tears of joy, but they're laced with envy, and smothered in the exhilarating pleasure of being able to watch a killer—*my killer*—commit brutal murder.

I press myself harder against the glass, seeking friction on my erection that tented my pants the second I saw the body hanging from the hook. When a whimper leaves my lips, Stefani's laugh echoes through the room.

"Let me in there," I beg. "I want to see him."

There's a soft chuckle, then, "You really want to go in there, don't you? You want to watch the master at work."

"Yes," I say without hesitation. "I do! I want to watch." Tears sting my eyes, and before I can take another breath, I'm yanked backwards and dragged by my arms through the doorway and into the middle of the murder room.

When I'm shoved to my knees in a puddle of thick, crimson blood, I drop my hands to the floor. I allow my fingertips to delve into the lifeblood that's poured from the man whose dangling feet are mere inches from my face.

I've heard people talk about the moment they discover their path in life. The moment they find God, or true love, or when they finally figure out why they were put on this earth.

I knew it before, felt it in the marrow of my bones. But right here, right now, as I kneel in the blood of a murder victim, and stare into the dark eyes of a killer, I know with absolute certainty, I've found my calling in life.

What I am, what I will always be, what I've dreamed of for so long, is to be right here, the victim of imminent murder.

I lick my lips as Diablo glares at me, bloody knife tight in his gloved hand.

"We found your pet wandering around," Stefani says, a wide smile on her full, red lips. "You should teach him a lesson."

When Diablo nods towards the door, Stefani giggles as she leaves.

From the corner of my eye, I watch her black boots disappear before the door closes, then locks with a loud click.

Diablo presses the tip of his knife to the underside of my chin. Using the flat side of the knife, he lifts my head until I'm staring into his

cold, dark eyes.

My chest heaves with each breath and my hands, sticky with blood, curl into fists. I imagine climbing on top of him and licking every sweat and blood covered inch of his tattooed skin. I beg my erection to wane, but it only grows harder, and when he drops his gaze to my crotch, I catch a spark of heat in his gaze, but it's gone in the blink of an eye.

"You shouldn't be here." He turns his back on me. "I'm disappointed, Killian."

"I'm disappointed, Killian." Those words cause a choked sob to escape my lips.

Seven years old

"You have to do what you're told," my brother Kaspian whispers from where he's sitting beside me on the dirty floor of our basement.

I uncross my legs and stretch them out. "I don't wanna," I say, flicking my hair off my face with the back of my hand. "They're not the boss of me."

Kaspian nods. "Yes they are. We're just kids. We have to do what we're told. That's what Mum said, same as school, you gotta listen or you'll get in trouble." He kicks my foot. "And you'll get punished again."

I look away from Kaspian. I don't wanna be punished again, but I don't like doing the videos. I used to cry a lot, but Mum kept saying, "Stop crying, stop crying, stop crying."

Now I just let them keep hurting me.

I do a big huff because I'm tired of waiting for Dad to come back.

When I stand up, Kaspian grabs onto my hand and tries to pull me back down to the dirty, dusty floor. I pull my hand away and start picking at the dry scabs on my fingers. They're still a little bit sore from punching the wall last night when Dad locked me in my bedroom.

The basement door creaks open, and I hear my mum and dad talking, then another voice I know. It's Gavin. I don't like him. He's the man who makes us do all the things for the videos. Sometimes, Mum and Dad do the videos with us, and that's when I try to be good, because if I'm good, I get special hugs the same as Kaspian.

I watch Gavin set up his camera and the big, bright lights. When Mum and Dad take off their clothes, I get a little bit of happy bubbles in my

tummy because today I might get hugs.

Kaspian wriggles closer to me. "Don't get in trouble, okay. I don't wanna do it by myself, I only wanna do it if you are."

"Okay," I say, then I listen to Gavin talk to Dad.

"This client wants ya all in bed." He waves his hand between Mum and Dad. "You two'll be fuckin,' then the twins'll come in. Let 'em touch ya, bit of jerking off, fingerin,' suckin,' all that shit. Got it?"

Dad nods. Mum smiles and gets on the big bed that has white sheets and pillows. Gavin tells me and Kaspian to stand next to him, and to wait until he tells us to get on the bed.

When Mum and Dad are making weird grunting sounds, Gavin smacks my bottom and says, "Get on the bed, crawl up in the middle."

I do what I'm told, and when I'm squished between Mum and Dad, Mum does the biggest smile and lets me lay on her while she cuddles me and pats my hair and my bottom.

Her skin is a little bit wet and sticky, but I don't care. I wish Mum would cuddle me all the time, but she only does it when Gavin makes the videos.

When Kaspian gets on the bed, Dad sits up and puts his hand around his big, hard dick and moves it up and down. "Do you want to touch Daddy's big dick?" he says, looking at me.

I put my head on Mumma's shoulder. "I wanna stay with Mumma." I scrunch up my nose and shake my head because I don't like it, and even though I know I'll be punished, the monsters in my head shout, No, no, no!

Dad makes a sad face, then he looks at Kaspian and smiles. "Come on, Kas, come and play with Daddy."

* * *

"I'm disappointed, Killian." Gavin drags me to the corner of the room and pushes me into the wall. "Next time you fuckin' play along like you're supposed to!" he shouts at me, then hits my face with the back of his hand. "You're costing me money, you little bastard!"

Mum wraps a long, red dressing gown around her body and puffs on her smoke. "Put him in the cellar," she says to Dad, but first, she gets on her knees in front of me and blows a big puff of stinky smoke in my face.

"Until you can do what you're told, we'll keep locking you in the cage." Mum's big smile makes me remember what she's going to do. She

holds my arm very tight, her long nails are pointy, and they poke into my skin, then she presses her smoke into my tummy.

It's hot and burning and hurts so much, and I try really, really hard not to cry or move, but some tears drip from my eyes, and I try to get away from her.

Mum flicks her smoke onto the floor and stands up, then she grabs Kaspian's hand and takes him upstairs.

I wish they would always give me soft touches and hugs like Kaspian gets, but I think they know about the monsters in my head, and that's why they always want to hurt me.

When Dad looks at me, I cross my arms and blink away all the cry-baby tears so that Dad doesn't get too angry. My dad likes hurting me too. I think I like it sometimes. When Mum and Dad are hurting me, I get to feel their hands touching me, and sometimes, the hurt feels like home.

"Fucking bastard kid," Dad says. "We should've never taken you in." When he picks me up and carries me down the stairs to the cold, dark cellar, I kick and wriggle and scream at him to let me go.

Dad turns on the light in the cellar and my eyes get stuck looking at the little cage. When he shoves me inside, I try to get away, but Dad is so big and strong, I can't get past him. He puts a lock on the cage and walks away.

When he turns the light off, I squeeze my eyes shut so I won't see the monsters that creep out of my head and hide in the shadows.

"Killian," the monster whispers. I wrap my arms around my body. "Hurt them, Killian. Hurt them like they always hurt you." I shake my head very hard, but another monster with a different voice sneaks into the cage.

I can feel its slimy fingers on the back of my neck, and it lets lots of tiny spiders crawl all over my skin. "Hurt yourself, Killian. You like to hurt, don't you?"

When I shake my head, the second scary monster gets very angry and puts its cold hand around my neck. I blink to try to see it, but it's too dark.

"No, no, no," I shout at the monster. "I don't wanna get hurt!"

"You want them to touch you. You want them to hurt you."

I shake my head because I don't want to listen. I pull my knees up and put my head down so the monster doesn't know I'm scared.

"You're going to die in that little cage. Die, die, die."

I try to shove the monster away, but my hands and feet don't want to move.

"You can't breathe." The monster squeezes my throat. "You're going to die." I open my mouth to scream. Lots of breaths and little squeaking sounds come out.

"You'll never get out." The monster stands on my tummy. It's so, so heavy and when I try to scream again, only very, very fast breathing comes from my mouth and lots of wet tears come from my eyes.

"It's so dark, Killian. So dark and scary."

I put my hands over my ears so I can't hear the monsters. "Go away, go away, go away," I shout.

"I'm disappointed, Killian," the monster says when it creeps back inside my head. "I'm disappointed, Killian. Disappointed. Disappointed."

I pull my hair and hit my head to make the monster stop talking to me. When the cold, slithery fingers touch me again, I smack them away and scratch and pick all the creepy, crawly spiders off my arms and my face and my neck.

"Go away!" I scream again. I bang and bang and bang my head against the cage, but the monsters don't leave, and all of my body is cold and shivery and wet.

"I'm disappointed, Killian," the monster whispers very softly.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry." I curl up into a tiny ball and promise the monsters I'll be good.

XXIII

*Maybe tonight
You'll meet your demise
For brutality lies
In envious eyes*

KILLIAN

Two days later

“This isn’t a good idea,” August says. “If he wanted to see you, he’d contact you, or he’d just fuckin’ take you, Kill.”

I brush off his concern as I pull on the smallest, tightest pair of leather shorts I could find. I need Diablo. I need him like a hard drug. I want his knife slicing into my skin. I want his hands on me, his teeth in my flesh. Since the night he kicked me out of the asylum and told me not to come back, I haven’t been able to stop thinking about him. Seeing him at the asylum only strengthened my resolve. Diablo King is the only one who can sate my sickest needs.

But why did he kick me out and send me on my way as though I was nothing more than an annoyance? Why does he keep pushing me away?

After pulling on my harness, I turn my back to August. “Can you fix the buckles?”

Huffing, he gets to work on the buckles then gives my ass a hard slap. “You’re gonna get me killed, you know that, right?”

I smile, but shake my head, dropping down to my bed to pull on my Docs. “Don’t be so dramatic, Aug. He’s not going to kill you for taking me to the club. He probably won’t even be there,” I say.

August goes back to the bathroom and leans into the mirror to apply thick, black eyeliner. When he comes out, his eyes trail over my body. “You look good enough to eat,” he says with a wink.

“Eat.” I shake my head and laugh. “I still can’t believe I ate human meat.”

August drops down on the bed beside me and rubs my thigh. “I thought you’d freak out, actually.”

“Does that happen a lot?” I ask. “I mean eating people—cannibalism?”

He shrugs. “Every induction ceremony, feast, ball. It’s so normal now I don’t even think about it most of the time.” August takes my hand in his and gives it a gentle squeeze. “Kill, I need to tell you—”

He’s cut off when his phone chimes with a message. Standing, August checks his phone, types out a message, then looks down at me and smiles. “You ready to go?”

“Wait, what were you going to tell me?” I ask.

He shakes his head. “Doesn’t matter, come on, let’s go.”

* * *

DIABLO

From the booth at the back of the club, I watch August Kensington enter Snare through the double doors. Twisted around his hand, a length of silver chain is attached to a thick, leather collar that sits snug around Killian’s neck. The sight causes my jaw to clench, and a low growl rumbles through my chest.

Salem clears his throat, knocking his knee against mine. “Calm the fuck down, you had to know this would happen.” He nods at my glass of whiskey. “Have another drink.”

Scowling, I lift the glass to my lips and inhale the rich, grainy scent of the amber liquid before taking a sip. It does little to calm the rage that’s brewing inside me.

Earlier, Salem received a text from August saying he was with Killian, and they were on their way here. My little hunter thought he’d try to make me jealous by showing up at my club with another man. *Two can play at that game.*

“Is everything ready?” I ask Salem.

He swallows down a mouthful of whiskey from his own glass, then nods. “Yeah, it’s all good to go. So, you’re really going to keep him?”

I nod once. “For now.” My focus shifts away from Salem when I catch a glimpse of August standing at the edge of the round stage in the centre of the room. He looks over his shoulder and says something to Killian as he tugs on the chain. Killian obediently steps forward, standing beside August as they watch the scene.

A man hangs from the rafters, his body trapped like a fly caught in a spider’s web. Tightly woven, red Shibari ropes crisscross around his naked

flesh and attach to multiple anchor points on the ceiling.

Arousal and longing surge through my veins, and I clench my fist around the whiskey glass, my knuckles turning white with the force of my grip. The surrounding air is filled with the sounds of whips cracking against flesh, and the primal moans and groans of patrons indulging in their darkest desires.

Snare is a club unlike any other. A hidden den of debauchery where twisted minds can run wild, and paraphilic perversions can be sated beneath the guise of secrecy.

Clad in skin-tight leather shorts, and a leather harness that crosses over his chest, Killian is on display for anyone's perusal. The eyes of strangers follow his every move, their lecherous gazes tracing his lean, tattooed body. Silver chains dangle from his nipples, connected to a central ring that's attached to his collar by another chain. His wrists are adorned with thick, studded leather cuffs.

As August wanders through the club with Killian, I'm consumed with envy.

Not only does he have my disobedient little hunter by his side, but throughout the wide, open space of the club's main room, and behind closed doors, others are indulging in the pleasures I crave.

Salem tugs up the sleeve of his suit jacket and checks his watch. "It's time," he says, pushing his empty glass across the bar.

When we reach the private entrance to the Dark Room, the door closes with a soft snick. The Dark Room is soundproof, causing my heartbeat to reverberate in my ears. As usual, it takes a few seconds for my hearing to adjust to the sounds of our combined breathing, and the lack of external stimuli.

Salem undresses quickly, removing his watch, shoes, socks, and clothes before pulling on his leather harness. Next, he swaps his black eye mask for a full-face, leather mask—his eyes and mouth are all that are visible. He leans casually against the wall, his scrutinising gaze taking me in.

"It's not too late to change your mind," he says, crossing his arms over his chest.

"I'm not changing my mind." I huff in annoyance and turn my back to him as I take my own full-face mask from the drawer and pull it on. "Just play your part," I remind him.

“Oh, I will.” Salem pats me on the shoulder. “You know how much I love to play.”

I let out an exasperated sigh. “Yes, I do.”

Salem laughs, and one glance at his eyes tells me he’s going to enjoy playing this up for the crowd.

From our place behind the raised stage, we’re shielded from view by long, black drapes, and as we wait for people to arrive, I lean back against the wall beside Salem. My body thrumming with anticipation.

The Dark Room is where patrons come to indulge in the most extreme and taboo paraphilias and fetishes. This includes biastophilia, piquerism, odaxelagnia, cannibalism, necrophilia, sadism, and masochism. Here, the deviants with minds so twisted and depraved they’d never dare to indulge outside this underground society, come to play.

Since becoming the owners of Snare, Salem and I have made few changes. The main one was letting new and prospective members know that nothing at all is off limits. This new ruling has made luring child predators into Snare almost too easy.

With Doctor Kate McCallister sending some of her clients here, and word spreading about Danse Macabre’s experiences and “cures,” those who are guided to our club hoping to sate their paedophilic perversions, find themselves wishing they hadn’t been so honest about their depravities.

My mind wanders as I fantasise about the paedophiles I’ve tortured, mutilated, and killed behind the doors of the private rooms. A lucky few were merely mutilated before being set free, only to be recaptured and used as fodder for our hunts.

Violent, bloody memories flash across my vision.

My father forcing his blood covered cock into my mouth.

Vomit, blood, bile.

My small body convulsing on the cold, hard ground.

His teeth biting into my buttocks, my thighs, my torso.

His words. “You asked for this, Darius.”

The whip slicing across my back.

Then...

His knife in my hand.

Me, stabbing his victims.

Me, begging to help him.

Him, fucking the gaping wounds while I watched on, my child's mind not able to comprehend the meaning of his actions.

Sucking the blood from my father's fingers.

The taste of flesh in my mouth, on my tongue.

My father rewarding me by forcing blood-soaked fingers inside me.

"One day, you'll be just like me."

"One day, you'll feel the need."

"NO!" I shout. I will never touch a child that way. I'll kill them all if I have to. End their lives before they know the horrors that await them. Before my hands can taint their flesh or torture their bodies.

Kill them all.

Kill them.

Kill!

Shaking out of my stupor, I turn to Salem. "I need to hunt."

He lifts his head, eyes narrowed in confusion. "What the hell, D? Now?"

I shake my head. "No. Yes?" I clench my fists as I pace back and forth. My head swims with visions of my father, of Chadwick, and of Killian.

I focus only on Killian.

My mouth waters at the thought of plunging my knife into his heart.

Killian.

Kill.

Kill him.

When sweat forms on my brow, I yank off the mask and swipe my forehead with the back of my hand.

"Damn it, Diablo, what's going on?" Salem asks, pulling me from my thoughts. "Are you fucking losing it?"

I plant my hands on the wall and drop my head between my shoulders, inhaling deep, ragged breaths. "I want to kill him. *Need* to kill him—" These warring emotions, these feelings of rage and desperation, of want and of hate, all of them are Killian's fault.

If I end him, these feelings will disappear.

"Then do it," Salem says as though it's that simple. "Kill him. Then get the fuck over it."

Whirling on him, I shove him against the wall and wrap my hand around his throat. “NO!” I roar, but the soundproofing in the room muffles my shout, and it doesn’t have the desired effect. “I can’t. I *can’t* kill him.”

Salem’s hand comes up, his fingers curl over my wrist. His grip is firm, familiar. His Adam’s apple bobs beneath my palm, and when I meet his heated gaze, I see the smile in his eyes. “Kill him or keep him,” Salem says with a shrug. He tugs on my wrist, pulling it away from his throat before his fingers slide between mine. He holds our joined hands to his chest. “Whatever you decide, I’m here for you, D. You’re not him—you’re not your father, remember that, okay?”

After squeezing his hand once, I drop my hand and turn around to pull my mask back on. “Thank you,” I say, annoyed that he can bring me down so easily.

There’s a quiet snicker behind me and I know Salem is smiling like a damn lunatic, naturally, I ignore him, and I switch on the monitor on the wall.

Salem comes up beside me. We watch as August enters the room and waves towards a plush leather recliner in front of the stage. Killian kneels at his feet as August orders a drink from the provided tablet.

When August’s fingers thread through Killian’s hair, and he slowly glides his hand down to wrap it around that precious throat, I clench my fists, ready to storm out there and snatch Killian away from his best friend. I know there is nothing but friendship on Killian’s side. And I am aware they regularly do scenes together, and that they have in the past, fucked.

For six years, I’ve been acutely aware of August’s presence in Killian’s life, but he belongs to me, and it’s time for August to go.

“August needs to go,” I speak my thoughts aloud.

Salem lets out a long-suffering sigh. “I still need him. Just a while longer.”

I don’t reply. My patience for August Kensington has run out.

The velvet drapes that shield the stage begin to part, revealing the rest of the Dark Room. Two, muscular, naked men in full face masks and leather harnesses similar to Salem’s, wheel a bondage frame onto the stage before leaving through the rear door.

“Let’s do this,” Salem says, giving me a pat on the back.

I step onto the stage to hushed whispers and muffled chatter until the attendant shushes everyone. The small crowd falls under a blanket of

complete silence. I catch a glimpse of Killian kneeling at August's feet. He's watching me closely, but I don't allow my gaze to linger on him.

Tonight, he will watch me give Salem the things he so desperately desires.

Once the crowd has settled, Salem steps onto the stage, hands clasped behind his back, his head bowed in a show of submission. While Salem is anything but submissive, we've done similar scenes more times than I can count. There is no one I trust more to pull this off.

Using my knife, I lift his chin and press my lips to his mouth before pointing to the bondage frame.

Salem moves slowly, positioning himself beneath the frame.

I sheathe my knife and move around him, attaching the chained cuffs to his ankles and wrists, then I attach the thick leather collar around his neck to the chain above his head.

The silver, spiked cock ring around the base of his dick will ensure he remains hard throughout our scene, and the thick, glass plug in his ass will heighten his pleasure.

With slow, deliberate movements, I draw my knife and drag the tip down Salem's abdomen until I reach his groin. I repeat the action four more times, leaving long, thin trails of blood behind.

Keeping my focus on Salem, I lick the blood from the tip of the knife, smearing it across my lips to leave them stained crimson. I twirl my knife in my hand, throwing it into the air and catching it again, earning me a few awestruck reactions from the crowd.

My gaze flits across the room, and I'm careful not to make eye contact with Killian.

Salem slows his breathing, his chest rises and falls. His hard cock is flushed deep pink and is dripping with precum. I circle him a few times, slicing small nicks into the flesh of his thighs, torso, back, and ass.

I stand behind him, reaching around with one hand to close my fist around his pierced cock, tugging on the thick ring in his crown between long, slow strokes.

"Fuck," Salem mutters under his breath as he bucks into my hand.

Looking over Salem's shoulder, I lock eyes with Killian. Lips slightly parted, his tongue darts out to swipe across his bottom lip. He swallows hard and his Adam's apple bobs as he stares back at me, jealousy and desperation smother his features.

I bring my knife up to Salem's throat, the tip of my blade pressing into his soft flesh until a trickle of blood drips from the wound.

Killian's eyes darken and narrow slightly as they watch the descent of my blade all the way down to Salem's cock. I give his hard length a short, sharp nick with the tip of my blade. At the same time, I tighten my other hand around his neck.

Salem sucks in a breath, his chest heaves, and I drag my knife across his flank.

I continue the action, short, shallow gashes into his side until droplets of blood trail down his flesh and fall onto the floor of the stage.

The scent of blood fuels my arousal, and my erection strains in the confines of my slacks.

I drop the knife and it lands on the floor with a thud.

I smooth my hand over the blood that oozes from Salem's side and use it as lubrication to jerk him off, my other hand now squeezing his throat in a vice like grip.

Salem's breaths go from slow and measured to heaving. "Fuck, D, hurry up and let me come!" Salem growls, hips bucking wildly.

"Shhh... you're not supposed to talk," I remind him.

He grunts in annoyance. Groans out his pleasure.

I press my clothed body against his back and give his piercing a hard yank, stretching his cock to the point of pain.

His loud moans and groans have the crowd aroused and taking their pleasure alone, or with others in the audience. When I reach down and unclasp the cock ring, his release spills over, smothering my hand and the floor at his bare feet.

I apply pressure to his throat until, with a long, heavy sigh, his body goes limp.

Eyes fixed on Killian, I suck each finger clean and lick my lips.

Killian's mouth hangs open and his hands tighten on the arms of the sofa. But as my focus on Killian shifts from his face, I realise he's sitting on August's lap, his legs spread wide. August is pumping his hips, his thick cock buried deep inside Killian's ass.

Breaths heaving, I swipe my knife up from the floor, fisting the handle.

Killian is staring at me. Into me. The heat of his gaze sears my flesh and a rage like no other courses through my veins.

My eyes drop to the silver blade of my knife.

Kill.

Kill.

Kill.

As I raise the knife, people gasp. I ignore them. My focus is only on Killian.

With a flick of my wrist, I toss my knife.

The blade whooshes past Killian's ear. He flinches, but it misses him and embeds into the leather recliner inches from August's temple.

The bastard smirks. His hand tightens on the chain attached to Killian's collar as he commands, loud enough for me to hear, "Come for me, Killian."

Killian's eyes never leave mine, but it's as though his body is controlled by August's words, and that tips me over the edge.

I stalk over to them and stand between Killian's spread legs. I lean over his shoulder, my hands pressed over Killian's where his are now splayed on the armrests of the chair.

I keep my voice low when I address August, "Would you like to die tonight, Mr Kensington?"

Killian gasps. His body stiffens.

August doesn't falter, though. "I'd rather not, Mr King." His fingers tighten on Killian's hips for a brief moment before he glides a hand up his spine. His fingers stop at the back of the collar. With one quick flick, he releases the clasp, and the collar falls loose. August reaches around to take it, then slowly lifts the studded black leather, extending his hand to me, a wide smile on his face.

Furious, I glare at him, Salem's words in the back of my mind—"*I still need him. Just a while longer.*"—Mean nothing.

Unfazed, August says, "He's all yours." There's a hint of amusement in his tone.

I pull my knife from the recliner and point it directly at August's throat. I'm so close to shoving it into his jugular vein and slicing him open from ear to ear. The only thing stopping me is Salem's need to use him.

"Leave," I say.

He pats Killian's thigh. "Up," he says. "I'll see you at home."

I clench my jaw to rein in my anger.

Like the dutiful little submissive, Killian obeys and stands, the action brings him closer to me and I fix the collar back around his neck. I twist the chain around my fist, lifting it up until Killian is standing on his toes.

“Hello, my little hunter,” I whisper against his mouth.

He releases a breath, then licks those delectable lips.

Hushed whispers surround us, and in the relative silence of the room, muffled moans and groans of pleasure hover in the air that’s now thick with the scent of sex and arousal.

As I lead Killian backstage, he steals one last glance back at August, so I yank on the chain, forcing him to keep his attention on me.

Backstage, Salem is swallowing down a bottle of water, a black towel draped over his shoulder as he casually leans back on the plush sofa. “You’re good?” I ask.

He nods and shifts his gaze between me and Killian. “Doc’s on his way to patch me up.”

“Wait, was that you on the stage?” Killian asks Salem.

Salem smiles a wide, toothy grin. “It was. Do you have a problem with that, Killian?”

I watch Killian’s expression morph from confusion to fear, and he steps back, putting his back flush against my chest. “No. No problem.” He shakes his head. “Why would I have a problem?”

“No reason,” Salem says, smirking. “I’ll see you at home, D,” he adds, then purely to garner a reaction from Killian, Salem stands and presses his lips to mine. “Thank you,” he whispers.

His little show doesn’t disappoint.

Killian’s jaw tightens and his cheeks flame red as he averts his gaze, telling me he truly believes his plan to make me jealous, backfired.

If only he knew.

I turn to Killian, tugging on the chain to pull him closer to me. When our chests brush, he stares up at me.

“You forgot my warning, Killian.”

“No, I—I was just... I needed—”

I yank on the chain, lifting Killian up until his feet barely touch the floor. “Disobedience leads to punishment.”

“Are you going to hurt me? Like you...” He hesitates. “Like you did to Salem.” There’s so much unguarded hope in those eyes, it feels wrong to

disappoint him.

“Yes. Yes, I’m going to hurt you,” I admit.

A small smile curves the corner of his mouth, and I smile back as I turn on my heels. I pull on the chain and walk through the door to head to one of the private rooms.

* * *

KILLIAN

Diablo locks the door then strides over to a large cupboard built into the wall. He returns with a pair of silver handcuffs. Without hesitation, I extend my arms, waiting.

Instead of restraining me, he pauses for a moment, a glint of amusement in his eyes. When he drops the cuffs on the richly decorated bed, I bite the inside of my cheek and drop my hands by my sides.

Watching him with Salem was infuriating. The way he gave Salem the things I want, the things I need. The way Salem reacted to his touch tells me they were—or maybe they are, lovers. *What about Justice?* I wonder, then decide it doesn’t matter.

I want Diablo. And it seems like trying to make him jealous will, as August said, probably get him killed. Sighing, I resign myself to the fact that Diablo is in complete control, and I have no choice but to follow his lead.

Without a word, he moves until he’s standing behind me, and he begins unbuckling my harness. It falls to the floor with a soft thud. Diablo tucks his thumbs into the hem of my leather shorts and pushes them down to my ankles. I step out of them, and he throws them to the side.

Next, he plants a hand on my chest and pushes me backwards until my ass hits the end of the bed. When I’m sitting, he kneels at my feet and unties my Docs before pulling them off and setting them aside.

Even with this man—this killer, kneeling at my feet, there’s something primal and dominating about him. Something that makes every hair on the back of my neck stand on end. I want him, but at the same time, I fear him.

I fear him because he could make me do anything. When I told him I had no limits, it was the truth. I’d kill for him, and of course, I’d die for him.

When I'm naked, Diablo takes my hand and leads me to the centre of the room where he fixes the silver cuffs to my wrists, then guides me to the pole that reaches from floor to ceiling. I stand still, breathing slowly as he cuffs my wrists around the pole and behind my back.

Sweat beads across my brow and drips from my hairline. Anticipation plays havoc with my body. "Diablo?" I want him to say something. To acknowledge me, to tell me what he's going to do, or at least look at me.

He does none of that. Instead, he approaches with a ball gag and wraps it around my head, positioning the ball in my mouth. It's big, and my jaw aches immediately.

When he paces around me, I feel the heat of his gaze on my skin, and my cock twitches valiantly, a bead of precum leaking from the slit.

His breath is hot against my ear, and his hand comes up and squeezes my throat. "Are you ready to hurt, little hunter?"

I grunt, sucking in air through my nostrils as I fight to remain conscious, desperate for his eyes to meet mine before I fade away. I moan around the gag, writhing and willing him to come back around to face me, to look at me.

I need to see him.

I need him to see me.

There's a soft chuckle against my ear. "There are so many ways I can hurt you without ever laying a hand on your precious skin."

I cry out around the ball gag, forcing it forward with my tongue to try to dislodge it, but it's no use.

When Diablo is finally standing in front of me, he smirks, a sinister gleam in his eyes.

I buck my hips, seeking friction.

Diablo comes closer until his clothed chest is pressed against my bare one, and he drops his head. He bites down on my earlobe, and I groan in frustration laced pleasure.

Until his words hit me. "I'll be gone for a while. I have business to take care of. And next time you want my attention, instead of playing games, you'll beg for it."

Saliva dribbles from the corners of my mouth. I plead with my eyes, glancing at the knife that hangs in a black leather sheath by his side.

He smirks again, knowing, and when he unsheathes the knife and holds it up, twisting and turning the blade, I let my tears of frustration fall.

Diablo leans in and blazes a wet hot trail up my cheek, gathering my tears on his tongue before he does the same on the other side. "Delicious." He groans before placing the tip of his blade to the base of my cock.

I jerk forward.

The blade nicks my skin.

A trickle of blood dribbles down my balls.

I let out a relieved sigh, but the look in Diablo's eyes tells me he's furious.

When he backhands me, I realise he wasn't planning to draw blood, merely tease me. I don't have it in me to be sorry. Instead, I try to smirk around the gag, and it works.

He holds the knife to my throat, pressing it against my flesh, his other hand holds my jaw with a death grip.

"The only one who decides when you bleed, is me," he growls against my lips.

I try to grunt out my frustration, but it's nothing more than an insignificant squeak.

"Goodbye, Killian."

He flicks the light off before walking out of the room.

I cry in frustration and allow my tears to dribble down my cheeks. My erection finally wanes.

Diablo was right, he knows exactly how to torture me.

The voices in my head return with a vengeance. *You're weak, Killian. You'll never be enough for him.*

Hours later, the door to the private room I'm in, opens, and the dim light is flicked on. My muscles ache, and my fingers are numb. Saliva has dried at the corners of my mouth, and crusty, dry tears cling to my cheeks.

"Wakey, wakey, little hunter," the familiar voice says.

I raise my head, wincing when my neck cracks and my shoulders tense. "Uhngh," I grunt out a garbled sound. My jaw aches, my throat is dry, and my voice hoarse.

"Time to go," Salem says. He moves around me, releasing the cuffs and chains before he kneels in front of me. It's only then that I realise I'm

on my ass, slumped against the pole I was chained to—it's the only thing holding me up.

Salem reaches out, and I flinch.

He huffs out a laugh. "Calm down, let me get this ball gag off you, then I'll get you some water."

I obey, my eyelids so heavy I need to blink a few times to clear my vision.

Salem unclasps the ball gag and drops it on the floor. He lifts my hands, inspects my reddened wrists, and says, "I'll help you to the bathroom."

Salem watches on as I down two bottles of water, then get into the shower, scrubbing remnants of sweat, blood, and tears from my body.

"Where's Diablo?" I ask as I tug on the pair of grey sweatpants and the plain black tee Salem left on the bed for me.

"Busy," he says. Hand shoved into his pocket, Salem runs his other hand through his thick, dark hair. His fringe hangs over his forehead and brushes across his brow, even after he attempts to swipe it back. "You need to go back to work." He scratches at the stubble on his jaw, and for the first time, I notice a thick scar around his neck.

Subconsciously, I bring my hand up and trace the lines of my own scars, but when Salem clears his throat, I shift my attention back to him.

"If Gavin contacts you, tell him to call me. You won't be working for him from now on."

"What? Why?" I ask, confused. "I can't—"

Salem raises his hand, cutting me off. "You can, and you will. If I find out you've been working for him, you won't like the consequences."

Narrowing my eyes, I cross my arms over my chest, pissed the fuck off that this asshole thinks he can control me. "NO! What the fuck? You can't just tell me what to do. You're not my pimp, and you're not my fucking boss, either."

Salem's glare turns murderous. "What did you say?"

Internally, I flinch at the look in his eyes and the flat, cold tone of his voice. On the outside, I try to remain calm. I fail dismally when Salem takes two steps forward and shoves me into the wall. My back hits the solid surface with a hard thud, forcing the air from my lungs.

"Are you saying no to me, *little* hunter?" Salem's hand darts up and tightens around my throat. "Do you know what I could do to this pretty

little body? How many ways I could carve you up while keeping you alive?” He licks his lips, eyes never leaving mine. “And Diablo, you might think he’d save you—” he says, then shakes his head. “No, he’d watch *me*. Watch *me* ruin you while he strokes that thick, delicious cock.”

I wait for my perverted brain to kick in and take pleasure in the tightening of his hand, but that glare, the expression on his face, it’s unlike anything I’ve ever seen. There’s something savage lurking beneath his skin, something so dark my mind actually wanders to thoughts of mythical monsters and demonic possession.

A flicker of a memory takes me back to the night of the feast and the way Salem’s expression morphed from rage to contentment in the blink of an eye.

Salem is deadly. Perhaps even more so than Diablo.

“Okay,” I say, nodding. “Okay,” I repeat.

And there it is again.

The darkness is gone, replaced with a smile and an almost serene expression.

His hand drops away from my throat, and he steps back, nodding towards the door. “Come on, I’ll drive you home.”

XXIV

*Jagged cracks are forming
You can't take it anymore
Submission and serenity
You feel him in your core*

DIABLO

Twelve days later

Twelve days, sixteen dead bodies. Ten of them paedophiles. Not one satisfied my urges. My appetite for Killian Graves has not been sated, and perhaps it never will.

I tried to ignore the pull I felt towards Killian. To ignore the heated looks he gave me the night he snuck into the asylum. As I committed cold blooded murder right before his eyes, I tried to ignore his erection straining at his tight, leather pants, and the way his eyes pleaded with me to do the same to him.

Then, again at Snare, I tried to ignore his desperation. His dire need to please me. To give himself to me. And the way he jerked into my knife, I was so close to ending his life.

Too close.

So, I did something I've never done before.

I ran.

Twelve days ago

"Di—Diablo?" Doctor Kate McCallister's brows were scrunched in confusion. "Have I done something wrong?"

Of course, she would assume I was there to kill her, or worse, torture her. I wasn't. "I need to speak to you," I said, keeping my tone even.

She locked the front door to her office, and minutes later, I was sitting opposite her, spilling the depraved secrets of my past. I didn't need to remind her that if any part of our conversation left her office, she'd find herself buried in a shallow grave—if she was lucky.

Kate sat in stunned silence as I revealed the details of the horrific abuse my father inflicted on me. How at first, I wanted it, and even at five years old, I begged for it. I stunned her with my intense hatred for babies

and children, and how seeing them, even in passing, would stir shocking memories of my father's brutal crimes. And I told her how my memories of those moments were as vivid now as they were thirty-four long years ago.

I told her about Loren, and my ongoing obsession with my little hunter. I left nothing out, and hours later, Kate dropped her notepad on the floor beside her chair.

"This explains a lot," Kate nodded to herself, a small smile tilted her lips. "There's still some debate surrounding the effect of nature versus nurture in patients who display symptoms of antisocial personality disorder. While there are signs that point at it being hereditary, upbringing plays a huge role."

I sighed and waved a hand in her direction. "I don't care about how or why I ended up like this. I want to know how to regulate my emotions again. I haven't had an issue with this since Loren died."

Kate shook her head, rested her elbows on her knees, and leaned forward. "Do you really need me to tell you? Or are you simply here to have me confirm what you already know?"

I remained silent for a long, drawn-out minute, tapping my fingers on my thigh as I watched her watch me. I was not, under any circumstances, going to admit the truth.

"So, Killian, huh? In a way, I'm not surprised." She smirked, but it disappeared quickly when I scowled at her, my hands clenched into fists. "Love makes you do, and feel, crazy things."

I scoffed. "I do not love Killian. I cannot love. He is merely a plaything."

She tilted her head, eyes scrutinising me. "You loved Loren. That's clear in the way you speak about her. And Salem, I've watched you with him. There's something more than just 'like' there."

"That was different. Loren was my moth—like a mother to me. It's normal to love your mother, even for someone like me. And Salem, he's been with me since we were children. He understands me, and I him. That's not love." I averted my gaze, ignoring the sensation of warmth that curled in my gut when I thought about Salem and the bond we shared. No, it's not love. It's loyalty and familiarity—he is family. "He's my brother, maybe not by blood, but in every other way," I stated.

"Okay," Kate said as she leaned back in her chair and crossed her legs. "What do you feel for Killian?"

“Annoyance.”

Kate let out a loud burst of laughter.

I narrowed my eyes, confused.

She cleared her throat, and asked, “Anything else?”

I sighed, then admitted, “I want him. I want to keep him. But I refuse to give him what he desires. The thought of not having him, it enrages me.”

“Then what’s the problem?”

“He makes me lose control. He has the ability to force my hand. If I kill him—” I paced the small office, my hands shoved into my pockets as I stared out of the floor to ceiling window that looked out over the city.

“If I kill him, there’s nothing left of Loren.” I turned, and Kate’s eyes grew wide.

She shook her head slightly and extended her hand towards the sofa, urging me to sit. “I’m just going to come right out and say this, okay?”

When I waved a hand in her direction, she continued, “It’s obvious you never got over Loren’s death. She was the first person to truly see you, to understand you, to protect you. She was the mother figure you never had. Now, you see Killian as an extension of her, of her love. As long as he needs you, as long as he wants you, you don’t have to let Loren go. I think most of what you’re feeling, Diablo, is fear of the unknown.”

I scoffed at that. “No. I have no fear of anything.”

She raised a brow. “Yet here you are, spilling your secrets, searching for answers, and trying to figure out why Killian Graves has you all tied up in knots.”

I stood once more, turned my back on Kate and walked towards the door. When I reached for the handle, Kate’s voice stopped me in my tracks. “Fear doesn’t make you weak, Diablo. Neither does love.”

Hand tight on the doorknob, I looked over my shoulder at her. “What does it make me then?”

“Human, that’s all. It makes you human.”

** * **

Now

“Clean up after yourself,” Annabelle says. “And don’t get blood all over my new sofa, or you’ll be buying me a new one.”

My lip quirks with the beginning hint of a smile so I clench my jaw, refusing to show any emotion in front of the old woman. Her wide smile and the light in her eyes tells me she already saw it.

Growling, I snatch the keys to the café's front door from her outstretched hand and shove them into the inside pocket of my coat. "Off you go then," I say, waving her away.

My hand hovers over the door handle that leads to Annabelle's office. Rage, desire, and agitation coils in the pit of my gut. I loathe losing control of myself, and the fact that Killian constantly causes these feelings to arise, enrages me.

For a moment, I stand at the door, eyes closed as I focus on each breath. *It's time.*

I turn the handle and slowly push the door open to find Killian sitting on the edge of a pristine, white sofa. I huff a breath through my nose. There's no way that sofa is coming out of this unstained.

"Diablo?" his voice forces my attention to shift to him.

After locking the office door behind me, I clear off Annabelle's desk with a sweep of my hand and order Killian to strip. When I have him bent over the desk, I part his cheeks and take in the sight of his tight hole.

"Please, Diablo, please fuck me." Sobs wrack his body as he begs. "I'm sorry, sorry I didn't listen, I'll do anything—"

"Not a sound." The sadist in me is overjoyed. "One utterance and I stop."

He nods quickly and slaps a hand over his mouth.

"No. Put your hands behind your back, you let go, and I stop. Make a sound, and I stop," I warn.

He nods again and grips onto his own wrists, arms and shoulders pulled back.

I grip those tattooed shoulders and pull him to a standing position before I coil my arm around his waist. When my fingers curl around the length of his cock, Killian bucks into my hand. I allow him a few, short thrusts into my fist before I glide my other hand across his abdomen, up his chest, and further up to his throat where I squeeze.

"My heart," I growl against his ear. "You stole what was left of my heart." I tighten my grip around his throat. "Now..." I stroke his hard cock, gathering the precum and smoothing it over his length. "Now, I have to spend the rest of my life watching it be carried around in your body."

Killian bucks violently against my hold, and swallows beneath my palm.

I continue stroking him, breathing against his ear, and biting down on the soft flesh between his neck and shoulder. Every purple tinged bruise and the teeth marks I leave behind, act as beacons. Visible proof of ownership. Soon, everyone in Newhaven will know that Killian is mine.

His heavy, frantic breaths cause his chest to rise and fall rapidly.

“You’re going to come for me, Killian.” Another long, slow stroke. I graze my thumb across his crown. “Then—” I glide my tongue down his neck, suck the pale flesh into my mouth. “I’m going to use your come as lube...” Another lick, another suck. I breathe against his ear. “And fuck you with it.”

I release his neck and shove my two middle fingers into his open mouth. Killian sucks greedily, pulling my fingers deeper into his throat as I stroke him.

“Say my name,” I growl against his ear as I slip my fingers free from his mouth.

“Di—” he hesitates, obviously recalling my warning to not make a sound, and I tighten my already punishing grip on his cock.

“Say it!” I demand.

“Diablo!” he shouts. “Diablo!”

I jerk him off, fast and hard, and when he starts throbbing, I bite into his shoulder and suck with vigour until Killian’s release spills over my hand. Gathering up his release, I shove him down onto the desk again and swipe his come down his ass, smoothing it over and into his hole. Without warning, I shove two fingers deep inside him.

“Ahhhh, fuck!” he cries out.

When I drag my fingers from the tight hold of his ass, he breathes heavily.

“Stay there,” I warn, and I step back, severing all contact.

Killian’s head turns, his eyes follow my hand, brows creasing in confusion when I reach into the inside pocket of my coat, pull out a cut resistant glove, and slide it on.

I reach behind my back to pull my knife from its sheath. A smirk flits across my lips when Killian’s eyes grow wide.

He gasps, and his body stiffens. Tiny goosebumps appear all over his tattooed flesh.

I twirl my knife in my hand, my fist tight around the blade.

I pull Killian to his feet and spin him around to face me, raising the knife between us. He opens his mouth, then closes it quickly and bites his pierced bottom lip.

“This knife,” I say, “It was given to me on my thirteenth birthday.”

Killian’s stare doesn’t falter, his eyes fixed on the carved, bone handle of my knife.

I reach around behind him and drag the handle down the crease of his ass. With my free hand, I separate his cheeks and feel his tight, already wet hole. He bucks forward, then back, squeezes his eyes shut.

“Open your eyes, I want to see your expression when—” Without warning, I push the six-inch handle of the knife into his ass in one, slow thrust.

“I, ohhh fuuuck—arghhhh—” His eyes widen in shock, and his words are cut off when he lets out a loud, painful gasp, rising on his toes as I impale him on the ornately carved handle of my knife. Pupils dilated, his eyes never leave mine as I drag the handle halfway out.

Tears form in the corners of his eyes. “Uh, ahhh...” He tries to speak. Nothing but moans and groans and garbled pleas of “more,” and “fuck,” and “please,” leave those perfect lips.

I force the handle of my blade inside him again. “This knife...” I pump it in and out, slow and deep. “Is what I used to kill your parents.” Another thrust. “Your brother.” I drag the knife out and press the end of the handle to his lips.

When he opens his mouth, I dip the handle in and he closes his lips around it, obscenely sucking while saliva dribbles down his chin.

I lean in, swipe my tongue across the corner of his mouth, trail it across his cheek, and down to his neck where I lap at the sheen of sweat that coats his skin.

Breathing heavily, Killian whimpers when I pull the knife away.

I spin him around again, push him down onto the desk, and slowly force the saliva coated handle back into his tight hole.

“Fuuuuck!” he cries out. “Fuck, give me more!”

This time, I give it a twist, and Killian keens against the desk. “When I’m with you...” I drag the knife out and swipe my tongue along the length of the handle. The taste of him lingers like an aphrodisiac. “When I touch you...” I spin the knife in my hand and fist the handle, dragging the

tip of the blade down Killian's spine. "I want to kill you." A thin, red line appears, specks of blood bead at the surface of the shallow, superficial wound. "I want to gut you." I trail the blade over his hole, all the way down to his balls.

His back arches on a cry, and he shifts on the desk, pushing his ass out, silently begging for more.

I lean over him, nip at his ear, follow it with a lick. "But all I can do—" I trace the curve of his hip with my blade. "All I ever fucking do is devour you."

Fist tight around my knife, I plunge it into the desk where it embeds deep into the polished wood, then I pull off the cut resistant glove and drop it on the floor.

I grip his hips and guide my leaking cock into his ass. Another needy whimper leaves his mouth, and although I told him to remain silent, I crave his desperate cries. "Can you feel me deep inside you?"

"Yes! Yes!" he shouts. "Moremoremore!"

"I'm imagining it's my knife," I whisper against the shell of his ear. "That every thrust is slicing you open. Carving you up from the inside. Your ruined body mutilated and bleeding. All. Over. My. Cock."

"Ahhh, Diablo! Fuckmekillmepleease—" his garbled words are cut off when his mouth opens, and a hoarse scream leaves his lungs.

Sliding one hand under his neck, I grip his throat and bring him up again, his back flush to my chest. I step back and sit in the leather chair, pulling Killian down with me.

The position impales him on my cock, and I groan at the sheer, exhilarating pleasure.

Tightening my grasp around his throat, I whisper against his ear, "I'm going to fuck you until you pass out. Do you want that, my heart? Do you want to be impaled on my cock when you take your last, dying breath?"

"Yesyesyes, fuckyessss!" He nods frantically, arms still behind his back, his fingers curl and uncurl against my abdomen, his body shuddering with pleasure. He clenches his ass around my cock.

I growl against his ear, then bite into the soft flesh of his neck, and suck. I thrust my hips, pegging his prostate. "You're mine." I wrap an arm around him, taking his perfect cock in my hand. "My little hunter." I tighten my grip around his throat, finding that perfect spot to starve him of the oxygen he so desperately needs to survive. "My heart."

Survive.

There is no way I can kill Killian Graves.

He is the air I breathe.

The blood I crave.

The heaven I will never see.

As Killian's release smothers his abdomen and my hand, his body goes lax.

I release my grip on his throat, smoothing my hand over his chest, memorising every inch of his body beneath my fingertips before I grip his hips, forcing him onto me as I pump my cock into his limp body. When my release finally fills him, I remain seated, Killian's body heavy against my own.

While he's unconscious, I take a moment to run my fingers through his thick, dark curls, to trace the seam of his lips, and to inhale his scent. Something that feels like peace and serenity settles in my chest.

"Mine," I whisper against Killian's cheek.

When my cock softens, I stand and lay Killian over the desk before I ease the plug I bought earlier, into his ass. I carry him over to the sofa to clean up his release before I double check the door is locked, and head into the small, attached bathroom to take a shower.

* * *

KILLIAN

The first thing I notice when I come to, is the fullness in my ass. I clench, then stretch my legs. When I reach down, I feel the end of a plug, and I smile.

Rolling onto my opposite side, I open my eyes to see Salem sitting behind the desk—my boss, Annabelle's desk—arms crossed, and feet propped up on the desktop as he glares at me.

"Where's Diablo?" I ask.

Still glaring, Salem says, "You're dangerous to him. If you hurt him, I'll gut you."

A frisson of fear causes me to shudder. "Me? Why?" I'm so confused. "I'm not going to hurt him."

Salem lets out a burst of laughter that doesn't match the blank expression in his eyes. "He'll kill for you. He's killing because of you, he's

being careless.”

“Because of me?” I ask.

Salem nods. “Twelve days. He was gone twelve days. Do you know what he did in those twelve days?”

I shake my head, then reality hits me. “He killed someone?” Disappointment laces my tone because I missed out on seeing it.

Salem huffs and shakes his head. “You have no fucking idea,” he says. “Get dressed, we have a meeting to get to.”

“We? And what meeting?”

He rolls his eyes, nods to my pile of clothes folded neatly on the chair, and repeats, “Get dressed. Don’t make me tell you again. I may not be allowed to kill you, but I can sure as hell make you fucking hurt.”

I swallow down the lump in my throat and obey.

The drive to the mansion is silent until we reach the long, winding, tree lined driveway. Salem pulls up at the porte cochère I arrived at for the ball, and says, “Our colleagues are here. You don’t need to interact with them, but don’t piss them off.”

I nod in acknowledgement and follow Salem into the mansion and along a wide hall that leads to an office with huge, carved double doors.

In the office, a dark timber table sits in the centre of the room. Diablo sits at one end, and he gestures for me to go to him. I’m shocked when he pulls me down onto his lap and inhales against my neck.

When my eyes meet Stefani’s, she raises a brow, smirks, then turns her attention to the folder on the table.

At the other end of the table, an older man in a black suit and tie glares at me through wire rim glasses. On his left, August sits, shock clear in his expression when our eyes meet. Beside August, a huge man with a bald head and a permanent scowl looks right through me as though I don’t exist at all.

Opposite Stefani, Salem sits beside a guy who appears to be in his mid-thirties. He reminds me of a biker with his full, black beard, close cropped hair, and the leather jacket he wears over a black t-shirt. Arms crossed over his chest, he blatantly looks me up and down before giving me a wink.

“Liam,” Diablo says in a low, warning tone. “Don’t make me end you.”

The biker, Liam, chuckles and shakes his head as I take each of these men in and wonder, not for the first time, if psychopaths—murderers—all share the same features.

Every man in this room has the same chiselled jawline and straight nose set between cold, deep brown eyes. Even Stefani shares those same dark, soulless eyes, high cheekbones, and thick, black hair.

“What’s this about, Diablo?” Glasses dude asks, a snarl forming on his thin lips.

Diablo clears his throat, and his hand squeezes my thigh before he slowly unbuttons my jeans then lowers the zipper. Anticipation causes beads of sweat to form on my brow. With the plug still in, my ass is full, and my needy cock is desperate for anything Diablo wants to give me.

“We’re bringing Killian on as a fully-fledged member. He’ll be inducted shortly after he’s completed the required three months of training,” Diablo says. “In the meantime, he’ll shadow me and attend every meeting held here.”

August gasps, opens his mouth to speak, but is cut off when Diablo introduces me. At the same time, he pulls my cock from the confines of my jeans and strokes me with slow, deliberate movements.

“Killian, this is Devin, also known as The Cleaner,” he says, pointing to Glasses Dude. “Beside Kensington, is Bruce, The Butcher.” I shake my head slightly, not used to hearing August addressed by his last name. “And beside Salem...” He sighs heavily. “Is Liam. And you already know Stefani.”

I nod and at the same time, Diablo squeezes my cock, causing me to wince.

“Hi—hello,” is all I can manage.

“So first up, the next Free Hunt is in two weeks. Once again, the ballot is full,” Stefani says, her attention on me. “You’ll need a full tour of the asylum, the mansion, and Snare. It’s important you know the layout of our spaces, and the tasks you’ll be responsible for.”

“Tasks?” I ask, proud of myself for my voice not shaking while Diablo relentlessly jerks my cock under the table. If anyone knows what he’s doing, they don’t mention it.

“Everyone pulls their weight,” she states. “You’ll continue working at Belle’s. Any contact with Gavin will cease immediately.”

Nodding, I squirm on Diablo's lap as his hand tightens around my cock. "O—okay," I say quickly. "Okay."

Devin glares at me. "No! I object. He's a fucking kid. He has no business being here. This is ridiculous, and what of The House rules? You cannot induct someone who hasn't made it through their second hunt."

Stefani raises her hand, wiggling her fingers to get his attention. "I'll ignore the *kid* comment since he's twenty-five, and you are well aware that excluding myself, everyone in this room was inducted into The House *as a child*. Now, Killian's second hunt has been scheduled. He will be sent into the arena along with the rest of the prey." She turns her wide, clearly fake smile on Devin. "Is there anything else you'd like to whine about, Devin?"

Devin's jaw clenches and he crosses his arms over his chest. "How do we know he won't receive preferential treatment?" He waves a hand toward me. "It's clear Diablo favours him."

Stefani lets out a loud burst of laughter, then smothers her mouth with her hand. Liam shakes his head, sighing.

Diablo's tone is cold, "The only person who receives preferential treatment, is Salem. That will not change."

I lock that bit of information away, hoping I'll be able to ask about it at a later date. There's definitely a strong bond between Salem and Diablo, and while it appears to be brotherly from the outside, the way they speak to, and about one another, still has me wondering if their connection runs deeper than that.

"Bullshit!" Devin shouts, pulling me from my reverie. "You have that kid warming your cock and you expect me to believe you're not going to keep him?"

With Diablo's fist around my cock, and Salem sitting beside me, bravery, and a little stupidity comes out, and I forget everything Salem said.

"I'm not a fucking kid," I say, glaring back at the cleaner. "What the fuck is your problem?"

"Oooh, feisty," Stefani mutters under her breath.

Someone else clears their throat.

Devin narrows his eyes and clenches his fists on the table. His murderous expression tells me my outburst may have been a deadly mistake.

Diablo squeezes my cock hard. The grip is punishing, but I smirk, eyes still fixed on the cleaner before I turn my head to Diablo, and say,

“Harder.”

When a hint of a smirk lifts the corner of his lips, I want to drop to my knees and worship his cock, but Diablo has other ideas. He clenches his fist so hard around my cock that white spots appear in my vision, and my body jerks violently.

Devin—the cleaner, slams a hand down on the table. “DIABLO! Whatever the fuck you’re doing with this kid needs to end. Get rid of him, or I’m out. I demand to see Chadwick, now!”

All eyes are on Salem as he stands and slowly walks to the end of the table. He places a hand on Devin’s shoulder. “All this time, and you still can’t hide your jealousy.” Salem clicks his tongue. “You should know better, Devin, he didn’t want you twenty years ago, and he doesn’t want you now.”

So the truth comes out. I hide my smirk by biting down on my tongue.

August moves his chair back from the table, and the butcher follows suit.

When Salem’s hand shoots out to grab a fistful of Devin’s hair, Diablo whispers against my ear, “Bend over the table.”

Cheeks flaming, I keep my eyes on the cleaner as I bend over, splaying myself on the cold, hard wood. The scent of furniture polish fills my nose a second before the plug leaves my ass with a wet pop.

Diablo slides his cock into me with one violent thrust that has the table shifting on its heavy, wooden legs. “You want to take his place, Devin? You want to be the one riding my cock? Want me to pound you into the table? Do you think you could take it?”

Another harsh thrust.

My eyes flit to August whose jaw tightens before he averts his gaze. Salem presses his knife to the cleaner’s throat. “Answer him,” he growls.

Another thrust.

I can’t stop the moan that spills from my lips.

“No, nonono.” Devin shakes his head, hands raised in defence.

One of Diablo’s hands leaves my hip, and I watch in awe as his knife flies through the air, skims past Devin’s head, and embeds into the wall.

Blood dribbles from Devin’s ear down to his crisp, black suit.

Salem raises a brow and smiles in Diablo's direction.

Diablo pounds my prostate as his release fills me. He quickly shoves the plug back in then pulls me down onto his lap to begin torturing my achingly hard cock all over again.

"Do not come," he warns, breath hot against the shell of my ear.

I nod, and Diablo shifts his attention to Devin. "You're done. Your access to The House has been revoked. Get out, and do not leave Newhaven."

Devin stands, his face bright red. As he reaches behind his back, all eyes are on him. Panic courses through my veins as I imagine him pulling out a gun and killing everyone in this room.

My panic is completely unwarranted.

There's no gun.

Instead, Devin pulls out a knife, the handle tight in his fist as he raises his hand.

"Do it," Diablo taunts. "Let's see how good your aim is, old man. There's a reason you're only the cleaner. You are easily replaceable."

Tension hovers in the air. Liam shifts in his seat, leaning forward slightly.

August's hand reaches down to his side, his eyes firmly locked onto Devin. The butcher watches on, hands clasped on his lap, and a sinister gleam in his dark eyes.

Stefani crosses her arms, a huge smile on her bright red lips as her head ping pongs between Diablo and Devin.

Devin raises his hand a little higher. "Chadwick was right, you know."

Diablo's fingers tighten against my hip as Devin continues, "You'll never be like him. You're weak, Diablo, and that..." He turns his hateful glare on me, waving his knife in my direction. "That will be your downfall."

Three things happen simultaneously.

Devin flicks his wrist and throws his knife directly at me. I don't get time to flinch.

Liam leaps forward, hand outstretched over the table, he grabs the knife mid-air. Somehow, he catches it by the fucking handle like he's a goddamn magician.

Salem pulls Devin's head back, dragging his knife across Devin's bared throat. Blood pours from the gaping wound.

"Good catch," Bruce, the butcher, says to Liam. "Glad to see you haven't lost your touch."

Liam twirls the knife in his hand before stabbing it into the table. "Kensington, go grab a body bag," he says.

Stefani begins a slow clap. "Good job, buddy, did you learn that on your holiday in the U.S.?"

"Do you ever shut the fuck up, you crazy fuckin' bitch?" Liam glares at her.

Stefani glares right back. The two of them are locked in some kind of stare-off until Liam looks away first, and Stefani smirks.

Diablo fists a handful of my hair, pulling my attention back to him. He tugs my head back to whisper against my ear, "My heart," before he turns my head, and his mouth smothers mine in a hard, wet kiss.

XXV

*I'd like to cut you open
Watch your red blood spill
To consume would be an honour
To taste, devour... kill*

KILLIAN

One hour later

I hang, suspended from the ceiling like the skeletons I saw in the macabre room in the asylum. The thought of Diablo leaving me hanging here until my death, terrifies me. I want hands on torture, not to be left alone to rot in the middle of an empty room in the basement of Diablo's mansion.

When he finally returns, he circles me, a hunter circling his prey.

It's all I've ever been to him. All I want to be.

The thought doesn't concern me anymore, instead, it settles comfortably in my gut. Diablo walks to the far side of the room where a wooden desk sits in the corner. With his back to me, he hums quietly along with the classical music playing from the overhead speakers.

Against the wall, a tall cupboard is pulled open. Inside, an array of tools catches my attention. Hacksaws, drills, hammers, and what appear to be clawed animal traps hang from the inside of the cupboard doors. A bolt of fear courses down my spine and my stomach clenches in knots. Is he finally going to kill me? The question has been playing over in my mind since Diablo tied me up in the basement of the mansion right after the meeting.

When he approaches empty handed, my fear is replaced with confusion.

"What should I do with you?" he asks as he trails his fingers across my torso. When he brushes those long, slender fingers down to my groin, I buck my hips.

"Touch me," I beg. "Hurt me."

His lip quirks slightly. "Oh, I'm going to hurt you, Killian. And this time, you're going to scream for me." He's behind me now, hot breath tickles my shoulder, and warm fingers trace my spine. His footsteps pace, but I can't see him.

From behind me, I hear a drawer being pulled open, then pushed closed, before a low buzzing sound hits my ears.

Diablo comes to stand in front of me. In his hand, some kind of electric razor. He holds up the handheld device. “Do you know what this is?”

I shake my head as much as I can. My arms ache from being held above my head, and with my toes barely touching the floor, my muscles are stretched and tense.

He tilts his head, a sinister smile quirks one corner of his mouth. “It’s quite similar to what medical professionals call an electric dermatome. It’s predominantly used for skin grafts.” He switches it off and presses it to my thigh. “With this, I can carve slices of flesh from your body while you’re still alive...” He trails off, eyes never leaving mine.

When he pulls the razor away, beads of sweat form on my brow, and as they drip into my eyes, I blink them away. “The people you—we ate at the feast. They were alive?”

Diablo huffs through his nose. “No. Actually, I’ve never tried this on a living person.” He smiles, eyes perusing the length of my naked body. “You’ll be my first.”

I swallow hard, every feeling I’ve had about being tortured reminds me that I want this. The thought of Diablo shaving off slivers of my flesh is both horrific, and exhilarating.

“You’ll—you’ll,” my voice is barely a whisper, “you’ll eat me while I’m alive?”

“Yes.” He paces in front of me, the device tight in his hand. “People are disgusted by cannibalism. They fear it, abhor it. Yet they partake regularly.” With his free hand, he wraps his fingers around my cock and gives it a long, slow stroke from base to tip. “The simple act of sucking your cock...” He licks his lips, eyes fixed on mine. “Of swallowing your release... inhaling your breaths.” He leans in and swipes his velvet soft tongue across my lips. I chase his tongue with my own, desperation clawing at me.

Diablo steps back. “Biting you, licking the blood from your wounds. They are all simply different, less intense forms of cannibalism.”

He steps back and clicks the device on. It begins its low hum as Diablo continues, “Humans are born to consume. They hunger, crave, lust over the object of their desire.” He glides his soft, wet tongue across my

chest, stopping to tug at my nipple with his teeth. I writhe and buck and beg for more.

When he bites down hard on my other nipple, I cry out.

He steps back. The buzz of the device starts up as Diablo says, “Imagine the eternal torture. Wanting to taste the very essence of a lover, yet never succumbing to those primal desires.”

When the dermatome touches my flesh, there’s a moment of sheer, exhilarating pleasure, knowing what this means, and what he craves.

Then...

Pain.

Excruciating, overwhelming.

Agonising pain.

A scream escapes from deep, deep down in my chest, unlike any sound I’ve ever made.

“That’s it, my perfect little hunter, scream for me,” he says against the shell of my ear.

I’m panting, writhing, screaming. My head spins, and my heart races so fast I feel like I’m about to pass out.

I can’t stop crying.

“Your tears, my heart, and your screams—” Diablo closes his eyes and groans, rubbing at the outline of his erection. When he opens his eyes, unbridled lust is all I see through a sheen of my own, relentless tears. “I could come to the sound of your screams alone.”

“Pleasepleaseplease. Stopfuckplease, more, no, ahhhh, fuck!” I don’t even know what I’m saying as my muddled words are choked out through broken sobs.

The humming stops.

Diablo steps back. “You are glorious,” he says.

For a second, a split, breathtaking second, there’s no pain. Nothing but numbness.

Then, the cold air hits the wound. I inhale and hold my breath, my throat too raw for another bout of screaming.

Sobbing and choking on each breath, I blink away the tears that have spilled from my eyes, trailed down my cheeks, and dribbled from my jaw.

Diablo steps into my space and lifts his hand. In it, a thin, almost transparent sliver of my flesh, shaved straight from my thigh.

Mouth open, he drags the flesh across his lips, crudely curling his tongue around it before he uses two fingers to push the sliver into his mouth. He licks his lips, steps even closer, and cups my cheek. A bloody thumb swipes across my bottom lip as he swallows.

“You taste like heaven,” he says with reverence.

When he leans in and kisses the side of my mouth, a hoarse cry escapes my lips.

“Stay right there, my heart. I’ll need to dress that wound. I don’t want you getting an infection.” He turns his back to me and walks away.

My chest heaves. Sweat breaks out across my body as I hyperventilate. Shaking my head, I writhe. Sudden, unexplained anxiety consumes me. As my heart races out of control, I suck in deep, panicked breaths, and finally, I scream again.

“Please, pleasepleaseplease don’t leave me. Don’t leave me alone.” I whimper like a frightened dog, beg again, scream some more. “Please, Diablo, please don’t go.”

A hand comes up and strong fingers wrap around my throat, squeezing hard enough to settle my racing heart. “Calm down,” Diablo says coolly. “I don’t want you going into shock.”

Breathing hard, I shake my head. “Don’t, don’t go, please don’t go. I—I lo—want, need you.” Salted tears continue to fall, my weakness on full display in front of this man who exudes nothing but strength and power.

When Diablo loosens his grip around my throat, my breath catches on an inhale. I close my eyes, and a second later, feel his lips against my own.

His kiss is soft and gentle. His tongue, pliable as it brushes over mine. Mouths wet, breaths frantic, we kiss the way I imagine lovers do. With quiet desperation and unhidden lust. His hands smooth down my chest until he grips my hips, his fingers digging into my flesh. “Perfection,” he whispers.

My thigh burns with excruciating pain when it rubs against his pants, and he shifts to separate our lower halves. But his tongue, his lips, that wicked mouth, it never leaves mine. He steals every breath I exhale, sucks each one down like I’m the oxygen he needs to survive.

A heady rush of radiant heat smothers me, but he pulls away too soon, and I’m left panting, mouth agape, saliva dribbling from the corner of my lips.

He cups my cheek again, and with his eyes still on mine, he says,
“Stay, my heart.”

* * *

DIABLO

12 hours later

“How long until he wakes?” I ask Doc.

He looks up from where he’s repacking his medical bags, his grey hair a mess of wispy strands, and his thick, black glasses balanced on the tip of his nose. “Around twenty minutes. I’d like to take another look at the wound in forty-eight hours. In the meantime, keep his fluids up, and ensure the wound site remains clean.”

Nodding, I extend my hand to shake Doc’s. “Thank you,” I say before he gathers his bags and heads out.

I sit on the bed, legs crossed at my ankles while I watch Killian sleep. The decision to keep him is weighing on me. After my discussion with Kate, I realised that yes, Killian is my final link to Loren, and perhaps that is the only reason I’m unable to kill the beauty spread out and softly snoring in my bed.

Seeing Killian chained and at my mercy, stirs a primal urge beneath my skin. Each time I see him, I crave him more. I need to rein in those cravings, for now.

With a sigh of frustration, I get to my feet and head down the hall. My hand hovers over the doorknob, fingers twitching. When I shove the door open, I stand and stare at the bed. Memories of the past come in flashes.

Screaming babies.

Pooling blood.

Cries of help.

As I step over the threshold and into the bedroom, I inhale, holding my breath as I approach the bed. When I look down at Loren’s skeleton, I close my eyes and picture her face. Her pale skin, her bright, blue-green eyes, and her long, flowing blonde hair.

I take another step forward.

Sit on the side of the bed. Lay beside her.

Hand cupping her cheek, I press my forehead to hers.
But it's not her.
She's gone.
Dead.

Twenty-seven years ago

"NO!"

The high-pitched scream had me running to Loren's bedroom.

"Darius, stop, I'm okay." Loren reached out from where she laid on her bed, her legs spread wide. The white towel beneath her was dotted with spots of blood. Her face red and wet with tears.

The doctor stood at the end of the bed, a blue-tinged baby in his arms. He was frantically trying to remove the umbilical cord from where it was looped around the baby's neck.

Even at twelve years old, I knew something was wrong. I knew that babies were not supposed to be blue. But I didn't care. I didn't want to see it. Didn't want it in my house, or near my family.

When I turned to Loren, she was staring at the baby, looking at it with something akin to hope in her eyes. "Please," she begged the doctor, "Save her."

"NO!" I shouted. "You can't have a baby. You have to kill it!"

"Darius," Loren gentled her voice, "You need to wait outside, darling."

I shook my head.

I couldn't wait outside.

The baby had to die.

Before...

Before someone broke it.

Hurt it.

Made it bleed.

Forced it to—

"No, no, no." I shook my head hard, slapping my hand against my temple. I had to stop the visions of blood and pain from pulling me back to my father's basement where babies and children were mutilated, tortured, broken, dead. "He'll come back! He'll break it, Loren! Kill it, kill it before he finds it."

“No,” she said. “He’s gone, sweetheart. He can’t hurt you anymore. He can’t hurt anyone now.” She pushed herself up on the bed, arms outstretched. “Darius, my little devil,” she whispered. “Come here.”

“NO!!” I screamed.

I lunged at the doctor.

Snatched the newborn from his arms.

Shook it violently.

A sharp, stabbing pain pierced my side.

There was a thud.

A scream.

Then...

Silence.

The doctor stabbed me with his scalpel in an effort to get me to release my hold on the baby. Loren’s baby. Her daughter.

Chadwick arrived home ten minutes later and beat me to a bloody pulp, leaving me with permanent scars, and a minor traumatic brain injury that only intensified my barely controlled, violent tendencies.

I woke five days later with Salem and Liam by my side. Their loyalty never faltered, and when they were beaten, too, they still returned, bruised, bloody, and broken, to keep a constant vigil at my bedside.

It was during one of those dark nights that the three of us, at just twelve years old, vowed to protect one another. Boyish hopes and dreams led us to make a blood pact we believed would bind us together forever.

After that, I did everything I could to hide my emotions from Chadwick. I never let him see the hatred in my eyes, or the fear that arose if he ventured too close. I excelled in music and dance, followed his orders to the letter, and ensured that every step I took, every word I uttered, met his expectations.

Although the beatings and torture lessened as I grew older, they never stopped. And none were ever as brutal as the first one. I didn’t let Chadwick know that the beatings he gave me only fuelled my hatred for him, or that when he sent me out to the arena to kill, every victim wore his face, and died with his name on my lips.

By the time I was fifteen, I was an expert in reading people, especially Chadwick, and it worked in my favour. I was unstoppable.

And finally, Chadwick saw me as another version of himself.

*An heir to his throne.
A loyal, submissive “son.”
Someone who would carry on his legacy long after he was gone.
I was well on my way to becoming the next leader of The House of
Machiavellianism.
And I let him believe he’d won.*

“Diablo?” Killian’s distant voice draws my attention back to the present and away from memories of the past.

I press a kiss to the top of Loren’s skull and gently place it back on the pillow. When I stand, I look down at her bones with reverence. “I saved one of them for you,” I say, before I turn on my heels and head out of the bedroom.

Back in my bedroom, Killian is sitting in bed, propped up with two plush pillows behind his back.

“How is your leg?” I ask as I approach the bed to pull back the covers and ensure the wound isn’t bleeding or weeping.

He nods, then rubs his eyes. “Not too bad. I feel like I’ve slept for weeks.” Narrowing his eyes, he looks me up and down. His blatant perusal of my naked torso and loose grey sweats, has my cock stirring. I adjust myself, smirking when his eyes follow my hand.

Sitting on the bed beside him, I say, “Your clothing and personal belongings are being delivered here today. You’ll be living here for the foreseeable future.”

Mouth agape, Killian sputters, before asking, “Living here, with you?”

“Yes, Killian. Here, with me.”

“But I... but—”

I cut him off, clenching my hand into the sheet to stop myself reaching out and wrapping it around his throat. Instead, I glance at the gauze that covers his thigh.

“Once that’s healed, you’ll be going back to work at Belle’s.” When he doesn’t protest, I continue, “When you’re not working, you’ll be here, training for the next hunt.”

“Hunt?” he asks, eyes wide. “I have to hunt someone?”

Shaking my head, I pat his knee. “No, Killian, you’ll be prey. You had August add you to the ballot, remember?”

He swallows, and his Adam's apple bobs. Fists tight in the sheet beside his thighs, he stares up at me. "You—you're going to hunt me?" Fear flickers in his eyes, but it's quickly replaced with heat. His chest heaves on an inhale.

I drop my gaze to see a bead of precum leaking from his crown. I smile in satisfaction, raising my head to find Killian still staring, those perfect lips parted and silently begging to be wrapped around my cock. "Yes, I'm going to hunt you."

"Will you ki—kill me?" he asks, those big, blue-green eyes full of hope.

I stand and avert my gaze. "The rules have been in place for decades. I have no intention of changing them, not even for you. Now, lie down on the bed, face up, and drop your head over the side."

Scrambling to obey, Killian winces when he stretches his leg too far and pulls on the healing wound.

"Carefully," I say. "I want you completely healed before the hunt."

Nodding, he shifts until he's positioned across the bed, his head hanging off the side as he looks up at me.

Eyes on him, I shove my grey sweatpants down, freeing my already hard cock.

Killian licks his lips, swiping his tongue across his piercing.

I gently slap his cheek. "Open." I guide my cock into his waiting mouth.

Killian groans around my crown, his tongue flicks over and around my piercing, causing sparks of pleasure to ignite deep in my gut. "I'm going to pierce your cock," I decide aloud. "Would you like that, my heart?"

He moans, nodding as much as he can with my cock filling his mouth.

His hand creeps up to reach for his leaking shaft, I lean over, forcing my length deeper into his throat as I bat his hand away.

He chokes and gags. Saliva dribbles from the corners of his mouth as I pump my hips in a slow, steady pace. Curling my fingers into Killian's hair, I force my cock deeper into his mouth until he's gagging and groaning intermittently.

From this angle, with his head hanging off the bed, I watch as my cock slips into his throat and cuts off his oxygen.

I count the seconds in my head, and when I reach eight, I pull back, leaving the pierced tip to rest on his lips as I take in the crimson stain of his flushed cheeks.

After a few long, deep breaths, his tongue darts out and curls around my piercing again. “More,” he begs. Tears leak from the corners of his eyes.

Killian reaches around behind me, digs his fingers into my ass and pulls me closer, forcing my cock further into his mouth. I pump my hips, slow at first until the wet, slapping sounds of my cock gliding into and out of the wet heat of Killian’s mouth has me thrusting wildly, forcing him to take more with every jerk of my hips.

The sight of his long, hard length leaking precum, and bouncing against his tattooed abs, spurs me on. “Are you going to come for me, little hunter?”

There’s a long, loud whine from his throat, and when he moves his hand to reach down and jerk himself, I take his hand and lace our fingers together, never stopping my relentless thrusts deep into his throat.

Killian’s fingers tighten where they’re laced through mine. He bucks his hips, seeking friction that doesn’t exist. When I pull back, he whines, long and loud. “Nonono, more, please, Diablo, I want—”

Before he can finish his sentence, I lace my fingers through his other hand and pound into his mouth. Tears stream from his eyes, and saliva and precum have drool running down his jaw and cheeks.

A glance towards his groin tells me he’s close. His balls are drawn up tight, the head of his cock red and swollen. He bucks his hips again, tightens his abs, squirms and writhes.

“Come for me,” I say. Unlacing our fingers and wrapping my hands around his throat, I pump into him hard, fast, and brutal.

As Killian’s release spills over his abs and his cock bobs, my own release fills his throat. The sensation of Killian swallowing around my length has me bucking my hips and groaning out loud as I pull out enough for him to breathe, and to use that talented tongue to gather my release and swallow it down.

As my cock softens, I pull out of his mouth for the last time and move onto the bed. Lying back on the pillow, I tug on Killian’s arm. “Come here.” I pull him closer. He straddles my abs, his perfect ass just inches from my spent cock.

I reach up and wrap a hand around the back of his neck to pull him down to me.

And I kiss him. It's wet and hot. Our teeth clash, tongues tangle, and I inhale every one of Killian's moans as he writhes on top of me, his hands splayed across my chest, then my shoulders, and my arms, until his fingers are twisted through my hair.

The kiss deepens. "Diablo," he sucks in a ragged breath. "Diablo," he says again. "I—" He rubs against me, his cock starting to plump again. "Uggghhhh. I want," he says on a choked sob. "I lo—"

"Say it," I demand.

He buries his face into my neck, licks my throat, nibbles at my jaw. Presses a kiss to my mouth. He inhales, long and deep, and on an exhale, he grinds against me, whining.

I lift my hand and flatten my palm over his heart.

"Say it, my heart."

"I—I love you," he whispers against my ear, then chokes out a pained sob.

As he lies atop my body, shaking and crying, I bring my hands around to his back and tighten my hold on him. "I never knew what love truly was," I admit. "I thought love was violence. I thought it was torture." I trace my fingertips along the length of his spine, feeling the goosebumps rise beneath my touch. "I know what it is now."

I twine my fingers through his thick, soft curls and inhale. "Love is my blade slicing your flesh. My tongue, swiping up your tears. My fingers curled around the soft, scarred flesh of your delicate throat. It's fear and murder, blood and pain." Tugging on his hair, I lift his head until his tear-filled eyes are looking into mine. "It's the irrational, incandescent hunger I have for you."

A tear trickles down his cheek and stops at his jaw.

I swipe it up with my tongue before pressing a hard kiss to his mouth, and whispering, "Mine" against his lips.

PART THREE

WE BATHE IN BRUTAL AGONY

*Deep down you know
Some monsters are men
And your villain will kill you
You just don't know when*

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XXVI

*Unmasked apathy
Unhidden, violent rage
You started something you can't stop
A war you cannot wage*

CHADWICK MONROE

The past

2000

Dead silence greets me when I walk through the front door. A cold chill whispers at my nape. The promise of violence churns my blood, readies me for slaughter.

“Loren?” My voice echoes off the walls, though the foyer is far from empty. “Lor?” I call again.

Nothing.

Nothing but the still quiet of the mansion.

In my mind’s eye, I picture a river of blood flowing down the staircase and pooling on the marble tiles, body parts strewn across polished floors. I imagine the screams of those responsible for silencing my wife as I feast upon their carcasses.

Because Loren is never silent by choice.

Since our marriage ten years ago, she has greeted me at the door every day, without fail. Her familiar face and the scent of her perfume, an aphrodisiac I came to crave, and the only thing—the only person, to ever calm the beast that crawls beneath my skin, ready and willing to explode at any moment.

I stop at Darius’ bedroom door, push it open, and step inside.
“Darius?”

There’s no reply.

I step back, but not before my gaze catches on the large jar sitting on top of an antique, mahogany side table. I retrace my steps, stopping in front of the side table. Reaching out, I place my hand on the jar that holds the preserved remains of my infant daughter.

Three years ago, during a psychotic break, Darius accidentally killed the infant moments after it was born. I arrived home to find Loren cradling

the newborn's small, grey-blue body. A twelve-year-old Darius curled up beside her, a thick pad of white gauze taped to his bare side.

I didn't feel loss or grief the same way my wife did, but I witnessed her sorrow. And no one who hurt my wife would live to breathe another day.

Darius would pay dearly for causing Loren's pain.

Rage consumed me as I dragged Darius from where he lay at Loren's side. I beat him until Loren released her hold on the dead baby and begged me to spare Darius' life.

After having the infant's body preserved, I placed it in Darius' bedroom.

A threat.

A promise.

A simple reminder that he was solely responsible for the death of Loren's first child. He was responsible for the tears in her eyes, and the heartbreak she tried to hide.

Had I been home earlier that day, the outcome may have been different.

This time, what I find upstairs will determine my next course of action.

An unfamiliar twinge pokes at the chambers of my heart as I recall a conversation I had with Loren so many long years ago.

"I love you," she said as we laid in bed, covered in crimson satin sheets.

Confusion warred inside me. There was an inkling of something I had no name for. A fleeting sense of ownership that told me to hold onto her, not physically, but mentally, perhaps emotionally. I had no reference for it.

Her smile widened at my confusion, like it always did. "I know you don't feel it." Hand splayed over my beating heart, she rested her forehead on my shoulder. "I understand. I don't expect you to reciprocate something you cannot feel."

"I want you," I told her with conviction. That much was true. "I won't allow you to leave."

"I know, darling." She caressed my chest, trailed long, delicate fingers over my torso. Pressed a kiss to my shoulder, then my jaw. "That's

what I love about you.”

Sighing, I remove my jacket and hang it on the coat rack. Next, I unclasp my gold watch, and remove the rings from my fingers one by one, slowly, meticulously. After placing them on the side table, I reach into my overnight bag to find my black leather gloves. I pull them on as I take the stairs to the second floor.

“Darius,” I call again, still not expecting an answer.

As I approach the door to the master suite, I listen intently. The sound of heavy breathing comes from the other side.

Door ajar, I reach out, pressing my fingers to the solid wood.

The door swings open.

I tilt my head, taking in the scene in front of me.

“Sadness,” Loren whispered as we sat at the back of the chapel surrounded by mourners. “Soften your face,” she said. “And relax your mouth.”

Unclenching my jaw, I glanced around the chapel, scrutinising the faces in the crowd. Tears, I couldn’t fake. Their expressions were easy to mimic, though. Downturned lips, wrinkled brows, averted gazes.

Loren squeezed my hand, sniffled, then dabbed at her crocodile tears with a wad of crumpled tissues. A choked sob came from her throat, and the woman in front of us turned.

Hand outstretched, she patted Loren’s knee. “Are you okay, dear?” she asked.

“I miss him so much,” Loren lied about the stranger in the wooden, flower topped casket while I watched on, memorising her reactions.

Blinking out of the memory, I focus on the bed.

The blood-soaked sheets. Loren’s body... unmoving.

Her blonde hair splayed across the pillow. Her pale blue eyes open wide, arm outstretched as though she was reaching for something...

No. Someone.

Darius.

Darius, whose hand is so tight around the solid bone hilt of his knife that his knuckles are white.

Darius, whose shoulders rise and fall rapidly, his breaths frantic.

Darius, who's about to plunge his blade into the chest of one of my sons.

Loren's sons.

Our sons.

As Darius' arm comes down, I lunge.

He lets out a pitiful cry, the sound like a wounded, dying animal.

"KILL THEM!" his scream cuts through the silence of the bedroom.

The babies wail.

I drag him backwards until I've pulled him to the floor, my hand around his wrist, my knee shoved against his chest. He holds the knife with a death grip as I try to pry his fingers off the handle.

"KILL THEM!" he shouts. "KILL THEM!"

When I finally have the knife out of his hand, I point the tip of the blade to his throat and nick his flesh. Blood begins to ooze from the wound.

He freezes, eyes wide and darting around the room. Panting breaths, chest heaving, it's almost as though he doesn't know who I am... who he is. He's overcome by insanity.

From the bed, the newborns continue to scream.

Darius blinks. Squeezes his eyes shut. "You didn't save her!" he accuses. "It's your fault. You should have been here. You're never here!"

"How did it happen?" I ask. Drawing the knife away from his throat, I stand and watch Darius get to his knees.

"Postpartum haemorrhage, I—I think." He closes his eyes, lips moving quickly as he lists off the causes of bleeding during childbirth, his voice barely audible. Shaking his head, he says aloud, "Blood. So much blood, it wouldn't stop." His eyes dart from me to the bed. "They killed her." He stands and takes a step forward.

I step back, watching him.

"She told me to save them." He shakes his head as though he's trying to clear a memory. "Savages," he whispers, his face morphs into a blank, dead expression.

Before I can react, Darius lunges for the bed and grabs one of the newborns. He holds the baby up, his hands clenched around its shoulders. Its legs dangle for a brief second before they're drawn up and the screaming starts again.

"Darius, put it down," I command. "She wanted you to save them, didn't she?"

She would have begged.
Pleaded with him not to kill her sons.
He ignores me and shakes the baby. It's unsupported head bobbles violently on its frail neck.

I feel nothing for the infant. But Loren would.
Loren would.
Loren.

"Darius, you killed our daughter, and I allowed you to live," I say. "I warned you not to do it again."

"But—" His eyes narrow in confusion. He shakes his head hard. "No. No, they will be ruined. He'll torture them. He'll fuck them like he did to me." He shakes the baby. "He'll fuck them and break them, he'll make them bleed. He's going to come for them. I have to kill them."

I shake my head. "He's gone, Darius, remember? Your father died."

"He died?" He turns to glare at me, then drops the baby back onto the bed where it lands with a gentle bounce, and finally goes silent.

"Yes, he's gone. He's not coming back," I remind him.

A flicker of something wild crosses his features, his pupils swallow up his brown irises. Darius lunges at me, incoherent screams coming from deep in his lungs.

The sharpened blade of his own knife—still tight in my hand—pierces his abdomen even as I step back.

Eyes wide, he stares up at me. "Chadwick." Tears trickle down his reddened cheeks. "Loren," he whimpers. "Not Loren."

"Sadness."

She taught him so well. His tears are real.

He can feel. The knowledge both confuses and excites me.
Emotional people are so much easier to manipulate.

"Why?" His question has nothing to do with the knife embedded into his stomach.

He wants to know why she died. Why she left him. Why his obsession with her caused him to feel something other than the innate desire to hurt, maim, and kill.

"It was her time," is all I say. "Now, pull yourself together and I'll get this cleaned up. Tonight, we will feast in her honour." The urge to twist

the blade and shove it deeper, is so strong my hand trembles. No. I remind myself of Loren's wishes and slowly step back as I draw the knife out.

One hand comes up to his stomach. He pats at his side before looking down at his bloody hand. "You stabbed me." His brows scrunch in confusion.

"You'll be fine," I assure him.

"Let me kill them," he says, eyes back on the twins. "They—they killed her. Let me kill them."

"No. She'd want them alive," I say. "I'll have Bruce deal with them. Go downstairs and see Doc about that wound, then meet me in the basement."

With a glance at Loren, he nods and turns to leave the room. "Chadwick," he says, one foot already out the door.

"What is it, Darius?" I question.

"If you don't kill them, I will." The door closes behind him.

After checking the infants and ensuring they're still alive, I cut and clamp the umbilical cords. The smaller of the twins, the one Darius shook violently, is drowsy, its head lolled to the side, its movements slow and weak. I wonder for a moment if I should end its life right now, but Loren's voice in my head deters me.

"We cannot allow Darius to be around the twins alone," Loren said. "Not after what he did to..." her words trailed off. Her eyes glassy with a sheen of tears. "I should have known better. He is unhealed, the trauma Arthur put him through will take years to unravel."

I nodded in agreement. "Yes, I know. I have spoken to Devin, he'll remain close at all times. As for the trauma, I trust you will get him through the worst of it."

"They need to live. I need them." Loren smiled and stepped into me, her swollen belly pressed against me. I wrapped my arms around her. "I love you," she said.

A soft, cooing sound catches my attention. The second twin is alert and wriggling, pale blue eyes like his mother's stare up at me. I avert my gaze and sit on the side of the bed. With my hand cupping Loren's cheek, I lean in and press my lips to hers, inhaling the cloying scent of blood and death.

“When I die, I want you to feast—” Head resting on my shoulder, her fingertips traced the curve of my stubbled jaw. “To consume me.” She trailed her fingers across my bottom lip.

“You won’t die,” I said as a command. “I won’t allow it.”

A smile played across her full lips. “Yes, darling, I will. Everyone dies.” She lifted her head and stared into my eyes. “Please, Chadwick, promise me you’ll do it.”

“I will do anything you ask of me, Loren, you know that.”

The memory fades as I swipe my tongue along the seam of her lips, then glide my hand up to smooth it over her cold forehead. “Anything you ask of me.” Her firm, cool body has already slipped into rigor mortis, and for a brief moment, I allow my gaze to trace the curves of her still, naked form one last time. “You were not supposed to die,” I say against the shell of her ear.

A knock at the door causes me to flinch, and I sit, pulling my hand away from my wife’s corpse.

A baby cries, and at the same time, Bruce steps into the bedroom.

“I need you to get rid of them,” I say.

His eyes widen and his jaw goes slack. “You want me to butcher the children?”

“No, you fool. I want you to take them away from here. Make sure Darius does not see you leave.”

Bruce nods once. “Yes, sir. Do you want them...” —he hesitates, seeming to search for the right word— “cared for, or?” His brow creases in confusion. “Sir, I’m not sure exactly what you want me to do with them.”

Standing, I gather the quieter of the two infants into my arms, wondering for a moment if Darius’ vigorous shaking has caused irreversible damage. I once again consider ending its life, but the scent of Loren’s perfume lingers, faint now amid the heavy scent of death, and I recall her words.

“We will train them to be just like you, my darling. Now that Arthur’s gone, we no longer need to worry.”

My blood runs through their veins. In time, I may be able to use them, to mould them into killers, into men worthy of The House, and of my name. *Their names.*

Small hands curled into tight fists, open, then reach out towards my face. I turn away, extending my arms to hand the baby over to Bruce. "Give them to Gavin. Have him find someone to take them in. They will be paid handsomely. I do not want to hear about them until I decide it is time."

"Yes, sir," Bruce says, as I hand over the second, wailing infant.

"And Bruce," I say, "their names—" I clear my throat. "Loren chose them. Killian and Kaspian." I wave a hand in the air. "Go."

With one final nod, Bruce turns and leaves the room, and I close the door behind him.

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XXVII

*A devil in the darkness
A game that can't be won
He'll cause your ruination
He'll bring you undone*

KILLIAN

The first siren blares, signalling the beginning of my second hunt, and jolting my heart into overdrive. Without hesitation, I break into a sprint, every muscle in my body burning with the intensity of adrenaline spiked fear. The ground is damp and uneven, strewn with rocks, fallen branches, and piles of rotting leaves that threaten to send me flailing.

I ignore the familiar path I mapped out during my training sessions, knowing it always led me straight into the hands of the hunters. Instead, I veer off to the right, plunging deep into the dense, dark forest. Trees tower above me, giant monoliths of twisted, creaking branches, and thick, solid trunks.

The undergrowth is a maze of tangled vines and gnarled roots that snag at my bare feet with every step I take. The air is thick with the scent of damp earth and eucalyptus. It mingles with pine and the acrid stench of decay that hovers like a suffocating fog of death and decay.

It was during my third training session in the arena that I stumbled upon a shallow grave filled to the brim with a dozen dead bodies in different stages of decomposition.

Stefani watched on, sucking in deep breaths like she was heaving in much needed oxygen, while I heaved the contents of my stomach onto the forest floor until nothing but blood-streaked bile remained.

According to Stefani, my aversion to the smell of rotting corpses means I'll be in charge of disposing of rotting corpses for *The House* until I overcome said aversion.

Stefani calls it "exposure therapy," and of course, Diablo and Salem agree. While Liam, who's become a bit like a brother figure to me, calls Stefani an "unhinged, torturous bitch." I have to admit, I'm one hundred percent with Liam on this one.

Rustling leaves catch my attention and I spin, searching for any sign of danger, until I look up to see the wide, round eyes of a possum staring down at me. It lets out a series of low, deep growls, then scurries away, its brushtail disappearing into the shadows.

Eyes back on the dark path ahead of me, I take off in a jog, my thin, black cotton t-shirt clings to my back and chest, and the long, equally thin pants do nothing to protect my limbs from the scraggly, dry branches that snag and scratch at my legs as I run through the leaf litter and underbrush.

As the forest thickens, I stumble forward, arms circling wildly when I try to catch my balance. Tripping on a mass of twisted vines and branches, I land on my hands and knees in a pile of wet leaves and dirt.

A blood-curdling scream tears through the air, followed by a gurgled cough, then a heavy thud. My heart races as I lay in wait, unmoving until silence falls once again.

I dig my fingers into the earth and drag myself forward, inch by tentative inch.

Keeping low to the ground, I move towards the cover of a nearby tree. With cold, trembling hands, I pull myself upright and peer through the low branches, scanning for any signs of my murderous hunter.

In the distance, the spotlights on top of the central lookout platform bathe the arena in pools of light that quickly fade into the foreboding darkness. Another scream slices through the silence and echoes around me, a haunting reminder of the world I've willingly become a part of.

When soft footsteps approach, I shrink back against the thick, rough bark of a tree trunk. A hushed voice whispers, "Hey, I can see you." It's a girl, she sounds young. "Let me hide with you," she pleads, her voice trembling with fear.

My blood boils with frustration at her recklessness. "Shut up," I mutter under my breath.

She persists, edging closer until she bumps into me. I whirl around and grab her by her narrow shoulders. She's small, only just reaching the centre of my chest. *A child?* I don't care. I can't care. "No," I say through gritted teeth. "Stay the fuck away from me."

"Please," she begs again, her cold, shaking hands grip mine hard. Through a thin shard of moonlight, I catch the glimmer of tears in her eyes. "Please, I don't wanna die."

I shake her off and step back, ignoring her pleas. I break away and sprint towards the boundary of the arena, the sound of her rapid footsteps behind me fade away as I up my pace to outrun her.

I stay low, using the shadows to shield myself as I race along the fence line.

An ear-piercing scream rings out again, this one too close for comfort.

He found her, which means he's nearby.

Panic sets in when I realise he's gaining on me. With a renewed sense of urgency, I push my body to its limits, leaping over boulders and dodging trees with reckless abandon.

I slide to a stop at the base of a tree surrounded by a huge, thorn covered shrub. The sharp spines poke and slice into my pants and my uncovered forearms as I force my way into the thickest part of the thorned plant.

Another scream. Another thud.

My heart pounds in my chest and I huddle down low, my trembling hands pressed hard over my mouth, muffling the sounds of my panicked breaths. I want to give in, to inhale a lungful of air and hold my breath until I slip into unconsciousness, but giving up is not an option. This is my entry requirement into a secret society where my savage, depraved dreams will come true.

The three months of training Diablo and his group of killers put me through to prepare me for this hunt, were nothing short of torturous. At midnight, for six nights in a row, Diablo opened the gates to the arena and ushered me inside before he made his way to the central viewing platform to watch my training.

My only goal was: *Don't get caught.*

The first two nights, Salem captured me within five minutes. The next two nights, Stefani managed to catch me before ten minutes were up. For the final two nights, Liam was the hunter. What I knew about him led me to believe he was the gentler of the foursome who'd allowed me to join their group.

I was devastatingly mistaken.

Less than thirty seconds into my fifth hunt, I was shoved facedown into the dirt, a knee in my back, and Liam's laughter echoing through the

forest. The last night ended the same way.

Over the course of the following three months, Diablo, Salem, Stefani, and Liam took turns hunting me through the forest. I failed to elude them every single time.

Seething with shame and frustration, I begged them to give me another chance, but with the date of my second hunt looming, and the arena needing to be prepared for the next intake of prey, I was basically fucked.

Then, at the end of my training, as if my life couldn't get any worse, Diablo led me down to a cellar deep in the bowels of his mansion.

All the way down the narrow staircase, I tried to hide my fear.

Tried to mask my emotions and put on a brave face.

It was useless. Fear was a palpable thing. A living, breathing entity that sprung back to life inside my head the moment my eyes locked onto the steel cage bolted to the concrete floor in the corner of the underground cellar.

Diablo watched me closely, his scrutinising gaze roved over my trembling body as panic consumed me.

"If I catch you before the siren sounds," he said, kicking the cage with the toe of his boot. "This will be your punishment."

My mouth went dry.

I wanted to beg. I wanted to scream. And I wanted to run.

Heart racing, head pounding, my fear took over. "No. Please, Diablo, anything but that. I'll do anything. Torture me, kill me—" I grabbed onto his forearms, felt the corded muscles tense beneath my touch. Begged again with tears welling in my eyes.

I stopped talking when Diablo's eyes, dark and knowing, met mine.

He knew.

Only one person alive knew my only fear.

August.

"August told you?"

Diablo nodded, his hand came up to cup my face. His thumb swiped the tear from my cheek. "He did."

Betrayal, thick and stagnant, caused bile to rise in my throat and I stepped back, breaking contact with Diablo, my arms wrapped around my middle.

"What else did he tell you?"

Ignoring my question, Diablo took my hand. “Let’s go,” he said, lacing our fingers together as though he didn’t just drop a bombshell on me.

Leaves crunch beneath heavy boots, forcing me to focus on the present.

His deep voice counts out loud as his steps pace. He’s close. So close I can feel his presence like a weight on my chest. A tickle at the back of my neck causes me to suck in a sharp gasp. I slap my hands hard over my mouth.

“Five.” His heavy footsteps fall silent. He inhales, long and deep. A primal action that equally arouses and terrifies me. How the fuck can I love this man and at the same time, be utterly fucking terrified of him?

“Four,” he calls. Then, another step. A twig snaps beneath the weight of his boot. “Killian?”

Why can’t I stop shaking? The fucking cage, it’s all I can think about.

And if Diablo’s hunting me, I must be the last one left alive. All I need to do is survive until the final siren sounds.

I dig my fingernails into my cheeks, the spike of pain helps me focus on something other than the terror that envelops me.

You wanted this! The voice in my head reminds me. *You wanted to be hunted.*

I did—I *do* want this. But the threat hanging over my head is all-consuming.

The punishment for being caught has me trembling with fear and desperate to remain hidden. I can’t let him find me. I can’t let him punish me.

Not in the cage.

Not like that.

“Three,” Diablo calls into the night. “Killian? Killian?” his voice is soft, his tone mimics a panic I am certain is nothing more than an act.

During the three months of training, Diablo had me shadowing his every move. He took me to every kill. Every bloody, brutal torture session, and every meeting he had with members of The House. He is a master at

manipulation and deceit and can change his tone of voice and facial expressions without a second thought.

Depending on the circumstances, he presents as a charming, handsome millionaire, or, when the need strikes, a twitch of his lips, or the flick of his knife brings out his other side—raw, brutal power enveloped in violent savagery.

“Two,” Diablo calls as a beam of light from the central platform shines through the darkness. “Killian?” Leaves crunch again, his footsteps quicken. His breathing grows heavier. “It’s over. You can come out now, little hunter.”

No! My brain screams. Wait for the siren. *Don’t believe him.* It shouts at me.

“Killian, I need you to come out now,” he calls over his rapid footsteps.

Go to him. My heart stammers. *He needs you, and you need him.*

Diablo’s frantic voice rings out, “Killian! Killian, where are you?” A choked sob comes from his throat. “Killian, please, it’s over.”

Don’t listen!

Don’t listen!

Don’t listen!

“Killian?”

My survival instincts kick in and warn me to follow the rules. *His rules.* Rules he admitted he never breaks.

He is the hunter.

I am his prey.

This. Is. Not. A. Game.

This time, his voice shakes. “Sweetheart,” he calls in a pleading whisper. “Please, come out now.”

Sweetheart? Is he serious? NO!

But what if?

What if he needs me?

What if he loves me?

Fuck! Slowly, I allow my hands to slip from my mouth.

A tickle of blood dribbles from my cheek where my fingernails cut into my flesh.

I creep out as quietly as possible through the thorn covered branches, my skin covered in scratches and dotted with blood.

Standing slowly, I scan the midnight darkness, searching for any sign of Diablo. The hairs on the back of my neck stand on end. A chill races down my spine.

“One.” His voice is deadly, cold, calculating.

And too fucking close.

He tricked me.

Run, Killian!

My foot barely leaves the ground to break into a sprint when cool fingers wrap around my throat from behind and squeeze. The scent of blood is heavy in the air.

I gasp when his knife cuts into my abdomen.

I choke on a sob. Pain shoots through my nerve endings as he draws the knife from my flesh. Blood dribbles from the wound, warm and sticky.

He licks my earlobe and whispers, “Found you, my heart.”

He raises his knife, presses the flat side of the blade to my quivering lips.

I open my mouth, panting through pain as I extend my tongue to lick my blood from Diablo’s blade.

His other hand smooths down my torso. He presses the tip of his finger into the open wound. My stomach lurches, but Diablo’s hold on me keeps me standing upright, my back flush with his chest. His erection grinds against my ass as he traces the blood covered finger across my lips and dips it into my mouth.

I curl my tongue around his digit, sucking as he bites down on my shoulder.

“Say it,” he demands. “I want to hear you say it.”

“I—I lo—” A lump catches in my throat. I will never tell him, but I’m fucking obsessed with the pet names Diablo calls me. While I’m acutely aware that he will never love me, let alone admit it if he ever did, having this brutal killer call *me* his heart... it wrecks me.

Every. Fucking. Time.

The tip of his blade trails over my bleeding wound. “Tell me what I want to hear.”

“I love you,” I whisper. “I love you. I love you.”

Strong fingers dig into my neck, and as I lose consciousness, the last thing I hear is the siren, signalling the end of the hunt, and the beginning of my torture.

I was so close.

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XXVIII

*Psychological sabotage
Will this be your end
Taunting you relentlessly
Those monsters aren't your friends*

DIABLO

The next day

Curled up in the fetal position, Killian's naked body shivers against the cold of the cellar.

From the warmth of my office, I lean forward in my leather chair and watch my little hunter on the monitor. He should wake any minute now, then, I have a surprise for him. Something that will unravel my beauty and prove to him that I am the only one who can—and will—give him what he needs.

Slowly, meticulously, I will annihilate every thread of Killian's existence outside my world, until he's completely unravelled and reliant solely on me—for everything. He will no longer breathe unless I allow it.

The thought causes my cock to throb in the confines of my slacks. I drop my hand down to adjust myself.

"I love you."

"I love you."

"I love you."

Killian's words play on repeat in the back of my mind.

Rationality tells me those words, uttered in the midst of intense desire and fear, mean nothing. Arrogance tells me they are the unguarded truth. The way his "I love you's" spill from his lips with quiet desperation and loosely guarded hope, tells me he craves that love to the depths of his soul.

Do I love Killian?

"No," I say aloud.

The word *love* is weak, substandard. It fails to capture the all-consuming obsession I have for Killian. What I feel for him is a fierce possessiveness bordering on intense madness. It consumes my every waking moment, leaving me completely untethered.

This heated sensation fuels my belief in foolish tales of fated mates and intertwined souls in the books Loren forced me to read as a child, believing they would stimulate my non-existent imagination.

I am a hunter, guided by the primal instinct to capture and kill. A predator guarding my coveted prey, patiently waiting until it is time to feast.

In my twisted world of savage violence and dark depravity, there is no love.

There is rage, brutality, and chaos.

But occasionally, when Killian's blood coats my tongue, and his breaths cease to exist in the spaces between us, there is peace.

In the cold, dark cellar, a dim lamp sits on a small, wooden table close by the five-by-five-foot square cage Killian is currently trapped in. The soft glow of the amber light gives me the perfect view as he uncurls his legs to stretch, only to have his feet hit the mesh wall of the cage.

Turning, he reaches out, tentative hands search the darkness.

Then, he panics. Thrashes and wails. Twists and turns.

A smile tugs at the corner of my lips. I press my finger to the button on my desk that controls the speaker in the cellar. "Good evening, Killian."

His head whips around, the whites of his eyes visible as he searches the cellar.

"Diablo?" he chokes out from between those perfect, plush lips.

"Plea—please, let me out."

Long, pale fingers curl through the mesh cage. He shakes it hard, the action doing nothing to assist in his freedom. As he peers out, eyes still darting around the dank, musty room, he gives the cage another shove. "I'm sorry," he shouts. "I'll do better, Diablo. Please, give me another chance. Please don't leave me alone."

When tears stream from his eyes and trail down his cheeks, I ignore his pleas and zoom in the camera to take in the beauty of his pain and suffering.

Face contorted in panic, his fingers work against the padlock and chains, frantic tugs and twists as he attempts to escape. When he realises it's all in vain, he screams at the top of his lungs, an ear-piercing shriek of fear laden with frustration.

"LET ME OUT!" he hollers into the silence.

I watch intently, relishing in his cries as he leans against the back of the cage and plants his feet on the opposite side, pushing, heaving, slamming his bare feet into the immovable mesh.

Five minutes later, exhausted and sobbing, Killian curls up in a ball again, and I remotely switch off the lamp, plunging him into complete darkness.

His breathing intensifies immediately. Rapid breaths on the verge of panic.

“Nonono,” he cries. “Let me out. Let me out. Let me out.”

The chain on the cage rattles against its locked door.

A scream echoes through the cellar.

“Please,” he begs in a whisper. “I don’t want to be alone.”

The repetitive knocking against the cage tells me he’s rocking back and forth. Fear enveloping him as his brain takes over. Memories of his trauma at the forefront of his fragile mind, thrusting him back into the cage that brought forth his childhood fears.

For the next hour, I watch as Killian succumbs to those fears.

Intermittently, I flick the light on to catch fleeting glimpses of dishevelled ebony curls and wide, panicked eyes. With his ears muffled by tattooed hands, I watch my little hunter turn into a shell of himself. His bravery replaced with cowardice, his strength replaced with weakness, and the light in his aquamarine eyes replaced with a haunted look of timid desperation.

Sated for now, I flick the lamp off one more time and shut down my computer.

I make my way into the kitchen to find Liam standing at the stove, the aroma of tomatoes, onions, garlic and herbs coming from the pot he’s stirring. “You feeding him tonight?” Liam asks.

I stop at the bench and pull out a barstool. “It depends. I have something I’d like to do first.”

“He’s good for you, D,” he says.

“He is nothing to—”

“Diablo,” Liam cuts me off, a wooden spoon coated in tomato-based sauce in his grasp. “You don’t have to lie to me—to any of us. It’s okay to want someone.” He shrugs. “Ain’t no shame in wanting a warm body beside you at night.”

I change the subject, and although Liam smirks, he doesn't mention it. "How was the U.S.," I ask. "And your friend, Demon. Have you heard from him lately?"

Liam's search for the men who kidnapped, raped, and murdered his sister, Mia, while she was on a skiing vacation, led him all the way to the United States. When he arrived, he made friends with Demon, a member of the Heaven's Guardians motorcycle club who are known for tracking down and ending the lives of paedophiles and rapists.

After working his way into the dark underbelly of numerous human trafficking rings, Liam inadvertently became an informant for Demon.

A few weeks after arriving in the country, Liam was able to track down the man who killed Mia. It turned out, that same man—Juan—was the right-hand man to Manuel Santos, the head of Demonio de Heilo, the cartel responsible for the death of Demon's sister.

Liam and Demon's friendship was forged through the heartbreaking pain of their shared experiences and their dire need for revenge.

When Liam first called, in the middle of a gunfight, to tell me he wasn't coming home until he helped Demon bring down the cartel, I was furious. While we had been trained to torture, maim, and kill, we had no experience with violent cartels. The fact that Liam put himself in the direct path of danger for someone who was essentially a stranger to us, had me wanting to fly over there and bathe the streets in blood.

In the end, Salem talked me out of following Liam into battle, and everything fell into place.

"Demon, he was—" Liam puts the wooden spoon on the bench, resting it on the edge of a plate. He scrubs his hands over his face. "I was worried about him for a while there. He was ready to go into the cartel's compound alone, guns blazing." He laughs, then adds, "Crazy motherfucker. He's got himself a woman now, and a kid." Liam shakes his head. "Fuck bringing a kid into this world, man. No fuckin' way."

"They are safe now, though?" I ask, wondering if he'll need to take another trip overseas anytime soon.

He nods. "Yeah, they're all good. I just hope there's no backlash, you know? Those cartels are somethin' else, D. There's always someone waitin' to take over." His eyes darken and his jaw tics. "I should have brought that bastard Juan back here to torture him. A bullet to the head..." Liam drops his head and sighs. "It was too fuckin' easy."

When Stefani enters the kitchen, Liam's expression changes instantly to one of irritation. The two of them have been at each other's throats since Liam arrived home from the U.S., and neither one of them are willing to talk about the problem.

If their immature spat doesn't end soon, I'll be forced to take action.

"Ohhh something smells good—Oh, you're here," Stefani says, her lip curled into a snarl as she looks Liam up and down.

He smiles wide, waving at her with the wooden spoon. "I am here, sweet cheeks." Liam puckers his lips and blows Stefani a kiss before turning back to the pot on the stove.

"Fuck off, asshole." Stefani's gaze flicks away from Liam and she addresses me instead. "How's your caged little hunter, did you break him yet?"

"This squabbling is becoming tiring," I say, ignoring her question and standing from the barstool. "You need to work out your differences, or else." Turning my back on them, I head down the stairs that lead to the cellar.

It's time to play with my little hunter.

* * *

A slick sheen of sweat covers Killian's skin, and his thigh, where it's been pressed against the side of the cage, bears the imprint of the steel mesh. He blinks, lifts his hands to rub his eyes, then lets out a choked sob. "Please," he begs, lacing his fingers through the cage. "Please Diablo, I'll do anything—"

A sudden, stabbing pain lances my heart. With haste, I take a step backwards, turning to put my back to Killian and the look in his eyes that tells me he would do anything to please me.

"Diablo?" his voice draws my attention back to him.

Kneeling, I pull the small, brass key from my pocket and unlock the padlock before unravelling the chains from where they're looped around and through the cage. In an instant, Killian springs free from the cage and throws himself into my arms.

Sobbing against my chest, his arms wrap around my neck as he cries. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry."

For a moment, I allow him the comfort, and relish in the feeling of his body wrapped around my own. I push my fingers into his thick curls and

pull his head back. His eyes dart away from mine and drop to my lips, but I don't allow him the affection he's searching for.

Instead, I remove his arms from my neck and stand, Killian follows suit.

Once standing, he stretches his arms and neck before looking down at himself. Specks of dirt still cling to his flesh, and his body is littered with small scratches and superficial wounds.

While I had him sedated after the hunt last night, Doc was able to clean and dress the minor stab wound in his abdomen, and the worst of the cuts and scrapes he received while running through the forest.

"Come," I say, "I have something for you."

A hint of a smile tips the corner of his lips, and when I reach out, he takes my hand, squeezing it tight as I lead him up the stairs and out of the cellar.

When we enter the locked room on the ground floor of the mansion, Killian freezes in place. His eyes wide as he takes in the equipment, his hand drops from my hold when he wraps his arms around himself.

"Is that?" he turns, eyes fixed on mine. "That's a fucking guillotine."

My lip twitches at his blatant shock. "It is. Chadwick acquired these pieces from a museum of medieval torture that closed down in the seventies." I walk further into the room, my hand gliding over the wooden stretching rack.

"Have you used this stuff on anyone?" Killian asks, stopping to trace his fingertips along the pyramid shaped tip of the Judas Cradle.

I approach him, stepping around the wooden pillory before I reach out and cup his cheek. "No, like the skin shaving device, you'll be my first."

Killian's breath hitches. He steps back, hands clenched into fists as his eyes dart around the room. "No," he whispers under his breath. Shakes his head hard. "No. Put me in the cage," he says, tone pleading.

Smiling, I take another step forward, curl my hand around the back of his neck and press my forehead to his. "My heart," I breathe the words against his lips, and he releases a sigh. He's so easy to manipulate. "Do you want to please me?"

He swallows down the lump in his throat, nods once, and says shakily, "Ye—yes." Blue-green eyes meet mine, and he nods again. "Yes, I

want—I want to please you.”

Turning, I make a show of trying to decide what instrument I’d like to use to torture my beauty. His eyes follow my every move, and I don’t miss his shaking hands or the barely contained terror that leaches from his pores.

Taking Killian’s hand, I lead him over to the guillotine and pat the seven-foot-long bed of the large contraption. “Get comfortable, I’ll set everything up.”

“Diablo—I—I... are you? Are you going to,” he hesitates, averts his gaze. “Is this it?” he asks. “You’re going to kill me, in here?”

Removing my jacket, I hang it over the wooden pillory. “Lie down, Killian,” I say with cool indifference. “I won’t ask you again.”

Slowly, Killian releases a soft sigh, then positions himself on the bed of the guillotine. He shuffles back, his eyes glued to the razor-sharp blade locked in place six feet above his head.

I stand behind the old, worn contraption, and look down at my little hunter.

So willing to please. So desperate to die. So perfect in his silent panic.

XXIX

*This isn't what I wanted
It isn't what I crave
The death of hope is here now
My own life I can't save*

KILLIAN

I. Am. Going. To. Die. I am going to fucking die.

The beads of sweat on my forehead feel as though they're drowning me, and there's a weight on my chest that aches with every inhale. With every exhale, bile rises in my throat.

You wanted this! The voices in my head wail. *This was your dream!*

There's a hum of electricity surging through my body. It weaves tendrils of fear around the chambers of my heart, suffocating me with a sense of impending doom.

When I close my eyes, I hear my blood coursing through my veins along with the frantic beat of my heart.

I am alive.

But I am going to die.

Why the fuck am I so afraid?

Because this isn't personal. I blink back tears. I want Diablo's touch. His fingers around the bone handle of his knife. That wicked blade slicing me open as he stares into my eyes. I want lust, and pain, and begging whispers of more and please.

Every part of me wants to scream out, to beg for one last scrap of attention from this man who can tear me apart and annihilate me without ever laying a hand upon my flesh.

I fucking hate it.

I fucking hate him—

NO!

I love him. I love him. I love him.

It's too late.

The tears continue to fall, and I open my watery eyes. Above me, a silver guillotine blade is fixed into a timber frame. The contraption is so old

the wooden support beams are littered with knots and gouges.

The clang of metal has me squeezing my eyes shut so hard that black spots appear behind my eyelids. I know what the sound is. *A bucket.* I know what it means. *For my severed—*

“No.” I try with all the strength I have to swallow it down, but a choked sob escapes my lips.

Diablo comes around to stand beside me. Eyes focused on his task, he reaches down and attaches the cuffs on my wrists and ankles to chains that connect to the base of the guillotine’s solid wood bed.

In my head, I imagine the medieval past, and the number of times this device was used to decapitate unwilling victims. Because let’s fucking face it, no one in their right mind willingly wants to have their neck perfectly aligned with a guillotine blade.

I am fucking insane.

And I am going to die.

“Perfect,” Diablo murmurs as he leans down and presses a soft kiss to the corner of my mouth.

Tears trail wet, salty paths to my hairline. Diablo’s fingers card through my curls and he whispers against my ear, “My heart. You own my heart, Killian.”

Fuck! “Diablo—” I whimper.

He cuts me off, “Hush, my little hunter.”

A strong, warm hand wraps around my limp cock. It betrays me by thickening as soon as Diablo’s fingers give it that first, slow stroke. His other hand reaches up to toy with my nipples, each one getting the same twist, pinch, and pull as the other.

I writhe.

Another stroke of my cock.

My back arches.

Then, his hot, wet mouth envelops me. He swirls his tongue around my length, presses it into my slit, and sucks it into his mouth until I’m bucking wildly and begging for more.

Of course, as soon as I beg, Diablo stands and steps back, licking his lips as he stares down at me. *Asshole!* Fuck, the way this man constantly enraptures me, makes me equal parts giddy and fucking crazy.

He walks over to a large armoire with ornately carved doors and pulls them open wide. Like the cupboard in his basement, this one is full of

tools, and what appear to be more medieval torture devices, including two steel contraptions that look like torture helmets.

Hanging from the inside of the door are lengths of chain, each one with a spiked ball on the end.

My erection wanes almost immediately. Before I can consider questioning him or begging him to just stab me and let me bleed out right here, Diablo turns to face me as he pulls on a pair of latex gloves.

“Remember when I said I was going to pierce your cock?”

I nod. *Yes, fucking please!* I will take anything over the guillotine hanging above my head. I subconsciously glance at the offending blade, wondering if this is all a ploy, if he’s merely trying to scare the ever-living fuck out of me.

If he is, it’s working.

Diablo’s sinister smirk is rapidly growing into a wide smile that doesn’t quite reach his eyes. “Oh, don’t worry, we will still be using the guillotine,” he says.

I swallow hard, my attention diverted when Diablo begins cleaning my cock with swift, clinical movements. After getting rid of the cloths, he returns with a long piercing needle and a circular barbell. A frisson of nervous apprehension sends a shiver down my spine as Diablo steadily marks the position of the piercing with a marker.

He uncaps the needle, looks over to me, and asks, “Are you ready?”

I nod, unable to speak as I watch him carefully position the needle. “Take a deep breath and release it slowly,” he says.

As I inhale, the sharp tip of the needle pierces my glans. The pain, while not excruciating, causes me to groan, then suck in a deep, ragged breath that I hold until white spots dance in my vision.

“Breathe, Killian,” Diablo reminds me. “Don’t hold your breath.”

Nodding, I focus only on slow, steady breaths as Diablo threads the circular barbell through, then attaches and tightens the small, silver balls.

When I open my eyes, Diablo’s expression is one of satisfaction as he works to dispose of the needle and wipe the area clean.

“Now,” he says, gently closing the armoire doors, “It’s time to prepare you for the guillotine.”

“Diablo,” I say urgently, “I don’t... I don’t want to,” I finally admit. “Not like this.”

From his spot behind my head, he looks down at me as he brings the wooden board over the top of my neck to hold my head in place.

The sliver of calm I felt minutes ago, has disappeared.

I am terrified.

Panic spreads through my body like wildfire, out of control. Urgent, desperate breaths leave my lungs and my chest heaves violently, my back arching off the solid base as I beg, cry, and scream.

“You’ve been begging me for months, Killian.” Diablo strokes my hair off my sweat covered forehead. “Begging me to kill you.” He leans down and presses a too gentle kiss to my lips. “Begging me to carve you open, to devour you.”

He raises his head, fiddles with something above me.

The blade moves ever so slightly.

I scream. “NO! Please no!”

I thrash.

“Let me out!” I beg.

“I love you!” I shout. “I love you, Diablo, pleasepleaseplease don’t!”

He smiles. Strokes my hair again. “Your tears, you know what they do to me.” He rubs his cock, stepping closer until his thigh brushes against my head. “I cannot wait to devour you.”

“NononopleasenopleaseIloveyou!” I scream out the garbled words in one, long run on sentence. Hyperventilating, I shake my head violently. My neck rubs against the wooden plank, the friction tearing at my sensitive skin.

Snot, saliva, and tears smother my face. I tug on the chains that bind me to the hard wooden surface beneath me.

Diablo reaches up.

There’s a click.

A whoosh.

The guillotine blade drops.

I. Am. Going. To. Die.

I scream.

XXX

*I will give you what you crave
I will submit to your demands
Your beating heart belongs to me
Your blood will stain my hands*

DIABLO

His screams. Intense. Breathtaking. Anguished.

His screams feed the ravenous hunger lurking beneath my skin.

I stroke his hair. The dark strands are wet and cling to my fingers.

One, two, three, four.

I lift the steel bucket by its handle and place it on the antique timber workbench beside a set of medieval carving knives.

Five, six, seven, eight.

Working quickly, I continue to count the seconds in my head as I release the binds from Killian's wrists and ankles. The chains clink as they land on the floor.

Nine, ten, eleven, twelve, thirteen.

I lift the wooden plank at the head of the guillotine, lock it into place against the support pole, and tug Killian's prone body closer to the end of the solid bed.

Fourteen, fifteen, sixteen.

"My heart," I say as I trail my fingers across his tattooed collarbone. The words, *memento mori*, a timely reminder. I continue trailing my fingertips across the smooth expanse of his tattooed chest, all the way down to his navel.

Twenty-five, twenty-six, twenty-seven.

The seconds tick by. Each one signalling another second closer to total destruction. Because Killian Graves has destroyed me. He's desecrated my structured, predictable world.

I can't think about that now.

Thirty, thirty-one, thirty-two.

A knock at the door catches my attention. "Diablo," Salem calls from the other side.

"Come in," I call back.

Salem steps into the room. "Need some help?"

I shake my head and realise I lost count. I look at my watch. It's just after seven, but I have no idea how many seconds have passed now. *Forty? Maybe fifty.*

"D?" Salem questions.

"Yes. Can you clean up in here?" I ask, then nod towards my still beauty. "I'll take him."

As Salem steps past me, he reaches out, squeezes my biceps with a firm grip, and says, "Yell out if you need me."

After a slight nod in acknowledgement, I heft Killian's body into my arms and carry him out of the room, kicking the door closed with my foot as I leave.

In my bedroom, I pull the covers back with one hand, then lay Killian on the clean, black satin sheets. He stirs, eyelids heavy as they flicker. Glassy eyes open wide and blink rapidly.

His hand comes up to his throat.

Another long, slow blink.

When he opens his mouth to speak, I press my finger to his lips. "Don't," I say.

A small nod is all I get in return.

After heading into my ensuite bathroom for supplies, I come back to find Killian holding his limp cock in his hand, inspecting his piercing.

"How's the pain?" I ask, fluffing up the pillow behind him so he can lean against the bedhead.

"It's—" He clears his throat, rubs at his neck. "It's not bad. Nothing I can't handle."

I hand him a bottle of water and strip off my own clothes as he swallows it down. "You went into shock," I explain, "You weren't unconscious for long. Around ninety seconds, I think."

"I... I thought you were going to..." he trails off, swallows another mouthful of water, and averts his gaze, picking at the label on the bottle.

"Kill you?" I lean over and cup his cheek. "If I kill you, I can't torture you now, can I?"

Killian's cheeks turn crimson, and he pulls his bottom lip between his teeth, his tongue toying with his lip ring. When he shifts on the bed, then winces, I take in the sight of his thickening length leaking precum.

“You like the sound of that, don’t you?” I trace my fingertips over his balls and his cock twitches, the bead of precum dribbles down the length of his shaft.

“You crave the torture.” I lightly trace my fingertip up the length of his cock, smoothing it through the precum, and stopping well before I reach the flushed head. “I could kill you,” I say quietly. “But for now, I’m going to keep you.”

The empty water bottle hits the hardwood floor, bounces, then rolls away. Killian lunges at me, and I fall back, allowing him to straddle me.

“Fuck me. Stab me,” he begs against my mouth “I need you—your cock, your blade, inside me, please.” Soft lips graze mine, and I open up to him. Our kiss is slow and deep. My tongue glides over his, and I bite down on his bottom lip, sucking it into my mouth.

“Please,” he begs again. “Fuck me.” Black curls fall over his eyes and I brush them back.

When he grinds against me, I grip his hips hard to stop him. “No.”

Brow furrowed, he opens his mouth to speak, but I cut him off, “You need to heal,” I say, circling my fingers around the base of his cock. He bucks into my hand, and I squeeze hard, a warning. “No. Shower and eat. We have business to take care of.”

Rolling onto his back, Killian groans in frustration.

Smiling, I get up and head to the shower. Killian trails behind me a few seconds later, a scowl marring his perfect face.

Soon, my little hunter will be so needy and desperate he’ll seek his own pleasure, and of course, I’ll have to punish him for it. Everything is going to plan.

XXXI

*It's all a game little hunter
But will you ever win
You cannot tame the devil
Until you're buried beneath his skin*

KILLIAN

I expected—and wanted—our first shower together to be full of wet, hard, steaming hot sex. Instead, I got a clinically detailed run down on caring for my new piercing, which included a neat little spiel about not being allowed to jerk off or receive a blow job for “*at least six weeks.*”

After that, Diablo washed himself, stroked his perfectly hard cock right in front of me with a smirk on his lips, came all over his own hand, then washed it off and walked out, telling me to be in the dining room in ten minutes.

All the while, my mouth was agape. I stood there, drooling, as I watched the water run in rivulets over his tattooed arms, chest, and abs. I licked my lips as it trailed paths down his perfectly lickable V, and my hands clenched into tight fists in an effort to hold back from grabbing this thick, pierced cock and choking myself on it.

Something tells me my new piercing is Diablo's way of controlling how and when I get to come. It should arouse and excite me, but my mind is still recovering from the shock of almost being decapitated. Because what the actual fuck?

The sheer terror that tore through my body when the guillotine blade dropped, was something I'll never forget. I felt my heart come to a complete stop in the split second before I passed the fuck out.

“You crave the torture.”

Diablo's words have me groaning in frustration. The cage, and now that guillotine, and that museum-like room of torment, filled with barbaric, medieval torture devices. There are clearly some things even my depraved mind has no interest in.

Shaking my head free from the images of the torture room, I pull on the clothes Diablo left out for me, buckle my leather cuffs around my

wrists, and make my way downstairs to the dining room.

As soon as Diablo sees me, he gets up from his seat and comes over. A hand cups my cheek, but as he leans down, his hand drops to tighten around my throat.

“My heart,” he breathes the word against my mouth. I can’t hold back my smile when his tongue blazes a trail of heat across my lips.

Firm, warm fingers tremble around my throat as if he’s using all the strength he has *not* to choke me into unconsciousness. As if he doesn’t know how to use a gentle touch without it leading to pain.

When he kisses me, he inhales. “You smell delicious.”

I squirm against him. Breathless and wanting, my mind trails back to the basement. Diablo shaving my skin, curling his tongue around the thin sliver, and consuming my raw flesh.

Someone at the table clears their throat, and I release a heavy sigh.

Diablo steps back and leads me to a seat between him and Salem at the lavishly set, mahogany dining table. Opposite us, Stefani and Liam sit, an empty chair between them, and I wonder for a moment if August is usually here.

Since the day Diablo had my meagre belongings moved into the mansion, I had been meeting August for coffee a few times a week after work, and we’d been texting every day.

Until the week before my second hunt when August pulled up outside the mansion on his Harley. It turned out Diablo had called him and asked him to take me hiking at Ironbark Mountain.

It wasn’t until we arrived that I discovered Diablo had an ulterior motive.

The next six hours were spent traipsing the mountain as August, map in hand, led me through winding mazes of manmade trails. Along the way, he pointed out the hidden caves and log cabins that double as hideouts and torture shacks for The House of Machiavellianism.

We reached the lookout at the summit of Ironbark Mountain, and I sat on the edge of the rocky outcrop, my head resting on August’s shoulder.

“Are you really okay living with him?” August asked.

“Yeah,” I said.

August huffed. “Even without getting what you want?”

I shrugged and leaned back, my hands splayed on the sun warmed stone beneath us as I closed my eyes and relished in the sunshine on my face. “He’ll do it eventually,” I said. “He knows I want it.”

August shook his head. “He’s toying with you, Kill. You really think he’s going to kill you?”

“He’ll do it, Aug. Even if I have to force his hand.” I kicked the side of his leather boot with mine. “You know how persuasive I can be.”

He laughed. “True.” When he turned to lie on his side, head propped up on his hand, he added, “I’d do it for you.”

“No,” I said without a second thought. “I don’t— I swallowed hard, not wanting to admit how much his betrayal stung. “I can’t trust you.”

“Why?” he asked, brow creased in confusion. “You know I can give you what you want. What you need.” He shrugged. “It’s only one step further than what we’ve already done.”

Sitting up, I ran my hands through my hair. “I just can’t. Not with you.” August sighed, and I continued, “You betrayed me, Aug. The stuff about knowing Diablo, about The House...” I leaned forward, hands clasped behind my neck. “I’m over that now, I guess, it’s just, whatever. I get why you had to keep it a secret. But you told him about the cage. Why the fuck would you do that?”

For a long minute, he remained silent. “I had no choice,” he finally said. “He wanted information on you, that’s all I could give him. Then after your stunt at Snare, trying to make him jealous. Damn it, Kill, I’m treading on thin ice, and unlike you, I’m not ready to die. Not yet.” August shuffled closer until he was sitting in front of me, legs crossed, our knees touching.

When he cupped my cheeks, I stilled.

Memories of the times I spent with August at home, on the streets, and at Snare, flickered. Each one a reminder of his friendship. A reminder of the times he gave into my desires and sent me spiralling into ecstasy to calm the chaos in my mind.

When his hand dropped down to my throat and squeezed, I sucked in a ragged breath. “I’m sorry,” he said, his gaze searched mine. “I’m so sorry, Kill.”

The sensation of his hand around my throat sent a surge of desire through my veins. It had been so long since I’d been to Snare, since I’d done a scene with August.

Strong lips clashed with mine. I grunted as I was forced onto my back, August's weight straddling me, his hands around my throat.

"I can give it to you, Kill," he breathed against my mouth, his thick cock ground against mine. "I want you. I've always wanted you. Let me do it for you."

What?!

An image of Diablo tore through my mind. His dark eyes, his sadistic smirk.

I gasped.

Kicked.

Punched.

Shoved August back and scrambled to my feet. "What the fuck!" I shouted. "Always wanted me? What the fuck are you talking about, August?"

He continued to stare up at me, shrugged, then said, "I've wanted you since the day we met. If it wasn't for Diab—" He scowled, averted his gaze. "If it wasn't for him, you'd be mine."

That day, August confessed.

Every moment we spent together, every conversation we had, even our scenes at Snare, they were all his ways of remaining close to me. He never wanted friendship, he always wanted more. His hope was that in time, I'd fall for him.

I should hate him for it, but it would be foolish of me to believe he possesses enough empathy to give a fuck. Besides, I have Diablo now, and there's not a part of me that can imagine a world where I don't want him beside me every hour of every day. I'm tethered to him, and I never want to be free again.

So, I've been avoiding August, *and* my feelings of naivety. Every call he makes to me, now goes unanswered, every text message, read, but never replied to.

When Diablo asked about the day at the mountain, I told him everything. And when he dragged me to the bedroom and fucked me like a savage, every piece of flesh August had ever touched, was replaced with bite marks and bruises from my perfect killer.

When a delicious scent wafts through from the kitchen, I blink away thoughts of August and return my focus to the quiet conversations around

the table. There's a beat of silence when Watson comes in carrying two silver platters that he places on the table. He pours each of us a glass of red wine then returns to the kitchen.

Diablo plates my food as Salem speaks. "We received an email last week about Father Norton. Liam and I went to check it out this morning."

Instinct tells me to speak up, to tell them I know about Father Norton. Instead, spurred on by hunger and macabre curiosity, I poke my fork into a thinly sliced piece of meat, stopping when it touches my lips.

My first thought isn't 'what is this,' it's *who is this? Am I eating a man? A woman? Someone who fucked me when I was working the streets? A victim from the hunt?*

Shaking off the thoughts, I place the sliver of meat on my tongue, once again savouring the delicate, almost sweet taste.

"And?" Diablo asks, addressing Salem before he takes a mouthful from his own fork.

Salem explains, "The allegations are true. Two children came forward, a third is missing."

Stefani lifts her glass of red wine to her lips and takes a sip, then, "There are rumours Gavin has one of them. A twelve-year-old boy," she says.

Bile rises in my throat at the thought of another child enduring what I did at Gavin's hands, and I ask Diablo, "Why haven't you gotten rid of him—of Gavin, I mean? You guys know what he's doing to those kids, right?"

A silent conversation passes between each of them before Salem clears his throat. "Chadwick hired Gavin. For now, he can't be touched."

"His time will come," Diablo states through gritted teeth.

Liam places his fork on the side of his plate. "I think we should let Killian do this one."

I stop chewing midway through a tender slice of rare meat to stare at Liam. "Do what?" I ask after swallowing.

"Take care of Father Norton," Diablo says simply. "I agree, it's time for our little hunter to catch and kill some prey."

Liam nods. "You ready for this, Kill?"

Nodding, I ask, "What do I need to do?"

While we eat, Diablo and Liam explain that I'll be sent in to distract Father Norton while Stefani breaks into his office and steals any records he

has pertaining to The House. Then, Diablo and Salem will come in to watch me complete the kill, while Liam keeps watch outside.

Finally having the chance to prove myself to Diablo, sends a thrill of excitement down my spine. “When do we do this?” I ask.

“Tonight,” Liam says.

My eyes grow wide. “Tonight?”

“That’s what I said.” He shrugs. “Unless you’re not ready.” Liam smirks, licks his knife, then places it on his empty plate. “Come on, you can choose your hunting knife.”

I turn to Diablo for approval. He nods and waves a hand towards Liam. “We’ll meet you at the car.”

When I stand, Diablo grabs my wrist and pulls me closer. I expect him to kiss me, or to wrap that strong hand around my throat, instead, he whispers against my ear, “If you fail, there will be consequences.”

Swallowing hard, I nod when I think about the brutal, torturous ways Diablo can send me spiralling into fathomless depths of terror. “I won’t fail,” I assure him. *Not this time.*

In the basement, Liam pulls open the cupboard. Inside, there’s a set of drawers and he pulls open the top one. “These are our spare hunting knives. When you’re inducted, you’ll be presented with your own bone handled knife, but for now, you can choose one of these.”

I reach out, my fingers hover above the knives as I take them in. Each six-inch blade is razor sharp and polished so that the silver glistens. The wooden handles are thick and marked with symbols and letters, but these are nothing like Diablo’s knife.

I pick up the one engraved with the letter D.

Liam huffs out a laugh.

“What?” I ask, closing my fingers around the handle, feeling the weight of it against my palm.

“That was D’s first hunting knife,” he says. “Figured you’d choose it.”

Smiling to myself, I ask, “What exactly do I have to do tonight? Do I just kill him, or torture him first?”

Liam hands me a black leather belt with a sheath attached. “Put that on,” he says as he closes the cupboard and steps back.

I do as he asks, then push the knife into its sheath, feeling, for the first time in my life, like I fit somewhere in this world. Goosebumps spread

down my arms, and as a sense of calm washes over me, I follow Liam out of the basement.

“You can torture him if you want to. If you think you can handle it,” he says, pulling the door closed and locking it behind us. “If you’re not ready for torture, you can stab him. You need to make sure it’s a fatal wound. The deeper the better, none of that superficial shit.” He stops at the top of the stairs, arms crossed over his wide chest. “If you can’t do this, Kill, speak up now, okay? If you think you’ll need help, I’m here for you.”

“I can do it,” I say quickly. “I just—” Clenching my jaw, I try to hold back my emotions.

Liam claps a hand on my shoulder, and I blurt out, “I want to make him proud.” Then I huff in annoyance at my blatant display of weakness. I lean against the wall, banging my head into it as I groan in frustration.

Liam laughs and extends his hand towards the narrow hallway. I walk alongside him as he continues, “I get it, man, you’re obsessed, we can all see it. But I don’t think you need to worry. D’s just as obsessed as you are.”

A hint of a smirk plays across my lips at that statement, and I reach down to touch the handle of my new knife as we make our way through the mansion, my body humming with anticipation.

Thirty minutes later, Diablo pulls up in the small, gravel carpark behind Newhaven’s only church. Run down, and in need of serious repairs, the church is mainly used for funerals since its grounds house the Newhaven Cemetery. To the side of the church, an attached, small, one bedroom cottage sits, surrounded by a white picket fence with peeling, faded paint.

“He should be in the cottage,” Diablo says, “If he’s not, you’ll find him in the church.”

The tinted car window is down, and I inhale deeply, the cool night air filling my lungs as I run through the plan in my head once more. On an exhale, I nod and step out of the car.

Gravel crunches beneath my feet as I make my way towards the small cottage adjoining the church. A dim light shines from a window, casting an eerie glow in the darkness that surrounds the church’s dry, brown lawns. My heart pounds in my chest as I reach the wooden door and knock, there’s no answer. I try again, but still, there’s no sign of Father Norton.

Undeterred, I follow the narrow path to the front of the church, my footsteps silenced by the overgrown weeds that swallow up the path. As I approach the entrance, I take in the weathered timber and the single stained-glass window above the arched doorway. Reaching for the large steel handle, I pull open the heavy door and step inside.

Rows of pews stretch out before me, the dark wood, glossy under the soft glow of flickering candles. The scent of wax lingers in the air, mingling with the musty smell of mould and mildew along with the faint hint of smoky incense.

Memories flood my mind as I take in the familiar church. I've been here so many times before, always the helpless victim.

Tonight, that will change.

Tonight, I will finally take revenge on Father Norton.

Eight years old

"Now, take your clothes off," Father Norton said.

Kaspian did what he was told straight away, but I shook my head. "I wanna go home," I said, crossing my arms around myself. "I wanna see Mum."

Gavin came back from where he was sitting on one of the long, wooden seats, and he grabbed my arm. "Do what you're fucking told," he growled at me.

I scrunched up my face and stared at him, but when Gavin took the collar out of his pocket, I did what I was told. The black collar was too scary. Gavin always pressed the button that made the collar do big zaps that made my whole body shake and hurt.

When I took all my clothes off, Father Norton smiled and patted my head. "They're perfect," he said to Gavin. "Where did you find them?"

"None of ya business, old man, just get on with it. I've got another client waitin' for 'em," Gavin said.

Father Norton did a big, big smile. He pushed the front of his pants down and pulled out his dick. "Who wants to be first?" he asked, looking at me and Kaspian.

Kaspian moved a little bit, then reached out to put his hand on Father Norton's dick.

“Good boy,” Father Norton said, patting Kaspian’s hair. “Now, show me how you can touch me with your mouth.”

When Father Norton reached out and told me to come closer, I shook my head and stepped back. “No, I don’t wanna.”

Kaspian turned around and shook his head too. “I don’t wanna,” he said.

When Gavin stood up, I ran to the back of the church and hid under one of the long seats. From where I was hiding, I could hear Kaspian crying, then a smack, and more crying.

“That’s it, good boy,” Father Norton was saying. “Just a little more.”

Gavin’s boots stomped between all the rows of seats, and he found me very fast.

He pulled me out from under the seat and put the black collar around my neck.

I screamed and kicked and hit him, but he pressed the button in his hand, and the collar did a big, buzzing sound around my whole neck. My body did weird shaking and it hurt a lot and made me cry.

“Stand up,” Gavin said.

My legs were shaky, so Gavin picked me up and put me on the seat. I pulled on the collar, but it was very tight, and I couldn’t get it off. After a little while, I could stand up again. Gavin grabbed my arm and dragged me back to Father Norton.

Kaspian was sitting on his knees on the floor with his head down and his hands behind his back. He was saying something like “Forgive me, Father” lots and lots of times.

“Now,” Gavin said, pushing me towards Father Norton, “Do what the fuck you’re told.”

“I wanna go home. I wanna see Mum and Dad.” I shook my head, but when Gavin showed me the button again, I remembered the collar was still around my neck.

Father Norton held my head in his big hands and kept making gross, weird noises when he pushed his dick into my mouth. I gagged and lots of spit and snot and throw up came out. Gavin got very mad. When he pushed the button for the collar, I fell down on the floor and cried.

Bile rises in my throat as I recall the nights I spent in this godforsaken shithole, sucking Father Norton's cock, vomiting all over him, and pissing myself thanks to the shock collar Gavin forced around my neck. When the old bastard went to prison, I thought I was finally safe. But three, short years later, he was out, and once again paying Gavin for our services.

"Good evening, young man," the familiar voice says.

When I raise my head, I expect him to recognise me. But other than his blatant perusal of my lean body and my face, he doesn't seem to remember me as the blond-haired boy he face-fucked when I was just a child.

"Good evening, Father," I say, bowing my head slightly as I approach the altar where he stands.

Visions from the past appear and I blink them away, clenching my fists and focusing on keeping my expression as relaxed as possible.

"Your reactions always show on your face." Diablo told me during my training sessions. *"They give you away every time. If you don't learn to control them, they will be your downfall."*

Father Norton steps down from the altar into my space, his hand reaches out and those long, cold fingers grasp my biceps. Eyes on mine, he tilts his head and smiles. "How can I help you, young man?"

My fingers itch to reach down and pull the knife from its sheath, but thoughts of torture, blood, and violence steal my breath. I gasp and step back.

Expecting Father Norton to be startled, or suspicious, I cross my arms around myself and avert my gaze. Another step back has me bumping into one of the pews, and I drop down to sit on the polished wood.

Unperturbed, Father Norton approaches. His hands reach out again. This time, he places them on both my shoulders and drops his head to look down at me.

Memories continue to flicker in the background while I try to focus on the present.

I remember the times Diablo appeared from the darkness, a sadistic killer ready to annihilate anyone who stood in his way—anyone who touched me.

It's my turn to kill. The corner of my lip curls into a smile.

Father Norton's hand shifts to the back of my neck, his thumb stroking the hair at my nape. A shiver of disgust trails down my spine, cold tendrils of dread that cause bile to rise in my throat.

I lean forward and rest my head on his abdomen. "Father," I whisper, dropping my head lower and nuzzling against his crotch. I tuck my hands beneath his unbuttoned robe.

He gasps, and a soft moan leaves his lips. "It is safe here," he says. "Take what you need, boy."

Slowly, I move my hands to the front of his slacks and begin unbuttoning them. His breaths become ragged, sharp inhales when I free his cock from his briefs.

Fingers card through my hair, gentle at first, until he tugs my head closer. "Mmm, aren't you precious."

Another harsh inhale.

With my hand tight around the base of his cock, I use my free hand to reach down and grip the hilt of my knife—*Diablo's first knife*.

For a moment, I still, rubbing my thumb up and down the wooden handle, feeling the small nicks and grooves in the wood, tracing the carved letter D.

Fingers tighten in my hair. "Good boy," Father Norton says, bucking into my hand. "Such a good boy."

I clench my jaw.

Behind me, the church door creaks open.

Father Norton stiffens.

I tighten my fist around his cock, draw my knife from its sheath, and shove the blade upwards, aiming for his balls. Blood smothers my hand, trails down his pants, drips onto the tiled floor.

"Bastard!" he screams in agony, stumbles backwards, then falls onto his ass. "What have you done!" Curled up in a ball, he shouts and groans while his hands cover his bleeding groin. His cries of pain are cut off when Salem drags Father Norton to his knees and brings his knife up to the old man's throat, forcing him to a standing position.

"I—I did nothing," Father Norton wails. "That boy forced himself on me!"

I stand and step forward, pressing the flat side of my knife to his lips. "You don't remember me, do you?" I ask, tilting my head and waiting for recognition to kick in.

Behind me, Diablo's presence strengthens me, and I take another step closer to the old man. "Look at me," I say. "Really look at me. Remember what you did to me."

Father Norton's eyes narrow, confusion mars his sweat covered brow. Hands still shaking and covering his bleeding crotch, his brow rises to his hairline. "Killian Graves." The bastard smiles.

His expression changes to one of smug satisfaction when his gaze shifts behind me to where Diablo stands. "My, my, my, isn't this a treat. The devil himself has greeted me with his presence."

Diablo leans in close to me, his breath hot against my ear. "What did he do to you, my heart?"

A shiver runs down my spine. My cock thickens, a pinch of pain shoots through my crown as it tightens around the piercing.

"Tell him what you did to me." I press my knife into Father Norton's mouth, but I'm no expert at torture, and I nick his quivering lips with my blade, causing them to bleed profusely.

He flinches. Blood dribbles down his chin. A shudder wracks his body, and he sucks in a pained grunt. "B—boy, you cannot do, do anything to me. The House protects me—as does God," he stutters through panting breaths. "This church is sacred. You cannot come in here and taint it with your wretched soul."

Diablo shifts, a low growl coming from his throat. "This church," he says, waving a hand. "It is nothing more than an abattoir, and *your soul* is about to be slaughtered."

Father Norton's body goes rigid, but when Diablo steps around me, I extend my hand to hold him back. I look up at him, pleading, "Please, let me do this."

With a silent nod, he steps back, the length of his body warm against my own.

Father Norton laughs, a sinister darkness shadows his features. "You loved it, boy. You and your brother, you loved being on your knees for me. So good at taking cock, weren't you."

"Take your clothes off."

"On your knees, boy."

"Good boy."

Screaming, I lunge forward to shove my knife into his heart.

Diablo wraps his arms around me and pulls me back.

Fighting him off, I shout, "Let me go, let me kill him!"

Calmly, Diablo turns me around, his hands tight on my biceps, send bolts of pain through my arms. "He is taunting you, and you are falling for it," he says. "Control your emotions."

I clench my teeth so hard my jaw aches, and after a deep inhale, I exhale and nod.

Diablo cups my cheeks. "Had I known this was personal, we could have dealt with it appropriately," he says. "We have other, better options for personal kills."

"I—I thought you'd stop me," I admit. "That you wouldn't let me do it."

A smile forms on his lips, and he raises a brow. And damn it, he's so fucking hot I want him to bend me over one of those pews and fuck me raw, right here, right now.

Behind me, Salem clears his throat. "D, we don't have all night, remember?"

After pressing a hard kiss to my mouth, Diablo physically turns me around, and says, "Go ahead, kill your prey, little hunter."

As I stalk towards Father Norton, his full-blown smile morphs into a stare of confusion, and finally, fear.

He finally fears *me*.

This time, I smile as I put the tip of my blade to the soft flesh beneath his chin. I shift my attention to Salem. "Will this kill him?"

Salem nods. "If you do it right. You need to find the soft spot and shove it up hard. If you hit the jawbone or gums, it won't have the same effect."

Father Norton's eyes leak with tears, and his pupils dilate. "You won't get away with this," he chokes out. "You can't... you can't kill me. Chadwick will hear about this!"

I trace the knife down to his Adam's apple, watching as it bobs when he swallows.

"Yeah, I can," I say. "I can kill you." I drag the knife down further, cutting the buttons off his shirt one by one until it hangs open. "I can torture you."

"I'll tell everyone!" he shouts. "I'll tell them what you did, I'll ruin you all."

When I reach his navel, I press the blade into his stomach, morbidly fascinated at the way the sharpened tip slides so easily into his fat, hairy flesh. I pull the knife back.

Father Norton struggles against Salem's hold.

I point the knife to his limp dick. "There are two sides to every story, old man." Behind me, Diablo's breaths are heavy and hot against my nape. Strong fingers tighten on my hip, giving me the confidence I need to take this final step. "You're dead in both of them," I say as I shove my knife hard into his dick.

He lets out a scream of agony, and when I draw the knife back and see the blade coated in his thick, red blood, I smile before shoving it back in.

Once. Twice.

Three, four, five times.

I plunge my blade into Father Norton's cock and balls until Salem releases his hold and lets the body fall in a heap onto the floor.

Blood pours from multiple wounds, and I—captivated—drop to my knees and splay my hands in the crimson liquid.

"Fuck," Salem says under his breath.

I bring my hand up, watching as crimson trails trickle down between my fingers.

"Holy shit," Stefani's voice comes from behind me, followed by a chuckle I think is from Liam, then, "He fuckin' did it."

I bring my hand closer to my face.

Inhale the rich, metallic scent of blood.

I open my mouth. Bring my fingertips closer.

"Stop," Diablo says.

I freeze.

"All of you out," Diablo's firm command has footsteps pacing away, the church doors close again.

A second later, Diablo is lifting me up from the floor, his hands tight around my wrists, eyes locked onto mine. "He hasn't been tested," he says.

"Tested?" I ask confused.

He laces his fingers through mine, the thick blood squelches between our palms.

Diablo holds my hands down by my sides as he leans forward to kiss me. It's hard, claiming... but too brief. "His blood, there's a high

probability it's not safe."

"Wait," I say confused, and at the same time I draw my hands away from Diablo's and wipe them over my pants. "You've done this before. I've seen you lick your knife. I've seen you eat raw, human flesh."

"Yes. You'd be surprised how simple it is to gain access to someone's medical records, or to simply take their blood under duress, then have it tested. We didn't make it this far in life by being reckless." Diablo takes my blood covered hand and traces my palm with his fingertip. "I won't have you risking your health, and I have something else for you, something better than the filthy blood of a paedophile."

"So what now?" I ask, leaning into him.

"Now, we would normally carve up the carcass and dispose of it. Tonight, Salem wants to watch the world burn." He shifts his attention to Father Norton's dead body. "His world."

A few minutes later, I'm standing beside Diablo, wondering why the hell Salem is still inside the church that's filled with so much smoke it's beginning to seep through the windows. It curls through the gaps in the front door and trails up the walls of the old, wooden structure.

Then, with a sadistic smile, Salem emerges from Newhaven Church engulfed in the smell of petrol. Behind him, roaring, fiery orange flames dance against the backdrop of the church, devouring the building as smoke billows into the night air. In a matter of minutes, the tall spire collapses into the glowing flames, taking the roof with it as it tumbles to ashes.

The intense heat radiating from the inferno forces us to step back.

Eyes fixed on the blaze as if it's breathing life into him, Salem watches on, the glowing flames highlight the expression of pure satisfaction on his face.

"Justice," he says with calm reverence.

"It's beautiful," Stefani drops her arm over Salem's shoulder and leans her head against his.

"Revenge," I whisper to myself.

Stefani presses a kiss to Salem's cheek and heads back to the car that's now parked a safe distance from the inferno before us.

We arrived back at the mansion just after midnight, and after congratulating me, everyone went their separate ways.

Diablo led me upstairs and into what was now *our* bedroom. After a hot shower where he demanded I wash my entire body twice to ensure all traces of Father Norton's blood was removed from every inch of my skin, I was ordered onto the bed.

Hair still wet and dripping, I cross my legs, watching as Diablo towel dries his hair. He runs his fingers through the damp strands and returns to the bathroom, but not before I catch the sight of his thick cock, hard and leaking precum. The silver barbells that trail down his length make my mouth water and my hole clench. The urge to curl my hand around my own aching cock, is strong, but I resist.

Diablo returns a couple minutes later, naked, with his knife clenched in his fist.

"You did well tonight," he says, approaching the bed. "Next time, though, you will speak up if you've had previous encounters with our prey."

I nod obediently. "I will."

"Good. Now, I'm going to reward you." He kneels on the bed, his pupils dilated and his lips slightly parted. "Unfortunately..." With his free hand, Diablo traces a single fingertip over my thigh, leaving a wave of goosebumps in its wake. "You won't be able to touch your cock."

Groaning in frustration, I grip Diablo's wrist. "Please," I beg. "I'll be fine. It's not sore at all." I reach for my cock, but Diablo bats my hand away.

"Up on your knees," he says, ignoring my begging pleas. "And if I have to remind you again, there's always the cage." That sinister glint in his eyes is warning enough.

I reluctantly nod as I shift to my knees.

"Now," Diablo says, pressing the flat side of his blade to my lips. "You're going to make me bleed." He lifts my hand, places his knife in my palm, then closes my fingers around the bone handle.

With the knife tight in my hand, a memory flickers before my eyes. Images of this very knife, the handle sliding into my ass, and dipping into my mouth.

"Where?" I ask, breathless.

Diablo's fingers trace his inner thigh, and for the first time, I notice the myriad of long, raised scars. His other thigh is unmarred.

"Here," he says, trailing those long, thick fingers over his smooth, scarless inner thigh.

On an inhale, I press the tip of his knife into his thigh, gasping when a long, thin trail of blood appears as I drag the blade slowly across his flesh. Raising my head, I search his face for a reaction.

“Again,” he says after a long exhale.

I repeat the action three more times, and each time his cock twitches. Precum dribbles from his crown, down the length of his shaft, and over his piercings. Blood soaks into the sheets, barely visible in the black satin.

Diablo swipes his hand over the blood and brings it up to my lips. He dips his fingers into my mouth, and I suck, curling my tongue around his digits and relishing in the metallic tang that coats my tongue with his essence.

My eyelids fall closed, and my body relaxes as I suck on his blood covered fingers. When there’s a sharp gasp, I open my eyes to see blood dripping profusely from a wound in Diablo’s thigh.

His grip is tight over mine on the handle of his knife.

“Fuck,” I say, shaking my head and forcing myself to focus. “That’s too deep.”

“It’s fine,” Diablo says. He drags his hand over the wound, and I watch expectantly as he strokes himself, wet, slick and obscene, blood covers his hand and his cock.

“Diablo,” I breathe his name on a whisper, too enraptured to utter any other word. He’s so fucking perfect I can barely hold back the urge to climb onto him and impale myself on his blood coated cock.

“Killian.” My name comes out as a whisper. After another long, slow stroke, he raises his hand and curls it around my throat. I can’t see it, but I can feel the bloody handprint stealing my oxygen. Thumb beneath my chin, Diablo tilts my head back. “You’re going to suck my blood off my cock.”

I nod quickly and when he releases his grip, I lie on my stomach and take his cock into my mouth, sucking greedily as he kneels in front of me, his legs spread wide.

A couple minutes pass before Diablo gives my cheek a few short, sharp slaps.

I release his length with a soft pop and get to my knees again.

He props himself up on the pillow, leans against the iron bedhead, and motions for me to straddle his lap.

Diablo reaches over to his bedside table and lifts the lid on a white, insulated box. When he opens the hinged lid and removes the contents, my eyes widen in shock.

“I had Doc prepare this,” he says, shifting into an upright sitting position so that our chests are almost touching. In his hand, a blood bag like the ones I’ve seen in hospitals.

My fingers tighten against his waist, and my mouth waters. “It’s your blood?”

“It is.” He nods, eyes never leaving mine.

“But—but that’s so much.” I lift my hand and curl it into a fist, anxious, but aroused.

“No,” he says, “it’s the normal amount one would have drawn during a donation.” A finger traces down the centre of my chest. “You’re going to look delectable covered in my blood.”

“Diablo,” I murmur under my breath. “I want—” Heart pounding, I’m almost delirious with ecstasy.

He cups my cheek, the action, as always, causes my heart to skip a beat. Does he realise what these touches do to me? Does he understand that these fleeting moments of intense, unguarded passion *look* and *feel* a lot like love and adoration?

“I know, my perfect heart.” Diablo opens the bag and tips it onto my shoulder. Blood—*his blood*—pools near my collarbone. “I know what you need,” the reverence in his voice leaves me breathless.

Blood trails in long, thin rivulets down my chest and abdomen. I raise my hand, my fingers, tentative at first, circle my nipple, smearing the warm blood. I flatten my palm against my chest, and smooth it down to my abs. The metallic scent lingers in the surrounding air, primal and decadent.

Diablo takes my hand and pours a small amount of blood into my palm. “Touch me,” he says, smoothing his own bloody hand over my bare torso and up to my throat.

I reach down and stroke him. His head falls back, revealing the tattooed death moth’s splayed wings. Below it, the word *mortem* curves around the base of his neck.

Eyes closed, and mouth open wide, he groans with each stroke I give his cock.

Power unlike anything I’ve felt before surges through my body and I stroke him harder, faster. Hips bucking, Diablo thrusts into the wet heat of

my hand, his thick cock throbbing, and his breaths coming in rapid pants.

There's a grunt as his body tenses, abs rippling, then, "Fuck, Killian, fuckfuck!" He groans as his release spills over, mixing with the blood on my hand. "You're—" He sucks in a few, ragged breaths. "You're perfect."

A low whine leaves my lips. "Please, let me taste you," I beg.

Hand cupping my cheek, he glides his thumb across my lips. "Take what you need, my heart."

I kneel between his thighs, licking up his blood and come, sucking his softening cock into my mouth, and swirling my tongue around and over his piercings. I move up, glide my tongue across his abs, and up to his navel where I dip it in, devouring every trace of his essence.

I crawl back onto his lap and our lips meld. We kiss with violent intensity. Tongues tangling for dominance, teeth clashing, saliva, blood, and the taste of his release fills my mouth. This can never end.

For long, drawn out minutes, we kiss and grind, grunt and moan. His hands touch me everywhere he can reach, his teeth bite into my shoulder, my pecs, my neck. The scent of raw sex and blood lingers in the empty spaces between us, filling them with primal desire.

When I bite down hard on his bottom lip, Diablo returns the favour, groaning into the kiss. "Can never get enough of you," he says, bringing my hand down to feel his cock that's starting to thicken again.

"Fuck, Diablo." I move against him, our cocks between us. I no longer care about my piercing, or the fact that I'm not supposed to be jerking off, let alone grinding into the blood covered cock and abs of this beautifully dangerous man.

"On my cock, now," Diablo commands.

Desperation takes over, and after he strokes himself to hardness, coating his perfect cock in a delicious mixture of blood and come, I lower myself on to his thick, hard length, inch by excruciating inch. I relish in the bite of pain that shoots through my ass as I lower myself down, pushing, panting, and moaning.

Finally, fucking finally, there's a sensation of complete and utter bliss as his pierced length fills me and I'm fully seated on his lap.

"My blood," he says. "My blood is inside you. You already have my heart. Now, you have everything." Gripping my hips, he holds me down so that his piercing hits my prostate with every desperate thrust. "And soon..."

He cups my cheek, his tongue glides across my mouth. “Soon, you will taste my flesh.” He grunts, and thrusts into me hard.

Fuck! “Yes! Diablo,” I whine, circling my hips, and wishing he’d take my cock in his hand and stroke it. “Please, I need more.”

“Tell me what you want,” he hesitates, drops his head so his forehead rests against mine. “My precious heart, tell me what you want, and I will give it to you.”

Your heart.

Your blood.

Your flesh.

Your love.

“My cock, please, touch me. Hurt me.” He thrusts into my ass, causing a low groan to come from deep in my throat. “Bite me. Taste me.” I beg. “I want your teeth in my flesh.” I rock back and forth, fast, then slow. I want to come, but I want to draw this out for as long as I can. “I want my blood on your tongue—in your mouth.”

Diablo bites into my pec, right over my heart, and sucks furiously.

I cry out in pain. “Yessss, devour me.” My words spill without a care. “Swallow me.”

He raises his head, my blood in his mouth. His teeth marks, deep in my flesh, are bruised and bleeding. “Take me, all of me... inside you,” I beg.

Our lips meet, and he forces my blood from his mouth into mine. We kiss with fervour, with reckless, wild abandon. Blood laced passion and desire consumes us.

“I love you,” I cry out my truth, raw and unashamed.

His cock pulsates inside me, his piercings pushing against the walls of my clenching ass.

“Fuck!” Diablo groans. “Your blood, your body.” He wraps his arms around me, forces his cock deeper, harder, deeper again. “You’re everything I crave, everything—”

Overcome with emotion, I cut him off, “Fuck, the things you say to me.” My fingers are tangled in his hair, our breaths frantic and hot, mouths desperately devouring, licking, claiming.

Between us, my aching, neglected cock throbs and leaks. “Pleasepleaseplease,” I cry out. “Please touch me.”

He relents and wraps his thick fingers around my cock, stroking me only once, but once is enough to send me over the edge.

“Come for me, sweetheart,” he says, and he bites down on my shoulder as he pounds my ass.

Sweetheart? I don’t have time to think about the endearment because my release spills between us, coating his hand and our stomachs. Diablo lifts his hand, licks his fingers, then wraps his arms around me.

My spent dick is softening by the second, and my ass is burning, but there is no way I’m done, not until I feel his hot release inside me.

“Tell me.” He breathes into my neck, licks my sweat covered skin, bites down again.

“I love you.” I dig my fingers into Diablo’s back, dragging blunt fingernails across his shoulder blades and down his spine.

I love him. I love him, and I want him to kill me, to hurt me, to consume me. And to ruin me. But something else lingers quietly in the back of my mind, it presses against the aching, erratic beat of my heart. *What if I want to live?*

“I lo—” My words are cut off when his mouth smothers mine.

His cock throbs inside me, and when the heat of his release fills my ass, he releases a guttural groan into my mouth, then stills for a brief second to look into my eyes.

In his eyes I see more than I’ve ever seen before. The shadows have given way to something else, something bright and open. As though shutters have lifted, and I’ve finally caught a glimpse of the man beneath the shroud of endless darkness.

He brushes my hair back off my sweaty brow. “I, I—I lo—”

I press my fingers to his lips, and his brow creases ever so slightly. “Don’t,” I whisper into the space between us. “I’m yours.” I drop my hand and flatten my palm over his heart. “Your heart.”

He nods once and drops his head to my shoulder.

“My heart,” he says on an exhale.

XXXII

*You had one taste of sunlight
Like a drug into your vein
Now you have something you can lose
And everyone knows his name*

DIABLO

Two months later

The bell over the door chimes as I walk into Belle's Books to stares and whispers.

For the past two months, I've been blatantly parading Killian around town. Showing him off to my allies and enemies alike. A warning of sorts, that if anyone dares to touch what is mine, they will cease to exist. While I am indifferent to the stares and whispers, Killian—my wild and reckless little hunter—loves nothing more than to let everyone in Newhaven know that he can, and does, get away with anything, as long as I'm by his side.

One week earlier

"You're loving this, aren't you?" Salem said from the driver's seat of his sleek, black Porsche.

Head still turned to look out the tinted, passenger side window, I tracked Killian walking along the street, disappearing and reappearing as he passed under the flickering glow of streetlamps. "I am," I admitted.

Salem chuckled, and when I shifted my attention to him, his expression grew serious. "You have something to lose, D. Other than me of course." A wicked smirk tilted his lips. "And everyone knows his name."

I clenched my fist on my thigh. "I won't lose you. You are capable of taking care of yourself, and unlike Killian, you don't have a death wish." I huffed out a breath and averted my gaze.

"That's true." Salem nodded in acknowledgement. "So... Are you still going to kill him? And more importantly, can you live without him?"

"I don't know. I've come close, too close, as you know. I may need to speak to Kate McCallister. The treatment has been working for Stefani, I don't see why it wouldn't work for Killian." But what if it changes him? I've been asking myself the same question for months.

I inwardly sigh. Torturing Killian has become one of my favourite obsessions. The way he so willingly gives himself to me, regardless of what I put him through, is exquisite.

I still want to kill him.

He still wants to die—at my hands.

This quandary I find myself in seems to have no end in sight.

From the corner of my eye, a commotion caught my attention through the side mirror of the Porsche. “It’s time to go,” I told Salem.

We stepped out of the car and made our way along the street, bathed in darkness. A few people huddled in doorways of closed businesses. Outside the electronics store, a group of teens stood in a circle, their faces awash with the yellow glow of neon lights. One boy looked up, a cigarette between his lips as he pointed towards the alley. “You lookin’ for Killi?” he asked. “He was talkin’ to Ken, they went down there.”

I knew where Killian was headed, and what he was doing, but the teens were doing exactly what they’d been told to do by Liam and Stefani. Watch, listen, and inform us of anything and everything that had to do with Killian Graves.

Two months ago, Liam and Stefani brought the small gang of homeless teens on as informants. Slowly but surely, we’re removing Chadwick’s influence on the streets and replacing his people with our own.

Thanks to Killian being more popular than I had first realised, these kids were more than willing to join us.

I stopped to thank them, and Salem handed over a wad of cash. “Keep this area clear until we leave,” he said.

The oldest of the teens, the gang leader, nodded quickly. “Yeah, ‘course, we won’t let no one through.”

A smaller, thin boy with short blond hair and freckles, who appeared to be around thirteen, crossed his arms around himself. Voice strong and determined, he asked, “You’re gonna kill Ken, yeah? You ain’t lettin’ him do nothin’ to hurt Killi, right? Killi’s one of us, no matter if you take him away from ‘ere.”

“Killian will be fine,” I said, amused at the youngster’s attitude.

The kid huffed, blinked a couple times, and lowered his voice, “Are ya gonna get rid of Gavin soon?”

Nodding, I shoved my hand into the pocket of my long, black coat and clenched my fist. The haunted expression in the boy's eyes told me Gavin was using him the same way he used Killian.

"Soon, you won't have to worry about him," Salem said when I didn't reply.

"We got you, man," the older teen called as we reached the mouth of the alley.

The stench of vomit and urine filled the air, and further down the alley, hushed voices whispered urgently. "Get him inside, hurry."

"Let me go, asshole!" that was Killian, playing the part he begged me to allow.

The memory flashed behind my eyes.

Killian hanging by his ankles from the ceiling of my basement. His hands bound behind his back, and a blindfold wrapped around his eyes as I thrust my cock into his needy mouth. The sounds of his chokes and gags spurred me on as he took everything I gave him, then swallowed my release with a smile on that delectably sinful face.

That night, he begged me to allow him to "lure" the prey he so desperately wanted to watch me kill. And fuck my life, but I was ready and willing to give him everything he asked for.

Still, the thought of those filthy hands on Killian's skin caused my jaw to clench. I curled my fist around the handle of my knife and nodded once to Salem.

Stalking through the shadows, we moved slowly alongside the brick wall as we continued down the dank alley to the doorway near the corner of the abandoned building.

Salem gave the door a push. It swung open to reveal a large, empty room with a few plastic chairs, two small card tables, and a row of dirty mattresses lined up along one wall. Drug paraphernalia, broken needles, and waste littered the floor. The comatose bodies of two half naked women who looked as though they'd passed out while injecting themselves full of drugs, lay on another, filthy mattress.

Bellowing laughter came from upstairs, along with Killian's shouts of "fuck you" and "you're gonna be fuckin' sorry."

My jaw clenched in annoyance, but there was no rush. I knew how much abuse Killian could take. The men he'd come in with had nothing on the brutality I could—and did—dish out to Killian almost daily.

"Fuckin' stinks in here," Salem said as he pushed a hanging blue tarp aside to reveal the staircase.

An idea formed while we took the stairs to the second floor. "We need to get rid of this filth."

Salem's eyes lit up. "Can I burn it all down?"

"Some of it," I said, knowing that would satisfy him for now. "This one can go, but let's not make too much work for ourselves."

"Sounds good to me, I'll bring it up at the next meeting," Salem said.

By the time we reached the right room, the laughter, jeers, and shouts of the men who were lured by Killian—were grating on my nerves.

With one swift kick from Salem, the door flew open and slammed against the inside wall.

The three men who were holding Killian face down on a billiard table, looked up. The one with his cock out, ready to plunge into my little hunter's ass, had his lust drunk gaze focused on a still, but wildly smiling Killian.

"It was Ken's idea!" one man shouted, finger waving towards the man with his cock out.

When Ken raised his head, his expression changed from ravenous hunger to sheer terror in an instant. He stepped back, fumbled with the zipper of his jeans, shook his head, and said, "No, no, no. I didn't do nothin'. Didn't even get to touch him."

As the other three men stepped back, their eyes darted around the room, searching for an escape route. Unless they were willing to leap from the broken window to their death, there was no escape.

Killian pushed himself up, got to his knees, and tugged his torn, black jeans up over his ass.

"Hey," he said. My reckless, wild little hellion crawled across the stained billiard table until he was on his knees again, staring into my eyes.

Raising my hand, I wrapped it around his throat and leaned in to whisper against his ear. "You said one man. I should punish you for lying to me."

He shrugged, then sucked his bottom lip between his teeth. When I tightened my grip around his throat, he said, "Hurry up and kill them. Then take me home and punish me."

"You're reckless, Killian," I said.

"You're hot as fuck, Diablo." He smirked as he hooked his fingers over my belt to draw me closer.

Killian Graves would be the death of me.

I swiped my tongue across his lips and over his jaw. The taste of his sweat damp skin sent a bolt a pleasure coursing through my veins. I leaned in and sucked the flesh of his neck into my mouth, marking him as mine again.

"Fuck me, right here," he begged. "Please." Those nimble fingers dipped lower.

My cock throbbed. My fingers twitched against his pulse.

Killian whined.

From beside me, Salem laughed.

"No," I said. With one hand still around Killian's throat, I threw my knife towards the closest man. There was a pained cry, followed by a thud.

The man continued moaning in pain as I reluctantly released my hold on Killian.

I gave my knife—still embedded in the man's chest—a hard twist before I drew it out slowly.

Two more men met their demise when Salem's blade sliced their throats open and spilled their blood before they had a chance to scream.

The last man, Ken, dropped to his knees and begged for his life while Salem and I dragged him to the billiard table and splayed him out.

I was acutely aware of Killian's gaze tracking me the entire time, and when I handed him my knife, he shuddered with pleasure, and I allowed a smile to curl my lips.

Five minutes later, Killian was covered in the blood of yet another man who had used and abused him while he was stuck under Gavin's thumb. And I was growing increasingly obsessed with him by the second.

In a rare moment of self-reflection, I pause and consider myself.

Before Killian, having someone constantly by my side would have been akin to unbearable torture. His presence evokes a range of emotions I was taught to bury. Desire, anger, contentment, and now fear. Fear because I

know what I would give up—what I would burn down, and what I would destroy to ensure my little hunter remains by my side, permanently.

Somehow, Killian has burrowed beneath my skin, seeped into every crevice of my being, and crawled his way into the ice-cold chambers of my heart and set them on fire.

I still don't know if what I feel for him is love, or pure, unhinged madness.

Most days, I look at Killian, and all I can think about is crushing his windpipe with my bare hands, or carving his body open with my knife and fucking the pulsating wound until all that's left of him are the remnants of my essence. His existence consumes me entirely. I am capable of ruining us both with my destructive obsession.

Striding to the counter, I keep my eyes fixed on the doors that lead into the kitchen, waiting to catch a glimpse of my heart.

Instead, I'm met with the shocked expression of Will, one of Killian's co-workers. "Um, hi. Hello Mr Ki—Mr King. Can I get you something?" he rushes out with a stutter that makes my eye twitch, and his cheeks turn pink as I glare at him.

Raising a brow, I tilt my head. "Where is Killian?"

The boy steps back, brown eyes darting from me to the kitchen and back again. "He's not here. He um, he left at three, I think."

I tug up my sleeve to check the time. It's four forty-five. "He doesn't finish until five. Why did he leave at three?"

The boy shrugs, and I sigh. I walk around the counter, and as I pass by, the blond-haired boy presses his back to the wall, visibly trembling as I make my way through the kitchen and down the corridor to Annabelle's office. I shove the door open to find her sitting on her stained white sofa, casually reading a book.

"Not interested," she calls out, lifting her open book. "I'm reading. Figure it out yourself."

I clear my throat and she turns to look over her shoulder. Closing her book, she lays it on the small side table as she sits and pulls off her pale green reading glasses. "Ah, Diablo. How are you, dear?"

I grit my teeth, seething with anger. There's a reason Killian is not here, and Annabelle knows better than to keep me in the dark. Keeping Killian safe means having eyes on him twenty-four seven, and while he's

working here, it's Annabelle's responsibility to ensure his safety is put before everything—and everyone else.

I hide my clenched fist in the pocket of my long, black coat. “Is there something you forgot to tell me, Annabelle?”

She presses a finger to her wrinkled lips, a contemplative expression on her face. “Not that I can think of.” She taps the same finger to her temple, a glint of amusement in her eyes. “Although, this memory isn't what it used to be.”

Jaw clenched, my fingers stretch and twitch to reach for my knife. “Where is Killian?”

“What?” Eyes narrowed, she hesitates for a moment, visibly confused. “He left to meet you.” Her expression changes from confusion to shock in an instant. “What's going on, Diablo?”

“He told you he was meeting me?” I ask, a familiar, burning rage settles in the pit of my stomach.

She nods. “At around three. Said he got a call from August saying you wanted him home asap.”

My hands curl into fists, nails digging into my palms. I turn, storm out of the office, and head to my car. As soon as I start the engine, I tap the call icon on the dash.

Salem answers on the first ring. “Hey, D, what's up?”

“Have you heard from August?” I ask.

“Ah, yesterday. Why?”

The engine revs again as I push the car to its limits, speeding through the streets until I reach the mansion. “Killian is missing.”

“What?” Salem's confusion is evident. “What do you mean he's missing?”

I pull up in the driveway and slam the car door closed before I rush inside.

Salem meets me halfway down the hall. “I went to pick him up from work. Annabelle said August called and told Killian I wanted to meet him. He left work at three. He's not answering his phone.”

Salem pulls his phone from his pocket and calls August. There's no answer. “Let's go check his place out,” Salem suggests.

When we arrive, the house is trashed. Clothes and paper are strewn across the floors. Stuffing has spilled from long gashes in the fabric of the

sofa.

“Over here,” Salem says. I meet him in the kitchen where a pool of blood is puddled on the white tiles. Killian’s or August’s? I don’t know.

Salem tries August’s phone again, while I try Killian’s. Both go to voicemail.

“Call Liam and Stefani,” I say.

* * *

KILLIAN

Two hours earlier

“Is it true you’re Diablo King’s boyfriend?” My new co-worker, Will asks.

I hold the stainless-steel jug beneath the steam wand as I texture the milk. “Yeah,” I say, “Diablo is mine.” I can’t help the smile that spreads across my lips.

“Aren’t you scared of him?” Will questions.

I shake my head and begin pouring the milk into two latte glasses.

“Why would I be scared of him?”

“I heard he’s killed people.”

“Wow,” I say sarcastically. “I haven’t heard that one before.”

Will huffs, and I ignore him to take the lattes to the two women sitting at a small table near the window. They look me up and down before they finally thank me, then go back to chatting, Diablo’s name is mentioned, but I ignore it.

I’m used to the stares and whispers now, and I don’t care. I get off on knowing that with one word, Diablo would kill for me. It’s a heady feeling.

When my phone vibrates in my pocket, I tug it out to check the message.

Having Diablo King as my lover has its benefits. With him wanting to know where I am at all times, Belle has no choice but to allow me to have my phone on me.

I look down at the message and stop in my tracks. I’m still ignoring August’s messages, but this one catches my attention and has me needing answers.

August: *Diablo needs you asap.*

Me: What? Why are you telling me. He knows I finish at five.

August: Something happened at the mansion. I'm here now, he needs you.

Me: Okay, I'll be there soon.

Confused as to why Diablo didn't call or text me himself, or have Salem, or even Liam or Stef text me like he usually does, I scroll through my contacts to call him when there's a loud crash from behind the counter.

Will stands, eyes wide as he raises his hands. "I'm sorry," he says.

Belle comes through the kitchen doors, takes one look at the broken plates and glasses, and sighs, shaking her head. "Will, Will, Will." She tuts. "Clean it up."

Before she can escape back through the doors, I reach out and place a hand on Belle's shoulder. "August just texted to say Diablo needs me," I say.

"Of course he does. Off you go then." Sighing, she waves me off to help Will sweep up the broken dishes.

The staff carpark behind the café is near empty when I get into the driver's seat of my car. I pull my phone out again to call Diablo.

I'm about to tap his name on the screen when a length of rope is pulled around my neck. My first thought is that it's Diablo, and for a brief, fleeting moment I give in and exhale, waiting for his whispered breaths against my ear.

Then, I hear a familiar voice. "Bet you're getting' off on this, aren't ya, ya fucking sick little bastard." It's Gavin.

I reach back, frantically punching and grasping for anything to grab onto, but it's useless. His larger frame and strong arms easily suffocate me.

As my vision blurs and darkness takes over, I think about Diablo, and hope that he'll show up to rescue me, then finally put an end to Gavin's pathetic existence.

* * *

DIABLO

Now

Four hours have passed with no sign of Killian, or August for that matter.

Every muscle in my body is taut and ready to fight. Adrenaline courses through my veins, and as my anger reaches boiling point, I punch my fist into the wall, once, twice, and again.

When that doesn't soothe my rage, I spin on my heel, pick up one of the office chairs, and slam that against the wall too. It breaks apart, splintered pieces of wood land on the floor.

"Diablo," Salem shouts, grabbing a hold of my biceps and pulling me back. "You need to calm down and focus. We'll call Chadwick, he might know something."

I pace the office, kicking at the remnants of the broken chair until I reluctantly agree. Pulling out another chair, I sit and tap the number on my phone to call Chadwick.

"Hello Darius, what a pleasant surprise."

I inhale, count to ten in my head, then exhale slowly. "I need your help." Never in my life have I asked for anything from Chadwick. He taught us early on that asking for things, physical, emotional, material... was weakness. If we wanted something, we worked for it, or we earned it through near impossible tasks he'd have us do just so he could sit back and watch us fail.

Salem sits in the seat beside me, and I tap on the phone to switch the call to loudspeaker. "And why would I help you, Darius, when you are intent on destroying everything I built. You're killing off my men, whatever you're up to, will not work."

"My name is Diablo," I state calmly. "Darius no longer exists."

Stefani and Salem watch me intently, and from the corner of my eye, I catch a glimpse of Liam on his phone, still trying to find out what he can about Killian's disappearance.

"Are you going to help me or not?" I question, keeping my tone even.

"I'll consider it, for a price," Chadwick says.

Salem shakes his head, and Stefani motions slicing her throat. When I scowl at her, she shrugs and smiles.

"Name your price," I say. I'll pay anything to get Killian back.

His silence tells me he wasn't expecting that. "Stay away from my son."

Anything but that. A huff of laughter leaves my lips. “Absolutely not.”

“Good luck then, I suppose.” He ends the call.

I raise my fist and throw my phone across the room, it hits the wall and shatters on impact.

“Well, that’s helpful,” Stefani says.

I glare at her.

“Oh, come on, D, you’re acting like a fucking toddler throwing a tantrum. We need to get out there and start killing people until someone talks.” She twirls her knife in her hand. “We could start with Chadwick.”

“Stef,” Liam warns. “We can’t, you fuckin’ know that.” When she fixes her glare on Liam, he raises his hands in defence, muttering under his breath, “Crazy bitch.”

Stefani’s knife flies through the air and embeds in the sleeve of Liam’s leather jacket, securing him to the chair.

“Fuck it, Stef, this is new!” He pulls the knife free from his jacket and pats at the hole in the leather. He throws her knife haphazardly onto the table. It spins a few times before Stef snatches it up.

“Stef’s got a point,” Salem says. “We need to get out there and start asking questions.”

Stefani’s brow creases and she huffs in annoyance. “I said start killing, not start talking.”

“The two of you can head over to Snare. Find out whatever you can,” Salem says.

Both scowling, they stand and make their way to the door. “And call my phone if you hear anything,” Salem calls out.

“Duh, it’s not like D’s got a phone now.” Stefani laughs as she gives us a wave and walks out.

Our first stop is Gavin’s house. Salem kicks the door open without knocking, and we stride in to find four people in the living room. While Salem checks the rest of the house, I take in the two women on their knees, greedily sucking the men’s filthy cocks. The men, oblivious to our presence, are focused on the TV.

Salem returns from down the hall. “There’s no one else here,” he says, and finally, the drunk, drug addicted fools all look up.

Salem plants his foot on the side of the coffee table and pushes it into the wall.

Eyes wide, the four stare up at us, unblinking.

“Gav’s not’ome,” one of the men slurs, his eyelids drooping. “Ya wanna beer?”

I pull my knife out and the two women predictably start screaming.

The first one runs for the front door. Salem stops her in her tracks, shoving his knife deep into her gut before letting her scab riddled body fall to the soiled carpet.

The second woman backs up against the wall, hands raised in defence. Her knees shake, and streaks of black mascara run down her pale, sunken cheeks.

One of the men leans forward, and as he’s about to stand, Salem grabs his shoulder, forcing him back onto the sofa.

“Sit!” I shout. “Where is Gavin?”

They all shake their heads.

I step over the broken needles and detritus on the floor and lean down close to the man who reeks of urine and weed. “Where is Gavin?” I ask again. I push my knife into his gut and twist the handle. “Again, where is Gavin?” When he doesn’t reply, I pull my knife out, and step back. He gropes at his stomach, patting his hands over the bloody wound. He’ll be dead in minutes.

The second man raises his hands, slurring, “Said he was goin’ to meet someone. To—Tony, s’ all I know, man, swear!”

The woman nods vigorously. “Yeah, yeah, that’s what he said. He was meetin’ Tony at the club.”

Nodding to Salem, I turn on my heels and walk out of the house to the garbled screams of the last two occupants dying at Salem’s hands.

As Salem gets into the driver’s seat, he calls our new cleaner—Devin’s replacement—Estelle, Stefani’s best friend, who’s been waiting years to move up the ranks. “Thanks,” Salem says, “And Stelle, we’re heading out of the city, so be ready for another call.”

He ends the call and drops his phone in the console. “Vapour then?” Salem asks, and I nod.

The drive to Vapour takes us an hour out of Newhaven, and when we finally pull up at the back of the club, it’s after ten. We head to the rear

entrance where an unfamiliar bouncer stops us, arm extended to block the door.

“ID’s,” he says, eyeing us up and down. He scrutinises me for a long minute, until it finally dawns. “Ha, you’re Diablo King.” His attention shifts to Salem and there’s no mistaking the heat in his gaze. “And you must be the elusive Salem,” he says, taking a step closer. “I’ve heard some interesting things about you.” The bouncer, a few inches taller than Salem, reaches out.

Three seconds later, he’s on his back, Salem’s knife digging into the soft flesh beneath his chin. He raises his hands high above his head. “Sorry, man, just playing around.”

“I need to see Tony,” I say, as Salem stands and helps the idiot to his feet.

Chastised, the bouncer pushes the back door open. “It’s poker night, Tony’s down in the cellar.”

The club is over capacity, loud, and reeks of body odour and cigarettes with an underlying, sickening stench of urine and vomit.

After stopping at the bar, the bartender points us in the direction of the cellar door. We take the stairs down to a dimly lit, smoke filled room.

A widescreen TV hangs on a wall, and at an old, worn card table covered in poker chips and playing cards, six men sit, watching a faux snuff video.

I know it’s not real snuff, because the young boy hanging from a noose, bloody, bruised, beaten, and appearing dead, is Killian. *My Killian*. In the video, a masked man grips Killian’s hips and thrusts into his limp, unconscious body as another man watches on, jerking himself until his release paints Killian’s abs and limp cock.

I stop in my tracks at the bottom of the stairs, bristling with fury.

“Tony,” Salem calls out. All but one man keeps their eyes glued firmly to the television screen. A thin man with a pockmarked face and receding hairline turns his head in our direction.

I rarely pay attention when someone looks at me. I have no interest in meeting the gazes of anyone except my screaming victims. But when Tony looks at me, when those murky brown eyes meet mine, and terror causes his pupils to dilate, a thrill of excitement courses through my veins.

Tony, the fool, flips the table and bolts through a narrow doorway.

The other men stand, confusion and panic etched on their faces. With Salem blocking their exit, they have no chance. With a swift swing of his arm, Salem slices the throat of one man before plunging his knife into the heart of a second. With a spin, his foot slams into a third man's jaw, knocking him out cold.

Knowing Salem is capable of taking down the others, I follow Tony through the narrow doorway that leads to a large storage room lined with steel shelving.

For a minute, there's silence. I catch the sound of his breathing and I stalk towards the far wall.

Tony leaps to his feet and pushes one of the shelves over, causing it to crash into the others. They topple over like dominoes, spilling their boxed contents of VHS tapes and DVDs onto the concrete floor.

I step back, my eyes tracking Tony as he races towards the open door.

"Hello Tony," Salem says, a glint in his eyes.

Tony backs up, right into my chest, and I bring my knife to his throat. "Where's Gavin?"

"I, I dunno, man. Haven't seen him."

Salem takes a step forward, his knife pointed at Tony's limp dick. "Gavin, or August Kensington, one of them has been here. Now, you can tell me which one before or after I remove your filthy fucking cock."

Tony mumbles and stutters, but it's nothing more than incoherent babbling. The scent of urine fills the surrounding air, and Salem's lip curls into a snarl.

"Where are they?" I ask.

"Dunno. I dunno. Please man, you gotta believe me." Still trembling, Tony continues to beg and plead for his life.

When Salem's phone rings, he pulls it from his pocket and answers the call, knife still pointed at Tony.

"Yes." His eyes meet mine. "No," he says. The look that crosses Salem's face is one I've never seen before. Eyes narrowed, I try to get a read on him, but it's impossible. "We're on our way."

Without another word, Salem steps forward, shoves his knife into Tony's gut and twists the handle before he pulls the blade free and turns his back on me.

“We need to go, now.” His tone bears no room for argument, and instead of questioning him here, I decide to wait until we reach the car.

Salem pulls the car door closed, his hands clenched tight around the steering wheel. His jaw tics. He inhales and holds his breath.

“Sal?” I question. “Talk to me.”

After a slow exhale, he says, “That was Gavin.”

“Gavin? Does he have Killian?” I ask, ready to find the bastard and torture the fuck out of him.

The steering wheel creaks under the force of Salem’s hold. “He has both of them.”

“Both of them, what do you mean both—”

Salem turns his head, and when his eyes lock onto mine, I see the boy I met twenty-nine years ago. I see his pain. His turmoil. And his desperation to cling onto the one thing that’s kept him tethered to this life since he was a child.

I reach out and grip the back of his neck, squeezing until he winces, a signal to let me know he feels me. That although words fail him right now, he knows I have his back. I’ll do anything to protect him from the infernal beast that lurks in the depths of his soul.

Leaning in closer, I press my forehead to his and bring my hand up to cup his cheek. The action feels foreign, but it’s something Loren used to do to us as children. And sometimes, in the middle of the night when we were supposed to be sleeping, we’d sit opposite one another on the floor of our shared bedroom, foreheads touching, hands cupping cheeks, we’d make promises to our future selves. Vow to burn the world and bathe in the blood of those who dare to touch us.

“Justice,” his shaky whisper fills the space between our breaths.

“You’ll get your Justice,” I promise.

* * *

KILLIAN

Meanwhile

As I come to, the first thing I notice is the frigid cold.

Then my body is shoved forward. A grunt of pained confusion leaves my lips.

The stench of vomit and urine assaults my senses. I gag, bile rising in my throat. I cough, then choke, my throat burns, and the foul taste of vomit and blood lingers at the back of my tongue.

Another shove forward.

A burst of pain surges through my ass, into my gut, and down my legs. My teeth chatter, and my fingers tremble. Nausea takes over and my head spins as the world tips on its axis.

Another shove.

I blink back hot streams of tears.

What kind of fucking torture is Diablo putting me through now?

Diablo.

I remember. The text message. Leaving work.

Gavin.

Panic consumes me as I surge forward, blinking the black spots out of my vision as I claw at the—What is this? *Where am I?*

My fingers curl to grasp something, but they merely slide against the cold, flat surface. When I attempt to push myself up, the rattle of chains against steel confuses me. Heaving in long, deep breaths I try again to focus on the room.

“You like that Killian?” Gavin’s voice sends my body into a violent spasm before I go rigid. Only I don’t remain still. I’m shoved forward again, and this time, I’m coherent enough to know.

Gavin is fucking me.

His body smothers mine, and with each violent thrust, the steel table beneath me is shoved forward.

I clench my thighs, buck my hips, arch my back. I writhe and scream and yank on the chains around my wrists, all to no avail.

“That’s it, fight back, Killian. That’s how you like it, isn’t it? Remember the last time I wrecked this hole?” A hand curls around my throat and squeezes. He continues spilling venomous words like vomit. “Feel that, Kill, can you feel my cock. It’s back inside you, back in this tight fucking hole making you bleed just the way you like it.”

“Fuck you!” I scream, wriggle beneath him, twist and turn.

With one last vicious thrust, Gavin stills, his hot release fills my ass and all I can do is endure until he finally gets off me, comes up to my face, and grabs a handful of my hair.

“I just did,” he says before slamming my head back onto the steel table.

A door slams, and silence hovers for what feels like hours.

“Killian,” a quiet voice whispers.

Trying to focus is near impossible. My head is foggy, nauseous, and heavy.

“Killian, wake up!” the voice is urgent now. “Don’t go back to sleep.”

I blink again, but my eyes are gritty and dry, and my ass is on fire. I squeeze my eyes shut, and this time when I open them, I see a figure dressed in black, lying on the floor.

“Who are you?” is all I can manage.

“Justice. You remember me, right?”

I try to nod, but a wave of dizziness has me clamping my eyes shut again. “How?” I can barely utter that single word, so I hope Justice can fill in the blanks.

“I was in the basement of the asylum. Gavin injected me with something.” Rubbing a hand over his head, he adds, “Everything’s a blur.” He moves to a sitting position. “They’ll come for us, Salem and Diablo. They’ll find us.”

He sounds so sure of himself, but he doesn’t know Gavin. “You don’t know—” I’m about to tell him as much when he cuts me off.

“Salem will find me. He always finds me. And all of this...” He waves a hand to encompass the entire cold, damp room. “Will be burned to the ground.”

I huff, but the action has pain lancing my throat. I swallow, then wince. “Can you—can you free my hands?” I ask, tugging on the chains.

Justice shifts again and pushes his leg out. “I can’t reach you. I’m chained too.”

Sighing, I give up and instead, I focus on the room. The plain, grey walls. The row of square doors with silver handles. The cloying scent of decomp and death, and—

It’s a morgue.

I’m face down on a stainless-steel mortuary table.

I close my eyes and succumb to the darkness that beckons.

XXXIII

*Memories come in flashes
What's left in the aftermath
A house of dust and ashes
The Savage and The Psychopath*

KILLIAN

The rattle of chains. My body hanging. Déjà vu smothers me.

A slick sheen of sweat clings to the tiny hairs on my arms and legs. It runs in rivulets down my bare skin, tracing a path over open wounds and deep, purple bruises. My arms ache from being stretched high above my head and bound by cold, steel chains that are embedded so deep into my wrists, blood trickles relentlessly down my arms.

Gavin's brutal assault before he dragged me into this room to be tortured by yet another sick fuck, left blood and the remains of Gavin's release, trailing from my ass all the way down my legs.

The sensation, like spiders crawling over my skin, tears me from reality and thrusts me back into the cage I was forced into as a child.

"You like to hurt, don't you."

"You want them to touch you. You want them to hurt you."

The monsters, I figured out much later were figments of my imagination. Twisted creatures my childish mind conjured in the depths of the shadows. They fed on my fear and created the terror I found inside that small cage.

The real threat was the panic that wound tendrils through my ribcage and around my heart, and later, the insatiable lust I found for pain and degradation. Yes, I wanted to hurt. But in the depths of my soul, the aching, painful truth was laid bare—I wanted to be touched... and to be loved.

The crack of the whip slices through the air again, tearing another violent scream from my lungs.

The unfamiliar, old man's voice echoes in the cold, dimly lit room. The same question is asked for what feels like the thousandth time. "Where

is your father?" And for the thousandth time, I reply with stuttered words and incoherent moans that my father is dead.

It's not enough to satisfy the maniac wearing a black tee, worn jeans, and scuffed sneakers. Being at the mercy of this savage, deranged lunatic, has me wishing for Diablo's predictable insanity.

Cold, thick fingers take my jaw in a punishing grip that forces my mouth open. The old man stares at me, dark, rheumy eyes trace every inch of my face. "There are so many ways I can torture you, Killian."

The familiarity in those words has me swallowing hard.

"There are so many ways I can torture you."

Diablo... Where are you?

I glare back at the old man. "I—I'm not sss... scared of y—you." The stuttering, and my trembling body covered in lashes and wounds, doesn't help me come across as fearless, but fuck this old bastard. If I can handle Diablo's torture, I can handle anything.

"Foolish boy, I don't need you to fear me. I'll simply continue to hack away at your body until you tell me where your father is hiding, or until you're dead." He turns his back on me and stalks over to the stone fireplace. Standing on the hearth, an iron stand holds a few poker and a small shovel.

The old man lights a match and tosses it into the fireplace. A burst of flames appear, then slowly dies down as the already prepared kindling begins to smoke and smoulder.

I clench my fists and try to grip the chains to heft myself up. When that doesn't work, I attempt a swinging motion in the hopes of somehow loosening the chains, but it only brings a sickening bout of nausea. Every attempt to free myself is futile, and leaves me more exhausted than the last.

Still facing the fire, he calls out, barely glancing over his shoulder, "You won't escape, Killian."

"Just kill me then," I say, and although I don't mean it, a small part of me longs for an end to this perpetual torture.

He approaches me again, this time with a knife similar to Diablo's. Where Diablo's blade is straight and razor sharp, the old man's is curved at the tip and serrated along the top.

He points the tip of that deadly blade to my hip, nicking my skin as he moves into my space. Hot breath puffs out against my torso, sending

shivers down my spine.

“It’s been a while since I’ve done this,” he says. “Hold still, okay? I like my meat cut fine.”

Oh, fuck no! Panic tears through me. “No, no, pleasepleaseple—NO!” Sweat drips from my brow.

He presses the sharp edge of his blade to my flesh. “I don’t care for these tattoos.” He clicks his tongue. “They can be somewhat unpalatable.”

I squeeze my eyes shut so hard it makes me dizzy. I can’t see what he’s doing, but I feel it—I feel everything, and I scream again as my flesh is sliced from my body.

The pain is excruciating. Tears stream down my cheeks, and I bite down on my tongue.

“Well, would you look at that,” he says. “Killian! Killian, look at this!” There’s an urgency in his tone.

Resigned, I open my eyes. I choke on the bile that rises in my throat.

Maybe Doctor McCallister was mistaken. Maybe there’s something else inherently wrong with me. Because while I yearn for pain, and death, and degradation, this sick fucking bastard doesn’t stir anything inside me except fear.

“It’s been a while, but I’ve still got it.” He holds up a piece of my flesh like it’s a trophy, waving it in front of me, blood dripping from his fingers.

“Wh—why are you do—doing this?” I stutter through shuddering breaths.

He swipes the back of his hand across his brow, brushing back his thick, grey hair in the process. “Your father took something from me. A few things, actually. Now, I have something that belongs to him. A piece of his son.” He dangles the bloody piece of flesh in front of my face then slips it between his lips and starts chewing.

“My father is dead, how many fucking times do I have to tell you?” I groan in frustration, writhing and kicking.

Holding up a single finger to silence me, the old man swallows, then licks his lips. “My, my, my, aren’t you a tasty little morsel. Now, it’s your turn.”

What? “No!” I shout, shaking my head vigorously. Pain lances through my skull and I squeeze my eyes shut.

The second his blade touches my flesh again, I scream in agony. Nothing deters him. Not my screaming, my begging, or my kicking and writhing. My vision blurs as I hyperventilate and start trembling all over.

“Ahh, another perfect slice,” he says, “Now, open wide, Killian.”

I clench my teeth and press my lips together, but the tip of his blade at my lips has me giving in and opening my mouth.

“Good boy,” he says as he shoves my own flesh into my mouth.

Blood coats my tongue, and as I close my mouth, I think about the slivers of human flesh I’ve eaten before, but it’s no use. The fine hairs on the slice of skin touch the roof of my mouth, and I gag. Bile rises in my throat, and after swallowing it down along with my own, raw flesh, I gag again, then vomit. The rancid stench assaults me, and my empty stomach revolts as I dry retch.

“Ah, ah, ah, you’re not getting out of it that easily, boy.”

Blinking back tears, I watch in horror as he pokes at my bile-streaked vomit to search for the piece of flesh I didn’t swallow.

“Please,” I choke out on a desperate sob. “My dad is dead, he died years ago.” I’m not above begging, and there’s not a part of me that isn’t in horrific pain.

“I like you, Killian.” Knife still in one hand, he wraps his other arm around my waist and inhales deep against my skin, the vomit and flesh forgotten. But he continues taunting me. “When I’m done with you.” He glides his tongue across my chest. Points the bloody tip of his knife to my heart. “I’m going to carve out your heart.” The knife slices into my pec, and I hold my breath, paralysed by fear. “Then I’m going to fuck your corpse. Would you like that, Killian?” He licks my blood from the wound, breath hot against my chest. “I think you’d like that. Giving yourself to me one last time.”

“Your death, little hunter... it will be magnificent.”

“And when I finally taste you, when I devour your sweet flesh, and lick your essence from my blade...”

“Your heart will be mine—”

I shake my head hard when Diablo’s words float through my mind. No. No. No. Diablo is nothing like this deranged monster.

I hold my breath and count the seconds in my head. I’ve done this so many times—I can do it again despite my throat burning, and my stomach

threatening to lurch. All I imagine is the respite slipping into unconsciousness will bring.

“None of that,” the old man says. He delivers a brutal punch to my gut that knocks the wind out of me and has me sucking in a life saving inhale.

“Now, let’s get back to our previous conversation,” he continues in that monotone voice that, for a fleeting moment, reminds me of the first time I heard Diablo’s voice.

“STOP!” I shout the single word out loud, begging my subconscious to stop comparing this crazed lunatic to Diablo.

“What was that, boy?” The old man’s expression remains blank as he studies me. “Did you say something?” Lifting a hand, he flattens it against my chest and smooths it down over my torso, trailing his fingers all the way down to my inner thigh.

“Do you know how many years I’ve waited for this?” His fist encircles my thankfully limp cock. “It’s been a long, long time since I’ve feasted on such a sweet carcass.”

Where the fuck is my own damn killer when I need him?

I shake and twist against my binds. “Don’t touch me,” I grunt through gritted teeth.

Being trapped at the mercy of this man is sheer hell compared to the intense, sexual gratification I get from Diablo’s torturous, fervid touch.

The moment Gavin shoved me, bleeding and broken, through that steel plated doorway and I landed at the feet of this decrepit bastard, the masochist inside me went into hiding. Pain without the promise of pleasure will never arouse me.

I swallow down the lump in my throat when he drops his hand. “It’s been a long time, boy, but I can still get it up.” After giving my cheek a hard slap, he turns and walks towards the door where the control for the hoist that lifted me into the air, is bolted to the wall.

He presses the button, and slowly, I’m lowered to the cold, hard concrete. “You on your knees yet, Killian?” he calls out, back still turned to me. The hoist continues its descent. “How about now?” he shouts as my knees hit the ground.

With some of the tension released from my arms, I manage to bend my elbows, but they’ve been straightened for so long, the action sends pain shooting through every muscle in my arms and shoulders.

When there's a heavy thud on the steel door, he removes his finger from the button and yanks the door open.

"They're on their way," Gavin says.

The old man claps his hands once. "Very good. Soon, we will be reunited. Now, get back in there and watch the others."

Others? Other than Gavin, and Justice, who was feigning unconsciousness last time I saw him, I didn't see anyone else. Unless... Does he have Diablo? Salem?

I shake my head to stop myself thinking, overthinking, and playing over scenarios in my mind. Diablo will find me, and when he does, I'll watch with satisfaction as he tortures and guts this old man who thinks he can touch me without Diablo's permission.

Justice was right, they will find us. They have to.

"Hey, asshole, what's your name?" I call out, recklessness taking over as I make a decision. If I'm going to die here, I'm going to give this fucker hell until the very end. "If you're going to torture me, at least have the fucking balls to tell me who you are!"

Getting up from his seat at the small, wooden table, he walks towards me, each step slow and relaxed, as though he's taking a leisurely fucking stroll.

He stops with his feet in front of my bent knees, and when he tugs down his zipper and pulls out his half hard, wrinkly old cock, bile rises in my throat.

"If that comes anywhere near me, I'll fucking bite it off," I warn, then clench my jaw.

When he grasps my hair and jerks my head back, I wince, but it's nothing compared to the fist to my jaw that throws me off balance.

Fuck, the dude may be old, but he's got a decent right hook.

"That mouth's going to get you punished, boy. And while I am planning on cutting out your tongue and fucking the bleeding, gaping hole that's left behind, I'd like to try this first," he says. A cold chill of terror pulses through my veins, silencing me immediately. "Now, you stay right there, okay?" he adds.

Blood dribbling from my split lip, I lie on my side, watching as he reaches into the fire and pulls out a branding iron. My heartbeat quickens as I use my feet to push myself back, slipping in the puddle of blood in the process.

“This is going to hurt, Killian.” He waves the branding iron around as he speaks, “I know, I know, you’re afraid of the pain. But don’t worry, boy, I’ll make it quick.”

I scramble back further, trying to get away from this fucking maniac.

He keeps pace, though, the branding iron, glowing orange, tight in his hand.

When I’ve gone as far as the chains will allow, he stands over me, black eyes cruel and unforgiving as he brings the branding iron down.

It sears into the flesh of my upper thigh. I scream until blood coats my tongue and the pain sends me spiralling into oblivion. My skin sizzles, the scent of burning hair and flesh assaults my nostrils. Black spots dance in my vision, and there’s a heavy, pounding beat in my head, along with ringing in my ears.

The old man sucks in a deep breath and exhales slowly. “Ahh, how I’ve missed the smell of burning flesh.” He bends at the waist, inspects the deep burn on my thigh. “Does that hurt, Killian? Are you in pain, boy?”

I curl into a ball and cry a river of tears. *Let me die, let me die.* The voices in my head wail. *Die, die, die, Killian.*

“No,” I murmur to myself. I can’t give in. Diablo is coming. I have to believe he will find me, avenge me, save me.

“All you need to do is tell me where your father is, and this all ends.” He taps the branding iron against the concrete. Tap. Tap. Tap. “I may even let you live, keep you as my pet.” Tap. Tap. “Would you like that, Killian?”

“He’s dead!” I scream, then choke on a sob. “He’s fucking dead! Why won’t you listen to me!”

Shaking his head, he tuts to himself, the branding iron still swinging from his hand. “Killian, Killian, Killian. Lying leads to pain, and from what I can see, you are not equipped to handle pain. Now, I’ll ask you again. Where is your father?”

“I’m here.” The voice is familiar. My heart and my stomach lurch in unison.

No. He’s not my father. *No, no, no.* It’s not possible.

I blink back the tears that blur my vision.

Through slitted eyes, I watch the old man walk towards Chadwick Monroe, arms outstretched like he’s greeting a long-lost friend. “Ah,

Chadwick. What a pleasant surprise. Come on in, old friend. I must say, you'll be overjoyed to know that your son has shown the utmost loyalty."

Old friend? What the fuck? I roll onto my hands and knees, my thigh burning with excruciating pain. I crawl towards the wall, trembling fingers curling against rough concrete as I try to get away from these men—No, these are not men. They are goddamn psychopaths.

"I suppose you could call it loyalty," Chadwick says, his stare fixed on the old man. "However, had you done your research—or had your informants handed over the correct information, you'd know the boy had no idea I was his father until I stepped into this room."

A split second of silence is interrupted by loud, guffawing laughter from the old man. It's so fake, it's frightening. And when it stops just as suddenly, I look between the men, waiting for some kind of violent confrontation.

"Well, isn't that a shame," the old man says, waving a hand in the air. "All that torture wasted."

Chadwick cannot be my father. It's not possible. Diablo *is not* my brother. I shake my head hard. "You—" I croak out, Chadwick's gaze shifts to me. "You're Diablo's fath—"

The old man cuts me off, "Ah, Chadwick, what lies have you been spilling to the boy?"

Ignoring the old man, Chadwick stalks towards me then drops to one knee by my side. Dark, soulless eyes stare into mine, studying me. "You look just like her." He turns his head, and looking over his shoulder, says to the old man, "Don't you think, Arthur? Doesn't he look just like his mother? It's the eyes, really. But you should have seen him before he covered up those blond curls."

Arthur. Why does that name sound familiar?

If I thought the old man's expression never faltered, the mention of my mother, whoever she was, causes his face to morph into an expression of sheer, unbridled rage. Arthur swings the branding iron.

At the same time, Chadwick raises his arm to defend himself.

The branding iron slams into Chadwick's forearm and grazes the side of his head, sending him to the ground with a pained shout. He lies on his side, blinking as he stares up at me. Blood drips down his temple, but he's alert, and he brings a hand up to feel around the wound.

Arthur grabs his arm and drags him to the other side of the room. He hefts Chadwick onto a chair and binds his wrists and ankles to the wooden arms and legs. Then he storms to the door, yanks on the heavy steel handle, and calls out, "Gavin, bring those other two in here, it's time for a meeting."

Gavin doesn't reply, and he doesn't come to the door.

* * *

DIABLO

Thirty minutes earlier

The house is smaller than I remember.

As a child, it appeared as a giant, empty mansion filled with places to explore. As a five-year-old, I was forever searching the shadows for secrets. Talking to myself as though someone would listen to the little boy whose only connection with the outside world were the brutalised, mutilated corpses of murder victims.

Salem stops the car at the end of the long, gravel driveway, and I stare out the window. The headlights light up the Federation style farmhouse with its boarded-up windows and a collapsed veranda that blocks the front door.

Weeds, and thick, tangled vines grow wildly, swallowing up the rotten timber and crawling into every crack and crevice of the once pristine house.

Years after I put my memories of this house to rest, research informed me the farmhouse I called home for five short years, was, back in nineteen-ten, the home of the town's doctor who was also the mortician.

What my father called his *work room*, was an old morgue, hidden deep in the underground basement of the house.

"You ready to do this," Salem asks.

"Yes," I say, although my mind is reeling with questions. The main ones... *How did Gavin find out about this house? And why did he bring Killian and Justice here?*

As I step out of the car, Liam pulls up behind us and cuts his engine. Stefani gets out of the passenger seat and the two of them make their way towards us. "You sure you can do this, D?" Liam asks.

I nod. "I'm fine," I state, reaching down to grip the handle of my knife.

“Wait here and keep watch,” Salem says to Stefani and Liam. “I’ll text you when it’s time to come in.”

They both nod as Salem and I head around the side of the house to go through the back door. Hanging off its worn, rusted hinges, the door creaks as I pull it open enough for us to squeeze through the gap and head inside, Salem’s phone torch lighting our way.

Rot and mould cover every surface. Scraps of torn, olive-green wallpaper hang in shredded strips against walls that have rotted away or been damaged through years of neglect or vandalism.

As we step over broken floorboards, detritus, and clumps of weeds, I extend my hand, guiding Salem towards the door to the basement.

A muffled scream comes from deep below, and Salem takes off. I follow on his heels, grabbing the sleeve of his coat to pull him back. “Wait,” I whisper-shout.

He struggles against my hold, grunting as I shove him into the wall. Dirt and cobwebs spill in a puff of grey dust over our heads.

“Control yourself,” I growl. “We need to take them by surprise.”

After rubbing his hands over his face, Salem nods, but he’s still breathing heavily. “Yeah, yeah, I know.”

A few seconds pass, and when his breathing evens out, I release my grip from his arm and slowly pull open the door that leads to the basement.

The first step I take has memories forcing their way into the forefront of my mind.

Babies and children.

Broken, bloody, screaming.

Mutilated.

“One day, you’ll be just like me.”

“One day, you’ll feel the need.”

I stop to suck in a breath before I shake my head and continue down the sixteen, rickety, wooden stairs until I reach the floor of the basement.

“There’s a door behind that shelf,” I tell Salem.

Keeping our steps light, we manoeuvre our way around a series of solid backed shelves that act as dividers. The steel plated door comes into view. Salem stops, pulls his knife from its sheath, and meets my gaze.

“Ready?”

I nod and wrap my fingers around the steel handle of the door, then push.

When we step into the cold, dimly lit room, I focus on the man with his back to us. *Gavin*. He's leaning over, punch after punch slamming into the helpless body of a figure dressed in black and curled in on themselves.

Salem sucks in a breath, and on an exhale, releases a primal sounding growl of pure rage. Before I can blink, he's lunging forward, his knife plunging deep into Gavin's shoulder.

Gavin howls in pain and hits the floor with a heavy thud.

With one eye on Gavin, I watch Salem kneel and gather Justice into his arms. "I'm here, baby. I'm here," he says as he rocks back and forth.

Blood sticks to Justice's face, and his hair is matted into wet clumps. His cheek and left eye are bruised, bloody, and swollen. His smaller body shakes violently in Salem's hold.

Leaning down, I take Salem's phone from his back pocket and text Liam to come down and get Justice, then I tell Salem, "Liam and Stefani will take care of him."

Shaking his head, Salem tightens his arms around a sobbing Justice. "NO!"

"Sal," I say, threading my fingers through his thick hair. I tug hard until I've pulled his head back and gained his full attention. "We have to finish this... together."

Eyes bloodshot and wet with tears, he blinks once, then nods and releases his grip on Justice who scrambles backwards, pressing his back to the wall.

Justice stares at Gavin with fear in his eyes. "He—he raped Killian, he... Oh God, I thought he was—" Justice covers his mouth with his hands, hiccupping coughs are all that leave his lips.

I leave Salem to comfort his little firebird, and I turn my attention to Gavin. I grab his arms and heft him to his feet before throwing him onto the stainless-steel mortuary table that's already smeared with blood and vomit. The stench is overwhelming, but I ignore it and fist the handle of my knife before plunging it down into Gavin's balls.

His screams feed my rage, and as I twist the handle, I lean over his face. "Where is Killian?"

A sadistic smile spreads across his lips, and he spits in my face, but I can still see the terror in his eyes.

“Killian,” I say again, wiping my face with the back of my hand. I twist my knife then drag the tip along his torso as he screams.

“He’s dead!” he shouts, bucking wildly. “He’s fuckin’ dead.”

NO! No. He’s not dead. I would know. I would feel it, sense it.

“Then I have no use for you,” I say.

Gavin’s eyes grow wide. “Wait, wait, no! I lied! He’s—”

I cut him off when I force my knife into his mouth and shove it down into his throat. His body shudders and his chest heaves. Blood still spills profusely from his cock and balls, and as he attempts another garbled scream, blood spurts from his mouth, a fountain of crimson that spills over his face and neck.

I pull my knife from his throat and position the tip of the blade between his ribs, then, with one final shove, my knife pierces his heart.

“...will take you home,” I hear Salem saying to Justice. “You’ll be safe there.”

Swiping my forearm across my brow, I watch as Stefani and Liam guide a hobbling Justice through the doorway and out of the basement.

Salem’s breath comes out in heavy, ragged pants. His blank, empty stare tells me he’s caught in a memory. His fist, tight around the hilt of his knife, clenches, his knuckles white.

When his focus returns from whatever was haunting him, he takes four steps over to Gavin’s already ravaged body and begins hacking at him. For a minute, I let him take out his rage on Gavin’s mutilated corpse, then I wrap my arms around him.

From behind Salem, I reach for his wrist and drag it down, squeezing the bone until he finally drops his knife and releases a heavy sigh.

“Justice,” he says in a broken whisper.

“I know,” I say against his ear. “You’ll get him back.”

I release my hold, and Salem turns around and swipes his knife up off the floor. “Let’s do this,” he says, cold detachment now the only thing left in his dark, calculating gaze.

* * *

KILLIAN

Now

As if summoned, Diablo and Salem appear in the threshold. Their faces and clothes, splattered with blood. Bloody hands grip their knives that are also dripping with thick, crimson blood.

I breathe a sigh of relief until—

“My sons!” Arthur calls. “Come, come, take a seat. I’ve been expecting you.”

Sons?

Diablo takes one step forward, then stops in his tracks. His face loses all colour. Beside him, Salem’s eyes are wide, his mouth agape. I’ve never seen them look so human, or so afraid. And if they’re afraid, I should be fucking terrified.

“Da—Dad?” Diablo says, his voice shakes, an almost childlike quality to it. “You’re—You’re alive?”

Arthur extends his hands. “I am alive. Welcome home, sons.”

“*Sons?*” Salem questions. He waves a hand between himself and Arthur. “I’m not your fucking son.”

A sinister smile spreads across Arthur’s face, but it doesn’t reach those dead, hollow eyes, and that smile... it makes him appear as a horrific clown from a slasher movie.

“You didn’t tell them, did you?” he addresses Chadwick.

Chadwick shifts his gaze between Salem and Diablo. “There was no need. What difference would it make? Loren and I adopted them. We raised them as *our sons*. They already believed they were brothers.”

Before I can blink, Diablo throws his knife, and it lands on the concrete with a clang. His hand darts out and he squeezes it around Arthur’s throat, sending him flailing backwards until they’re on the floor, Diablo’s knee firm against Arthur’s chest. “Start fucking talking,” Diablo demands.

“Salem is your brother,” Arthur says, not an ounce of fear or apprehension in his tone, even though Diablo is holding him down like he’s a rabid dog ready to bite.

“Half-brother,” Chadwick adds. “Arthur wanted to spread his seed.”

Diablo’s brow scrunches in confusion and he shares a look with Salem I can’t decipher. Then... everything falls into place.

Salem must realise at the same time because he shakes his head and says, “You fucked random women and had them carry your bastard children?”

“Sons,” Chadwick corrects. “The girls were disposed of. And the women weren’t random, they were selected, paid to have his children. At fifteen, the boys were meant to be inducted into the house.”

Arthur turns his head in Chadwick’s direction. “The weak needed to be weeded out, replaced with my superior genes. Darius and Salem are prime examples. They were born to be like me, to hunt and kill, to feast on the weak.” Shifting his attention back to Diablo, Arthur says, “Now, Darius, if you’ll let me up, Chadwick can tell me where the rest of my sons are, and we can finish this meeting.”

My mouth gapes open, unable to fathom the depths of Arthur’s insanity. The bastard is flat on his back with a killer straddling his body, and he’s *still* ranting like a fucking lunatic.

“How many children?” Diablo asks. “How many fucking brothers do I have?”

Arthur shifts beneath Diablo’s weight. When a minute passes without an answer, Diablo slams a fist into Arthur’s jaw. “How many?” he roars.

Arthur spits a glob of blood in Diablo’s direction. Another punch to Arthur’s face has him grunting in pain. His head falls to the side, eyes blinking rapidly as Diablo stands and begins pacing.

Chadwick, realising Arthur is done talking, says, “We don’t know. Fifteen, twenty maybe. Loren was tracking them.” His gaze shifts to me. “Until she died.”

“*Until she died.*” I don’t remember Chadwick, let alone my birth mother.

But the inkling of a conversation returns again.

“*A guy like Monroe...*”

He did sell me—*me and Kaspian*—to the people we believed were our parents. Or he simply gave us away.

“*Yours.*”

“*Someone I loved.*”

“*Someone we both loved.*”

The skeleton at Diablo's mansion is—was—my mother. *When did she die?*

The empty place beside Chadwick at the table during the feast.

The newborn baby in the jar.

Nausea sends me sliding sideways until I'm slumped on the floor. The cold concrete a welcome relief against the burning sensation flowing through my veins.

Diablo shifts his attention to Chadwick. "What have you done?" he asks, brow creased in confusion.

Chadwick blinks a few times then tilts his head back and forth to crack his neck. He shrugs and says, "I did nothing. He was attacked in prison. They thought he was unconscious. But on the way to the hospital, he killed the guards and escaped."

"So Connor lied and said he was dead? What was he thinking?" Diablo tugs on the long, thick strands of his hair.

"Oh fuck!" No one hears the whispered words that spill from my lips as the shocking revelation finally hits me with the force of a freight train.

Arthur.

Arthur Phillip Kingsford.

The Savage. The Serial Killer who supposedly died back in the nineties.

He's Diablo's—and Salem's—father.

Bile rises in my throat, and my stomach clenches in knots. I dig my heels into the concrete and shuffle back until I'm leaning against the wall. My arms are still extended above my head and attached to the chains on the hoist. The raw, open wound on my hip stings, and the smell of my burnt flesh lingers beneath my nose.

Chadwick continues, unfazed, "My father wasn't willing to take the fall, so he staged Arthur's death and wiped his hands of it."

Arthur turns his hard stare to Chadwick. "And I would have stayed away, instead, I found out it was you who led the police to my home, sent them to me in the middle of the night. You had me arrested."

Chadwick manages a half shrug. "You were bringing too much attention to us. All those women," he adds, "your little fan club. They were

bound to talk eventually. We did what was best for The House, and for those children.”

“The children...” Arthur scoffs, shaking his head. “The only person who cared about the children was Lor—” He hesitates for a moment, then continues, “Those women, they were loyal to me. Devoted, unlike your late wife.” He walks towards Chadwick, but Diablo steps between them.

“Loren never wanted you,” Chadwick says, craning his neck to look around Diablo and address Arthur. “She was using you, studying you like a caged animal. You were nothing more than an experiment to her, a serial killer she became infatuated with.”

Diablo looks up, and for the first time since he entered the room, his eyes lock onto mine. His gaze trails the length of my battered and bruised body before his attention is back on Arthur—his father.

“The other boys Loren found... his sons?” Salem asks Chadwick. “They’re members of The House?”

“Not all of them,” Chadwick says. “I’m having some watched from afar. Two are in Iron Tomb. There’s you and Salem. Liam, Gavin, August.”

“August.” I gasp in shock. *Does he know? God, is he even alive?*

Salem paces back and forth before he cautiously makes his way over to me and begins removing the chains from my wrists. Arthur glances our way, but he must realise that chained or unchained, I’m not a threat to him, not in my weakened, bloody state.

When I’m finally unchained, Salem returns to his spot against the wall, leaning back with his arms crossed, watching Arthur’s every move.

“Gavin and August?” Diablo asks, eyes narrowed in Chadwick’s direction. “Are you certain?”

Chadwick’s response is immediate. “Yes.” He huffs out a breath. “You can ask Doc to provide you with the unaltered DNA tests.”

Diablo shakes his head, his brow creased.

“It was Loren’s decision not to tell you,” Chadwick explains. “She didn’t want your thoughts or actions swayed. Like Arthur, you were nothing but experiments to her. She was obsessed with you boys, desperate to figure you all out,” Chadwick says without a care.

Diablo’s jaw clenches and he runs a hand through his hair, his focus back on me. His long strides reach me in seconds. When he kneels and cups my cheek, I try to raise my hand, but I’m too weak.

“You’re hurt,” Diablo says.

A huff of laughter comes from between my split, bleeding lips. A mixture of relief, pain, and the sight of Diablo King staring at me as though I'm everything he needs, has me feeling ecstatic. "A bit," I say. "You're Darius. You didn't die in the asylum fire."

Diablo nods. "I am, and no, I didn't die."

"And you knew who I was all this time?"

"I did," he says.

For a long minute, I stare up at him, wishing I was back in his bed, or damn, I'd even take the guillotine, or the cage at this point.

"It's so hot," I whisper, closing my eyes and resting my head on the cool ground, respite for my sweat covered brow and the inferno simmering beneath my skin.

"Come on, I'll help you—"

"DIABLO!" Salem's shout draws my attention. I open my eyes to see Arthur swiping Diablo's knife from the floor, but it's too late. Arthur is already up, and with his other hand, he swings the branding iron.

There's a pained grunt before Diablo's body slumps over mine.

Arthur holds the knife to Diablo's throat, and the last thing I see before I pass out is Salem dropping his own knife, and stepping back, hands raised in the air.

XXXIV

*He was merely a child
When he was taught to destroy
And who could love a monster
In the shape of a boy*

DIABLO

AKA - Darius Arthur Kingsford

Five years old

The night of Arthur Phillip Kingsford's Arrest – May 1990

I open the door and look down the dark stairs that go to the basement.

"Dad!" I call from the top of the stairs. When he doesn't answer me, I step down, down, down, counting the steps. One, two, three, four... when I get to sixteen, I jump onto the hard floor. "Dad! I'm calling you," I say again.

A loud scream comes from Dad's work room and little bumps jump up all over my body. My dad likes making lots of people and kids and babies scream, and when I behave, he lets me watch. Sometimes, he even lets me help.

When I get to the big, heavy door, I bang my hand on it, but I don't think my dad can hear me because the person inside is screaming. It's open a little bit, so I give the door a big push, and it swings all the way open.

My dad turns around, his face and hands are covered in lots of red blood.

"Dad, I was calling you," I say.

He wipes his hand across his mouth, and the person I think is a man, is lying on the table and has ropes tied around his legs and arms.

"What is it, Darius? I told you I was working."

"I wanna help you." I walk closer to the wiggling man. When he sees me, his eyes get very, very big and he starts moving and shaking his head.

"What are you doing?" he shouts. "Let him go. Oh my God, you're fucking crazy!" The man looks at me again. "Run, run away, kid, hurry!" the man shouts at me.

“I don’t wanna.” I shake my head because I don’t want to run away from my dad.

“You fool,” Dad says to the man, and he pats my head. “Darius is my son. Did you know a child cannot be charged with murder? Interesting, isn’t it?”

Dad gives me his big knife and when I take it, lots of blood gets on my hands, so I lick it off like Dad does.

The man shakes his head again. “No, no, no! What—what are you doing? You fucking crazy fuck! Let me go!”

But Dad doesn’t let him go. He never lets people go, even when they shake their head and say no, no, no.

Dad picks me up and lets me sit on the silver table next to the man. “Do you want to play, Darius?”

I nod, and Dad tells me I can do cuts and stabs. First, I push Dad’s very sharp knife into the man’s tummy. He screams and wiggles around some more. When I make a big, big cut, I stick my finger in like Dad showed me, and I feel all the squishy, wet blood and meat inside the man’s tummy.

The man keeps screaming and saying “No,” and “Stop,” and “Please,” but Dad tells me not to listen to him, so I do more cuts. Small cuts and stabs, and big cuts and stabs. When I push the knife into the man’s neck, lots of blood comes out and he stops moving and screaming.

“He stopped, Dad.”

Dad nods at me. “He’s dead. We’ll feast on his carcass tonight. Remember what I told you, Darius?”

I nod lots of times, and Dad picks me up and puts me back on the floor. “We eat meat called pork for dinner. Meat that you make,” I say to Dad, so he knows I remember.

“And no talking about the work room.”

“Okay, Dad,” I say.

“What happens if you talk about this room?”

A big shiver makes my whole body shaky and cold. Lots of the little bumps go all over my skin again. I turn to look at the big pole where I have to stand when Dad ties up my hands.

“I get the whip again,” I say.

“That’s right. Now, sit on your chair. I need to finish with this carcass.”

I do what I'm told and sit on the big spinning chair that Dad got especially for me. When I climb up, it spins around a little, and Dad turns it around so I can watch him.

Dad takes all his clothes off, and for a long time, I sit on my chair and watch my dad lay on the dead man. Dad's whole body at the front is covered in red blood, and when he licks and kisses the man, more blood gets on his face, and he makes lots of loud noises.

Later, when I'm sleeping in bed next to my dad, I hear a big, loud bang on the door, and I wake up. My heart does big bump, bump, bumps, and I shake Dad very hard to wake him up too.

When Dad gets out of bed, he picks me up and carries me to the living room with him.

The door bangs open, and lots of big men wearing black clothes come inside. Some of them have guns, and some have torches that make bright lights flash around the house.

They all stop moving and talking when Dad puts his big knife at my neck. "One more step and I'll kill him," Dad says.

The men stand very still. One of them lifts up his hand. "You're surrounded, Arthur, put the kid down."

Dad moves the knife down to my tummy and pushes it into me. It's very sharp, and dribbly tears come from my eyes when Dad falls down.

There's a big, loud bang, then lots of men shouting, and when someone picks me up, I scream for my Dad to help me.

* * *

One week later

"Hello, Darius, I'm Doctor Benson. How are you feeling?"

I look around the white room and scrunch up my face.

"I don't like this place," I tell her.

"Hospitals can be a little bit scary, but you have to stay here for a while until your tummy feels better." Doctor Benson gives me a soft brown dog that's not real, and when I hold it, it feels funny on my hands.

"What is it?" I ask her.

"It's a stuffie for you to cuddle, do you want to give him a name?"

I poke the dog's hard eyes. "Does it do things?"

Doctor Benson looks at the dog, then she pats its brown head. “No, it’s just a soft toy. Do you have toys at home?”

I shake my head. “I saw kids playing with blocks on the TV one day. Is that toys?”

“Blocks are toys, yes.” She smiles. “What kinds of toys do you have in your bedroom at home?”

I pat the dog’s head like Doctor Benson did. “I only sleep in my dad’s bedroom. There’s one bed and one drawer. I wanna see my dad,” I say.

There’s lots of beeping sounds and yucky smells, and a white blanket is on top of me.

Doctor Benson puts her hand on my leg. I wiggle it away from her, but my tummy is very sore, and some tears come from my eyes. “You must miss him. Can you tell me about your dad?”

“He’s got black hair and brown eyes,” I say.

She does a little smile. “Can you tell me about your house?”

“It’s got bricks and wood and a big veranda. It’s called a farmhouse. We have four bedrooms and one basement that has sixteen steps to go down, down, down.”

She writes something on a piece of paper. “That sounds like a very nice house. Can you tell me some more about the basement?”

I shake my head, remembering that I’m not allowed to talk about it. “No.”

“Darius, when the police went to your house, they found another man that wasn’t your dad. Can you tell me about him?” Doctor Benson asks me.

I shake my head again. “Only me and Dad live in my house.” I always remember the things my dad tells me to say. If I remember all the things, I don’t get the whip.

She smiles and nods. “Do you remember what you had for dinner last night?”

“Pork,” I say. “My dad made it. When can I go home?”

Doctor Benson doesn’t talk to me again, but another girl comes in and tells Doctor Benson she can leave.

The different girl has hair that’s blonde. That’s what my dad calls it. He likes making the girls with blonde hair scream the most. He always calls

the blonde hair girls the name Loren. I think my dad likes that name the best.

The girl closes the curtains on the little window and makes the lights very low. She sits next to me on the white bed. "Hello Darius, I'm Doctor Monroe, but you can call me Loren."

A big, shocked sound comes out of my mouth and my eyes get wider and wider. "My dad likes your name," I say.

"Really?" Her eyes get a little bit big, then she smiles. "Well, I like your name." She whispers very quietly in my ear, "Can I tell you something about me?"

"Yes," I say.

"When I was small like you, a nice man looked after me. We had a very big secret and he said I was never allowed to tell anyone."

"Was the man your dad?" I ask.

She nods and does a big, big smile. "Yes. Yes, it was my dad. Have you ever had a very big secret with your dad?"

I nod then remember my dad's words, and I cover my mouth with my hands.

"It's okay," Loren says, "I won't tell anyone, it can be our special secret."

"Okay," I say.

"Darius, your dad is going to go to prison for a long, long time because he killed lots of people." She watches me, but I don't say any words, and she keeps talking. "Do you know what all of that means?"

I nod. "Killed means they're dead and never coming back alive. No one can find them anymore."

"That's right. And because your dad is in prison, you'll be living with another family. Their names are Kevin and Desi, and they have twin girls named Natalie and Jemma, they'll be your sisters."

I shake my head. "I don't want sisters. I only want my dad."

"I know, sweetheart, but your dad made a big mistake, and he has to stay in prison."

My tummy does big flip flops, and it makes me push my bottom lip out. "I wanna go home."

"You can't, Darius. I'm sorry," Loren says. When she holds my hand, I feel that hers is warm, and I squeeze it tighter.

“But my dad will be very angry. He’ll kill more people. Do you know my dad’s secrets too?” I ask Loren.

She nods and puts her hand on my head and plays with my hair. “I know lots of secrets. Is there any other secrets you want to tell me?”

I scrunch my nose. “You won’t tell Doctor Benson?”

She shakes her head. “No, I won’t tell her.”

“My dad lets me play with him.”

“How do you play?”

“Sometimes, he lets me use his big knife to cut and stab people.” I pretend to do stabby stabs with my hand to show her.

“What else does your dad do?” she asks.

“He lays on the dead people and gives them kisses and licks the blood off them. And sometimes, he licks all the dead blood off me too. And one time, Dad let me lick all the blood off his whole body.”

Her eyes get very big and wide. “Wow, it sounds like your dad likes blood a lot.”

“He does. Dad said dead blood is the best because the people don’t scream and tell Dad no. They just lay very still and let Dad do all the things to them.”

“What kind of things does he do to them?” Loren asks.

“He cuts off their skin and eats it, and he puts his big, big dick in their mouth and in the middle of their legs. Sometimes he does big cuts in their tummy and puts his dick inside all the blood and meat. And one day dad let me have a baby, but it was screaming and screaming and screaming and dad broke it.” Watery drips come from my eyes, and I wipe them away with my hands.

“How did he break the baby, Darius?”

“He put a big hole in its tummy with his knife. Dad wanted me to play with it, but I was crying and crying, and I didn’t want to look at it anymore.” Big breaths and coughs come from my throat, and my tummy hurts. I shake my head lots of times. “I don’t like broken babies. No, no, no. But Dad said I have to learn, that’s why he puts his knife and his fingers in my mouth and in my bottom. He said one day I will feel the need. Do you feel the need?”

She shakes her head. “No. No, I don’t feel the need. And you won’t feel it either, okay? I’ll make sure you don’t.”

“Will you make me play with the broken babies?” I ask Loren because I don’t want to play with them anymore.

Loren holds my hands and squeezes them very softly. “No, sweetheart, you’ll never have to see broken babies again.”

When I do a big smile, Loren has some watery drips coming from her eyes. I think that she doesn’t like broken babies like me.

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XXXV

*Play for me death's symphony
He'll come for me, just wait and see
Death will never let us be
So play for me, death's symphony*

DIABLO

I'm torn from the horrific memories when my father—my real fucking father, The Savage, who is still alive—shoves my own knife into my thigh.

“Fuck you, you sick bastard!” My body bows forward as I choke and gasp on each ragged breath.

“Can't handle a little pain, son?” He pulls my knife back, then, with a flick of his wrist, throws it across the room where it lands with a clang on the concrete. “I didn't raise you to be weak.”

I don't know what happened in the moments between Arthur slamming that branding iron into my head, and now, but when I blink and clear my blurred vision, I can barely hold back my shouts of rage. I thrash against the ropes that bind me to the wooden chair, but there's no give, and my violent movements only serve to shake the chair and make my head swim with nausea.

Rather than continue to struggle and ending up on the floor, where I know he'll leave me, I still, and focus on the others.

Beside me, Chadwick sits in silence, his calculating gaze follows Arthur's footsteps as he paces back and forth between us. Opposite me, Salem is bound to a chair, and beside him, Killian is slumped and shivering on the floor, now unchained. A thick sheen of sweat covers his bruised and battered flesh. If he doesn't receive medical attention soon, he won't survive the multiple external injuries, let alone the hidden, internal ones he surely sustained at the hands of my psychotic father.

“You could have been brilliant, Darius,” my father says. “You had all the makings of a killer. You were my perfect son. I chose *you* as the heir to my legacy.”

Flashbacks force their way into my vision. I blink rapidly to focus on the present. “I was five years old. You were a murderer. A paedophile,” I grit out, “and I was a stupid fucking child.”

“A child who was born with a purpose,” he says, still pacing. “Until Chadwick here decided to turn on me.”

“Sounds like you were fucking unhinged,” Salem mutters. “And where the hell have you been all this time?”

Arthur stands behind Salem and pats his shoulder. “America. So many hunting grounds out there. I was having the time of my life, so imagine my surprise when—”

“You followed me back here.” Liam stands in the open doorway, knife in his hand, he points it at Arthur. “I fucking knew you looked familiar.” He shakes his head.

My father—*No, I have to stop calling him that.* Arthur waves a hand, motioning for Liam to enter, but he remains in the doorway, and Arthur continues, “Liam, my son, please, come on in and take a seat with your brothers. You’re right, as soon as I saw you, I knew you were one of mine. I watched you from afar, saw you help your friend take down that cartel. When I followed you to the airport, I took a chance.” He turns to Chadwick next. “Then I see your face plastered around town. The mayor, the governor. Good old Connor passed it all onto you. Tell me Chadwick, how does it feel knowing you’re about to lose everything?”

Chadwick doesn’t reply, and I ask, “How did you find Killian?”

“Friends in low places,” Arthur says. “Gavin was a wealth of information. All I had to do was promise him an hour with the boy before I took him, and I was set.” He leans down close to Salem’s ear, “I hear the scarred one belongs to you. Didn’t get a chance to taste him, unfortunately.”

Salem stiffens, a mask of pure rage smothers his features.

Liam takes another step into the room.

Arthur brings his knife to Salem’s throat.

My heart rate increases and sweat beads on my brow. I cannot lose Salem. Not like this. Not at his hands. The thought sends panic surging through my veins.

I shake and twist violently. My chair rocks back and forth, and finally, it topples over.

“Darius. Please, calm down,” my father says. “Can’t you see I’m busy, you remember how much I love a clean, straight cut, don’t you?”

“LET HIM GO!” I shout. “I’ll fucking kill you!” Using all the strength I have, I yank on the binds, try to kick out and throw myself back. A leg of the chair snaps.

Arthur looks over at me, Salem's dark hair twisted through his fingers.

Salem's eyes meet mine, tears welling, he knows what's coming. "You'll be okay," he mouths the same words he spoke to me when we were fifteen-year-old boys, longing for a connection with someone who understood the insanity that lived and breathed inside us.

I shake my head. "Sal... no."

The flashback assaults me, and I suck in a breath...

We were lying on the grass in a small clearing in the middle of the forest the night before Salem's first hunt. Salem pointed up at the scattered stars. "If I die in the hunt, I'll be right there." He circled his finger to encompass the brightest star we could see. "I bet that's heaven."

"You won't die," I said, grabbing his hand and pulling it down. "And heaven's not real."

He laughed, threaded his fingers through mine, and pulled our joined hands to his chest. "I might," he said. "Some of the prey are strong, and I'm not as good as you, D."

I turned my head at the same time he did. Dark brown eyes met mine, and for a brief moment, I believed in something other than pain and violence. Something that had no name, but felt so big I could barely breathe.

"You won't die," I said again. "I need you." I didn't know where those words came from, or what they really meant, I just knew that I needed Salem... always.

A smile spread across his face. "You'll be okay," he said. "You'll be okay without me."

"Sal... no, you can't die. Don't—"

My words were cut off when his lips brushed across mine.

It was fleeting, so swift I barely felt it. But at the same time, it was as though he slammed into me, a chaotic, but silent explosion of confusion that quickly morphed into knowledge.

I was fifteen, and for the first time in my life, I had someone I wanted to keep.

Liam's knife clanging to the concrete pulls me from the memory.

He kicks his knife away, eyes fixed on Arthur and the blade he's holding to Salem's throat. "You spill one drop of his blood, and your next breath will be your last, old man."

Undeterred, Arthur moves to drag his blade across Salem's throat.

At the same time, there's a shout of "NO!" from Killian who leaps forward.

Arthur stumbles backwards, the knife falling from his grasp.

With a loud, guttural shout, I throw myself back, breaking the chair into pieces. The arms of the chair hang off my wrists, and while they're still bound with rope, I manage to untie my feet.

I scramble to Salem, but he bats my hands away. "Go, go help Killian," he says, one hand covering his bleeding throat.

Liam reaches down to help me up, but there's a second of hesitation on my part. I can't leave Salem. It's a second too long, and when I hear a pained cry ring out, I turn to see my father about to slam Killian face first into the concrete.

"NO!" I shout.

But Killian kicks out, turns, and brings his hand up from where it was tucked around his waist. Tight in his grasp is Salem's knife.

Killian plunges the knife into Arthur's side. It's not deep enough to kill, but it throws him off his feet again and gives Killian the chance to stand.

Knife in hand, he glances over his shoulder at me, a questioning gaze—is he seeking permission? He doesn't fucking need it.

"Do it," I say, and I watch as my little hunter lunges, the knife plunging deep into Arthur's throat.

But he doesn't stop there. Screaming, he straddles Arthur and continues wildly stabbing his chest, neck, and face. Blood sprays in an arc across the wall and floor. It pools beneath Arthur's dead body, and smothers Killian who continues his brutal assault.

Arthur Phillip Kingsford—my father, and the serial killer known as The Savage, is finally dead.

"Killian," I call. "Killian, stop!"

He stands, dazed and trembling for a long moment. Then, he walks right past me, his entire, naked, damaged body, painted red. Blood drips down his face, chest, and legs.

He stops at Chadwick's chair, looks down at him with a blank expression and asks, "Did you want me?"

"No," Chadwick says, his face remains blank, his eyes, nothing but dark, empty voids.

"My mother?" Killian's voice shakes. "Did she—did she want me?"

"Yes. She loved you, even before she knew you," Chadwick admits.

"When... how did she die?" Killian asks, swiping a hand across his bloody forehead.

"In childbirth, haemorrhage. Darius was there, you can ask him." A smirk curls Chadwick's lip. "He wanted to kill you. The only reason you're alive is because I didn't allow him to end your life."

"And the only reason you're alive..." Killian hesitates, looks over to me, then adds, "Is because I haven't asked him to kill you yet." He turns his back on Chadwick and approaches us.

Liam tears his own t-shirt into strips, creating makeshift bandages as Killian stands before us, hands shaking, body trembling.

Killian extends his hand, holding out Salem's knife, his gaze shifting between me and Salem, he says, "Kill him," before he kneels, then slumps to the floor, his hands covering his face as he breaks into choking sobs.

My fingers itch to reach out and hold him, but Chadwick needs to die first.

"I'll watch him," Liam says. "You and Sal finish him, it's what you've always wanted."

I pull off my coat and drape it over Killian's shoulders before Liam kneels to bandage some of his wounds.

Chadwick looks up at me, then Salem. "I gave you everything," he says. "If it wasn't for me, you'd have nothing. You'd *be* nothing. You'd both be dead."

Salem and I share a glance.

We smile.

"Everything you have is thanks to me," Chadwick says.

We ignore him. Salem reaches out to squeeze my hand, I squeeze his back.

"One," Salem says.

"Two," I follow.

“Three,” we say in unison, and together, we shove our knives into Chadwick’s stomach. Salem drags his knife to the left, and I drag mine to the right. Blood, viscera, and intestines spill from Chadwick’s gut and onto his thighs, then the floor.

There’s a choked gurgle from his throat, and the bastard smiles, teeth covered in blood. Psychotic until the very end.

Blood dribbles from the corner of his mouth. His eyes grow wide. Pupils dilate. A final, gasping breath tumbles from between his lips.

“So, we’re really brothers,” Salem says, his gaze still fixed on Chadwick.

I take his hand again and give it a hard squeeze. When he does the same back, I say, “We always were.”

BANG.

BANG.

BANG.

Turning, I look towards the door.

“What the fuck is that?” Salem asks.

I turn, groaning in pain when I remember the wound to my thigh. Salem rushes over to Liam, grabs a torn piece of his t-shirt, and kneels to wind it around my thigh. “Let me help you,” he says, wrapping an arm around my waist. We head to the door that leads back into the morgue.

“Diablo,” Killian croaks out. “Where’s Diablo.”

“He’s right behind us,” Liam says, upping his pace.

BANG.

BANG.

“The drawers,” I say, knowing. I rush ahead, limping and wincing with every step.

I get three of the eight doors open before Salem reaches for the door closest to the back wall. “It’s this one,” he says.

BANG.

BANG.

Salem pulls on the steel handle to open the door and reach inside. He drags the sliding, steel slab out.

A bruised and bloody August thrashes violently. “Fucking stupid fucking asshole!” he shouts, curses some more, and throws himself off the raised slab only to land on the concrete with a heavy thud followed by a long groan of agony.

Face swollen and bruised, and with a bleeding and weeping branding mark to his neck, August glares up at us, eyes burning with rage until he blinks, and through narrow slits, says, "D? What the fuck!" He brings a bloody hand up to his neck. "What the fuck is going on?" he finally asks through a series of hacking coughs. "Gavin," he says, rolling onto all fours to cough again. "He fuckin' drugged me. I woke up with his filthy fuckin' cock in my ass. Then he threw me in that other room with some old bastard who fuckin' branded me." He winces when he touches his burned neck, then slumps to the floor again. "When I find that prick, I'll fuckin' gut him!"

"Too late," Salem says. "Diablo beat you to it."

Footsteps coming down the basement stairs have us shrinking back into the dark corner of the morgue. I reach for my knife but let out a relieved sigh when I hear Stefani's voice.

"Sal, Diablo? You guys down here? Liam," she calls. "You assholes better not be fuckin' dead!" She enters the morgue with Estelle by her side, both of them dressed in black leather pants and black tees, their knives in sheaths by their sides. Stefani plants a hand on her hip and scowls. "Really guys? You could've waited for us." She approaches August and shoves him with her foot. "You still alive, dickhead?"

August groans and throws his hand out in an attempt to shove her away. "Fuck off," he grunts and writhes, but when Estelle kneels by his side, he lays still and allows her to check his injuries.

"Let's get out of here," Stefani says, "Chadwick's been reported missing. We need to come up with a story until we find him."

"He's here, and he's dead," I say. "We'll tell you what happened when we get home."

"What about this one," Stefani says, kneeling down to grab a fistful of August's hair. "We keeping him?" She looks at Estelle who's holding August's hand and telling him he'll be okay.

Stefani raises her head and sighs heavily. "*You* are not fucking keeping him, Stelle. Besides, he only likes cock."

"Fuck you, Stef," August slurs.

Estelle smiles and squeezes August's bloody hand.

I'm about to tell Stefani to end him when Salem says, "Yes, we're keeping him. I've got an idea."

As we exit through the back door, I take one last look at the house and recall the words Chadwick spoke to me the night I was inducted into The House of Machiavellianism.

“And what are the rules we must follow?”

And my reply...

“No indiscriminate murder. Always remain calm and in control. Focus on the task at hand and leave only when that task is complete.”

Five minutes later, I leave.

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XXXVI

*They were made to be used
In a world built on lies
But the secrets we keep
Will mean our demise*

LOREN MONROE

The past

It was 1975 when I saw my first horror movie the day after I turned fifteen.

I'd come out of my bedroom to go to the bathroom down the hall. As I walked by the living room, the flickering light of the television caught my attention.

I stood by the doorway, my hands shaking so hard I had to clasp them together as I watched a masked man grab a kicking and screaming young girl from the front door of a house she was trying to escape from, and drag her back inside.

Covering my mouth to stifle a gasp, I took a quick, sideways glance at my parents to make sure they hadn't noticed me. Like me, their eyes were glued to the television screen.

The seized girl screamed and writhed while the masked man ignored her desperate, wailing cries and carried her into another room.

A familiar warmth pooled in my belly, and I clenched my thighs, confused about the sensations of desperation and need that were growing inside me over what I knew should have been a terrifying scene.

Eyes wide, and with my heart in my throat, I watched in fascination as the killer hefted the girl up and impaled her on a large, silver meat hook. Blood spurted from her back and sprayed in an arc across the wall. She screamed again, mouth open wide, hands clawing at the hook that was embedded into her back. The killer strode to a bench, picked up a chainsaw, and started it.

I swallowed down the lump in my throat.

Squeezed my eyes shut.

Pictured myself in the girl's position... No. I couldn't do that. It would have been too final. Instead, I imagined myself by the killer's side. Watching as he brutalised, tortured, and murdered his victims.

That was what I wanted. A killer of my own.

Over the following three years, I devoured every horror movie I could get my hands on. By 1978, my obsession with serial killers and murderers ran so deep, I'd become reckless.

I frequently walked the dark streets of my hometown, alone and unafraid, hoping I'd get the chance to come across my own, elusive murderer. It never happened, so instead, I shifted my focus to studying, and spent countless hours at the library pouring over stacks of books about criminals, psychology, and serial killers.

When I turned eighteen, Halloween came out at the movie theatre, and it was there that I met Chadwick and Arthur. For six tumultuous years, the three of us stuck together through thick and thin. Our love triangle was the talk of the town. They wanted me, and depending on my mood, I wanted one or the other, sometimes both.

Then, the rumours started.

Police were hunting a serial killer, and Arthur had been spotted in the surrounding areas at the times of four of the murders. He was taken in for questioning. Chadwick and I had to give our statements, and all the while, I wondered if Arthur was capable of pulling it off. And if I had, unknowingly, been a lover and friend to a serial killer all along.

In 1982, Arthur went to prison on rape charges, and the same day, Chadwick revealed the truth. They were both murderers and had been for years. Although Chadwick argued that Arthur was worse, he admitted they'd both been regularly consuming human flesh, and partaking in necrophilic fantasies.

I waited for the disgust to come. For seeds of hatred and revulsion to grow. And I waited for fear to take over. None of that happened. Instead, my obsession with the two men, grew stronger.

In 1983, one month after his release, Arthur disappeared and we didn't hear from him again until December 1985 when he showed up on our doorstep, a large, black duffle in his hand.

Inside that duffle, a baby boy was nestled in a thick, wool blanket, spots of blood splattered across his blue jumpsuit. Big, brown eyes stared up at us, eyes that looked so much like Arthur's, the resemblance was uncanny.

"He's my son," Arthur said. "I'm going to keep this one, train him to be like me. He'll be my first heir."

That same night, The House of Machiavellianism was created.

* * *

The Past

The Night of the Asylum Fire

1995

I push the door to Chadwick's office open to find him sitting on his recliner, Devin on the sofa opposite him.

"I want the boys," I say to Chadwick. "Tonight."

He leans back into the plush leather, a cigar between his fingers, and his foot propped on his opposite knee. After a long inhale, he exhales the acrid grey smoke, eyes still riveted to mine. "Then take them," he says.

For ninety-nine percent of the population, having an apathetic, brash, often violent partner, would be a nightmare. For me, it's almost like a game. Some days, I consider my words and actions right down to the smallest micro expression to garner the reactions I desire.

I thrive under pressure, come alive under the threat of violence, and crave those tiny, fleeting moments when I catch Chadwick's expression morph from a blank, empty stare, to a hardened gaze of determination, or when the flicker of lust in his eyes takes a turn into the darkness and he uses me to feed his deadly depravities.

The men in my life believe they hold the power.

They have no idea how easily I can bring them undone.

Studying them like they're caged animals, is the highlight of my days.

"I need some help. I'd like to use Devin and Bruce," I say, blatantly ignoring Devin and only addressing Chadwick.

A tiny crease forms between Chadwick's brows, he's considering my words, unable to comprehend the statement. To him, help does not exist. People are used, abused, and discarded depending on what he requires at any given time.

To ask for help, is to show weakness.

"Help?" he finally asks. "Why?"

"I'll need someone to drive in case the children need my attention. I also need them to dispose of a few bodies," I explain.

There's a flicker of light in his otherwise dark eyes. After another long puff on his cigar, he nods once. "And you've planned this?"

I nod in return. "Of course I have, darling."

The smallest hint of a smile tugs at the corner of his lips, but it disappears when Devin stands and says, "I'll need the details. Where are we going? And how many bodies?" Devin's brusque tone has no effect on me, and he abhors that fact.

With a wave of Chadwick's hand, Devin remembers his place. "You'll do whatever Loren asks of you."

"Yes, sir," Devin says, a single nod of acknowledgement is all I get, but I still smile.

One word from me and Chadwick would have Devin's tiny, black heart shucked from his chest like a raw oyster, and I'd be right there beside him, feasting on it.

I reach out to give Devin the three pieces of paper with the children's pictures on them. "Do not allow these children to perish," I state. "They must remain safe." I hand over another two pages, these ones with the names and faces of the doctors who'll be on the night shift. "These two, I need you to dispose of."

After a quick discussion with Chadwick, Devin leaves the room telling me he'll find Bruce and explain what's going on.

When the door closes behind him, Chadwick drops his cigar into the ashtray and motions for me to go to him. I kneel at his feet, my hands rubbing his thighs as he reaches out, eyes slightly narrowed.

He brushes my hair back from my face. "Still no sign of Arthur?" I ask.

"No," he says. "And all going well, it will remain that way."

Smiling, I slide my hand further up Chadwick's thigh, but he places his hand over mine, stopping me from reaching his dick. "Loren," he says, his voice stern.

I turn my hand beneath his and relish in the rare feeling of his palm against mine. "Let me pleasure you, my love." Tentatively, I climb onto his lap and glide my hands down his torso until I reach the button of his slacks. "Forget about Arthur, he's long gone by now."

"He should have been put down, permanently," Chadwick says, his hand coming around to grip the back of my neck. "If he comes back—"

I cut him off with a kiss, but he plants his hand on my chest. “Go, get your children and bring them back here. They will begin training immediately.”

Standing, I smooth my hands over my jeans and pull my hair back into a loose ponytail. Smiling, I lean down and press a chaste kiss to Chadwick’s lips, and without waiting for his reaction, I walk out, pulling the door closed behind me.

* * *

Newhaven Asylum

2:00am

“Hurry, we need to get the children to safety,” I shout as I usher Doctor Carla Benson towards the children’s ward. “You check the rooms at the end of the corridor, I’ll check the playroom.”

Nodding, she pulls her thick, wool jumper up to cover her mouth and nose as she rushes towards the stairs.

Smoke alarms blare.

Water sprays down from the sprinklers above.

Children scream, cough, and choke.

Downstairs, patients are panicking, and doors are slamming.

I race into the staff room and pull open the large cupboard. Three pairs of eyes look up at me, and I smile. “Come on, boys, let’s get you out of here.”

Sal sucks in a deep breath, a huge smile spreads across his face and lights up his brown eyes. “I wanna see the fire,” he says bouncing on his toes. “I wanna see the fire!”

“Me too,” Darius says, although his face is a mask of confusion.

I reach out to take Sal’s hand, but he shakes his head and grabs the hands of his two new friends—his half-brothers. That intuitive act of wanting to remain with them, of seeking comfort from them, and their touch, warms my heart.

The boys have no idea who they are to one another, and yet they are irrevocably drawn to each other, and were from the moment they met. They’re perfect for my next experiment studying the influences of nature versus nurture.

“Come on, L,” Sal says, using the shortened name he gave to the mute little boy who arrived two weeks ago. He does the same to Darius who looks down at their clasped hands, still decidedly confused.

The poor boy is so touch starved and unresponsive to emotions, he has no idea what to do with Sal, so he simply follows his lead.

“Okay, you can hold hands,” I say, “But you cannot let go, Sal, no matter what.”

“Cannot let go, Sal, no matter what...” he repeats, and I have the innate yearning to fall to my knees and pull these boys into my arms.

Later. I remind myself as smoke begins to fill the staff room.

As I usher the boys towards the emergency exit, Doctor Hart rounds the corner. “Oh my god, Loren, I just called triple zero, the fire department and ambulances are on their way.”

“Thank goodness,” I rush out. “Carla’s gone back for another child, please, George, you have to help her,” I say urgently.

He nods quickly and glances at the boys. “Hurry.” He points to the exit. “Get them to safety.”

Ten minutes later, Bruce is driving back to the mansion, Devin ahead of us in his own car, the doctor’s bodies in the boot. The three boys are sitting behind me in the back seat, eyes wide as they stare out the back window as the asylum goes up in flames.

I sit back in the passenger seat, and smile.

Soon, my family will be complete, and with Arthur out of the picture, my boys will be safe.

THREE DAYS AFTER ARTHUR & CHADWICK'S DEATHS

BREAKING NEWS

NEWHAVEN ROCKED BY SHOCKING NEWS

Late Thursday night, authorities were called to an incident at the Kingsford farmhouse. Abandoned and left to rot in 1990 after the arrest and incarceration of serial killer, Arthur Phillip Kingsford, the fenced off farmhouse attracts tourists whose morbid curiosity has them delving into the dark and depraved past of the infamous serial killer known as The Savage.

After arriving at the property, detectives found the bodies of two men identified through dental records as Newhaven's mayor and governor of Iron Tomb prison, Chadwick Connor Monroe, and Arthur Phillip Kingsford, who was believed to have died in prison in 1995.

A third body is believed to be that of local Pawnbroker, Gavin Rafferty, who had been imprisoned multiple times for various offences, including child abuse, drug possession, assault, and fraud.

On Friday morning, eighty-nine-year-old Connor Monroe, former mayor and governor of Iron Tomb, was arrested in his home on the outskirts of Newhaven.

In a shocking twist, Connor Monroe admitted he was responsible for the incident that led to the country's most prolific serial killer escaping during his transport to hospital for severe injuries sustained during a riot within the prison.

In his confession, Monroe told police that since 1995, he and his son, Chadwick, were responsible for the murders of at least twenty-three government officials, police officers, and prison staff in an effort to cover up their misdeeds.

Authorities are still trying to piece together the events that led up to the deaths of the men. Their only witness, August Kensington, who was found with life threatening injuries at the rear of the property, was questioned by police at Newhaven Hospital where he remains in a serious, but stable condition.

Our reporter spoke to Senior Sergeant Jameson Oaks outside Newhaven Hospital last night.

“We are still piecing together the events that occurred up to and on Thursday night. Police urge anyone with information to come forward, no matter how insignificant you think it may be. In the meantime, a curfew has been put into place to ensure the safety of Newhaven’s residents. Details can be found online and in the local papers.”

Our reporter and the small crowd gathered outside the hospital were left stunned when Senior Sergeant Oaks continued...

“Finally, it is with pleasure that I announce I have accepted the tenure as Iron Tomb’s new governor, and as Mayor of Newhaven. I look forward to cleaning up the town and removing corrupt individuals from our society. I won’t be taking any more questions at this time. Thank you.”

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FINALE

THE DEVIL'S WAIL

Devour. Devastate. Invalidate.
Ruin me.
Try.
I will outdo you. Because I am worse.
I am worse.
I am worse.

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XXXVII

*He sold his soul
To the devil in disguise
But the devil got lost
In the beauty of his eyes*

KILLIAN

Six months later

Leaning back on my chair, I prop the toes of my Docs on the edge of the table. I rub my fingers over the scars on my wrists, constant reminders of the torture I endured at the hands of Arthur Kingsford. Though my body has healed, the nightmares still haunt me, a never-ending torment that Doctor McCallister's therapy has so far, not been able to ease.

Opposite me, Jameson Oaks clears his throat, his smug expression filling me with rage.

A month after Diablo brought me home, he and Salem discovered that Jameson had been working for Chadwick. The day Jameson questioned me at Gavin's pawnshop, he was attempting to gather information on Diablo. Now, on principle, I hate the bastard and will never trust him.

Jameson smirks, gives me a wink, then leans forward, elbows resting on the table. "The next thing I'd like to discuss is The House of Machiavellianism," he says. He takes in each of us before his gaze stops at the head of the table where Diablo sits.

He's impeccable in his black business suit, and the unbuttoned black shirt that reveals a glimpse of the tattoo across his chest. My name, and below it, the words *My Heart*. He's a fucking romantic and he doesn't even know it.

Ignoring Jameson, I openly stare at Diablo, blatantly licking my lips as my scowl grows into a smirk I know will get under his skin.

When Diablo's jaw clenches, I smile, the heat in his eyes as he glares at me is a dead giveaway. He wants to hurt me, and fuck, I want the pain. If I asked, he'd bend me over this table right now and fuck me. I just wish he'd give me the one thing I truly want, but he still refuses. *Take it. It's time, Killian!* My plan to force his hand is going to happen soon.

I lick my lips again, swirl my tongue around my lip piercing, and reach down to adjust myself.

Diablo's growl is primal, beastly. And I love it.

From beside me, Salem laughs and shakes his head. "Want us to clear the table?" he asks.

"Yes," I say at the same time Diablo says sternly, "No."

I huff and cross my arms over my chest.

"Whenever you're ready," Jameson says with an arched brow.

Stefani, who's sitting between Liam and Estelle, uses her knife to point at Jameson. "*You* have no business being involved with The House. It belongs to Diablo and Salem now, and you were never inducted, so whatever Chadwick told you, can be forgotten."

"Stef," Salem warns. "If we want to keep The House running, we need to make a few changes."

Spinning her knife on the table, Stefani narrows her eyes at Jameson who averts his gaze. If there's one thing I've learned about Stef in the past year, it's to never underestimate her, not if you want to keep your cock *and* balls attached to your body.

"What kind of changes," Liam questions, his voice laced with suspicion.

"First," Jameson says, "You need to stop with the innocents being sent into the hunt. The scum, the addicts, criminals, pedos, I don't care, but no more innocents."

"But they're so much fun," Stefani whines, her voice full of sadistic delight. "They're like cute little rabbits."

"Rabbits you want to gut and kill," Estelle reminds her, then shrugs. "I think it's a good idea. If they're innocent, they have people who care about them, people who will ask questions."

Stefani rolls her eyes, disgusted. "So? We hunt them too, obviously."

I stifle a laugh behind my hand.

"I agree with Jameson," Diablo says, surprising me with his serious tone. "No more innocents." The room falls silent when Watson comes in, wheeling a silver cart filled with bottles of whiskey, rum, and vodka. After placing the glasses on the table, he nods towards Diablo and leaves.

"August isn't causing any trouble?" Diablo asks Jameson.

Jameson shakes his head. "All good there. He's already in with the Reapers," he shifts his attention to me. "He's been asking about you," Jameson adds, "anything you want me to pass on?"

I shake my head, not wanting to think about the torture August endured simply because Gavin found out how August really felt about me. After being raped by Gavin, August was beaten, stabbed, and branded by Arthur. Then, the psychotic bastard removed two of his fingernails before August passed out, and Gavin shoved him, unconscious, into the refrigerated drawer in the morgue.

After spending four weeks in hospital, August was released, but Diablo was still on the warpath. He wanted August dead, and no matter how many times August swore he didn't send me the text message that landed me in Arthur's hands, Diablo refused to believe him.

To save August's life, and quite possibly, Diablo's sanity, Salem came up with the idea of putting August in prison where he's now acting as an informant for The House, and for Jameson, the new governor of Iron Tomb.

"How much longer does August need to be in there?" Estelle asks.

"Until I decide he can come out," is Diablo's cold reply. "Anything else?" he directs the question at Jameson.

Jameson's piercing gaze turns to me, and I narrow my eyes, already defiant. "You need to stop drawing attention to yourself," he warns. "There's only so much I can do to clean up your messes."

Clenching my teeth, I drop my chair to the floor and stand, hands planted on the table as I lean forward, glaring at the arrogant prick in front of me. "You need to shut the fuck—"

"Done," Diablo cuts off my retort.

For a brief second, I'm speechless, and seething with rage that Diablo would side with this asshole. When I turn to him for an explanation, he doesn't even spare me a glance.

Jameson leans back in his chair, arms crossed over his broad chest, he smiles, clearly enjoying my reprimand. Instead of playing the obedient little pet, I reach down and unsheathe my knife. With my eyes locked on Jameson, I raise my arm.

"Killian," Diablo's tone borders on deadly.

"Diablo," I reply coolly, and with a flick of my wrist, I release my knife the way Liam taught me. A chorus of gasps fills the office as my blade whizzes past Jameson's head and embeds itself into the wall behind him.

"You fucking little—" Jameson snarls and lunges across the table at me. His meaty fist twists the neck of my t-shirt as he pulls me close to his

face.

Unflinching, I count the seconds in my head, and before I reach three, *my* killers come to my rescue, each of them brandishing their own knives.

The sharp tip of Diablo's blade points dangerously close to Jameson's throat. "Unless you'd like to lose that hand, you'll remove it, now."

With a huff of annoyance, Jameson releases my t-shirt and I drop into my chair, propping my feet back up on the table. It's my turn to smirk at Jameson Oaks who truly believes he can dictate what I do.

"Liam, take Killian to the cellar," Diablo orders firmly.

And there it is. The only drawback to my impulsive actions. My recklessness always leads to punishment.

"Fuck," I mutter under my breath as I stand and follow a chuckling Liam out of the office.

* * *

DIABLO

Five hours later

From where I'm sitting on the half circle sofa in Snare's lounge, I watch Killian on the small dancefloor with Estelle and a group of random, half naked strangers. His body moves with the music, and his sweat drenched curls sway around his face as he raises his arms and nods along to the beat. Dressed in skin-tight leather shorts and a leather harness, his body is once again on display for the crowd who are blatantly taking in every inch of tattooed flesh that's now covered in a myriad of scars.

"You know he's trying to make you jealous?" Stefani says from beside me. She brings a blue cocktail to her lips and sips from the straw.

"I am aware of what he's doing," I state without inflection. "Do you expect me to do something about it?"

Laughing, Stefani pats my knee. "I just love how emotional you are now, D. It's cute."

Turning my head slowly, I glare at her. My jaw tics, and I clench my teeth to stop myself saying another word to this woman who knows me far too well.

“Come on, Stef,” Estelle calls from where she’s dancing with Killian, “Come join us.”

Stefani gets to her feet, places her drink on the small, glass top table, then gives me a wink before she sashays onto the dancefloor. A minute later, Salem and Liam drop down on the sofa either side of me. “So, you going to do a scene with him?” Salem asks, his eyes tracking my little hunter as he speaks.

“No.” I take a mouthful of whiskey to avoid the conversation I know is coming, but Salem, being the asshole he is, doesn’t take the hint.

“What do you want, Sal?” I ask.

Liam huffs out a laugh, and Salem follows suit. “We decided that if you’re not going to do something about Killian, we will.”

“What?” is the only word to leave my lips as I consider what Salem is saying.

“We spoke to Kate,” Liam says, “she reckons the meds will work for Kill.”

I bring my glass to my lips again, my eyes riveted to Killian’s ass covered in tight, black leather.

When I don’t reply, Salem continues, “We know he’s not going to take them willingly, but we could force him.” He shrugs, then leans forward, elbows resting on his knees. “He’s pushing you, D, and soon, you’re going to break.”

“You’ll regret it,” Liam says.

Still silent, I consider their words, roll them over in my mind. Do I want to change Killian? No. Do I want to kill him? Yes, but...

There’s always that “*but*”.

Having Killian is like living in a house of cards. Everything is balanced precariously on a razor’s edge of insatiable, savage hunger, and sheer frustration. All it will take is one, reckless step from my little hunter to send it crashing down.

“I’m fine,” I lie. “I have it under control. Hold off on the medication for now.”

Salem sighs, and Liam shakes his head. “D, if you lose him—”

I slam my glass down on the table. “Stop! I don’t want to hear another word about it.”

“Got it,” Liam says.

From the dance floor, Killian catches my gaze, his hips swaying, his eyes alight with mischief and pleasure. My heart beats hard against my chest, and my cock strains at the zipper of my pants.

When a pair of arms come around Killian's waist, I stand and reach for my knife.

"D," Salem warns. "Not tonight."

Ignoring him, I stalk towards Killian. He's already pushed the stranger away, but I track the man's movements as he sidles up to another young guy.

"Something wrong?" Killian asks, rubbing his half naked body against mine.

Growling, I grip his throat and tuck my thumb under the edge of the solid, silver collar I bought for him last week. I pull the chain from the inside pocket of my coat and clip the end to Killian's collar before I yank hard, lifting him up by the chain until his mouth meets mine.

The kiss is wet, hot, and hard, and when Killian groans into my mouth, I splay my hand across his back. For a few, long seconds, I allow my fingertips to trace the thick, raised scars on his back. The reminders of Arthur's torture cause my fist to clench, and my fingers to curl into Killian's soft, marred flesh.

"I'm here," he whispers into my mouth as his fingers fumble with the button of my pants.

I slap his hand away and spin him around so his back is flush against my front, and I spread my hands over his chest in a possessive hold. A few people glance our way as Killian grinds his ass against my hard cock. Others blatantly stare. "*Look.*" I want to shout, "*Look at what is mine. Look at what you'll never have.*"

I drop my head and bite into the soft flesh of Killian's neck, and I suck until the faint tinge of blood coats my tongue.

He moans, fingers gripping the sides of my thighs as he continues grinding against me. "Diablo," he says on a moan. "Fuck me," he begs and tilts his head, giving me more room to devour him.

The heavy, erotic beat of the music, and the moans and groans of patrons succumbing to their pleasure, reverberates through my body, sending a rush of heat into my veins.

I smooth one hand over Killian's harnessed chest and down to his abs.

He bucks his hips. Writhes. Begs. "Pleaseplease, Diablo, touch me, fuck me."

I dip my hand into his tight shorts and wrap my fist around his leaking cock. I tug on the thick ring pierced through his crown.

"Ahhh fuck," Killian shouts. "Diablo!"

I stroke him, long and slow, never taking my eyes off the way his entire body ripples with pleasure under my touch. "The way you move for me." Another stroke has him bucking wildly into my hand, and I nip at his earlobe as I grind my aching cock against his tight, leather clad ass. "So bold, my little hunter."

I glide my thumb through his precum and pull my hand out of his pants to push my thumb between his lips. "The way you leak for me." I drag my thumb from his mouth and dip two fingers in, sliding them over his tongue and down his throat until he gags. Saliva dribbles from his mouth. "You're so fucking perfect." I breathe against his ear.

"Touch me," he begs again. "Please, Diablo, pleasepleaseplease."

"You beg so beautifully, my heart. Now, take those shorts off," I say, "let everyone see what they'll never have."

He doesn't hesitate to obey, and when I glance up, a crowd of people have gathered to watch us. I don't give a fuck whose eyes are on Killian, but soon, there won't be a human left in this world who has touched Killian Graves. The stains on his flesh will be carved away, consumed and obliterated until the only touch he knows... the only touch he remembers, is mine.

My fingertips glide over Killian's ass, and he bucks his hips again, whining and writhing against me. Precum drips down his hot, hard length. I reach his hole and tug on the silver plug, earning a long, low whine from my attention seeking little hunter.

When I remove the plug, I drop it on the dance floor where it lands with a thud. "You want me to make you come, sweetheart?" I inhale against Killian's neck as I slide two fingers deep into his ass, and without hesitating, I graze my knuckles over his prostate. "Right here in front of everyone?"

"YES! Fuckyesyesyes!" Killian shouts and jerks forward, but when the action causes my fingers to slip from his ass, he rocks back again. I slide them back in, slowly finger fucking him as he bucks wildly, incoherent cries and begging pleas spilling from his lips.

I reach around and wrap my free hand around his needy cock, stroking him, and fucking him with my fingers, a simultaneous rhythm that matches the beat of the music.

Killian turns his head as much as he can, and I cover his mouth with my own, swiping my tongue across his, licking his lips, and breathing into his open mouth as I continue my relentless assault on his ass and his cock.

“I’m gonna—” His cock throbs in my hand as he cries out and his ass clenches around my fingers.

“Come for me, my heart,” I whisper against his ear before I suck his flesh into my mouth again, covering his neck in love bites and claiming him right here in the middle of the dance floor.

With a loud cry, Killian’s release spills over my hand, and I continue pumping my fingers in and out of his ass. “MINE!” I growl the words out loud. “Mine,” I repeat.

The scent of sex is heavy in the surrounding air when Killian turns to breathe against my ear. His tongue darts out, licking around my earlobe before he whispers, “Always.”

XXXVIII

*You've become complacent
And forgotten what I need
I'll search for your replacement
If my appetite you can't feed*

KILLIAN

Boredom is smothering me. Drowning me beneath waves of mundane repetition. Every day is the same, boring routine.

Work. Work. Work.

Kill. Kill. Kill.

Rinse and repeat.

While the sex, and our nights at Snare have been wild, brutal, and bloody, the rest of my life has become a fathomless void that can only be filled by my reckless streak that more often than not, lands me in the cellar, locked away inside that goddamn cage.

Over time, the fear has slowly waned, now it's the separation, the silence, and the lack of touch that sends me spiralling into the pits of utter fucking despair.

Watching Diablo continually give his victims the things I still, to this day, crave to the marrow of my bones, is torture. For a while, I was satisfied with the near-death experiences Diablo was offering as an alternative to my desperate need to have him end my life.

But the high never lasts long enough, and no amount of bloodshed can soothe me. Nothing, not even his hands around my throat, or his knife piercing my flesh, can bring me undone anymore.

It's not enough.

Nothing is ever enough.

Now, as he watches me, eyes flickering with a mixture of insatiable lust and cool indifference, I know it's time to push him. I need to force his hand.

His indifference is what fuels the raw desire coiling inside me, a desperate, clawing sensation that reminds me why I became obsessed with Diablo King in the first place.

"The way you unravel for me," he says, leaning over to lick the smooth, scarred expanse of my torso. He laps at the sweat that clings to my

skin, and the blood that pools in the ridges of my taut muscles. “The taste of your sweat, your blood. I could taste you forever and it would never be enough.”

Head shaking violently, I beg, “Please Diablo, it’s time.” Tears of frustration trickle from the corners of my eyes. Salted tributaries that trail down to my hairline.

He drags his tongue along my temple and down to my ear, lapping up the tears. “Your tears are pure decadence, sweeter than the finest wine.” With the tip of his knife, he traces my lips. “Your lips are perfection.”

My tongue darts out as I try with all my might to pierce it on his blade. I groan in frustration when he pulls it away.

“You’ll really die for me, Killian?” He traces the knife across my abs, outlining them with the tip of his blade before he drags it down to my hard, leaking cock. “After all this time, you’ll die for me?” He drags his knife along my length, and my cock twitches when he stops to press the flat of the blade to the soft flesh between my cock and balls.

He leans over me again, this time to swipe his tongue across my lips.

I snag his bottom lip between my teeth and bite down hard, but my attempt to enrage him doesn’t work. He dribbles his blood and saliva into my open mouth before he smothers my lips and kisses me hard. Our tongues tangle for dominance. Teeth clash, lips meld, wet and sticky with blood and saliva.

He tears off his black, silk shirt. Buttons fly, and he grunts as he removes the torn fabric. His hot, hard body smothers me, skin coated in a sheen of sweat, he grinds against me. I open my mouth to release a cry of sheer, exhilarating pleasure.

NO!

It’s time to die. My head spins with images.

His knife in my heart.

His fingers in my gaping wounds.

His inhale swallowing my final exhale.

NO!

I can’t let him distract me. “Ahhh... stop!” I shout and tug on the chains. “Please, please kill me!” I buck my hips and arch my back.

“Swallow my breaths, inhale me, Diablo.” I writhe beneath him, but he

remains just inches away, taunting, teasing. “I’m begging you,” I plead. “Kill me. I’m ready.”

He steps back and drops his knife on the floor.

“NO!” he bellows. “You’ve ruined me!” He scrubs his hands over his face before shoving his fingers into his hair and tugging on the long, dark strands. “This world I constructed, it wasn’t made to be shared, not with you—” He spins around, putting his back to me. “Not with you,” he repeats.

“Kill me then,” I say.

Anger darkens his eyes when he glares at me, his heavy footsteps pace back and forth over the hardwood floor.

Push him! My inner voice is relentless. Push him. Taunt him. Force his hand.

He stops, eyes on mine. “For thirty years, I’ve sated my sickest desires with more blood, flesh, and depravity than you will ever know. I am a killer—it’s what I was born to be. It’s *all* I was born to be... then you—”

“Kill me then. Fuck, Diablo it’s what I want!” I shout. “It’s what I want.” Lowering my voice, I add, “I want it to be you. I want your knife in my heart, your fingers in my flesh.”

His fists clench and his pupils dilate, so I continue, relentless, “You want it, Diablo, you want that power. You want to take my life, end it with your bare hands, your knife—”

“STOP!” He approaches, hovers over me and raises a fist.

I freeze, waiting for the blow. Instead, he swipes his knife up off the floor, returns, and slices across my abs, the shallow wound causes me to clench as it seeps with blood.

“Do it again,” I shout. “Hit me! Stab me! Fucking kill me!”

He sits on the edge of the bed, knife in hand, and his back to me. “I cannot kill you. If you die, I have nothing left.”

I pull on the chains that bind me to his bed. “You’ve done it before. You did it to everyone else. You killed my fucking brother. Why not me?” Tears stream from my eyes. “Do it,” I beg. “It’s all I ever wanted. Please, Diablo.” My voice shakes and I clear my throat. “I can’t live like this anymore. I need it. I want it. Please, please kill me!”

“NO!” he roars as he throws his knife across the room. It hits the wall with a heavy thud and falls to the floor. Hands back in his hair, he says, “Killing you will obliterate me. I’m selfish. You know this. I refuse to allow

your death to ruin me.” Spinning around, he stares into my eyes, slamming his fist against his own chest with each sentence. “I am ruin.” Slam. “I am wreckage.” Slam. “I am devastation.” Another slam. He shakes his head. “*I do not succumb to such things.*”

I scream in frustration. “You’re nothing. Nothing! Nothing but a weak, pathetic piece of shit. I hate you. I fucking hate you.”

With a calmness I’ve never seen in him before, he leans in close and cups my tear-stained cheek, his thumb brushing across my lips. “I never asked for anything else.”

“KILL ME!” I scream in his face, shaking my head to get his goddamn hand off me once and for all.

“Never,” he says. He makes his way around the bed, releasing the cuffs and chains.

After shaking out my hands and rubbing at my wrists, I stand tall. Shoulders straight, chin lifted in defiance.

His dark eyes are fixed on mine, and that hot as hell scowl is right there on his flawless face.

“Fine, I’ll find someone else to do it,” I say.

“I forbid you,” he says.

“Fucking stop me then!” I scream back, hoping he’ll finally give in.

XXXIX

*He tried to destroy me
Right from the very start
But he didn't know, he couldn't tell
He would always be My Heart*

DIABLO

Unravelled.

My heart—my little hunter. My Killian has finally unravelled me.

And as I stand here and watch him annihilate me, I realise this is my punishment for every sin I've ever committed, for every life I've taken, and for every single, violent act that led me to this point in my life.

Never before have I wanted, craved, ached to feel the touch of another's hands upon my skin the way I do with Killian. No one else has ever enamoured me or crept into the depth of my psyche and made a home within the walls of my heart.

Ruined.

My heart—my little hunter. My Killian has finally ruined me.

I can't live without him.

As Killian pulls open drawers and haphazardly shoves his clothes into a duffle, I swipe my phone up from the bedside table and send a single text.

I need you here immediately.

I don't wait or check for a reply before I drop my phone onto the end of the bed.

"Killian," I say.

He brushes past me, face contorted with anger, eyes filled with unshed tears. His hands shake violently as he shoves more clothes into his duffle.

"Killian," I repeat.

This time, he lets out a heavy, irritated sigh, and when he turns to open yet another drawer, I take in the sight of his back. Long, raised scars stretch across his back, over his perfect ass, and across the backs of his thighs, courtesy of my father—of Arthur Kingsford.

I shake my head.

Choke on the lump that's lodged in my throat.

"Killian, stop!" I command.

He stops, and for the briefest, fleeting second, his feet don't move. Then he glares at me, and when those pale blue-green eyes meet mine, he squeezes his shut and spins on his heels, putting his back to me.

There's a single knock at the bedroom door, and Killian turns to me again. "Who did you text?" he asks. "If that's fucking Salem..."

"Not another word," I say.

"What—"

I cut him off when I stalk towards him, grip his throat tight enough to make him cry out in pain, then, I throw him down to the floor. A gasp of air leaves his lungs when his back hits the hardwood. "You are not going anywhere," I state.

He writhes beneath me, arms flailing as he tries to fight me off.

"Fuck you!" he screams, legs kicking out at empty air. "Fucking let me go."

"You want to die, don't you?" I ask.

For a second, he stills, then he shakes his head frantically. "No, not with you. Fuck you! You'll never do it, you're too weak."

I allow a wide smile to stretch across my lips as I wrap a second hand around his throat and straddle him. Leaning down, I position my fingers away from his windpipe, my mouth hovering over his. "All this time you wanted to die, now you're saying no to me." I press a kiss to his mouth, glide my tongue across those luscious, full lips. "Do you want to die or not, Killian. This is your chance."

He nods. "Yes, yes, I want to," he says with so much conviction I have to avert my gaze to avoid his knowing eyes.

Tightening my hands around his throat, I breathe into his mouth as he exhales. "Are you ready to take your last breath, little hunter?"

"Ye—yes," he can barely breathe out the words, his face red, but slowly turning a perfect shade of purple. Eyes wide, he reaches out, grips my wrists. Tears leak from the corners of his eyes. He bucks his hips, his hard, leaking cock seeking friction. I ignore it.

Devastate.

Annihilate.

I always knew he would ruin me.

I allow him a short lungful of air, and he sucks it in, his chest heaving. Parting his legs with my knee, I spread them wide, spit into my palm, and rub the slick saliva over his tight hole.

The first violent thrust has me groaning, and Killian tenses, his wince of pain unhidden. I thrust again. He chokes out a desperate sob, followed by needy whimpers.

With both hands back around his throat, I pound into him, rocking my hips, squeezing his throat, and watching the expression on his face change from overwhelming pleasure to sheer, unadulterated panic when he finally realises what I'm doing.

"You want to die..." I thrust into his ass again. "You want me to kill you."

His brain finally registers the lack of oxygen, and he begins to fight.

Back arching, hips bucking wildly. His hands come up to fight me off, but I easily avoid his flailing.

"This time, my little hunter." Another violent thrust as I slam my mouth down over his and suck in each of his desperate panting breaths. "I'm going to kill you."

A low whine leaves his lips.

His eyelids flutter.

I grab his cock and pump hard. Once, twice, three times.

His release spills over his abs, and I swipe it up and lick his come off my fingers while my other hand tightens around his throat.

Thrust.

His eyes roll back.

Thrust.

He gasps.

Thrust.

I lick into his open mouth.

Splay my hand over his heart.

His eyelids fall closed.

I press my lips to his pulse and wait.

One thrust.

Another thrust.

He stops breathing.

I graze my lips across his neck.

His pulse is gone.

He's gone.

He's gone.

"Doc," I call, my cock still buried in Killian's ass.

Doc rushes in and stops a few steps away.

"Save him," I demand, digging my fingers into Killian's hips.

"Di—Diablo." Confusion mars his brow. "What are you doing? What's—" He brings his shaking hand up to his gaping mouth.

Purple-tinged bruises splay handprints across Killian's throat.

"SAVE HIM!" I roar.

"Fuck," Doc says shaking his head. His knees hit the floor, and he pulls out a stethoscope. He checks for Killian's non-existent pulse.

Then, he begins CPR.

I thrust into Killian's unconscious body as Doc starts chest compressions, counting with each hard, fast push he makes against Killian's chest.

"One, two, three, four, five, six..."

I thrust in time with his counting.

"Seven, eight, nine, ten..."

I groan out loud when my release fills Killian's ass.

"Di—Diablo. This isn't work—" Doc swipes his brow across his shoulder. "I can't do this. He, he's gone. It's too late."

"Keep going." I reach down beside me for my knife, point the tip of my blade beneath Doc's chin. "Save him or die."

Still performing CPR, Doc stutters as sweat drips from his brow. He gives Killian two rescue breaths that make his chest rise and fall. "I—I can't, Diablo, I, I can't just..."

"DO IT!" I shout.

As Doc continues chest compressions, my cock slips from the hold of Killian's ass.

I don't move.

Doc keeps counting.

Two more rescue breaths.

A minute passes.

He slams his hands into Killian's still chest, begging him to breathe.

Thirty seconds pass. Another rescue breath. Then one more.

"Please," Doc says, hands shaking. "It's too la—"

Killian chokes. Coughs. His chest heaves and his back arches.

Doc's eyes grow wide. He frantically presses his stethoscope to Killian's chest. Checks his pulse. Pulls his eyelids up and peers down at his eyes with a penlight.

"Fuck," he says, shocked. "Fucking hell, Diablo, what were you thinking?"

I wasn't. I didn't. I can't do this.

Killian's eyelids flutter.

He blinks.

Groans.

Blinks again.

I pull him up, spread his legs over my thighs, and sit back on my heels, cradling him in my arms.

"I did it," I say against the shell of his ear. "I killed you."

"Wha—" His head drops to my shoulder. "What?" he says in an almost incoherent whisper.

I repeat, "I killed you, sweetheart."

His head, heavy on his neck, lolls to the side. I tuck my fingers into his thick, sweat drenched curls. His eyes roll back as he continues to regain consciousness.

"Diablo," Doc says, "I need to check him. He needs to be monitored."

"No," I say.

"Diab—" Killian tries to speak, but I silence him with a soft, gentle kiss.

"I gave you what you wanted." I smooth a hand over his back, trace the ridges of his spine with my fingertips. "You forced me to kill you, but you're back now."

I close my hand around the hilt of my knife. Push the sharpened tip of the blade into his side. "You're mine. In life..."

He gasps, eyes searching mine, confusion mars his brow.

"Diablo..." Tears spill from his eyes.

"In death..." I cup his cheek, gather his tears on my thumb. "In every fathomless void."

"What are you..." his voice trails off as his eyelids flutter.

With my other hand, I push the knife in further. "For the first time in my life, I feel..." I kiss beside his open mouth. "I feel it now." I press a kiss

to his jaw. "I feel you." My lips linger beside his ear. "In the air. In my veins. In my heart."

Blood spills from the wound. Trickles down his side, over his thigh. Onto my leg, warm and wet. "And I can't let you go."

He inhales.

I draw the knife back and twist my hand to push my blade into my own side.

"I'll never let you go." I drop my knife on the floor.

I pull Killian closer and cradle his head in both my hands as I brush soft, fleeting kisses across his slightly parted lips. "Mine."

"Yours," he says on a broken whisper.

I swallow his exhale and lick the tears from his cheeks. "My little hunter."

I kiss him one more time. "My heart."

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STILL TO COME

This isn't the end for The House of Machiavellianism

The Desecration of Justice

BOOK 2

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The Desecration of Justice

in the

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THANK YOU

I want to say a huge thank you to my author bestie, Ashley Lane, for allowing me to use Liam in Danse Macabre. Liam was created as a side character in Ashley Lane's

Devoured by Demons, the fifth and final book in the [HEAVEN'S GUARDIANS SERIES](#)

If you're into MC Romance, check out Ashley's books at Amazon, or click the link above.

“But if this book was your jam, you probably won't like Ashley's books since THEY LIVE HAPPILY EVER AFTER AND MAKE BABIES WHO LIVE TOO.”

Direct quote from Ashley Lane – 12.58pm June 8th, 2024

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

To my family

Thank you for loving me and always encouraging and supporting my writing.

I love you all so much and could not have gotten this far without you.

My son, Blake

Thank you as always for all the encouragement, ideas, and feedback you give me for all of my books and covers.

Kayla, Tania, Estefania, & Lynette

Thank you for reading *Danse Macabre* before it was ready for the world.

Kayla

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Ashley

I love you, and I'm sorry about the baby (well, babies...)
(kind of, *insert evil laugh here because *you know me**)
Thank you for Liam and his life with Demon and the Heaven's Guardians!

And finally...

Thank you to my editors & sensitivity readers.
As always, your assistance, support, and feedback is invaluable.

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

THE FOLLOWING LIST

CONTAINS MAJOR SPOILERS

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

Ages listed coincide with the 'current day' at the beginning of the book.

Arthur Phillip Kingsford – 64

Serial Killer AKA The Savage
Father of Darius, AKA Diablo
Co-founder of The House of Machiavellianism
Birth father of Salem, Liam, August, and Gavin

Chadwick Monroe – 64

Father of Killian and Kaspian Graves
Co-founder of The House of Machiavellianism
Governor of Iron Tomb Prison
Mayor of Newhaven

Loren Monroe – (died during childbirth, 40 years old)

Chadwick's wife
Birth mother of Killian and Kaspian Graves
Former Director & Head Paediatric Psychiatrist at Newhaven Asylum

Diablo King – 39

Previously known as Darius Arthur Kingsford
Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Adopted by Chadwick and Loren Monroe at ten years old
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 15

Killian Graves – 24

Son of Chadwick and Loren Monroe
Kaspian's twin brother

Kaspian Graves – (died 2018 – 18 years old)

Son of Chadwick and Loren Monroe
Killian's twin brother

Salem Frost – 39

Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Adopted by Chadwick and Loren Monroe at 10 years old
Lifelong best friend/business partner/half-brother to Diablo
Other half siblings – Liam, August, Gavin
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 15

Liam Taylor – 39

Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Adopted by Chadwick and Loren Monroe at 10 years old
Lifelong friend/business partner/half-brother to Diablo & Salem
Other half siblings – August, Gavin
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 15
Sibling – Mia (*deceased*)

Stefani Cifarelli – 35

Friend/business partner to Diablo and Salem.
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 25

Estelle Devine – 35

Cleaner for The House of Machiavellianism
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 26
Best friend of Stefani since childhood

Justice Bane – 34

Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 30

August Kensington – 35

Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Acquaintance & Informant to Salem
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 15
Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Half siblings – Diablo, Salem, Liam, Gavin

Gavin Rafferty – 46

Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Pawnbroker, pimp
Inducted into The House of Machiavellianism at 18
Son of Arthur Phillip Kingsford
Half siblings – Diablo, Salem, Liam, August

Jameson Oakes – 44

Police Senior Sergeant in Newhaven
(at the end of the book) New Governor of Iron Tomb Prison
(at the end of the book) New Mayor of Newhaven

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



• TEARS • TRAUMA • TRAGEDY •
MM & MF Author & Poet

Julie Anne Addicott writes across a range of genres, including pitch black, traumatic tragedies, dark and toxic love stories, and poetry and romance.

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